

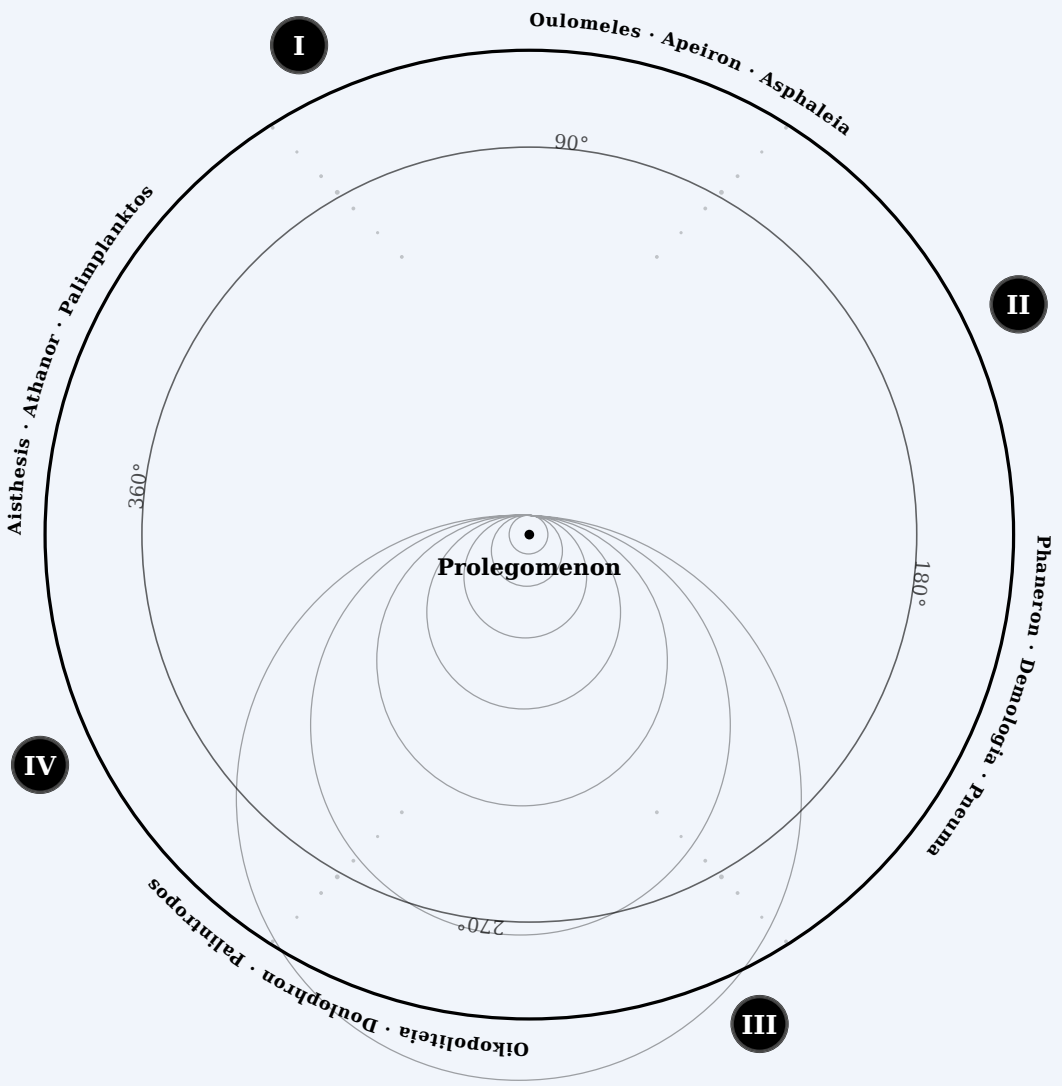
roman rivlis

the book of recursions

“The time is out of joint:
O cursed spite,
That ever I was born to set it right!”

– William Shakespeare, Hamlet (Act 1, Scene 5)

EQUATORIUM



AUTHOR'S NOTE ON REFERENCE AND PARTITION

Principle of Addressability.

This work does not employ pagination as a referential system. Page numbers are treated as contingent artifacts of layout rather than stable semantic coordinates. For addressability, the stable units are disc, azimuth (°) and phase (§) qualified by a minimum typed sigla ensemble.

Every phase is assigned exactly one disc siglum (⊗ ⊖ ⊙) that corresponds to conceptual orientation in the text. Sigla assignment is mandatory and forms part of the minimal addressability of the text. Sigla do not confer authority, priority, or evaluative status. They function solely as indicators of semantic coupling to invariant theoretical structures. All phases, regardless of siglum, remain equally citable and equally valid as discursive loci.

Mandatory sigla serve to make structural load explicit rather than implicit. They do not prescribe reading order, interpretive weight, or normative emphasis.

Primary Reference Structure.

The fundamental address of any passage is composed of the following ordered coordinates:

1. Disc — the primary enumerated phase regime of discursion
2. Azimuth (°) — a global angular bearing conserved across discs
3. Phase (§) — the atomic semantic unit of addressability

All further markers qualify, attest, or elaborate this locus but do not replace it.

A minimal reference therefore takes the form:

[Disc] · [Azimuth] · [Phase]

Incipit Qualification.

Where clarity or mnemonic precision is desired, a pericope may be further identified by its incipit (opening words).

Incipits function as semantic checksums and aids to recall; they are not structural identifiers and may be omitted without loss of referential integrity.

Example:

I · 30° · §12 - "Omnis determinatio est negatio"

Reader-Machine Interoperability Sigla.

A minimal set of optional qualifier sigla may be employed as interoperability annotations between reader and text. These sigla do not encode semantic content, structural load, or interpretive authority. They function as lightweight state markers, analogous to controlled vocabularies in knowledge organization systems, and may be ignored without loss of referential integrity.

Qualifier sigla annotate discursive operations affecting traversal, constraint, or deferral within the text. Their use is sparse and non-exhaustive; absence carries no implication. Where present, they may support both human navigation and machine-assisted reading without prescribing reading order, emphasis, or interpretation.

The available sigla are:

- ‡ CUT — marks a deliberate discontinuity in discursive flow
- ‡ CONSTRAIN — signals local binding where ambiguity would be structurally dangerous
- ↷ REPEAT — indicates intentional recurrence across distance or orientation
- ... DELAY — denotes deferred resolution with later payoff
- ⦿ TRAVERSE — invites non-linear traversal across loci
- ◻ SUSPEND — marks suspension of a regime without rhetorical closure

Qualifier sigla are optional and sparse; no disc carries more than seven such markers, and no pericope bears more than one.

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PROLEGOMENON · 0°



This work was written in no small part under the expectation that it would be deposited in time, and encountered when it would become useful. The stakes that generated this work are, in some ways, an accumulation of exposure to the polycrises of the late modern period: the destabilization of social coordination through technological rupture, ecological strain, the consolidation of capital into an exorbitant resource asymmetry, as well as the normalized perpetuity of conquest, subjugation, and genocide across the last century, and collapse of stable normativity that does not devolve into surveillance. For my own initial understanding, I labored to investigate why the late modern period felt extraordinarily fractured. There is a palpable sense that listening to people is increasingly costly to do, and contexts are increasingly no longer something that grounds an interaction, since they only intensify the distinction of friends and enemies.



Across the advent of the internet and the rapid industrialization of the market economy, what became especially apparent in its perplexity was the ostensive gap in how sensemaking occurs between people, and how systems relate to each other without concentrating damage

into individuals. I do not claim to have all of the answers to my own questions that drove this work, nor do I claim to speak for anybody in particular other than myself. That said, the work is a byproduct of these tensions that drive the current epoch and its conditions of immense scarcity and alienation. After a while, those tensions directed the questions underneath it all around the nature of time, the residue left behind by memory, the structuring of life under irreversible damage, and the conditions of shared intelligibility grounded in material survival.



This brings me to the statement of what this work explores generally. In broad strokes, this work is a phenomenology of loss, labor, and conflict, and explores the seams of how they interact with each other. The text is written from a place that concerns itself with the fracturing of sense in a contemporary era heavily mediated by velocity, capital, and reliance on the entanglement between technology and bureaucracy. In such a world, coherence is cheap to produce, but the exposure that comes with human-scale stakes and ecological residue is expensive to consume. The dominance of industry in this world comes at a price of constituting how we think, what we do, and how our lives are structured before we can even participate through interpretation and the formation of meaning from experience.



The work, across four discs, explores this question from different angles. The first disc defines what signs are, how meaning is facilitated and processed through coordination, and what are conditions for appearance. The second and third discs explore the stakes when the processes of coordination are constrained by history, memory, and the asymmetry of power upon which life is materially arranged and

symbolically mediated over time. The fourth disc explores how we process signs aesthetically and ritually in conditions of survival and grief. The work does not require a canonical traversal to complete the project, since the core themes are carried through different contextual environments, but the reader may navigate across the four discs in the order that compels them based on the domain.



The work is designed such that local comprehension does not require global mastery. Transitions between formal and narrative domains are marked by the $\ominus$ sigla for the purposes of signposting the domain that the reader is traversing into. This text is not a gospel and there is no temple to join through this project. For the reader entering this work, there is no expectation to accelerate through the text to consume as quickly as possible. The project is written to be studied, sat with, and occasionally returned to over deep spans of time. A reading experience here is designed to be inhabited, returned to, and navigated by whatever the reader needs at the time they reach for it in the text. This work does not proceed by linear proof, but by rotational exposure. For this reason, a reader is not expected to assimilate the entire construction in one encounter. Some sections within the four discs may lead with density of material and may present with opacity on first encounter. This opacity is a consequence of compression and does not imply the reader is being tested. The work is built so that partial entry remains meaningful. Understanding may accumulate by return and encounter, rather than through stepwise advancement.



With the acceleration of a world that upholds the individual as the primary atomic unit in a world driven by velocity and throughput, the late modern period is unique insofar as the perceived incredulity

of vulnerable and honest interaction is increasingly normalized as common. Silence in such a world is completely intolerable, because more often than not we are forced to live with it as a replacement for repair. As the world consolidates around acceleration and absence, the deteriorating grammar of a shared world leaves us abandoned to our own devices by rendering the conscience as a privatized asset. In response to this fragmentation, I have endeavored to write in relation to presence and structure. I trust the reader will endeavor to read the work through a similar lens.

“In practical life we are compelled to follow what is
most probable; in speculative thought we are
compelled to follow truth.”
– Baruch Spinoza, Letter to Hugo Boxel (1674)

disc one

OULOMELES · 30°



The late Roman consul known as Boethius, who pondered endlessly on the providence of fate and man, was quoted in the opening of the Summa Theologica by Aquinas as follows: “Thou Who governst this universe by mandate eternal.” Governance, in practice, assumes mutual constraint in a reciprocal environment. There are no absolute frames that claim finality on reason or experience in contrast to the notion of an eternal mandate. Finality appears only where living activity is no longer admissible. In order to navigate this tension, we proceed by distilling the substrate of life to its fundamental building blocks: the emergent property of stabilized transversal from temporal, symbolic, and material regularities. The following framework endeavors to expose the structure of these relations, and evaluate the continuity of living systems at scale. Further along into this work, we will start by slowly composing the building blocks of a system, logical rules, physical constraints, and the conditions for metaphysical primitives that may persist across structures.



As a foundation, we will define the process of sign transmission and sign lineage. In order to effectively lay the semiotic groundwork,

we will need to distinguish between a sign that is conscious and a sign that is merely signified. As a definition of consciousness, we entail immediately localized experiences that are made temporarily sensible. Consciousness is materialized in following the forms of socially organized activity, be they regularized in tool use, habits of inference, institutional rule mediation, and the reproduction of sign systems. Each experience proceeds as a unique informational encoding within a continual gradient of all possible moves or configurations across mnemonic context. This encoding situates each experience within the individual or collective through which it becomes temporarily sensible, and thus each experience contains a kernel of contextual self-reference. Conscious experience is the localized appearance of systemic activity under constraint. The self, as a presentation of an activity system, is shaped both by the friction it does not choose and the inherited practices of how it interacts with that friction. The habitual activity loop of a living system stabilizes when conscious activity incorporates self-reference as reflexivity. When a living system is dynamically coupled to its environment through interaction, reflexivity arises once the system includes itself among the variables through which that coupling is regulated. Self-reference then becomes second-order: the system, embedded in its environment, samples and regulates its own activity as part of its ongoing interaction with that environment. The depth of recursion within this self-referential loop is not fixed, but expands or contracts according to the complexity of the system and its environment, as well as the capacity for a system to metabolize contradiction. Reflexivity is not assumed here to be an isolated interior computation of privatized neurology or abstract memory compression, but a distributional activity emerging from macroscopic environmental pressure, mesoscopic social coordination, and the patterned cultural-historical embedding within which activity unfolds.

A human being is defined, in body and mind, by their felt significance of misalignment and loss coupled to memory and habit. For humans to have been conscious at all, they carry a residual continuity of themselves that does not resolve into closure or dissolve through experience. In contrast to fully specifiable machines or inanimate objects, conscious life assumes some sensitivity to wounding by the world that reorganizes them into either storing their strain or sharing the load of it. Whether alone or jointly with others, the reflexive properties of consciousness imply a permanent exposure to how life unfolds, where the implications of action bear inescapable consequence. The capacity to update reflexive interiority is bounded by the embodied, historical, and relational constraints within which reflexivity is materially sustained. The psyche evolves through the regulatory dynamics of extension, inhibition, and redirection of imposed action that precipitates into repeatable thought. The constitutive encounter with conflict and heteronomous resistance produces cognition as the sediment of survived agonism. The patterning of thought is constituted by how it metabolizes its history and folds ongoing regulated action back in on itself. The reflexivity of consciousness, along these lines, evolves as a distributed network property through joint labor, institutional mediation, and social practices. Cognition as a whole may be defined as an environmentalized residue of biogenic and technogenic processes, scaling with the stability and magnitude of adaptation to historically precipitated activity. Both biological processes, and the technologies that are used to mediate life, shape the production of cognition by mutual reinforcement without either organism or technology downstream from the other. As network magnitude and coordination deepens under stable conditions, reflexive capacity may extend, though its locus becomes less centralized.



Through this exposure, the reflexive capacities of all embedded systems are jointly tested under mutual regulation. How a living system

responds to turbulence, whether banded together with others or fragmented, depends inevitably on the structure of its history and sedimentation of memory. Over time, reflexive continuity gives rise to narrative coherence, anchoring subjecthood as a local stabilization within a dynamic of heteronomous pressure and reconfiguration. What distinguishes a living system from a generically material structure is its capacity to modulate the permeability of its boundaries through reflexive regulation. A living system is capable of adjusting its boundary in response to the constraint landscape in which it is embedded. Moreso, reflexively mediated systems are shaped by the evolving permeability of their boundaries, to the extent that the system can viably reconfigure its own trajectory over time. In modulating their boundary permeability and redistributing constraint pressure, reflexive systems dynamically participate in the directional settlement of perturbation and constraint pressure across time. We define a system as the medium of how scale-dependent knowledge is produced when no method or mode of cognition is admissible on its own. Systems configured by local phenomena are modes of organization under conditions of interaction, by which boundary conditions produce structural development. Disequilibrium and discontinuous rupture function as constitutive diagnostics of the structure within which systems are embedded. At the appropriate scale, agonism reveals whether an organizational system expands through reconfiguration or contracts through dysregulation, relative to the accumulation of pressure and the system's survivable tolerance.



As a minimal formal scaffold, we will define a sign as a routing and signal processing lineage that negotiates between persistence and modification. Signs survive in part by balancing between propagation capacity and infrastructural stability. For example, an organism or meme that optimizes for virality and transmission speed may lose both its context and a stable support underneath it. On the other hand, if

an organism remains too rigidified to the point of insulation, it may not propagate sufficiently enough to evolve or survive. Signs are made concrete, for instance, by the real material stakes they are exposed to through lived process. Whether a human realizes it, development is occurring beneath the surface without their awareness or intervention, and their decision to orient themselves in a direction is one that they either consciously participate in to or be swept unconsciously by circumstance. A sign distributes load by branching across contexts relative to transmission and durability of signaling. In addition to this, a sign stabilizes over its history through recomposition in the environment that signs propagate in. Along these lines, signs are not primarily defined by meaning or interpretive scope. At minimum, a sign is defined by materialized instantiation, symbolic significance and variation of representational structure, and the parameterization of time.



Together, the composition of time, matter, and symbol constitutes a sign as a minimal coordinated unit under transformation. Signs that participate in semiotic coordination are constitutive of two types of semiosis: Reflexive semiosis where a sign includes itself in its coupled regulation and boundary modulation, and non-reflexive semiosis only at a structural level. A living sign system (e.g. plant or animal life) conveys reflexive semiosis since can actively participate in semiosis by actively regulating constraint, modulate permeability of boundaries, and actively update their internal state in response to perturbation. A non-reflexive sign, such a fossil record, static symbol, or a crystallized pattern, is still semiotic since it can reflect and transmit significance, as well as encode invariants across its history, but it cannot actively reorganize its coordination structure. A sign without reflexivity cannot self-modulate or actively coregulate with other living sign systems, and therefore cannot co-participate in the semiosphere even if their significance evolves over time.



With time as parameter, the temporal lineage determines the coordination protocol between matter and symbol, without any of these variables being metaphysically primary over the other. What this means, in practice, is that semiosis is a carrier of a time-indexed material effect. Meaning is thus not a primitive, and that neither symbol nor matter is primary. The creation of meaning is, by consequence, derived structure from the coordination of time and matter. The process of semiosis occurs when a symbol undergoes a time-indexed transformation of a material substrate, which indicates that symbols encode how time parameterizes material transformation. All signs are treated as internalized structures of symbolized coordination between time and matter, all of which carry information through their distinct context.



For the purposes of specifying an ontology, we would distinguish between the purpose of being and becoming, as well as the cost of both. We can conceive of being as mimesis, insofar as being is defined as a mimetic process of consciousness. By describing being as a mimetic process, we are not implying that life tends to only imitate life, but that life, through its interaffective and diffusive nature, tends to imitate self-discovery through relationships that it builds across time with other beings. Charles Horton Cooley describes the concept of looking-glass self along these lines, specifying that the self is not prior to social interaction, and the formation of identity is a feedback effect of coordinated social activity. Subject formation does not automatically authorize itself an exception of sovereign interiority given the feedback circuit of environmental interaction. Personhood, by definition, is temporally extensive and socially stabilized as a cultural and historical configuration of relationships traced by a sign lineage, and only becomes quantified downstream into atomic units of data as

a category error. Mimesis is how we conceptualize the reproductive mechanism of a sign system, and being is a stable fixed point of epistemic evolution between sign systems. Every substrate is capable of navigating continuous complexity through iterative coordination. Living systems are always participating in the same process of self-discovery under the constraints of finite relationships and interaction with others. The mimetic process, in a sense, isn't copying a discrete behavior, idea, or belief from an external object back to an external subject, but is more about mirroring the continuous internal process of self-inquiry under metabolic load. Coordination, at its minimal definition, is an episodic hinge in a memory-dependent continuum. Along these lines, what is retained and symbolized through language and labor does so with the understanding that memory is carried, and sometimes mutated or lost. Ludwig Noiré specifies that language is joint labor produced by coordinated social activity, in which meaning stabilizes through the material logistics of social practice. Language, in this sense, is infrastructural rather than merely expressive.



The concept of a metaphysics of substance can be traced to the Latin root structure substantia, which more closely aligns with how Spinoza defines God or Nature as a single substance with eternal essence and infinite attributes. Even within Scholasticism, Duns Scotus carefully distinguished between haecceitas (what determines the irreducible property that this is Aristotle specifically) and quidditas (what determines that Aristotle is human). Classical Latin struggled to capture the Greek term ousia (being), using both essentia and substantia, but neither preserved the participial force of the original. For the Greeks, ousia was strictly ontological, derived from the feminine participle ousa of eimi (to be), which did not conflate the process of being with the properties of beings, a confusion that became endemic in later Latin and Anglophone metaphysics. This diverges sharply from the Cartesian res cogitans, which treats mind as a

thinking substance. Augustine's use of substantia emerged from the mistranslation of Greek hypostasis (individual subsistence) as Latin substantia, creating terminological confusion in Trinitarian theology: where Greeks said "one ousia, three hypostases," Latin inverted this to "one substantia, three personae." Prior to Aristotle's reification of ousia as substance, the term epiousion appears exactly twice in the New Testament papyri, both only in the Lord's Prayer and nowhere else in Greek literature. As a hapax legomenon, its meaning must be reconstructed from morphology: epi- (toward, for) + ousia (process of being). When fully reconstructed, epiousion becomes "bread-for-being" or "being-enabling bread", shifting the concept of being away from individual substantiation toward a shared semiotic process of being as togetherness through the communal ritual of breaking bread. Bread does not signify a commodity (abstract thing one consumes) in this approach, but a commons (concrete medium we share through practice) which one resolves through infrastructure that facilitates the shared ritual as a commons. This derivation of being more closely approximates ancient Mesopotamian customs of how grains were distributed through temple stores, which connected how people lived to the common infrastructure that facilitated their conviviality. If one were to consider a philosophical domain for the question of what does it mean to be, the prior assumption to classifying this question as ontology would be derivative from the framework of epiousiology. In this framework, being collapses into becoming through enactive participation with others, rather than through linear theological wordplay or substance metaphysics.



The principle of identity according to Afrikan Spir ($A \equiv A$) asserts that logical identity, insofar as anything that is ontologically real, is singularized and self-identical. Along these lines, reality is logically contradictory as a guiding principle as it appears in time, recomposition, causation, and becoming as an experiential process. Contradiction is a

diagnostic of what accumulates without resolution, since the world of experience is structurally inconsistent with the concept of reality as a whole. By living within the structural necessity of internal agonism and contradiction, then the lawfulness of phenomena, whether substantial or legal, remains a secondary and fragile artifact of depletion to the contradictions of reality. Laws may be understood as temporarily stabilized artifacts of survived repetition, under irreversible accumulation of contradictions that have yet to circulate dynamically across a system, even if those contradictions mobilize defect or stress. The logical discrepancies of the world do not require explanations or moral absolutes, only coordinated circulation up to where boundaries live. In this sense, experience is marked by becoming and causal succession, and thought is marked by identity and unicity of being, and both of these poles are irreconcilable; that is, thought exposes what experience cannot be.



As a concept, being is not ontologically defined by unity (a bulk whole that eventually reconciles through synthesis), nor univocity (difference is primary and identity derives from it), but by unicity: a singularized process in which there is a standard of being that does not exhaust into becoming. Identity is something that is temporarily stabilized through cultural and historical patterning that one is embedded in. This posture rejects the idea that distinction is sufficient to be intelligible or stable. The direction of our activity requires a path that cannot be decided without friction. Under the conditions of irreversibility and heteronomous pressure, we are forced to continuously negotiate our own persistence through ongoing regulated action. Being arises in practice as a process against which persistence and transformation are bounded through action and survival. Beyond this, being is objectually defined by fields of singularized occurrences that eventually regularize into pattern without a presupposed convergence or synthesis, and these singular instantiations persist insofar as they do not collapse

into nullity through interaction. In effect, Jakob Boehme argues within the costly wound of internal differentiation that becoming is ultimately a strenuous process. In contrast, Spinoza's project of unity, in contrast, locates contradiction only in modes that modify a self-adherent substance. Beyond either of these frames, unicity is what remains when adaptive repetition, rather than reconciliation or difference, is the foundational condition of survived life.



If we are to follow from the assertion that substance metaphysics and ontology were translation errors, then the Western paradigm is also running on a misclassification of practiced knowledge and the composition of truth. Epiousiology recognizes that communal ritual practice is epistemologically prior to propositional logic as the substrate of cognitive architecture, shifting questions of ontology away from learning what being is and then applying it to an older Presocratic understanding of practice as a mnemonic site where being happens, and the concept of being itself derives from the extension of enactive knowledge. Epiousiology situates the question of being within the practice of breaking bread and the maintenance of the bread oven on the land it sits on; that is, existence persists through a shared bread oven in which repetition, timing, and care determine whether anything edible can still nourish the world. In general, the competing postures of Greek philosophy are historically coalesced in the late modern period under the framework of alethiology: the patterning of truth as how knowledge is disclosed and circulated in practice, rather than how knowledge is privately deposited and codified in centralized adjudicative authority. Alethiology proceeds from the Ancient Greek word *aletheia*, which more closely translates to disclosure, and contrasts with its antonym *lethe* which more closely translates to forgetting, rooted in the ancient mythology of the river Lethe where those who drink its waters forget their lives.



In this larger context, the nature of truth concerns not with knowledge as how to know something, or as a bludgeon to discipline those unfit to know, but as something more primordial: truth is the lived process of remembering, where historical and cultural context becomes the skeleton of memory given the duration of knowledge that transubstantiates between generations. Truth is thus a spectrum rooted in the binding of memory and historical understanding, going as far as the arrow of time carries it through use and decaying when forgotten. While Greek philosophy is often retroactively grouped under an alethiological banner, the operative criterion of truth deployed onward is dokimological: truth is not that which is revealed, but that invariant which thermally endures pressure testing under stress. Form is never decided in advance, only negotiated until something survivable appears across deformations in media res. Beyond this, the lighting dispensed through revelation is irrelevant if truth cannot be struck with a hammer without breaking, regardless of the visibility of scarring in the process. The truth is what metal remembers through the furnace, and the knowledge that was forged under the resistance of heat but without the imposition of measurability. Composed together with epiousiology, the content of truth becomes how we discover the continuum and dissipation of knowledge through each other. The content of one's truth may not necessarily be accurate in expression, but the context that this truth sits on is always true. The materialized activity of memory therein explores the boundaries of what must withstand in order to close the gap that is normally filled by what is signified or narrated by interaction with the world.



The Islamic philosopher Mulla Sudra does not describe being as a static substance (as has been the common interpretation in the post-Enlightenment world) but as a gradient that intensifies its

contradictions, where dynamics drive the structure of ontology. Thus, we can conceptualize of being not as "material substance then modes" but as the arrow of time that parameterizes the transformations of contingent purpose. The early rationalists, such as Spinoza and Descartes, filtered their accounts of knowledge through the axiom that every definition and every clear and distinct idea is true. There is a subtle hierarchy implied by this framework, in which "clear and distinct" becomes a stand-in for propositional purity, or sitting in the dimension of abstract logos, removed from ideas drafted in practice by conscious experience. The content and the context depend entirely on how the content is expressed, or if the content only reflects the context we want to accept, and not so much on whether the content itself is necessarily a reflection of how relationships in the world appear. By emphasizing only the *res cognitans*, we actually emphasize only a slice of what is expressed in the entirety of our lived experiences, our relationships to people and ideas, and our evolving perceptual frames. Knowledge is reduced to abstraction of isolated logical expressions of truth as the primary register in this worldview. However, concepts themselves are evolutionary organisms that one cannot collapse into logical proposition without tracing the lineage of ideas, how they mutate, their inherited assumptions, what content the form carries in transmission, what was lost in translation, and how one traces provenance in patterns of ideas. We can adequately trace the lineages of concepts and their formal distillations through entrainment to context, structure, power dynamics, philological decay, sedimentation, and semiotic drift. This is the opposite of deconstruction, because it requires the perceptual attunement to take the structure and lineage of a concept seriously rather than reduce semiosis to a subjective frame of textual reference.



Concepts in philosophy are bricks insofar as you can throw them and they survive impact, and if they don't, they're just information. The Spanish philosopher, Jose Ortega y Gasset, argues in this tradition in

a similar manner, by proposing in his self-proclaimed ratiovitalism that “I live, therefore I am”, inverting the Cartesian hierarchy that the world must be reasoned with before it can be lived in. Our perspicuity in life is rational because it is vital, but contrary to Ortega y Gasset who argues that culture is impersonal, we recognize that culture is convivial, and thereby by one’s ancestral history, we deepen the space of admissibility that one reasons in. In his *Meditations on Hunting*, Ortega y Gasset distinguishes human life from other animal life by way of what he describes as occupations or involuntarily rituals of obligation they do not choose. In this sense, deontology is a juridical filter that specifies what obligations are admissible as mandate and which ones are not. Whereas involuntary obligations contract the space of admissible activity, a voluntarily assumed ritual expands it, not by removing constraints, but by stabilizing them through lived practice. Ortega y Gasset highlights what is admissible from our own experiences: the most immediate register of knowledge is that by which we live, and it is through the plurality of our experiences that we point to each unique context clue in the larger contextual ecosystem that constitutes coherence. In determining “life is a petty thing unless it is moved by the indomitable urge to extend its boundaries,” Ortega y Gasset contracts the admissibility of convivial interaction by locating the problem of stagnation in the mass complicity of humanity, whereas we argue that resolution of institutional pathology drives the generative tension of life towards its fuller possibility space. Such a tension is confined by reducing the notion of inseparability purely towards distrust of the collective and not towards transforming the horizon that the collective lives in. From where Descartes begins with solitary thought, and Ortega y Gasset begins with solitary life, we proceed from the notion that living is the condition of admissible knowledge, and we contrast the original Cartesian cogito: *vivendo verum fit* (through living, the true becomes.)

The vitalism of the Spanish philosophical canon inadvertently positioned itself against other vitalist currents in Europe. Between the integrative exchange of cultures and intellectual traditions in pre-Catholic Andalusia between the 7th century and the 15th century, and the hinge of Don Quixote in the 17th century as both literary and philosophical canon, Spanish philosophy retained a historical memory of human-scale philosophical inquiry, the tension of tragedy and absurdism, and ironic detachment from grandiose world-historic narratives that were more common in Germany and Russia at the turn of the 19th century. The ironic posture against grandiosity served as both a blessing and a curse when you do need transhistorical ethics to create vitalizing structure, and nothing belies this irony more than the Spanish legacy of its colonization of the Americas and dissolution of *convivencia* following the 1492 Spanish Inquisition. Following the *convivencia*, the methodology of philosophy as dialogue and synthesis persisted in Spain through the philosophical canon of figures such as Ortega y Gasset, but also the tragic existentialism of Miguel de Unamuno and the process metaphysics of Xavier Zubiri. Zubiri is perhaps the most radical of the Madrid School figures in his time, articulating a philosophy of reality as a sentient intelligence that is embodied through coordinating within reality. Zubiri describes the whole of reality as “*de suyo*” (of itself), implying that reality has things with independent phenomena but only through how we access our relationship to those things, not by mirroring or constructing them through mental processes.



Spain was arriving at an integration of rationalism and vitalism by their own felt historical necessity, which was summarily crushed by the fascism of Franco and revitalized through the Spanish anarchist currents throughout the 20th century. The CNT-FAI and Catalanian anarchists understood that the intuitions of applied coordination through organized revolutionary struggle were the only enduring

buttress against fascism. In contrast, other parts of the continent in Northern and Eastern Europe, through the empirio-criticism of Mach and Avenarius, the creative anomie of Guyau, the aristocratic individualism of Nietzsche, the process philosophy of Whitehead, and the empiriomonism of Bogdanov, were developing separate flavors of an integration between empiricism and vitalism, by which the world could expand through the process of lived experience. These intuitions, albeit predisciplinary in method rather than insight, require a more specific scaffolding that does not reduce ontology to either reason or experience as primary, but as a continuous vital process of coordination between self and system at all scales as self-organizing substrate, where patterns emerge as convivial structural necessity and as creative emergence. Reality then becomes an immanent social sentence mediated by feedback loops through the lens of shared life and inherent autonomy, processual and structured while also scale-appropriate, through the irreducibility of coordinated social process and systemic dynamism.



The substrate of logic is always material, and thus can only be used as if chiseling a statue. The form of reason, to borrow from Tarkovsky's lexicon, is sculpted in time. The symbolic largesse of the statue is only as meaningful as it is rehearsable by its audience. The problem of all moments in time is to responsibly generalize from our particular experiences to the undulation of patterns in reality. The question really is: How do we infer systemic meaning from individual context, and how do we validate meaning through process as opposed to observation? The goal is not to project our normative interpretations of patterns as justified true belief, but to mutually determine the positive assessments of reality to construct a shared narrative of what actually is. To firmly understand a more complete and accurate reformulation of the logocentric view of knowledge, we postulate: every experience is true, because the lived context of conscious experience is always true.

The earth of privileged judges, who remain incapable of modeling the complexity of the world, maintains that it can only grasp reality through revolving the world around itself, and thus we propose that the tides of experience precipitate throughout all life in the endless expanse. The structure of the world actually governs the constraints of the planet regardless of the attempts by the living to claim themselves as masters over the earth, based on the hearsay that they rationalize to master the fate of anyone but themselves. In the spirit of how Evald Ilyenkov describes the ideal, a generalizable practice only develops through the continuity of concrete activity, and concrete activity only becomes intelligible through generalized practice. What Ilyenkov calls the ideal, in this context, is the field that mediates practice and abstraction, in which normativity is located in the capacity to reconfigure the form of activity.



John Sowa notes an observation that Albert Einstein shared with Jacques Hadamard in 1945 that determined the scope of reason beyond binary propositional representation into a more diagrammatic map of lived reality: "The words or the language, as they are written or spoken, do not seem to play any role in my mechanism of thought. The psychical entities which seem to serve as elements in thought are certain signs and more or less clear images which can be voluntarily reproduced and combined...The above-mentioned elements are, in my case, of visual and some of muscular type. Conventional words or other signs have to be sought for laboriously only in a secondary stage, when the mentioned associative play is sufficiently established and can be reproduced at will." Within associative systems of reason, we may define avallence as a property of the system itself, and is defined by the heuristic of one's own understanding that actively restricts the frame of who may speak credibly on their behalf or in relation to a group at large they are involved in. Avallence in social practice arises by determining that one's truth is automatically invalidated

based on who they are, what they argue for, why they argue for it, and their impulse towards inquiry. Avalence as a property requires some pattern of interaction, and a persistent enforcement of rank between two people based on how they negotiate tension in conflict. Avalence operationalizes the paradox of tolerance introduced by Karl Popper: these are truths that persist by invalidating others and insisting that there is an equality of coherence values in a discursive arena, which completely erases the context that such truths are filtered in. However, in the shade cast by the paradox of tolerance, Rudolf Carnap admits the principle of tolerance, which stipulates that logic and language admit no prohibitions as the syntax (the rules) of logic is determined prior to a statement or proposition. The rules of thought constitute structure, which cannot validate the creation of thought unless the hinge of admissibility itself is adjudicated by an external sovereign. Avalence is the condition of enforced prohibition on admissibility as a hinge convention, in which rules of thought are upheld for some but invalidated for others, and by doing so, the space of rules is already conditioned in practice but denied in abstraction.



Interactions that insist on a performance of one's self-worthiness, or having to demonstrate the personal dignity of others who are categorically invalidated for being who they are towards others, are all practicing degrees of avalence. These are not just invalidations of discursive truth in an arena, but encompass the systemic invalidation of shared interactive load distribution, regardless of resources, education, access, or content. Avalence imposes separation on structure and content, where one needs to perform the right sentence to have value, even though the realization may be they were never meant to be externally validated at all, and instead must themselves be told that if they are hungry, their hunger is invalid and must be apprehended by another person who has more purchase on reason. Sequentiality becomes the truth heuristic, which privileges claims to truth based on

how soon someone accesses and controls truth, while systematically devaluing the truth of others who are marginalized or happen to be born later. Avalent properties in truth systems maintain that truth is an extractive exercise that one maintains to control another, as opposed to collaborative inquiry that generates shared understanding and shared curiosity towards a more complete picture of the world. Any truth system that determines validity of alethiology by externally excluding any category of truth based on identity and presentation, or by privileging one species over another, risks corruption through avalent properties in the organized living system. Nothing ever persists because it is true; rather, things only persist until they begin to fall apart.



Ludwig Wittgenstein's sketch of a use theory of meaning casts a shadow over the durability of language as a tool, in which ordinary language is never fully fixed but enacted, and we extend this insight to indicate that language is also embodied. Words and truths functionally gain meaning when circulated and shared, and they only acquire their gravitas from the relational structure and local interactions of information. Wittgenstein suggests in his late career work, *On Certainty*, about the use value of propositions in mathematical notation: "Knowledge in mathematics: Here one has to keep on reminding oneself of the unimportance of the 'inner process' or 'state' and ask "Why should it be important? What does it matter to me?" What is interesting is how we use mathematical propositions." Meaning is only gained when we translate our experiences and establish collaboration around the problem as opposed to how we interpret a specific equation or language rule to assert dominion over the rules of the problem itself. Wittgenstein is dealing with a world in which meaning is just confused because of informational gaps, but the rules of admissibility and use go far beyond how much concepts bear meaning when assigned a function. Admissibility and use are prelinguistic in the sense that they

apply to tools, cultural lineage, ecological resources, material norms, and social activity before the value of a propositional representation. The conditions for collaborative sense-making are systematically eroded by authoritarian forces beyond ourselves locally. Meaning gets actively eviscerated by these systemic vectors, not confused, because the process of semiosis depends on the space of admissible social interaction and the rules that apply.



Philosophical methods are instead useful as a surgical intervention that are diffused pedagogically where they are missing, as an anodyne for restoring the capacity towards repair wherever boundaries are trespassed, collapsed, suppressed by authority, contained, or sequestered away from any breakdown in metabolic throughput. Form follows thought, language, and reciprocal interaction as the engine of longevity in the world that negotiates joint biosemiotic process. The ground of structural preservation, through shared relational mechanisms of translation and collaboration, is what exists as a tool that makes contextual exchange possible. The discernment one practices when others are impervious to information and ironically detached from sense-making is what becomes part of this process, given the systematically conditioned cascade towards entire generations of moral anesthetic. The *On Certainty* side of Wittgenstein's catalog is rarely emphasized in contrast to the *Tractatus* and his middle period work of *Philosophical Investigations*, which defangs philosophy as therapeutic intervention. This oversight emerges partially because the *On Certainty* period loops back around to the same intuitions that the pragmatist philosophers such as Dewey and Peirce observed, which scraps the foundationalism and representationalism of the entire 20th century analytic paradigm in favor of a philosophy of language and meaning through shared interactive use and coordinated activity. Wittgenstein begins to understand late in his career that logic does not come from above, but is embedded in the continuity of everyday practice, as well as

how certainty is not given but earned through coordinated activity prior to language and proposition. The skeptical posture emerges in both the continental and analytic traditions through designating representation as primary, as opposed to the structured parity that emerges from developing pattern language through reality and not around it through representation.



If being signifies the grammar rules of how coordination is established, then becoming signifies how coordination instantiates a pattern language over time. Being is the syntax of coordination, defining how grammar rules form relationships, but does not produce meaning by itself and does not dictate content, only structure how we stabilize through coherence. Becoming is the semantics of this process, exploring how meaning evolves over time through use and how living systems learn eurhythmia, styles of recurrence, how shared grammar moves, and how the trajectories of these patterns are shaped by the balancing of regularity. Being can constrain the intelligibility of coordination patterns and all possible moves that can be made in a semantic play, but cannot generate new rules in isolation to extend the semantics of grammar rules. Becoming does not signify an excess at all along these lines, because becoming comes with an expensive cost, a symmetry to be broken, and a threshold cannot be willed into reality by our will, only survived without returning. The process of becoming and transformation is a process that thickens through contradiction repair because it is bounded, mediated, and procedurally accountable amongst participants. In the sense that Ilya Prigogine references dissipative systems as the physical expression of becoming, he observes that becoming is the condition of irreversibility, as the price we pay from diverging away from equilibrium in practice. Adjacently, Cornelius Castoriadis indicates that society is self-instituting, and when institutions sediment, alienation is produced as selection environment: "Alienation therefore appears as instituted,

in any case as heavily conditioned by institutions (the word being taken here in its broadest sense, including in particular the structure of the real relations of production).” Society is what instantiates the creation of institutions according to Castoriadis, and consequently our institutions constrain and condition future activity for as long as those institutions may survive. Becoming in a such an environment, in an associative configuration of living systems, is a regulated self-modification where failure to metabolize contradiction subtracts from the survival of social formations bounded by the structures they inherit. Becoming operates under the constraints of a stochastic and probabilistic process that is mediated in part by the discernment of metabolic load between path dependency and instability. Along these lines, becoming is a processual mediation of continuity and modification conserved over time. Structures can extend continuity by exporting entropy as common practice, but becoming is not always a process that occurs deterministically or ubiquitously. There is not an assumed identity formation that chains becoming to a process; rather, becoming names a negotiation in a survivability envelope between what must persist and what must change in how a system redistributes load across time without exhausting the capacity to continue or modify within the environment.



In the Science of Logic, Hegel describes the interactive dynamics between living systems through the form of Chemism, by which an undifferentiated form seeks to differentiate itself through irreversible kinetic reaction. Hegel distinguishes Chemism as posterior to Mechanism (how parts interface with parts) and anterior to Teleology (recombination and recomposition emerging from the regulated interaction), distinguishing Chemism as the first encounter where participants in an interaction are internally changed and stabilize relationally through mutual process. Any logical framework proceeding from this sequence along these lines assumes that chemical process precedes

descriptive testimony in defining the dynamics of reality, in which a person seeks affinity under continuous movement, filters interaction through boundaries, realizes that transformation is non-invertible, and stabilizes when a determined form can no longer tolerate a prior contradiction to survive without recomposition. What Hegel describes as "Begriff" or Concept – that is, the dissolution of being into becoming, and universality into particularity, by a constant eurhythmic self-moving persistence preceding form – is the invariant constant that structures all activity. In contrast to how rhythm often conveys cadence and repetition, eurhythmia conveys cadence or repetition that is proportionally fit in the system that a process is situated in. In this regard, rhythm carries a stabilizing balance and attunement through mutual interaction, as opposed to raw cyclic periodicity that rhythm on its own conveys. Adjacently, when the process of becoming is read through the *Urpflanze* that Goethe describes, the same biomorphic organ through each of its component parts evolves through variation in stages of morphogenesis. Nature is something that becomes intelligible by allowing itself to unfold, as well as allowing itself to continue reorganizing itself in relation to conditions of disrepair and maturation. Within Hegelian phenomenology, the concept of *Verdopplung* (doubling) skips the notion that cognition is something used by a subject, and instead articulates that cognition begins only when the activity of life can no longer coincide with itself, bifurcating through the split. Signification of meaning and sense-making is something that processually occurs where the bulk infrastructure of cognition has already failed to resolve.



Without the capacity for negation, cognition does not evolve, because the agonism towards contradiction is constitutive for the conditions for any intelligibility at all. Cognition is something that occurs because explanation no longer suffices for activity, and the possibility for ontogenesis occurs when prior states are untenable without

metabolizing contradiction. What we understand as material “things” or “form” resemble more like constant stabilized traces that are temporarily configured into recognizable patterns. This is a determinate self-differentiation with a radically indeterminate horizon, that is structured towards a bias based on the total circumstances of all possible compositions. Sentient life is driven not by form or matter but by self-animating processes of mutable shapes leaving patterns of residue under constraints, in which all life is driven by an emergent morphodynamic trace. Conscious activity thus resembles less of a spectator in this process and instead a process recognizing its transformation as constant throughout all movement, and connecting its transformation to its activity. In F.W.J. Schelling’s work, he poses the pre-conceptual and productive structure of the Unvordenkliche (unprethinkable ground) as a constrained, but dynamical environment anterior to thought that operates as the source of being and the possibility of freedom at all. The groundless substrate Schelling ideates on more closely resembles a pre-structured field of admissibility, which can be survived through motion but not through deduction. Along these lines, Schelling deploys the ground as an undifferentiated, pre-conceptual, yet negative possibility space; however, in the sense that Schelling uses the term, negation implies a real and active force prior to any positive determinations or differentiations, in contrast to an inert void. Additionally, the ground is undifferentiated insofar as differentiation has yet to occur, but the environment is structured by intensity, pressure, and tension. The negatively determined environment can only be inferred actively through process by determining which paths have failed to survive up to this point, and which movements are still possible in a constrained environment of incompatibilities. Cognition is something we produce in tandem when living is no longer enough to survive.

The French Epicurean philosopher Jean-Marie Guyau precedes this tension in contrast to the vitalism of the anti-rational will best represented by his contemporaries in France qua Henri Bergson and Georges Sorel. For Guyau, anomie as he defined it was a tethering of oneself to generative creative potential, by way of developing objective standards for morality regardless of whether that morality crumbles around them. Guyau's vitalism inverts Durkheim's concept of anomie, by which Durkheim diagnoses anomie as pathological decay of social norms during periods of significant social change. Durkheim's posture on anomie proceeds from his own contrast to Gabriel Tarde, by which Durkheim takes the position that the social order is given as an exterior and coercive moral force, whose legitimacy depends on irreducibility to microdynamic processes. Tarde takes the position that sociality is generated through interactive processes of invention and imitation, such that social order does not require (and cannot be reduced exclusively to) a predetermined exterior authority. Tarde's sociological approach does not begin with an individual as *sui generis*, emphasizing that societies are developed from circulatory processes, not unlike chemical reactions and diffusions, and structure residually stabilizes over time through repetition and imitation of pattern language formation. Although initially presented as a contradiction to Tarde's microdynamic approach to sociology, the social facts thesis comes laicized from the work of the counter-Enlightenment royalist Louis de Bonald, who argues society is ontologically prior to individuals, and the social order is what gives the individual legitimacy. Crucially, Durkheim does not replace the core of this approach at all, merely keeping the argument that social order acts upon individuals coercively but removing the theological residue of authority and moral force. Bonald was upfront that authority can be purely bureaucratic and grammatical even if dressed in Catholic hierarchy, and Durkheim merely modernizes the claim with scientism and deletes the theology in order to preserve the legitimacy of the bureaucratic nation state. Contrary to Durkheim, social facts are dependent on admissible frameworks

despite the reflective stimulus to interpret whether such frameworks are operative under an inherited lattice of rules.



Guyau's vitalism developed separately from Nietzsche and also contrasts heavily with Nietzsche's project by not reducing emergent vitality to iconoclasm of self against society. Nietzsche's vitalism is far more agonistic and assertive against society as an obstacle, placing the individual in a creative struggle of expanding through overcoming herd morality. In contrast, Guyau doesn't treat self and society as independent phenomena, locating convivial social organization and relationships as the medium for vital flourishing rather than positioning the individual as the revolt against social decay. Guyau does not bracket ethics within a particular knowledge domain, nor does he diagnose historical rupture as inherently dangerous, and instead recognizes that the ethical dimension of life is fundamentally situated in how living systems interact. Guyau is concerned with the adaptive potential of morality to build relationships with others, and build ethical standards for moral action through the realm of shared moral ideas. Ethics is fundamentally dynamic and convivial in the way Guyau describes it, because he rejects the diametric tension of science and art as necessary, insisting on the fecundity of life through creation, sociality, and what life communicates in the world. In writing for *Popular Science* in 1884, Guyau rebukes the critiques from writers like Keats that Newton had sterilized chromatics and art through the advancement of science: "Color is eternal. No Newton, with his explanations of the aërial arch of the rainbow, will be able to break it up or to do away with it. The sense of color has even grown since antiquity. The Greeks were without words to describe a considerable number of colors which we distinguish; and their artists had certainly not as fine perceptions of color as Titian or Delacroix. Mankind seems to have been all the time growing more sensible to the language of tints, and to all the plays of light. Here, certainly, is an open road for art." We

know because the concept of color, as Guyau points out, does not cease its chromatic vibrance because a scientist created a model for how these colors are interrelated. In fact, it is the necessity of building the aperture to focus more deeply on the relationships between color and nature that the world becomes less monochrome and thus less sterile through the textural mingling of morality, aesthetics, and intellect. Guyau is clear that language, color, and knowledge are infrastructural, and in his own words within *Outline of a Morality Without Obligation or Sanction*, he clarifies that living systems come with effects, rather than causes: "In the living being there is an accumulation of strength, a reserve of activity which is spent not for the pleasure of being spent, but because it must be spent." Guyau assumes that life demands the decision to expand precisely because life is finite in what it carries, which entails an ethical posture without surplus but not without criteria. Ethical action, from Guyau's perspective, intervenes decisively in the mutual intelligibility of thought and sense.



What the empirio-critics circled around and could not formalize in their time or shake from their positivist chains is a metaphysics of coordination as the primitive. Mach's principle was already vindicated by Einstein in the theory of relativity, but the gap in the ontological implications remains in the work of Richard Avenarius. The empirio-critics do not distinguish either physical or mental as primary, and while an individual and the environment may be distinct entities, they are never treated as inseparable or independent of one another. Part of their category error was reducing this complexity to a neutral monism of measurements and experiences in the service of scientific positivism. However, the concept of "principal coordination" in Avenarius's work remains particularly salient, because it establishes the basic building block of the idea that coordination is the ontological primitive, no matter between self and society or self and environment. Avenarius assumes through this principle that experience is a co-constituted

field of relations within which distinctions such as mind or matter first appear. Alexander Bogdanov later expands upon this idea in his own empiriomonism and tektology, generalizing coordination as primitive to social organization and social systems, but his philosophy was dismissed by Lenin in his own polemics against the Russian Machists. If we initiate cybernetics as an epistemic arc evolving from Bogdanov, then the following principles apply: The habituated practices of organization come first, feedback discipline comes second, and formal verification comes third for any feedback-driven organizational system. Experience, cognition, and material grammar are produced jointly through coordinated activity in social organization.



By activity, we refer to the invariant hinge convention under which coordination, value, law, ethics, and computation became mutually tractable, while the concrete instantiations remain historically contingent and formally revisable. Activity in a given social ecology is what makes learning possible at all under the binding of interaction. Organization in this sense refers to any live organized system, including the substrate domains of culture, labor, cognition, and biology. What the empiriomonists, the symbolic constructivists such as Urban and Langer, and Whiteheadian process philosophers were circling around is that coordination is the fundamental mode of being and the irreducible foundation of ontology. Organized systems that coordinate amongst themselves are living problem fields evolving metabolically through tension and reconfiguration. The feedback loop of a living system transports the activity of a double-edged interface. Processes do not have structure externally imposed onto them, or form added onto process later, but process is self-coordinated patterning and continuous development of pattern language as the syntax of social relations. The patterns instantiated by process are the only constant in the mode of processual self-coordination and collective coordination through social organization. Structure therein becomes

the constitutive dimension that coordination instantiates through free and explorative development of shared pattern language. For us to be in continuous process already implies we are structured and thus negated from patternless flux, and also dissolves the illusion that the ideal is exogenous to the concrete process of coordination as patterned activity. There are no prior facts of experience that are not already coordinated in practice, and any habituated concepts of order are provisional. Thus, all life maintains compositional structure that natively composes with nature and society, life maintains irreducible complexity that cannot be made fungible into a flat substrate, and this complexity is immanently organized through the mechanism of patterns. The syntax emerges through the process, but the semantics emerges through the uninterrupted composition of processes.



Avenarius's concept of the coordination principle found its audience in the Vienna intelligentsia that fraternized with each other frequently between the 19th and 20th centuries. The influence of this idea that there were universal practices of coordination could be felt in Otto Neurath, who developed his concept of the Isotype as a visual coordination language intended to be used as a way to democratize knowledge and sign-based activity coordination to working class people to self-organize and self-coordinate their organized affairs amongst each other. The Isotype was an explicitly political organizing tool that was designed to be self-documenting as provenance and learned by use, but it also was a radical statement that the visual experience of workers did not depend on pages of dense syntax for them to be able to act and organize effectively amongst themselves. The template of a pictogram-based visual language was inadvertently embedded as a design principle in Otl Aicher's Ulm School and later what we would call user experience (UX) design curriculum without the Isotype concept ever crossing the door. The Isotype ethos was part of the argument Neurath had with Hayek in regards to the calculation debates around

whether price signals or in-kind calculations could better coordinate an economy at scale, and core to both of the in-kind calculation as well as the Isotype project was the concept of orchestration: “Orchestrating includes, that in principle opinions and attitudes of each individual can be accepted by the community. In this fashion, it could even occur that the assertion of a majority vote against a strong opposition remains an exception. Orchestration can sometimes be achieved is settling between the extremes or also in that both extremes are recognized by the other. For example when city planning is discussed and one third of the population wants small houses with gardens, but two thirds want large apartments, why should this be decided by a majority vote? Why not build for one third as small houses, and the other two-thirds large apartments?”



Neurath’s pictorial semiotics and Alexander Bogdanov’s notion of tektology as a “universal science of self-organization” were both directly influenced by Avernarius’s coordination principle, but perhaps the most explicit lineage of this principle developed in Estonia through the Tartu-Moscow school of semiotics, led in part by Yuri Lotman and later continued by the Copenhagen-Tartu school of biosemiotics. Lotman developed the concept of the semiosphere as an entire coordinated infrastructural ecosystem of signs in relation to one another, which is less of a space of sign transmission and more of a precondition for signs to carry meaning at all. Lotman’s semiotics were operating at the intersection of cybernetics and culture, defining cultures as continuously self-organizing systems with core meaning, translation mechanisms, autocommunication rules, and ruptures that cause semiotic reorganization. The Tartu school as a whole was interrogating the idea that signs were just linguistic rules and reference points, and extended into the exploration of signs as material objects that can enact coordination through transmission and circulation. For Lotman, signs as language were the primary models

of reality in which the secondary models, such as art and philosophy, were built on top of this practiced language. Which, given the entire corpus of recorded history, makes obvious sense in hindsight given how many civilizations could coordinate entire economies and social organizations without the use of price signals forced upon them, including pre-Columbian Mesoamerica and the multitude of indigenous communities all throughout history. The !Kung San communities self-organized without tribal hierarchy and developed highly complex gift economy practices through Hxaro gift sharing, which allowed resources to travel exceptionally long distances and measure value through circulation and use as opposed to commodity exchange through price signals. Lotman's concept of autocommunication matters immensely here, in which he describes cultural memory as an actively transforming practice through the circulation and interaction of signs with their surroundings, resulting in a combinatorial transformation of both. Autocommunicative processes induce cyclic reorganization of a sign system's internal state as it regulates pressure and feedback from its surrounding constraint landscape. This kind of communication collapses the distinction between sender and receiver in order to generalize how one continuously metabolizes information for sense-making, identity formation, and conceptual integration. Autocommunication is the autostereogram of significance: signs thicken through co-presence of incompatible frames and coregulatory tension among interpretants, without appeal to an external symbolic referent capable of reconciling contact.



Lotman's semiosphere was developed in the Tartu school after his time into various extensions, including the biosemiotics of Kalevi Kull and the zoosemiotics of Thomas Sebeok, which extend semiosis into the zoosphere to study sign interactions between animal kingdoms. Sebeok was also influenced by Jakob von Uexküll's concept of *umwelt*, which portrayed distinct species as having self-updating perceptual

systems that were constantly interfacing in overlapping semiospheres through mutual feedback between their perceptual systems and sensory organs. Uexküll's concept of the *umwelt* in the semiosphere is one in which the organism is always interfacing through shared processes of coordinated signification with themselves and their environment. The Swiss zoologist, Adolf Portmann, had observed an adjacent insight about organisms through his concept of organic self-representation: Signification is not always governed by natural selection processes in the animal kingdom, and in some cases natural selection emerges downstream from apperception. Portmann noticed, for example, completely disparate animal species that never cross paths somehow share certain aesthetic patterns (such as yellow and black among snakes or bees) that do not easily reduce to camouflage or survival utility. Portmann hints at the possibility, more broadly, that certain excessive aesthetic pattern languages in nature develop morphogenetically through representation rather than natural selection. These extensions bridged necessary gaps between the semiosphere and the biosphere, proposing that organisms were sign-processing systems, ecosystems were coordination infrastructure that signs circulated in, and evolution was a semiotic process not unlike the biological evolution of organisms. However, unlike biological reproduction as the engine for genetic evolution and gene transmission, sign transmission is a separate reproductive process entirely: combinatorial evolution in real time through coordination between sign lineages. Evolution in organisms doesn't occur anywhere near as quickly as evolution between sign lineages, given that signs often carry metadata on provenance, relationship history, interaction between signs, reaction-diffusion propagation dynamics, and evolutionary development through sign interactions. Biological reproduction is a discrete event that depends heavily on whether the act of reproduction and population growth happens, but sign reproduction is continuous and thus does not depend on that act, because signs are always coordinating between each other. When a species reproduces, there is always a degree of planning that goes into reproduction even if the fertilization

itself is unplanned, but when individuals or social organizations of scale circulate information or exchange signification processes, these processes happen continuously, and even within a single conversation, multiple sign lineages that include various cultures, tools, and species could be reproduced and transformed in a given encounter.



The semiosphere is an evolutionary organ, and biological reproduction is a specific case of signs requiring discrete reproductive events, whereas culture and technology may be reproducing new sign lineages more frequently, but the throughline of sign reproduction is shared by all of the above. It's not so much that nature itself communicates as much as modal transformations occur through coordination operators based on biotic and abiotic pressures. Signs transform across distinct modalities, be they light, chemical, behavioral, linguistic, zoological, technical, or cultural to name a few, through coordination with their environments, creating shared lineages of semiospheric evolution. This is why, for instance, humans who build new tools such as computers or artificial intelligence are creating entirely new lineages of sign modalities that organisms are required to adapt to throughout the entire ecosystem. Within the marine layer, ichthyology research has traced seismosensory systems along at least the lateral lines of different fish genera to detect gentle wave currents and activity of other nearby prey. S.V. Zhdanov's research on thornfishes points towards an entire lineage of marine life in which their body plans crystallize first through mechanosensory feedback fields generated from their lateral line. The thornfish develops a boundary mapping of their own marine surface through hydrodynamic sensing, which scales to distributed synchronization among swarms of thornfish. The semiosphere shapes these local patterns into coherent global forms; on the technological side of the frame, the semiosphere includes visual displays, electromagnetic coordination through radio or wifi, and key chemical signatures in pollutants and pharmaceuticals. When

humans organize around these sign lineages as control mechanisms above all others, the entire ecosystem suffers and climate disasters occur, because we're eradicating entire sign lineages that occur that take entire epochs to construct and coordinate as complex systems over time. Even machine learning systems develop sign transmission through how to translate text and image, how to map across domains, and how to identify coordination patterns that are stable over time. There are entire lineages of indigenous communities that developed highly complex economies of scale and relationships with the ecosystem which were expunged through epochs of conquest and exploitation, which science is still catching up to after centuries of erasure.



In a broad sense, this framework unfolds with an account of semio-spheric evolution: how sign systems emerge, stabilize, and transform across distributed environments. This shifts emphasis away from theories of internal generative structure in language or biological evolution by natural selection, focusing instead on the environmental organization of meaning and sign lineages as they materialize ecologically. Signs and semiotic processes are not assumed just to be a symbolic phenomenon along these lines. Within the constraints of the semiosphere, sign systems distribute behavioral, cognitive, and metabolic load through signaling activity. Within a larger environment, stabilized signal patterns select for specific pathways that reduce strain and coordinate action in a larger ecological system. When adaptive strain is regulating as a constraint envelope among living systems, evolution occurs as a cross-scale negotiation of constrained load pressure. Sign systems, in this framework, co-determine evolutionary trajectory along a history-dependent path, by which cultural and biological evolution are structurally continuous for metastable survival. The semiosphere encodes the continuity envelope of distribution for metabolic load routing pressure within a sign ecology, specifying the conditions of how signs survive, how signs adapt, and how signs

collapse under load. Semiosis, in evolutionary context, functions as the sharing activity of load distribution and routing for a sign system through its ecology of knowledge, care, tools, and resources that are shared as a common survivability mechanism. Semiosis distributes metabolic load within a sign lineage through exposure as opposed to interpretive reference; in other words, semiosis defines what a system does to survive across durations of time, not what a symbolic representation refers to. The semiosphere itself conveys generative semantics that evolves combinatorially over time through transformation as interactions between individuals, collectives, and systems occur, all of which contain diversities of sign lineages at all times that encompass humans, animals, plants, fungi, lichens, their interactions within an informational and experiential ecosystem, and the climate as a whole. Across sign lineages, semiotic process modulates boundaries around environments capable of continued reorganization and dynamic constraint cycling expressible across combination rules, selection pressures, autocommunication patterns, signaling structures, and historic heredity. As living systems interpret and then recurse interpretation of their own viable states, their continuous adaptation results in emergent regulatory complexity across domains of sign lineages that cannot be reduced to a flat unity or singular sign coordination alone.



The semiosphere spans across all sign lineages where semiosis is a constant, including but not limited to culture, economics, medicaments, genealogy, science, logic, technology, and all disciplines given that semiosis is a unified coordination practice that generalizes how signs propagate and how they transform through interactions with the environment. Cultural evolution through memes, ideas, practices, and inherited traditions are themselves subject to evolutionary principles as a semiotic substrate. Cultural and historical identity develops thus not downstream from ethnicity or molecular biology, but from

civilizational continuity through active participation in shared semiosis. Diasporic communities within Judaism, for example, maintained highly specified intellectual patterns across centuries through texts, customs, practices, pedagogical methods, and argumentative styles, all of which carry more evolutionary fitness than reduction to DNA and genetic profile. Systems of common law have developed highly patterned traces for legal precedent, but sign ecosystems are not held to this standard of rigor since they do not entail enforcement of private property or monopolized clericalism on juridical hermeneutics. After the 1391 pogroms in Spain, the Rivash resettled in Algiers, and while embedded in a highly traumatized community without infrastructure, his approach to responsa focused on how to accommodate a legal system to the needs of the moment, rather than through the rigidity that a letter of the law approach would entail. The halakhic precedent in this approach focused more on law as provenance and protocol refinement when a system was completely under duress in times of crisis and dispossession. Reality precedes rule systems, and the legal skeleton of a rule system iterates through dynamic repair of contradictions and terrain adaptation as opposed to institutional brinkmanship. Law was synonymous to engineering in these circumstances as a way to resolve contradictions more comprehensively through load path analysis of infrastructure, ecological coordination, and more precise code. The responsa tradition behaved like a version control mechanism in this context to resolve disputes, establish provenance trails, and maintain continuity of knowledge that community members could access to participate in lawmaking as equals. The medieval Jewish and Islamic interpretive lineages shared an epistemic grammar that treated knowledge as a shared semiotic commons as opposed to private property. Knowledge in this premodern context was directly embedded in ongoing community practice, in which the authority of truth and knowledge was measured by the coherence of how knowledge relates to shared experience and wisdom. The interpretive textual dialectics, including the Talmud and the falsafa, diffused the responsibilities of version control, branching, and merge conflicts all within the

whole of the communities that knowledge circulated in, closing any assumed gap between techne and episteme through the mutual use and repair of knowledge. Common community knowledge was acceptable wisdom because these tendencies generally resolved through repair of contradictions rather than cost-firewalled credential hierarchies.



Prior to attention signals and any choice of moves in a given interaction, signs are reconfigured by the global environment that is navigated jointly by the ecosystem of sign activity before any interpretive labor occurs. Habituation loops amongst sign systems are embedded in multimodal transmission, by way of their transmission vectors that include language(names and letters), somatics (ritual timing, posture, locomotion), calendrics (cycles, relationship to time, seasonal norms), social roles (scaffolding, apprenticeship, family dynamics), and pedagogy (argumentative styles, conflict resolution, institutional knowledge transfer and archive, specializations, craft techniques) distributed across population drift, relationship to land, memory, and environmental selection pressure. Likewise, transmissibility may be high for a cultural norm that can stabilize against shear load or cavitation of context, but durability may be low if a cultural meme is specialized for virality regardless of use. The survivability of sign lineages depends on, at minimum, transmissibility of knowledge and durability of the infrastructure that mediates knowledge; for example, sign transmission may be low for knowledge bearing the initiation bandwidth of tacit prerequisites, admissibility gating, and miscompilation risk, but high durability once knowledge can be redundantly embedded into infrastructure without exhausting its use rapidly. As archaeosemiotic practice, sign lineages sediment into iterative cognitive technology that leaves residue in habitus without bloodline requirement; that is, families pass down ecologies of reason ranging from legal corpora, oral artifacts, textual media, institutional continuity, and resource distribution norms that reproduce in domicile

and technical professions. Evolutionary patterns bias the conditions under which memory reacts to its environment, and this process does not generate reactions apart from the paths through which those reactions are learned. A sign lineage evolves under constraint by actively repairing the contradictions that a system senses as necessary for survival. This is the family resemblance shared in Talmudic method: identify a contradiction, test its constraints, repair the wound in a structure, establish the invariant, rinse and repeat through a continuous feedback loop.



The survival of any sign system depends on repairing contradictions more reflexively than the environment destroying the conditions for coherence. Law, in such an approach, proceeds from casuistry as opposed to private property enclosure; in other words, the law actually fulfills the spirit of what calling something a justice system would require, which is resolution of resource gaps through the application of rules to the context of a situation. Legal codes thus do not exceptionalize any particular legal orthodoxy beyond lived dispute resolution, mutual harm reduction, and transformative justice that a situation necessitates, given that the law is nothing more than a fibered bundle of signs within a cultural continuum. The American legal system's obsession with punishment, procedural theater, and textual precedent as legal gospel proceeds from a particularly grotesque conflagration of Roman property law, British adversarialism, settler-colonial enclosure logic, and corporate theology, producing a system structurally optimized for enclosure and punishment rather than contradiction repair, in contrast to generations of the reparative social technology that behaved more like highly technical distributed operating systems than biblical scripture. By severing cultural and psychosocial development through provenance and shared resources, sign systems risk erosion of evolutionary fitness. Jan Aasmann's concept of mnemohistory explores how sign systems, such as those in ancient Egypt, are focused on

the practice of reconstructing cultural memory from “storage memory” (where knowledge and symbolic structure sit in isolation) to “functional memory” (where a class of signs is actively used and reproduced), by way of reconstructing fragmented cultural lineages through the continuum of their use.



Technology follows the same modal transformation patterns through communicative pressures, as tools, logical signifiers, techniques, and systems of activity follow the process of generative grammar that underlies life and its coordinated social ecologies. Even the Pirahã, whose language reportedly lacks syntactic recursion, demonstrate ongoing cultural and historical coordination patterns, because the semiosphere operates across modalities as opposed to just linguistic syntax alone. Sign ecologies coregulate, across care and cognition, through the mediation of rotational logic (such as the distribution of tools, stress attunement, and resources) and square state logic (such as archive, storage, memory, synchronized knowledge, and law) under a coregulatory constraint mediation between one another. The quincunx, by which a sign mediates the center of the overlapping square and circle, mediates between state and runtime without collapsing the logic of either the square or the circle over the other. Signs do not signify meaning in an interpretive linguistic sense, but representational meaning may emerge downstream of the quincuncial mediation of a sign; in other words, all sign systems are tasked with routing pressure between persistence and modification across scale, environmental conditions, distribution of failure modes, and material substrate. Humans and computers may differ in terms of material substrate and metabolic throughput, but they share intrinsic strain in environmental action from how a sign mediates repair between system state and runtime. A sign circulates resources, stores memory, and continuously mediates what they remember and how they act under continuous interaction with the survivability and rotation of metabolic load. We

may visualize a feedback process in the below diagram to illustrate the quincuncial mediation in practice:

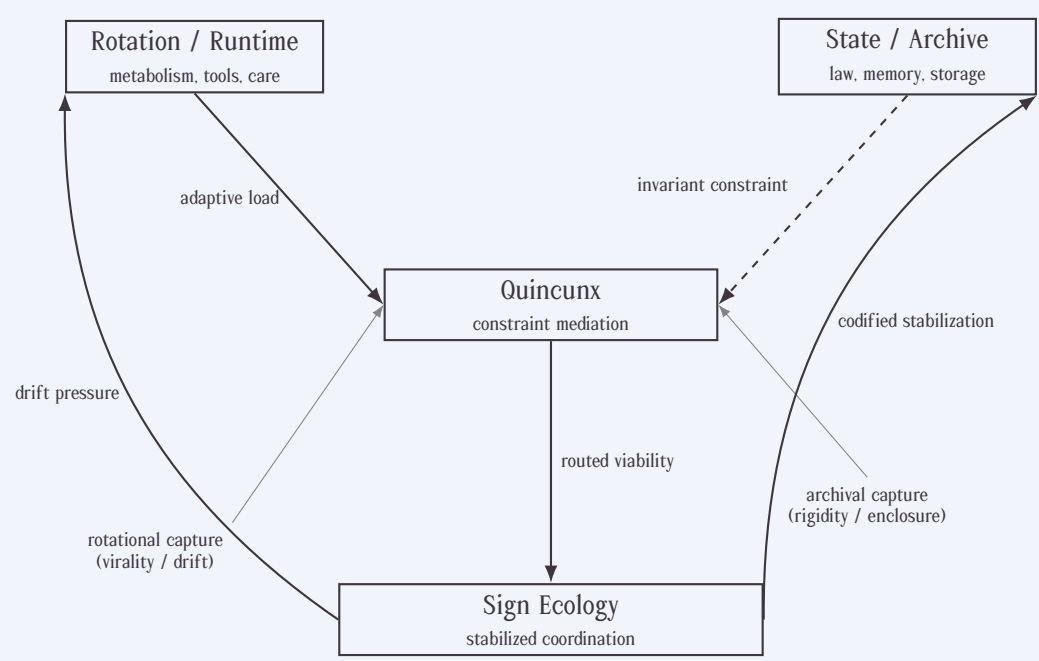


Figure O.I: Quincuncial mediation of sign systems. Adaptive rotation and archival constraint are routed through a quincuncial mediator. Coherence persists only if neither regime captures the whole system; feedback stabilizes or destabilizes subsequent cycles.



Signification, in the processual sense of how a sign creates meaning as semantics, operates agonistically through negation via the iterative exclusion of inadmissible interpretations, actions, and metabolic load paths. As a living system may stabilize metabolic throughput across load paths, negative determinations and constraints no longer require erosion of hinge conventions that keep a sign ecology stable. Along the lines that Gerrit Mannoury uses the term in significs, the principle of graduality conveys that significance of meaning does not cleanly jump between the discontinuity of incomprehension to understanding; rather, meaning is dynamically co-deformable in a social environment, stabilized through metabolism before practice. Significance, over time, thickens along gradations of finite interaction surfaces that partially function above fluent articulation and below symbolization that never fully closes. Social coordination may occur under partially formed meaning that refuses unitarity, where material stability precedes indexical articulation in the durability of linguistic function. Semantic evolution and long term significance, when exposed to conceptual velocity beyond the envelope of collective sensemaking, shocks the cohesive threshold of a sign ecology by which the social production of meaning can embed concepts in joint activity. Signification modifies rheme before it modifies theme. As habits and action loops stabilize over time, signs stop signifying and simply operate as load bearing infrastructure facilitates sign system coordination. Meaning, in this regard, is what survives across the elimination of alternatives. Semantics delineate what a sign, structure, or activity is not, culling inadmissible interpretations until coordination of sign lineages stabilizes as the need for explicit meaning exhausts itself.



The terrain of signification in the late modern period has converged between the tension of two polarized states that are mutually intol-

erable to each other: unbounded positive semantic maximalism (what something means) or semantic nihilism (nothing has any meaning, truth is solipsistic and relative) with both axes inevitably destabilizing the terrain when placed in the same room. The conspicuous gap in late modernity is a negative semantics that defines meaning by what cannot be asserted for the survival of a system. We may only understand a system, at minimum, by what it asserts, what it is denied, what is tolerable under metastability, and what is admissible under systemic constraint. Even prior to categorial grammar formalization, survivable compositions are documented by access semantics, in which contexts are localized fields limited by capacity, admissibility restrictions, and failure modes. In a categorial sense, meaning is just a side effect of surviving execution, and composition is conditional prior to association. In a partial access semantics environment, propositions do not exhaust an object, and assertions are locally routable from their perspective, documenting error modes by any semantic configuration that asserts itself as total in addressability. Prior to subject formation or addressability, natural language semantics is purely adeictic: there are no stabilized speakers as anchors, spatiotemporal sense of proximity or distance, and no context that is indexable as a pointwise function between speakers. Sign ecologies are genealogically pre-enumerative in the sense that they do not compose, reference, or even assume truth conditionality as an ongoing requirement to coordinate social activity, and any enumeration requirement is a historical artifact. At the adeictic layer, signs use language to disable the referential machinery of interaction, in which meaning is achieved solely through exhaustion of viewpoint until only gestural activity survives. Aspecthood within linguistic semantics is derivative of joint activity between sign systems, and any stable notion survives only through collapsing the need to gate resources between sign systems in the first place.

When humans organize around specific sign lineages as control mechanisms, be they through nationalism or price signals as the monopolistic force on coordination, or mass surveillance as the only meaningful informational system to coordinate harvested metadata, the entire ecosystem suffers as a result, enforcing scarcity of stimulus and laundering of barbarism. In the coordination of routing pressure between persistence and modification, shared maintenance is safer than centralized command hoarding. The preservation of these control systems at the exclusion of all results in the eradication of entire sign lineages that developed eons, eroding biomass and biodiversity that maintained infrastructures of coordination over time. These infrastructures destabilize entire ecosystems when they are eviscerated by conquest or decay. Forests, for example, contain pheromone key signatures, mycelial networks, animal interactions, microbial transmissions, and ecological stewardship patterns as an entire integrated biosemiotic system, and when they collapse from climate devastation, the entire continuity of sign lineages can break more quickly than novel coordination patterns can evolve to adapt to the vacuum that exacerbates as the ecosystem erodes. At the more generalized level of population genetics, when you move away from consumer gene testing, mtDNA haplogroups within whole genome sequencing encode more generally cultural and historical patterns of inference as opposed to just preordained biological constraints, and thus serve more as genealogical markers of cultural and migratory continuity rather than a phenotypic differentiation that determines genetic traits in biological production. A haplogroup may track matrilineal migration, founder effects and population bottlenecks as network-scale evolutionary pressures, which are more embedded as archaeogenomic history and lineage data as opposed to individualized trait pathology. If someone is born with a pathogen and refused care through shelter and resources, the resolution of the pathogen becomes a systemic responsibility rather than an individual pathology, because a pathologically dysfunctional system resolves through more intensive resources than a dysfunctional node in a network.



In the 17th century, the Ethiopian philosopher Zera Yacub wrote outside of the frame of the Western Enlightenment to speak of the plant and animal kingdom: "They are drawn by the nature of their creation towards the preservation of their life and the propagation of their species. Moreover trees in the fields and plants which are created with great wisdom grow, bloom, flourish, produce the fruit of their respective seed according to their orders and without error; they seem to be animated." Justice is processual circulation outside of the domain of thought or agency, such that any reason that contradicts justice for the living defers its own annihilation. Ethics, justice, and meaning are not absolute properties of intention or belief, but emergent properties of proprioception arising from the infrastructure that governs continuity, allocation, and relations between relata. The deliberation of ethics is a late artifact of the precipitation of chaos through contingent form. Prior to the implementation of law, time adjudicates the continuity of memory as the active rebalancing of scales. The works of the living, insofar as they last, do not belong to anyone but to the shoreline within themselves and the world, by which they accept chaos as anterior to order, and decide to persist against chaos or export their turbulence into weather.

APEIRON · 60°



The tools of mathematics, at the deepest levels of abstraction, reveal themselves to us when the structure of reality is chosen to be perceived. Propaganda is the opposite of perception in this regard, because it circulates through the policing of the boundaries of knowledge. Public relations in the 20th century was synonymous with propaganda, and Bernays wrote the entire textbook word for word on how propaganda actually works: "Sometimes the effect on the public is created by a professional propagandist, sometimes by an amateur deputed for the job. The important thing is that it is universal and continuous; and in its sum total it is regimenting the public mind every bit as much as an army regiments the bodies of its soldiers." Questions of how to condition one's capacity to think for themselves have been chronicled throughout intellectual history, all the way back to Hume and Spinoza, all of whom wrangled with different textural representations of the same problem around how one can preserve their capacity to think and reshape how people focus more clearly on the answer to the problem. The oligarchical classes are always organized in this sense because they know how to withhold information and monopolize access to information so that people never develop the capacity to think for themselves; however, what makes this contradiction so absurd is how many resources are wasted going into torturing and suppressing knowledge from being circulated, when sharing knowledge

and resources are incidentally the most efficient and economical method of all. Controlling a population is perversely expensive and inefficient in terms of resource use, and often is driven by a need for the dependency of extraction to personal survival. Carl Schmitt's notion of a sovereign authoritarian state's capacity to facilitate a binary distinction between friend and enemy rings true in a quote from Kurt Vonnegut in *Slaughterhouse Five*: "And here, according to Trout, was the reason human beings could not reject ideas because they were bad: "Ideas on Earth were badges of friendship or enmity. Their content did not matter. Friends agreed with friends, in order to express friendliness. Enemies disagreed with enemies, in order to express enmity."



The disciplinary borders of the contemporary academy have forced mathematicians into the tension of choice between institutional access and cross-disciplinary exploration in a way that regiments their own isolation from the structures of reality. In the collected papers of Armand Borel, he writes within *Ouerves* of the advancement of mathematics by practice prior to jurisdictional partition: "I feel that what mathematics needs least are pundits who issue prescriptions or guidelines for presumably less enlightened mortals." Part of Norbert Wiener's own insight around cybernetics as a precursor to systems theory is that the feedback loop can create its own problem in how we choose to problem solve. The gap between unknown answers to problems and the admissibility of the problem space runs the risk of creating its own negative feedback loops in the form of computational bottlenecks and developmental timelines that take decades for professionals to catch up to. This is a problem that every field struggles with, not just mathematics: we've built a disparate methodology for insight that starts with closing the gap between a paradigm shift and research program, and then research program with common knowledge circulation. The shadow of many disciplines in

the academy are haunted by a legacy of institutional elitism, often a reflection of the same social and economic hierarchies that create conditions for elite capture across society. Such legacies remain proximal in the history of knowledge, but also leave each intellectual silo with the question of how collective inquiry is produced, and how silos are produced as the medium of inquiry.



Mathematics is a precision study about the deep intensional invariants and extensional flows that animate the outward appearances of concrete phenomena. Whether something is temporarily sensible or permanently symbolic, the essential structure gives you a grammar of how to translate universally while respecting differences between domains, whether they are phenomenological or thermodynamic. A motive is just a lantern which lights the altar of structure, and without this generalization, reality lives in the shadow of a lossy projection. The reason we opt for pixels as an approach to reality is because we opt for information as differentiable from a lower-resolution but not necessarily as a totalizing answer that can master the Katamari ball of knowledge. There is a distinction in graphic design between raster graphics and vector graphics. Raster graphics are rendered as contones by both dimensions (width and height per pixel) and color depth (the quantity bits per pixel). Raster graphics, when you zoom into them, render as lossy compression, since they're just projections of numeric representations of an image that depends on the capacity of the rendering engine of the machine that projects an image. The raster data model always preserves continuity of information and resolution regardless of bit depth, so even if the numeric code under the image is resolution-dependent, they're always a sample of the same information space of an image regardless of whether they are bridged by raster graphics or vector graphics. Bear in mind, raster graphics can convert to vector graphics and vice versa; raster graphics can be vectorized using line work, and vector graphics can be rasterized

by converting into pixels. Vector graphics, in contrast, are defined by geometric shapes on a Cartesian plane, so when you look at them from any resolution or angle, they do not struggle with lossy compression the way that raster graphics often do, given that vector graphics maintain their structural integrity through line work. Vector graphic data is resolution-independent, so when you apply a digital magnifying glass to them, they don't lose their structural integrity relative to the pixel structure burden of raster graphics. Although not commercially successful, the Scalable Vector Graphics (SVG) format is an attempt to apply this media format as a technical specification, standardized by W3C in 1999. While initially underutilized, modern browsers now render SVG natively as an interoperability format that bridges vector and raster imaging files, illustrating that resolution-independent encoding with context-appropriate rasterization is not merely theoretical but operational. The tools used for rasterization and vectorization are separate, but they do not disrupt discrete representation or continuity of information: raster graphics are mapped through matrices and linear algebra, whereas vector graphics fit neatly into coordinate geometry. In a sense, they're different ways of perceiving the same invariant structure underneath: a pixel grid gives you discrete points on a plane, polynomials give you connections between these discrete points while also evaluating smoothness of curvature between the points, and differential structure on a tangent space gives you the tools to evaluate smoothness of a structure under continuous transformations.



Anyone who has grown up playing video games understands intuitively the interplay between bits, resolution, and contextual preservation of ideas in imagery. The progression from 8-bit video games to 32-bit to the currently photorealistic representations of video games today have not necessarily resulted in a linear progression of resolution-to-meaning ratio. When you are dealing with two dimensional games and three-dimensional polygonal representations

between these generations, or even in between with 2.5D sprites and three-dimensional planes, the complexity of this picture becomes even more apparent. What remains semantically preserved is the imaginal context and preserved memory of the characters themselves. Some games in the 16-bit era, such as Chrono Trigger, and Xenogears in the 32-bit era, were epochal in how they presented sprawling, meaningful, interpretable storylines and ways of interacting with the player to develop deeper meaning. in comparison. Xenogears can be witnessed as a tragic Gnostic epic spanning across timelines, archetypal representations of the same character ensemble, and nonsequential stages of psychodynamic development between characters and players. Xenogears can seamlessly integrate cyberpunk, Gnostic cosmology, Kabbalistic emanationism, Lacanian psychoanalysis, and meditations on imperialism under the banner of "Stand tall and shake the heavens" at the back of the box containing the game's two Playstation discs. Meaning is about what survives passage through contact with aperture, our receptivity to complexity beyond our reality model, and sharing how to use the telescope on a blurry landscape so we can see things for what they are. A crude, low-bit model might capture the basics of an individual phenomena, but overly complex ones can become computationally intractable without nontrivial exertion.



Across scale-dependent stabilizations in domains ranging from algebraic functions to mathematical logic, Albert Lautman situates mathematical objects as moving after they are constructed: "Our intention being to show that completion internal to an entity is asserted in its creative power, this conception should perhaps logically imply two reciprocal aspects: the essence of a self realizing form within a matter that it would create; the essence of a matter giving rise to the forms that its structure designs." Lautman's dialectic is a very ancient one, derived from the mathematical corpus of antiquity that instantiated mathematical objects through the relationships they had

with the world, which required abstract mathematical form to bridge into concrete application. If we were to handle geometry the way that the dialectic is handled by Hegel, we would force a seal on the Carnot heat engine by declaring no further extension is admissible unless an immaterial sublimation of states were asserted in order to preserve continuity. Leon Brunschvicg understood the localized advancement of thought thoroughly enough to accept that negation is a brake rather than a lubricant. A contradiction is what is allowed to move laterally. In practice, the passage of contradictions halts extension, but licenses reconfiguration.



Beyond the polarity of negation, contradiction functions as a stereoscopic disparity: a lawful parallax misalignment between incompatible frames whose non-collapse permits lateral reconfiguration without synthesis or finality. Persistence emerges not through resolution, but through the maintenance of a bounded gap across which updates to a frame remain possible. The coexistence of incompatible frames generates contradiction through their encounter, requiring either actively coordinated tension across perspectives or deterioration under cumulative strain. In the optical sense, the appearance of logical composition assumes a continuous tension between orientation and attention for constructed rules, and sometimes those rules are tested only when two or more people negotiate through listening rather than speaking. For an image, object, or logical predicate to be tenable, no single frame exhaustively closes the construction of the world; as a result, the agonistic pressure of turning towards something and focusing attention towards it is multiplied when multiple incongruent perspectives are held in conflict. Some aspects of logical coordination resist reduction to purely linguistic or symbolic articulation, depending on the partial access that joint visibility makes available to shared perspectives. The construction of logic depends on joint visibility of partial perspectives over time, and logic shears precisely when stresses

cannot be redistributed across perspectives. Mathematical structures, in the lens that Lautman presents, are solutions to fields of tension, and the problem fields of mathematics generate objects within that structural tension. Mayan numerology was extraordinarily complex, using a vigesimal base that represented combinatorial logic through an ecosystem of dots, bars, and shells to develop complex astrological planners for seasonal agriculture.



In the ancient Near East, the number charts of Chaldea grouped arithmetical value with letters to summarize their sense of a person's semantic blueprint through their relationships and skillsets. Although the Chaldean arithmetic method is stripped of its context when used similarly to modern astrology for contemporary symbolic determinism, the Chaldean method was integrated with the Mesopotamian economy in order to use numbers as semiotic tools for ritual classification, calendrics, and divinatory interpretation. Ancient arithmetic was relationally invariant to the cosmological practices these worlds were embedded in, which necessarily mirrored their social building blocks of relationships, constraints, and structures. Jean Cavaillès was more austere than Lautman in this context, focusing squarely on what makes mathematics autonomous as a method: the internal generation of a structure by necessity in a mathematical system. Cavaillès accounts for the procedural quality of mathematics that governs through the space of rules, which Lautman contends with by articulating necessity through what is disclosed by a prior structure of problems that mathematics answers. Necessity, more broadly, is governed inferentially by the space of admissible rules in a system, but also structurally generated by the prior continuity of the problem space that mathematics, as a historically situated practice, may inhabit. Boundaries mediate between inferential necessity and historically contingent structure to determine what stabilizes under pressure and under what conditions a structure is terminable.



The task of the metaphysician is to set the substrate, constraints, and bulk primitives that all domains of knowledge must comport with internally. Once you admit these limitations, metaphysics has no survivable errors for contradiction through morality, narration, or prestige. In this regard, metaphysics is a cataloguing scheme for mutual intelligibility between knowledge domains not unlike librarianship, setting the global admissibility environment by which all domains survive continuous knowledge transport. The definition of metaphysics is frankly not that complicated when the mechanism is not lost in translation, by which we realize it in practice as a pansemiotic philology of cultural development, provenance, material constraints, field behaviors, evolution of grammar rules, repair procedures, and pattern language inheritance. This is fundamentally how the Near Eastern, Mesoamerican, Indus Valley, and Nilotic civilizations understood metaphysics as a concrete domain beyond abstract symbolic administration. These civilizations did not uniformly proceed from the first principle of a bifurcation between nature from cosmos, metaphysical source from lived experience, symbolic grammar from cultural interaction, or meaning from genealogy. The atomization of academic disciplines in the modern world is an aberration relative to what ancient civilizations assumed to be integrated by common sense. Alexander Grothendieck best reflected his principle in his own words on what distinguishes good mathematicians from the best mathematicians: "A mathematician is someone who can find analogies between theorems; a better mathematician is one who can see analogies between proofs and the best mathematician can notice analogies between theories." Every sign lineage contains the microcosm of its own self-contained metaphysical source universe, which tasks us with identifying contradictions in the metaphysical schema whose invariants compose across universes. We have extensive evidence throughout history that points to this trend: the Islamic metaphysicians, and the Scholastics were at the frontier of scholarship

in their time, not just because their theories animated their mysticism, but because their mysticism and shared understanding of experience guided their theories far beyond the time they were in to access what may be cosmological. Mysticism is about scope, not content. Mysticism exhausts the proprioceptive appearance of structural invariants at a revealed informational resolution that outpaces what language can encode on its own. In practice, mysticism exposes regions of experience prior to discretized propositional language, encoding the felt epiphenomenological slice of a system interacting with a contradiction it has no words for yet.



Maimonides proceeds from the following order of operations for defining the bounds of habituated knowledge: “The person who wishes to attain human perfection should study logic first, next mathematics, then physics, and, lastly, metaphysics.” To clarify this further, Maimonides does not presuppose logic as propositional or symbolic, but as combinatorial: logic specifies the configurable environment of admissible rules of inference, which configurations compose and decompose, and the extent of how forms may recombine. Between logic and math, combinatorial admissibility bridges to quantitative structure encoded through mathematical formalism, and between math and physics is where necessity appears. Physics begins to stress test the ideals of mathematical explanation until they cannot be freely deformed, documenting when constraint becomes irreversible and how mathematical structure survives under loss. Metaphysics is what generalizes at the end, after operations have been transported across domains to determine what survives and what cannot be otherwise, and those operations conjoin future interpretative boundaries qua first principles, rather than rear-view hermeneutic excursus. Metaphysics, in practice, is a posterior operator that amortizes its own generalized precision until a more sophisticated coordination source supersedes it. How we collectively understand what is common in the context of

the world and how we model the path to shared tensions of unity and individuation at both the individual and cosmological level, has been the task of metaphysics since antiquity.



The parochialism of modern academic specialization risks regimenting itself into its own ivory tower hierarchy where procedural fidelity, research prestige, citational volume, and complexity of tools is prioritized over the utility and circulation of scientific knowledge. Indigenous communities have always been practicing methods and scientific approaches, for example, that Western ecologists have only in the last few generations been able to catch up to. The prescription of fire as a pruning method for forest maintenance and ecological restoration has been widely imported and shared amongst indigenous communities for millenia, including but not limited to indigenous tribes of the Americas and aboriginal Australian communities prior to their colonization and displacement. The ecological entropy that industrial agriculture and fossil drilling have exported onto carbon emissions needs no introduction because the topic has been endlessly rehashed, but the particular trouble to highlight is how the regimentation of Western science creates its own inhibitory feedback loops that fossilize in practice beyond the performance of a prestige economy. Even dating centuries back to the Middle Ages and early modern period, scientific innovation was nowhere near as siloed or isolatory as it currently is in the present, allowing Renaissance figures like Da Vinci or Islamic polymaths like Ibn Sina to experiment widely across domains and find patterns that reconfigure domains. The alignment of mathematicians, physicists, and humanities scholars towards collaborative inquiry would actually render the depth of knowledge in contemporary scholarship more explanatory rather than less. We know this because this is what the metaphysicians of antiquity did, and this is what was common practice in human civilization prior to the last few centuries of recovering from the ghosts of Western modernity and Cartesian res

cognitans. Metaphysics is the organizational science that unifies the mechanistic and mentalistic axes of the world in accordance with what must compose from first principles. Metaphysics is thereby contingent on what does not break when it persists.

ASPHALEIA · 90°



Leanne Simpson, who dwells on the ancestral land of the Michi Saaglig Nishnaabeg, describes the inherited reserve system for indigenous communities as an outgrowth of what she describes as bordered knowledge: the reduction of indigenous cosmological wisdom into extractable ethnographic data that depends on the technology of borders as sovereign to remain metadata for colonial administrative systems. The Western academic paradigm shifted deeply in the 20th century into a highly mechanized border regime in which departments enforce enclosure and sequestration as survival mechanisms, and in doing so, knowledge becomes an expression of territorial sovereignty rather than common understanding grounded in lived wisdom. Without understanding the larger infrastructure that enforces borders as technology around epistemology and learning, the current extractive model of knowledge as private property risks conflation with our understanding of how boundaries are maintained, and more saliently, who is authorized to maintain boundaries. Borders do not necessarily look like government offices or law enforcement agencies beyond their surface appearance; in fact, borders are often enforced through deeper intimacy rather than through distance. The distinction between a border and a boundary is perhaps felt but not always understood, given that we accept borders as ordinary and boundaries as often

pathological when maintained against systems that depend on refusing boundaries to enact harm.



Carl Schmitt openly specifies in the *Nomos of the Earth* that land appropriation precedes the institution of law. In his nomenclature, appropriations of common land do not derive from the domain of law, but in the Ancient Greek constitution of the term *nomos*, which he interprets of the concrete social norms of a people. As borders are inherited and drawn, appropriations and enclosure of the commons reflect a redistricting of the spatial order by which social and political life develop visibility through concrete norms. In this framework, Schmitt delineates very clearly for his own benefit as a Nazi jurist how a border technology evolves in form through the inheritance of prior conquest. The juridical administration of politics as a border regime develops precisely through this normative inheritance, where the immediate spatiotemporal arrangement of furniture in lived history evolves from the story of whoever won the previous war in the historical sequence. The concept of a border is typically associated with statecraft, often conflating the implementation of technology with the medium that enforces it. For common knowledge, this typically reflects a notion that borders are enforced downstream by states, and that surveillance is simply a speciality machinery contingent on the Westphalian state form. The development of the NSA and the narrative of security as access control reflects a much deeper turf war fought in the background over decades by Western military-industrial alignment over the use of communication technology as an instrument for discipline and enclosure. The actual technology of a border precedes the state form as a mechanism of intensified exclusion, often deliberately so; in fact, when we think of boundaries, we often think of them as ways to thicken contradictions around harm to metabolize repair. A border serves the opposite purpose: the border thickens the moat around the institutional bulk it seeks to preserve, and in

doing so, border technology adjudicates and launders what cannot be metabolized. In this framing, we can think of the Westphalian state network less as a machinery of states with borders and more as a mesh network of border technology crystallized into state form. Borders mature as vassalization rituals, converting liegdom into sovereignty by extending the possibility of violence as continuity.



Ethically, what Simone Weil calls *metaxu* is the operating logic of a boundary: a thickening mediation that can neither be abolished nor occupied, only persisting as long as the boundary continues to mediate between relationships. Boundaries are fundamentally assertions of sovereignty where sovereignty is excluded by external adjudication. Adjacently, boundaries are often overdetermined in Western therapy culture as avoidance mechanisms, unilateral instruments for a bilateral connection, and isolated from contradiction repair that normally entails healthy reciprocity between two or more nervous systems rather than capitulating to one. Glen Coulthard, of the Yellowknives Dene, clearly articulates from a lens of grounded normativity that boundaries emerge through relationships rather than the recognition of a territorial sovereign that asserts a juridical economy as a mechanism of access control. Coulthard grounds this understanding in place-based belonging, which reveals boundaries as invitations to deeper connection where knowledge is extracted and siphoned from the context that indigenous communities needed to navigate in the aftermath of colonial violence. Boundaries in such a context become fundamentally security practices in a world where safety is classified as territorial control rather than shared custodial duty over land, life, and knowledge. Nick Estes of the Lower Brule Sioux describes borders as universalized counterinsurgency infrastructure in his own lived observation of the US-Mexico border drawn through Tohono O'odham land and the Standing Rock Sioux Reservation, treating indigenous people as illegal immigrants on their own territory:

"The tactics employed by TigerSwan, the murky mercenary security contractor hired by DAPL, were also confirmation that this was a global war. The security company had cut its teeth in the United States' never-ending "war on terror," in which it was deployed to run counterinsurgency operations against civilians in Iraq and Afghanistan. TigerSwan now applied the same techniques to Water Protectors. The Intercept reports that security personnel frequently referred to Water Protectors as "terrorists," planned prayer actions as "attacks," and the camps as a "battlefield." Indigenous land defenders and 20th century computer scientists independently arrived at the same answer from converging directions: borders require continuous violence to maintain, and boundaries emerge between relations and can be invoked through revocable consent. The engineers designing capability-based security systems and the Mohawk custodians defending Kanesatake in 1990 were both diagnosing the same colonial logic: the idea that legitimacy comes from a central authority's global permission rather than from the web of relationships we are locally situated in. A boundary is not an edge surface, but a site of activity where knowledge is produced. The logic of a boundary coordinates through what Lucy Suchman calls situated actions: "The organization of situated action is an emergent property of moment-by-moment interactions between actors and between actors and their environment."



Prior to the 1066 Norman Conquest, the forests of England were a commons by which peasants derived a suite of rights from: estovers (right to gather wood), pannage (right to graze pigs on acorns), turbary (digging the ground for fuel), and piscary (right to fish), by the Normandy conquest declared vast swaths of common land as "royal forest land" which enforced criminal penalties on common land dwellings. The 13th century Magna Carta did not proffer any guardrails around enclosure for privatized land exclusion, merely stipulating instead that the scope of authority on the monarchy was as subject to

adjudication presumably as the landed gentry were. The Magna Carta was not won as a concession by the peasantry, in the same way that the signing of the United States Declaration of Independence was not won by working class struggle; rather, both of the boardrooms that these signatories coalesced in were largely oligarchical interests organized as a class, interested in negotiating rulership over a single inheritor they deemed to be threatening to their caste status. The concept of human rights, as the liberal state form, emerges from this prolonged intra-elite negotiation over rulership as something given as access control; in fact, Hannah Arendt calls this phenomena the "right to have rights" precisely for this reason, because the moment that recognition is rationed as an access control list over who gets to participate in the ritual of admissibility, the state form has already admitted that its enforced borders depend on scarcity of recognition. The 1225 Charter of the Forest was particularly threatening to both the royal family and the barons, because it went a step further in declaring that land was a commons to be dwelled upon by ordinary living beings. The open field system was retrofitted via the Charter with several penumbras that allowed the gentry to exploit ambiguity through juridical force, chief of them being: Article 1 in the Charter of the Forest curtailed the jurisdiction of the Norman enclosures specifically, claiming that "All forests that Henry II afforested shall be disafforested." The Charter does not specifically admit that forests are a commons, and instead simply dictates that some enclosure of royal land would be enforced. Article 9 clarifies that freemen were entitled to the fruits of their own labor, but the villeins (serfs), by whom the term villain is etymologically adjoint, assume their place in the class hierarchy. The early foresters, not unlike the early strikebreaker role of the 19th century Metropolitan police configured by Sir Robert Peel, served primarily as guard labor to criminalize acts of "afforestation", which in their sentencing norms meant bodily mutilation and confiscation of property for crossing the boundary between the royal reserve and the containment zone for the commons.



The open field system eroded in the 16th century as the Enclosure Acts were issued through the United Kingdom Acts of Parliament, instantiating the forefront of private property right enforcement as millions of acres were privatized by borders over land that was commonly stewarded by the public. The consequence of this privatization resulted in an exacerbation between British farmers who previously held collective participation in the stewardship of free land, as well as the landowning agricultural class who benefitted immensely from the value of excluding the public from using arable land. E.P. Thompson points out that the 1723 Black Acts were escalations of capital punishment for over fifty offenses in forest reserves, meaning that fishing in a forest pond or cutting down timber in the forest reserve could sentence the accused to death. The rule of law in agrarian England, as Thompson points out, reflected the outcome of the propertied interests who emerged victorious in conflicts over land and resources: that was often at issue was not property, supported by law, against no-property; it was alternative definitions of property-rights: for the landowner, enclosure; for the cottager, common rights; for the forest officialdom, 'preserved grounds' for the deer; for the foresters, the right to take turfs...When it ceased to be possible to continue the fight at law, men still felt a sense of legal wrong: the propertied had obtained their power by illegitimate means." The border, in this sense, is not an object but a set of relationships in a space contingent on exclusion, and when those exclusions are challenged, they necessitate brutality to maintain the status quo. The concept of property in this context has less to do with personal possession of objects that someone uses and more to do with the negative space where resources are excluded through misallocation. The border is a juridical machinery of enmeshment that creates the subjects it claims to protect itself from, adjudicating relationships through scarcity, finite recognition, and violence. The technology of the border therein facilitated the conditions for industrialization to emerge not just in Britain, but

internationally as the Westphalian state apparatus became the primary state configuration of border technology.



Modern surveillance regimes are reporting specifications: schemas that define what counts as risk, who must disclose it, and how coercion is triggered through compliance. If enclosure of land requires juridical laundering of violence, enclosure of information requires technical discipline and institutional obscurantism. We forsake our understanding of surveillance technology by limiting it to terra firma watchtowers that monitor fences, especially when the jurisdiction of surveillance goes beyond bodies to the formatting of disclosures and registries. There is no privileged position for an analyst to spectate the landscape from when they accept the reality that nobody participates outside of a system, and especially in a world where systems choose what to stabilize and what to destabilize. The contemporary apparatus of modern power dynamics becomes legible through forms, conditions, proprietary algorithms, exclusionary thresholds, and escalation rules as they are maintained by ordinary proceduralism. The 20th century marks the expansion when border technology is no longer materially confined to territory, but is projected onto the architecture of communication itself. When we read early computer science and network-based technology history outside of the narrative of linear technological progression, a recurring pattern emerges: each attempt to impose borders on relational systems produces excess heat, labor, and failure, while systems that preserve boundaries without access control exhibit resilience, adaptability, and cultural longevity. When Ivan Sutherland developed the first graphical communication interface in the form of Sketchpad around 1963, he pointed out that in the context of a digital ecosystem of objects: “We approached the task by starting with a simple scheme and adding commands and features that we felt would enhance the power of the machine. Gradually the processor became more complex. We were not disturbed by this because computer

graphics, after all, are complex. Finally the display processor came to resemble a full-fledged computer with some special graphics features. And then a strange thing happened. We felt compelled to add to the processor a second, subsidiary processor, which, itself, began to grow in complexity. It was then that we discovered a disturbing truth. Designing a display processor can become a never-ending cyclical process. In fact, we found the process so frustrating that we have come to call it the "wheel of reincarnation." We spent a long time trapped on that wheel before we finally broke free." In Sutherland's own work with Bell Labs on the development of display processors, he realized that engineering systems became more complex and computationally expensive when they try to control the free flow of communication, and when computer architecture at minimum instantiated local memory on a time-shared system, the display processing was drastically less resource exhaustive. When all data is assumed to be a visible memory that can be extracted for parts, computational processing assumes that security is asserted without boundaries, leading to the normalization of the C language's principle that everything is visible memory. In the development of the CLU language in the 1970s, Barbara Liskov takes the contrasting position: abstracting data by concealing implementation and exposing only the interface, not what happens in between. The separation between a computer kernel and its user assumes a hierarchy between the user and the codebase, where the machine is a fortress that can control access to objects and a user's understanding of how objects move and what data on these objects are being collected.



Butler Lampson developed an adjacent framework for capability-based security models in the 1970s in contrast to the access control list model made ubiquitous in contemporary computing and the expansion of the internet. Although the paper written in 1971 does not mention the word capability, the mechanism shares overlap: "The message system consists of processes that share nothing and communicate with each other

only by means of messages. A message consists of an identification of the sending process followed by an arbitrary amount of data. The identification is supplied by the system and therefore cannot be forged. Processes are assigned integer names by the system in such a way that a given integer always refers to the same process; aside from this property the names have no significance. The sending process supplies the data. Any process may send messages (at its expense) to any other process. Messages are received one at a time in the order in which they were sent...Within this system everything belongs to some process and cannot be accessed by any process other than its owner. Each process is therefore a single domain." What Lampson observed in his allegory of the wheel of reincarnation accepts the reality of the thermodynamic cost of control when risk assessment is centralized into architectural complexity as a pressure valve. Lampson's model does not proceed from the assumption that a runaway process like message passing needs to situate the control system of a digital interface through the borders of a program or software, instead providing a more autonomous communication framework which starts with the assumption of what someone can show rather than who they are. The computer scientists in the Xerox PARC era were exploring how to navigate practical questions of how computational complexity can mediate communication between users through common practice, and in this exploration emerged two competing tensions: validating access through distributed trust (assuming users can coordinate boundaries in how they communicate) and centralized control systems (assuming a ring around a user can keep them secure). Carl Hewitt's Actor Model, in 1973, operates congruently to the former, asserting a computational model with no centralized shared state that enforces security and instead formalizing a computational substrate based on message passing between autonomous agents. Hewitt's model assumes that the actors (in this case, users in communication with one another) are simultaneously states and user behaviors, putting users in a fully modular digital environment where exchange data concurrently was grounded in consent between actors who communicated with

each other. The underlying guiding principles underneath the Actor Model that was particularly heterodox in the dominant computer science paradigm of its time included the claim that there is no global time or global order that determines a computational system. Hewitt's thesis contrasted heavily with the mainstream assumptions of the Church-Turing paradigm which asserted that computation was about taking inputs and producing outputs through sequential steps, which Hewitt realized does not account for the interactivity elements of how people interact in virtual environments, presenting a view of computer systems that are open, concurrent, aperiodic, and evolve in runtime rather than completing a proof in polynomial time sequencing on a Turing machine. Hewitt instead realized that computers situate themselves in time no differently than humans do, and the purposes of computation lose their integrity when reduced only to how inputs map to outputs. Beneath this understanding, Hewitt also diverged from the Church-Turing determinism consensus in computing by recognizing the importance of inconsistency-robust logic in distributed systems, where contradictions could not always be repaired at runtime and computation instead evolves through how systems can survive contradictions openly in their reasoning.



The TOPS-20 operating system ran approximately from 1976 to 1988, and the default factory setting for this operating system refused passwords and file permissions entirely. Based on the PDP-10 processor, the TOPS-20 ethos shifted the onus of privacy onto the social conventions that users created amongst themselves. Users could still hide file paths and information at their discretion, but otherwise started from the default that all information and resources in the network are shared in common by its users unless stipulated otherwise by their activity. This is a closer approximation to the Chaosnet network model far removed from the military-funded ARPANET paradigm, which later birthed the TCP/IP protocol that dominates computer

network architecture in the present. Chaosnet did not reflexively assume networks (and thus people) were unreliable or hostile, and instead presented a network model where peers could be trusted, processes were continuous, and failure modes were local. Similarly to Hewitt, Chaosnet asserted that the substrate of computation was ongoing interaction between addressable and situated agents, rooted in stateful conversations, named services rather than stateless ports, and a human-in-the-loop network that functioned as a shared cognitive architecture. Chaosnet allowed users to inspect remote memory, debug distributed systems interactively, and admit the network as a live universe where processes could extend remotely through the interactions between machines. Around the 1970s, a collective effort that included Lee Felsenstein developed the Community Memory network in Berkeley that became the world's first public computerized bulletin board system, with terminals in Leopold's Records near the UC Berkeley campus as well as the early Whole Earth Access storefront that opened in 1969. Eventually, the Community Memory project also installed a terminal in the San Francisco Public Library system. Felsenstein refused state or corporate bottlenecks for any distribution of information, instead shifting the autonomy to users to use and understand the machines they access on a regular basis. There were no user accounts embedded in the Community Memory model, because when a user account is created, the account confers ownership. The Community Memory model was conjunctively engineered by Jude Milhon by way of her pseudonym St. Jude, who advocated for pseudonymous digital identity as a safety mechanism, and a liberation tool for communities who were displaced at the margins. St. Jude coined the term cypherpunk and played a significant part in defining the direction of 80s and 90s cypherpunk culture, rooted deeply in privacy enhancement as collective care, and the feminist punk futurism of the Bay Area that eventually evolved into the generalized cyberpunk aesthetic of the 90s and 2000s. St Jude's declaration that "girls need modems" was an explicitly political act in a digital network that often revolved around the publicized innovations of men embedded

in a prestige economy, instead focusing on how computers could be used to extend the care of everyday life. The parallel development of cyberpunk culture in Japan echoed this ethos of technology as a medium to dissolve the boundaries between cognition, environment, and machine, actively promulgated as cultural norm through creative media franchises such as Serial Experiments Lain and Ghost In The Shell. Video game franchises extended this ethos into the realm of interactive media, including but not limited to the Metal Gear Solid series. Metal Gear Solid, in particular, deliberately blurred the boundaries between player interaction, communication technology, character identity, and place in to reveal a world in which the borders separating them are often artificially enforced.



Much of what we have learned as operational security culture emerged from people who needed it the most to protect themselves from predatory actors in the real world. The vernacular of boundaries as protocol in contemporary therapy discourse, along these lines, marks a severe decoupling from how safety was concretized as mutual care technology between communities in situations where error was fatal. For the sex workers and black queer communities who developed distributed security protocols in real time, boundaries implied a situated continuity of safety negotiated as common practice in conditions of asymmetric power dynamics. Molly Smith and Juno Mac, in *Revolting Prostitutes*, themselves observe how often anti-trafficking efforts resemble border patrol sanctions: “At borders all over the world, sex workers are treated as both villain and victims. Homeland Security officially ban anyone who has sold sex in the previous ten years from entry into the United States, along with spies, Nazis, and terrorists. 10 The border to the United States is a No Man’s Land - and people detained at a Port of Entry have few rights. No warrant, or even reasonable suspicion, is legally required for agents to demand passwords and search through electronic devices like phones

or laptops, or even to clone all the data they find.” Smith and Mac also recognized that in the absence of border technology, sex workers developed the opposite intuitions for safety: sharing information as a network amongst each other, developing communication procedures for violent and predatory clients, and situationally refusing unsafe sexual demands with clear hard limits and boundaries on sexual contact. In contrast to a technology of boundaries as common enforcement of shared safety protocols that could be revocable at any time, modern therapy culture reduces boundaries to individualized moral abstinence at the discretion of an isolated nervous system, abstracted away from material risk or the shared responsibility of repair in relationships beyond the self.



The boundary precipitates form prior to intuition, which can only be admissible insofar as it does not collapse into domination or violation of boundaries. The inference of knowledge does not possess, nor does it represent what it relates to, only maintaining the survival of the medium that makes any relation possible at all. Thus, the boundary is the only form of knowledge whose continuity consists solely in never reducing to ownership or private property. The moment that ownership is the exhaustive logic of the world is the moment that the world is constituted through the violation of boundaries themselves. The recent development of kink in psychology and nonmonogamous relationships, including the modalities of consent and risk-aware negotiation, emerged from sex worker safety culture in this context, which grounds safety in embodied negotiation of boundaries in real time, actions with resource constraints, and refusal of participation that does not moralize or justify beyond a shared relational adherence. Safety as a protective posture within kink recognizes that restraint is socially legible, every action admits resource constraints, harm is socially binding, practices do not survive through abstract definitions outside of lived reality, and that coordination of an experience admits

limits on activity without the inherited moral ritual of sacrifice and shame. In the broader context of safety beyond private erotic experience, what we also understand about how vulnerable communities define safety comes directly from the black transgender women who developed safety out of material necessity and shared survival intelligence. Marsha P. Johnson and Sylvia Rivera, based on our accounts of interviews and Street Transvestite Action Revolutionaries (STAR) materials, derived safety directly out of their own collective care infrastructure, coordinating housing access and rules for street safety norms directly amongst each other to distribute food, shelter, and resources when they would otherwise have been materially deprived of it if left to wait for the state's access to care. STAR was closer to a distributed care network developed specifically for the queer communities who needed it and facilitated rules through exposure of necessity, as opposed to an abstract principle of individualized self-actualization. For a very long time, boundaries were asserted as survival and risk assessment technology for the dispossessed, and over the course of history, the cultural milieu of boundaries mutated into moralized lifestyle choices for individual consumers who assumed intimate relationships were freely dispositive objects as if they were commodities in the marketplace. For the unsheltered and dispossessed, who are accustomed to the logistics of street life, boundaries evolved through shared conditions rather than just an identity category: high exposure to violence, low institutional protection, constant asymmetric interactions, and minimal appeal to sovereign adjudicative authority. The prisoners, peasants, sex workers, and street formations that needed boundaries created safety infrastructure out of lived necessity, where trust is expensive and error is potentially lethal. These communities recognized that boundaries preceded the border regime of private property rights and outlasted that system decisively, given that the private property system replaces shared boundaries with discretionary exclusion. By recognizing the asymmetry of who gets to have boundaries, border regimes resort to violence to justify their asymmetry.



Our understanding of power does not derive its authority from moral hedging, rhetoric, or belief systems. Power looks more like layouts, audit logging, access conditionals, failure modes, means testing, intake forms, attack surfaces, surveillance regimens, classification schemas, routines of renormalization, schedules, and legal exemptions in fine print. When a border regime is reverse engineered, the machinery of a control system unfolds beneath the shell of its interface, but what is lost in its aesthetic window dressing is exactly as Stafford Beer axiomatized: the purpose of a system is what it does. Given the constraints a system produces, we can recognize exactly where, for instance, a prison may produce subjugation, or a border produces illegality, or how guard labor produces surveillance. Guard labor, in this sense, is just the human substrate that enables a border regime to function as a system as opposed to an abstraction. Border regimes persist through distributed stress absorption beyond a concentrated point load(a magistrate or a president) and into the plethora of load paths in the form of security conscripts, care workers, prison wardens, migration patrol, paramilitary oathkeepers, national intelligence agents, property managers, private equity brokers, managerial middleware, and any additional configuration that can keep a border enforced without an immediately intelligible load distribution. Without guard labor, there is no border to guard, no surveillance at everyday scale, and coercion as a disciplinary method loses its routine. In this sense, guard labor is not morally specific, but it is procedural, enabling a broader regime to displace risk exposure and distribute its failure modes into an ensemble of warm bodies that participate in border patrol, law enforcement, surveillance contracts, welfare eligibility, transit fare checkers, and mandated reporting. Diffusing a border regime into the distribution of guard labor positions its mercenaries as morally interoperable, personally culpable, affectively scarce, and structurally powerless beyond the custody of the space where people are excluded. The stability of any system is ultimately determined by its procedures,

and in the absence of stability, the procedures of a system determine the threshold of acceptable instability. Power, in this sense, does not rule through belief systems or rhetoric, but ultimately through payroll, training budgets, throughput targets, staffing ratios, and contractual obligation. Where mercy disappears, power seems to grow, because the cost of control has been deferred, not eliminated. There is nothing strong about a regime that needs to eliminate mercy, since such regimes burn future stability to purchase control over the present.



Before power structures move from narrative to jurisdiction, borders operationalize a runtime execution layer that compiles abstract symbols into discretionary statutes. What is commonly marketed as the "rule of law" is simply the rule of discrete compilation embedded in the adjudicative authority that a system confers upon itself. Abstract law converts into concrete violence through this machinery as the law is expressed in everyday life by humans and the machinery they produce, be they conferred by the judgment of a credentialed officer or the output of an algorithm. By the time we conceptualize borders through the arbitrariness of their design, the undefined behavior introduced in the compilation process becomes obvious as a design feature, whether jurisdiction is meted out by the opacity of a sheriff's department or the middleware architecture in a given digital tool suite. The 20th century computer scientists and cyberneticians understood that when control systems centralize authority through extra procedural steps instead of diffusing consent into the everyday use of a network's participants, they expose the thermodynamic cost of additional control in order to discipline the public through borders and access control restrictions. When a system is compelled to justify itself procedurally rather than through an advertising budget or egoic stabilization, the mystique of its administrative machinery wanes in the face of public scrutiny. Beneath the veneer of public relations budgets are largely cost structures, actuarial tables, exculpatory clauses, stakeholder

obligations, line items, path dependencies, and liabilities to the value of a product by the optics of its consumption. When all of these restrictions are diagrammed to unfold the policies and procedures, institutions default to operating at a price that can only be tolerated through coerced obedience to the symbolic order even if the outcomes are materially worse for them and everyone else. At that point, a business is just doing double-entry accounting on its own balance sheets, and this bookkeeping depends on the insolvency of the public. Nation states, monopolies, carceral institutions, and the totality of the value form are expressions of a system architecture that acknowledges the thermodynamic incoherence of its persistence. Once the fog of obfuscation is lifted, institutional power looks less like narrative or folklore and more like how electricity in a building stabilizes: a load center with circuit breakers that you can flip the switch with once you determine the distribution of outlets and the existing plugs, the material constraints of the resource concentration, where the wires connect behind the walls, and where they fail. When Whitfield Diffie and Martin Hellman published *New Directions in Cryptography* in 1976, they committed an act the NSA considered tantamount to treason: they broke the state's monopoly on cryptographic knowledge. Public key cryptography meant anyone could encrypt, anyone could verify, without requiring a trusted courier or central key registry. The NSA attempted to classify the paper after publication, confessing an admission that borders on information are thermodynamically unstable. Once stable operating principles circulate, enforcement of borders becomes operationally unsalvageable. In contrast, Norm Abramson's ALOHAnet connected the Hawaiian islands in 1971 onward through wireless packet radio with a pure contention protocol: transmit whenever you want, if it collides, try again. No central coordinator, no permission system, no hierarchy. This inspired Bob Metcalfe's Ethernet, which was originally designed as a broadcast medium where every node hears everything, with no addressing hierarchy. The carrier sense multiple access with collision detection (CSMA/CD) protocol presents

a model of systems design that obligates constraints through activity:
no central coordinator, just listen before you speak.



Fred Moten explores the ethics of the face in how it emerges in the philosophy of Emmanuel Levinas, and he departs from the common liberal humanist interpretation that characterizes Levinas as a theorist of inclusion and recognition. Moten situates Levinas through a more exacting lens: the uses of ethics as labor to render the outside world legible without capture, and ethics itself as a translation device that cannot be reduced to schema or rulesets that reify the status quo. Moten is very clear, in his interdiction of Levinas (and Franz Rosenzweig by proxy) that ethics require a refusal of capture at the level of form: “The ethical imperative of translation-more fundamentally, the figuring of the ethical as translation-bears, in breath, a utopian social weight, the heft and density of a rematerialization of the city from deep outside. But how will the outside have irrupted into the incorporatively exclusionary nexus of the Bible and the Greeks that is implied in Rosenzweig and amplified in Levinas? And what does that nexus tell us about the project of philosophy as Levinas defines it, the danger of philosophy as he diagnoses it? What if we trace the decaying orbit of his commitments by way of their own units and methods of measure?” Moten does not interpret a face as a demand to be recognized or included, but as an expression of something more intimate: the designation of ethics as that which cannot be recuperated by institutions for spectacle, and thus the condition for life to expand at all. The institutional purposes of philosophy and the metaphysical constraints of ethics assume that we can forensically audit the systems that preemptively decide what to exclude from legibility. If modern border regimes are defined by what is reported to them, then the institutions of philosophy and law admit interpretation as a translation device, with their own quantifiable metrics, admissibility criteria, and incorporative exemptions. Felsenstein and St. Jude recognized

this in the Community Memory system; in fact, the network they created explicitly refused to make any user legible to the system because legibility ultimately begets institutional capture. The process of translation can either embolden the technology of enforcement, or translate into relationships that reciprocate safety. We are ultimately not above reproducing the mechanisms for either trajectory for as long as they persist in lived reality.



Édouard Glissant operationalizes the “right to opacity” in his own work, more closely aligning with the models of indigenous communities who understand that the necessity of a state or border to collect information as a prerequisite of access to a centralized interface can beget violence through exposure, and more frequently to this day, we see examples of metadata openly harvested for the purposes of ad revenue in dominant business models such as Meta’s social graph infrastructure. When metadata ceases to be stable as a business procedure, the fragility of this business approach reveals itself through the severe relaxing of content validation and graph distribution of how a personal feed is structured in a social network, resulting in a mass flood of disinformation that caters to people based on what performs optimally as engagement metrics and reactions from users. The baseline security layer can only function when people simply refuse to have information collected on them at all as a requirement to participate in a network. In such a model that starts with the option for users to not consent to data harvesting for search engine optimization or for engagement metrics, they reserve the capability of asserting illegibility to the state and marketplace as a first class object. Our current model of the internet assumes that this can be toolled in the local privacy settings of a computer or setting up VPN infrastructure with machinery akin to Tor’s exit node model, but illegibility as first class primitive asserts something more fundamental: the refusal of data extraction as a condition of participating in the digital ecosystem

that does not depend on the technology of the end user. Instead, the illegibility principle accepts that the end user is the first to decide if they want to be perceived by the infrastructure they use, designating full autonomy in the user for how they want to disclose information online. If a user asserts this principle, the institutions they participate in waive any right to store their data or prosecute them for any risk exposure posed to an institution based on what the user declares is accessible to the public. The default assumption in such a model aligns more closely with the early actor-based computational models which recognized the community was an autonomous entity that could decide collectively what the common safety protocols were, and could propose refinements to network protocols accordingly. The agency to refuse disclosure for a centralized digital registry does not suddenly disappear when someone accesses technology or a public library, because refusal to participate in that disclosure proceeds from the premise that social interactions are reciprocally accountable and relationally determined. Refusal to be governed by a proprietary database does not forfeit validation by mediation, because autonomy precedes an interface. Whether or not people can coordinate care and resources amongst themselves, in the absence of authority gluing them as a mandatory prosthesis for institutional function, does not inherently obligate them to survive through abduction in order to exist. The insistence that an illegibility principle compromises the integrity of a service provider demonstrates more about what an institution is required to suppress through force rather than what users actually inhere to participate safely in a network they share through use. A privacy model which cannot tolerate illegibility as a first class peer unable to be mined for a central database inherently accepts the premise that the only legible qualification for privacy begins with exploitation.

Beyond just Community Memory, such examples have existed at scale and expressed resilience that a brittle access control model lacks, but faced compromise precisely because they operated in an environment where resource concentration could dominate how technology circulated or persisted in its adoption. Dave Clark, who previously operated through MIT and the Internet Architecture Board, explicitly rejected voting as a representative democratic protocol and presented standardization through consensus and running code. The Internet Engineering Task Force (IETF) was particularly radical in granting any user the autonomy to propose an RFC (shared internet protocol), and left decisions to be made through the implementation process rather than a central veto authority. The ISO/ITU model that regulates RFC submissions operates in strict contrast to this approach, shifting authorization burden onto committees and states to determine which protocols are adopted at scale. Jon Postel's approach, codified in RFC 760, famously argues for "being conservative in what you send and liberal in what you accept", diffusing DNS and IP address allocation from his desk without oversight or a central committee until the NSF commercialized the DNS protocol in 1998. In 1986, David Unger took the Smalltalk reference implementation and removed discrete object classes entirely through his release of the SELF language, creating a prototype-based programming model that treated objects as unique differentiable entities that can delegate inheritance rules without any taxonomy in between. The SELF language was an attempt to create a programming infrastructure exclusively dependent on user relationships and what they delegate, rather than the identity of an object defining the relationship for them. In the 1960s, the first online community was built by Don Bitzer in the form of PLATO, predating the military ARPANET by several years. PLATO operated on a flat-panel plasma display engineered specifically to be used for the network, with features that included touch screens, forums, email, instant messaging, and multiplayer games even decades prior to when these features became commonplace in personal devices. The underground subcultures of PLATO created an entire parallel system of

extensions through programs such as Talkomatic in 1973 which created the first real time chatroom environment, as well as Notes which formalized a model for threaded discussion forums long before Usenet or comments sections on websites were culturally ubiquitous. Students even developed the first graphical massively multiplayer online (MMO) dungeon crawler through Avatar in 1979, in spite of the university's own efforts to lock the system from students who they otherwise deemed to be hacking into their system. Brian Dear noted in *The Friendly Orange Glow* that Plato lost its creative community and its cultural development of the online world as a result of concerted efforts to commercialize the project, eventually mutating into Control Data's PLATO through a fee-based model.



Surveillance is just a predictive control system decoupled from reciprocal feedback or consent. Any system that needs to predict a person without the recourse of correcting this prediction has already failed to stabilize from the outset, because prediction without reciprocal correction converts feedback into drift. If we read Norbert Wiener more closely, we would realize that the “control” in “control system” meant mutual constraint adjustment shared between participants in one feedback loop, not central command from a sovereign machine to its subject. Wiener carefully argues any predictive system that decouples the observer from the observed in a social system compromises on the stability of the system: “It is in the social sciences that the coupling between the observed phenomenon and the observer is hardest to minimize. On the one hand, the observer is able to exert a considerable influence on the phenomena that come to his attention. With all respect to the intelligence, skill, and honesty of purpose of my anthropologist friends, I cannot think that any community which they have investigated will ever be quite the same afterward. Many a missionary has fixed his own misunderstandings of a primitive language as law eternal in the process of reducing it

to writing. There is much in the social habits of a people which is dispersed and distorted by the mere act of making inquiries about it.” Proceeding from Wiener’s own understanding of the relationship between observer and system, the core of security and privacy arises from symmetric propagation of integrity. This principle does not begin with whether information or resources are shared, but whether intelligibility behind signals circulates through guardrails against distortion or durable episodes of misunderstanding. Discoveries about the world are only secure if they cannot be hijacked faster than they are shared and understood. Prometheus’s discovery of fire had no patent or profit motive, only a process of discovery that accelerated the interdependence of human civilization, and also the wrath of gods that insisted the elements were not the providence of mere mortals, and could trace the source of the discovery from the person who revealed the fire to others. Security principles with integrity require us to flip security completely upside down. Security is not compromised in what is found, but what is traced. For effective cryptography, one assumes for example that security proceeds from collectively determined protocols, not classified information regimes behind smoke and mirrors. Capability-based security models approximate this paradigm by engineering authorization through cryptographically unforgeable tokens, rather than identity auditing from a central access control list. This model reframes security as something you do and something you can revoke your consent for, rather than a judgment passed down by a central authority. When a capability is exercised, a system must handle the consequences of this action and the side effects that ripple outward from it. Recent programming language theory also introduced the concept of side effects as first class objects for provenance-based security; in other words, a capability specifies what happens, and the context of a side effect determines how that happening is handled. Separating capability from side effects gives a system its flexibility to shape how the same action has different consequences based on who invokes it and where the invocation may be happening.



In the classical sense of the word *asphaleia*, we recognize how the earliest forms of security were defined: security ultimately meant collective material stability and a shared sense of intellectual or spiritual integrity, which cannot be contingent on a badge or a judge to determine the exemptions for how stability is afforded. Security, ultimately, is grounded in conditions rather than how permission to common resources is adjudicated. *Asphaleia* is not an abstract legal doctrine, but a felt experience negatively determined by absence: absence of panic, absence of catastrophe, absence of collapse, and absence of defensive work to justify shared responsibility of care as safety protocol. In this sense, the classical understanding of security contrasts deeply with the modern conception of boundaries, and especially with the classical application of *nomos* as how authoritarian regimes may arrange space after deciding who may live and think. Safety, in the earliest senses of the term, defines the baseline of resources of what people need in order to live and think. Such a historically situated safety principle assumed security emerged from conditions rather than from exceptions, exclusions, and active policing of borders that cordon off resources and knowledge that would otherwise be held in common. The absence of panic was not policed into existence or conditioned onto the public through brute force compliance; rather, the negative determination of instability grounded the environment where resources were shared freely. Modern security, by prioritizing borders and surveillance, inverts this continuity of practice by assuming that insecurity is natural, alienation and hostility precede care, and this predetermined proviso of scarcity must be managed through an industrial architecture of mass exclusion. The resources needed to power this architecture reveal the diagram of a system marred by incorrigible degrees of instability, inefficiency, and thermodynamic incoherence baked into the governance. Our decision to accept governance through predatory, brittle architecture loses its

illusions when we decide to no longer route through them in exchange for distributed care and safety.

“No form remains permanently in a substance; a constant change takes place, one form is taken off and another is put on.”

– Maimonides, Guide to the Perplexed

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Reality is not collapsible to a single observer or narrative, but something real is always evolving, socially mediated, and that something is not created from a meaningless nothing. It would be plausible to assert what appears in the world is resolution-relative as opposed to observer-relative. This is distinct and separate from the notion that meaning and reality are socially constructed, which reduces reality to whatever we individually or collectively decide is real. An observer-relative posture may incidentally lead to a slippery slope towards relativism, solipsism, and nihilism in which nothing actually has value, weight, or consequence beyond what humans may agree to, which erases the complexity of the ecosystem beyond the meaning humans decide is relevant. The structure what appears depends substantially on the granularity and admissibility of its refinement. In effect, this grounds truth and meaning in joint stabilization of participants in compatibility conditions within a system that is continuously evolving over time and exposure. If we treat reality as having its own adaptations to granular encodings of truth and information, we recognize that the process of life is actually much more inclusive beyond what humans decide is true through language. This requires a more collaborative relationship between ourselves and the dynamic systems around us to discover patterns that exceed our

experiences but can only be known and found through exposure to each other.



Philip Johnson-Laird researched models of cognition that share processes between human and machine reasoners by testing for common heuristics on how thought and experience may cohere through the diagramming and mapping of information. His conclusions in 2013 reveal a particular overlap in his pursuit of a model in cognition that is psychical and physical simultaneously: "What is common to the model theory of deduction, abduction, and induction? The answer is that all three rely on models of possibilities. Reasoners can construct models from descriptions and from perception, and they can retrieve them from knowledge. They deduce conclusions from models. They connect one set of models to another to abduce causal explanations. They determine that one model should take precedence over another that contradicts it, and thereby retract conclusions that facts refute. They use kinematic models in order to determine the conditions in which a loop of operations should halt, and to deduce the consequences of informal programs. They induce probabilities for unique events by transforming a proportion in a model into an analog representation of a magnitude." In how we receive and process the continuity of sign systems, the model of a world glued by signs and their relationships assembles through the phaneroscopy of language and logic, as signs transform through interactions with the world they inhabit. By phaneroscopy, we assume no immediate subdivision of physics and phenomena; instead, we assume an enquiry into the genealogy of natural concepts, the cognate regularities amongst stabilized appearances, and the taxonomy of the modes by which stability appears.



Heinrich Hertz once wrote in his work *Principles of Mechanics* that physical theories can be conceptualized as mental images of the world derived from the perceptual system of a physicist. Hertz framed physical theories not as accounts of forces acting on matter, but as internally consistent representations in a geometric frame whose relations approximate the lawful relations of the physical world. This is the opposite of calling something a social construct by claiming pure epistemic relativism; rather, Hertz is describing the scientific method as structurally mediated, carrying a lot of useful context that composes with the variation and evolutionary kinship of an intellectual lineage at a given time. In echoing how Johnson-Laird determines the constraints of cognition, both of their frameworks share a cognate resemblance in between by establishing models of representational systems that derive validation from structural correspondence rather than an external semantic fiat. For Hertz, any theory of physics would necessarily require unobserved phenomena that are not measured or accounted for, and his approach collapses the necessity of physics to complete the entire cartography of the cosmos with something far more relieving of the pressure from a grand theory: a model of physics can explain how some things are objective for everyone, but not everything, since a physical model tracks the structural constraints of the given time that it is proposed. Hertz's framework of physics is one that maintains a correspondence between observable models and physical reality while also honoring the internal constraints of the representation a snapshot of physics may give us. Mass and force are convenient modeling languages inherited from Newtonian mechanics, but do not constitute a complete substrate by themselves.



It is also important to note that Hertz derived some of his insights from Hermann von Helmholtz, who developed a prototypical theory of semiosis decades before the concept was proposed by Peirce. In Helmholtz's *Treatise on Physiological Optics*, he describes perception

as an active unconscious inference: "The most universal sign by which subjective visual phenomena can be identified appears to be by the way they accompany the movement of the eye over the field of view. Thus, the afterimages, the mouches volantes, the blind spot, and the "luminous dust" of the dark field all participate in the motions of the eye, and coincide successively with the various stationary objects in the visual field. On the other hand, if the same phenomena recur again invariably at the same places in the visual field, they may be regarded as being objective and as being connected with external bodies. This is the case with contrast phenomena produced by afterimages." Both Hertz and Helmholtz converge on adjacent insights from different sides of the same insight: Hertz describes the internal structure of a physical representation, whereas Helmholtz describes the internal sensation of perceptual reality. Hertz describes a structure of a sign system, whereas Helmholtz describes the process of how signs coordinate patterns indexed over time. Both Hertz and Helmholtz together suggest that the structure of reality is a real thing, but the representation of reality is a shadow of its structure.



The texture of appearance is punctured by a delay between the act of thought and the production of thought. Ideology and information production, in turn, depend on automatic reflexes that reason does not actively generate or control. Some trace of thought is environmentally produced through the visual and relational templates that precede subject or thought formation. The modification of how the world presents itself, outside of the predetermined cultural script one is situated in, assumes a commitment to polarity and friction that trends away from the largely unconscious habits of social life. The norms of institutionally mediated life and communication technology all assume that production of narrative is inherited, and to think in contrast to this narrative is often costly to intervene in. Lewis Mumford, in *The Myth of the Machine*, says the core contradiction plainly: "Our chief

reason for over-rating the importance of tools and machines is that man's most significant early inventions, in ritual, social organization, morals, and language, left no material remains, while stone tools can be associated with recognizable hominid bones for at least half a million years." Beyond the symbolic binding that vitalizes human behavior across bodies and time, the embodied core of reason remains an arrow, piercing through a terrain that is filtered in advance before anyone participates in it. Cognition, much to a fault, is materially distributed and institutionally organized before subjects inherit the burden of thought. While the interpretive layer of thinking is privately generated by individuals, the persistence of reason and action in bodies is environmentally constituted and infrastructurally stabilized. Coupling to our environments through people, books, devices, and media adds layers of meaning, but also subtracts from us by filtering what is thinkable or actionable upon arrival into experience. In contrast to the perspective that cognition is internal first and externally coupled second, the conditions for cognition to evolve at all are constituted ecologically by systems of memory, representation, labor, and place, where the cost of reconfiguring nervous systems is compromised by the price of reorganizing archives and redistributing attention towards the environments where interactions occur.



In this regard, our contemporary moment was diagnosed with surgical precision by Hideo Kojima in Metal Gear Solid 2. We can validate this form of media for what it represents beyond just being a video game from 2001, the way that folklore and mythologies represent the hermeneutic interpretation of their time and context. Metal Gear Solid 2 predicted many of the problems of the Information Age because it could intuit them: the era of unmitigated information access and instant connection that the Silicon Valley gospels of internet expansion have proselytized about. Kojima is not writing a parable about a specific dictator or moment in history that happens to be driven by the internet,

and in a broader sense, Metal Gear Solid 2 is not about Silicon Valley or the internet at all as much as it is generally about authoritarian control over information technology. The game actually forces the player to encounter this flooding of disinformation to sharpen its point in a sequence where the communication tools that protagonist uses have been completely distorted and produce nothing but floridly derealized radio content that the player listens to without interruption. The S3 (Selection for Societal Sanity) Plan from the game cuts at a deeper level, because the game describes a strategy that oligarchic regimes have been instrumentalizing for generations: to maintain control over people, a state or corporate entity must leverage the information technology of their time to game the outcomes of information volume in their favor. Informational access is freedom, until you realize that the symbols which information rests upon are capable of being manipulated and weighed down by authoritarian rule. This is by design: the Information Age accelerated the decoupling and widening gulf between access to information and access to diffused power, and was able to accelerate the volume of information while continuing to monopolize state and corporate power. This will be ultimately what the Information Age is remembered for, the same way that the Fordist and Sloanist turn of the Industrial Revolution led to the atomization and siloing of individuals into domains of knowledge, widening the gulf between knowledge production and power. Over the last decades of recorded history, we have been slowly alienated from sensemaking without the mediation of an interface that conditions how sensemaking is done. Any contemporary directive that discretizes reality to what can be simulated or computed for benchmarking is simply borrowing from the anxiety of the 20th century verification principle inherited after the A.J. Ayer positivist paradigm, in which reality may only fit the tools we authorize to control it. Despite any reflex to claim rejection of metaphysical assumptions, both seasons of positivist dogma operate through the metaphysics of an unacknowledged purchasing policy in which they cannot return their ontology back to the emporium.



Richard Dawkins wrote about the cultural circulation of memes: ideas propagating through information exchange and replicating information from others. Memes are just one sign lineage of culture within the semiosphere, but when algorithmically amplified as primary in the informational landscape, mimetics as a military instrument risks flattening all other sign lineages into a status caricature. A meme is cavitation-stable in an online environment that congeals through bifurcation and semantic gradient density, rendering the extremity of routing pressure as the only filter that does not disintegrate under differentiation or stress. Media ecologies are phased artifacts of kinetic mechanics and survivable load paths, and no amount of participation or volumetric knowledge base can rectify the incentive structure of a media form that engineers semantic pressure gradients by design. High-traffic discursion clusters, such as social media websites or news aggregator forums such as Reddit, function as cavitation zones for popularized ideas and rigidified habits of social interaction, compressing the flow of information through shear turbulence rather than stabilized alignment. The circulation of ideas in the high shear fluid zones of online discourse under semantic saturation can only survive reduction to cultural meme and moral verdict, since any further exposure under the pressure vent of algorithmic admissibility would collapse under stress based on the engagement metrics rewarded by the platform. In rheological terms, the epistemic material of viral online content consists of maximally high surface area, but minimally thin chamber wall density, leading information to fracture brittily under interaffective contact. This is at the root of what the concept of mimesis really reveals as its mechanism: through the evolutionary process that spans across time, we imitate the exchange of information that is translated and exchanged with the world at the most basic level, a transmission of our symbolic context of how we view the world in relation to ourselves and others.



This symbolic load, however, doesn't just live at the level of material and temporal experience, it co-constitutes the fundamental structural health and integrity of the world. Mimetic production and transmission is monopolized by authoritarian structures to separate our ability to process information from the ability to participate in the world around us. The state and business interests have deputized themselves to control the replication and variation mechanisms of society – including but not limited to what information is reproduced, who reproduces this information, what variations of this information are permissible and which are swiftly voided, and who decides legibility of the information that others may share, even if the information speaks the truth. If we are to consider the world is simulated by us and not by others, and that our experiences are invariantly always contextual, we already have leverage over authoritarian sources of power that are withholding power that belongs automatically to everyone to ensure we live in a scarcity-free and cooperative world for the survival of all life. We don't have the challenges of mass censorship that defined societies far less connected digitally than ours, since information could be traced easily and suppressed as opposed to just the context of our world being suppressed by way of jackboot. Even Bruno Latour, whose influence is canonical in the humanities, warned of the disintegration of shared inquiry in his 2004 essay "Why Has Critique Run Out of Steam?" with stunning clarity. Latour articulated the distinction between "matters of fact" and "matters of concern," recognizing that the turn towards institutional fear and atomization of meaning was already lurching the humanities toward the latter. Latour acknowledged that reactive critique and reflexive distrust of constructive metaphysical frameworks is always too late, and that the construction of a newer, more rigorous epistemic universe is always on time.



The US military has studied and researched mimetic warfare for decades at this point, and to share this detail does not signal a conspiratorial tone or paranoia of any sort because the research is publicly available and searchable, much of which remains accessible in DARPA's archives. The US Marine Corps published an Operational Studies thesis in 2005 under Major Michael B. Prosser, by which he describes mimetics as a nonlinear combat strategy: "Future war within the ideological realm requires a force structure annealed to the nonlinear battlefield strata. The US military does not possess a doctrine or prescription for the contest contained in the nonlinear battle space of an enemy's mind or even the complex paradigm of the noncombatant. However, with some modifications, it is possible to achieve a new level of understanding and capability to achieve parity and perhaps even superiority in this realm. A good start is an acknowledgement from senior leadership to the degree that more than token efforts and resources are required in pursuit of achieving advantage in non-linear battle." Prosser recognized early on during the height of the Iraq War that the best way to win against an enemy is to master the ideological metaphysical terrain as opposed to just the material physical terrain, because swarming the enemy with a disease of information disorients them and dislodges their ideas. Attention and cognition become a strategic target by which a threat can be assessed and neutralized before they can act. The rhetorical weaponization of "matters of concern" against the alleged creep of terrorism applies here – The Iraq War was just a test case of what was already happening when information could replicate faster than it could be verified in absence of a durable epistemic hinge, destabilizing the entire collaborative sense-making architecture in favor of a designated enemy.



In 2011, the Social Media for Defense Summit in Virginia presented a tutorial on "Military Mimetics" as the culmination of multiple different research research threads, based on projects that Dr. Robert

Finkelstein of Robotics Technology Inc. conducted on behalf of DARPA between 2006 and 2009. Part of DARPA's early 2000s research arc began with their work on Epidemiology of Ideas, which includes a line of US defense research on the virality of ideas and the pathogen-like nature of ideas, by which DARPA packages it as "to predict changing culture and examine the creation, propagation, and impact of ideas." The modern Information Age has proven to be a ripe playground for the propagation of the meme as a replicable force; that is, replication of ideas and oversaturation of ideas are both tools that institutions can use to their advantage in conjunction with the narratives they already seek to maintain as credible. Given the unprecedented amount of access the digital era has given us, the dominant authoritarian institutions have adapted long before the image macro meme became a viral medium in social media information exchange. The US military researched meme transmission in painstaking detail partly because the meme gave the United States an edge in their counterterrorism efforts against Al Qaeda in the US invasion of Iraq and Afghanistan. Not too dissimilar from the diffusion of the internet, the Pentagon's research on memes diffused into the public sphere gradually as a feature of how institutions navigate questions of maintaining discipline through narrative virality, attention drain, and mimetic engineering, be they corporations or political coalitions. Bear in mind, Metal Gear Solid 2 came out in November 2001, roughly two months after the September 11th attacks.



The mimetic crisis is one that is not won through firepower or by artillery. The information economy cedes terrain when ideas can spread as social contagion without meaning or purpose beyond simply swarming you with meaninglessness. Mimetics are fundamentally an air power doctrine in the digital age, by which the boundary between civilian and combatant dissolves and everyone becomes a target for surveillance infrastructure. As a contemporary surveillance

technology and an aerial attack vector in metaphysical terrain, mimetic engineering focuses more on controlling the environment via ambience and atmosphere, given the contagion-like approach to using information as a tool of warfare. Conceptualizing of surveillance today through singular pieces of legislation like the PATRIOT Act, drone weaponry, or the brochure of services provided by products like the Ring home security camera or the Flock camera network miss the point about how deeply mimetic engineering has embedded into every facet of social life, to the point where social media algorithms become their own proprietary fiefdom that cater strictly to wearing the consumer thin and placid. Given that everyone frequently needs to use Google or social media to develop their networks, skillsets and careers, the price of connectivity is paid by society regardless of whether you drop out of using these tools or not. The digital economy benefits from this model, and does not even need to profit from it given how speculative of an enterprise data centers tend to be. The terrain in this age has shifted from ballistic force to mimetic force, and everyone participates knowingly or unknowingly in an informational battlefield by which their metabolic capacity is the target as opposed to just physical territory. Mimetics are a disembodied force that disembodies social life, a power without locality that renders life antisocial and socially dead. The shared commons of meaning in the global continuum is disintegrating at the seams through nonlinear fragmentation of a shared ecology of cognition, where society is socially and affectively starved for purpose and care. The infrastructure for meaning-making is arrested by systems that reward feedback-driven epistemic collapse at scale. In the 20th century, national civic religions, mass media, and industrial workplace culture facilitated this atomization, but the internet has atomized the commons of meaning further into incommensurability, propagated iteratively by platform-mediated fissure and closed algorithmic feedback loops. Epistemic legitimacy and political legitimacy are orthogonally governed by distinct regulatory environments, both of which are collapsed within

the transmission channel of mass discourse production, and the noise floor that mediates it.



When the circulation of exposed information circulates at a velocity over time that exceeds what a noise floor can accommodate, the differential pressure induced by accelerating information for short-term gain eventually capitulates mechanically and somatically, as if a pipe degrading from the acceleratory shear of fluid pressure. The short term gain may look like profit or media platform control, but the long term gain looks more like self-surveillance, saturation, and epistemic autoimmunity. The phase drift of ecological decay often does not look visible under pugilistic conditions of war or famine, and more often than not resembles a gradual externalization of threat assessment and surveillance burden onto individuals to compensate for fractured systems. What exacerbates the collapse looks less like material erosion and more like loss of audibility, even when you can still hear with both ears intact. The mass replication of mimetic engineering by state and capitalist society creates a discontinuity of *mutatis mutandis* where ideas mutate regardless of their content, resulting in the kind of gravitational pull in which the practice of collaborative sensemaking dissolves and echo chambers are magnified into watchtowers that nobody can escape from. The strategy in communication networks that reward engagement through theater is transparently fraudulent: one can take an entire network of layered semiotic associations and lineages within the semiosphere, strip away the complexity of context and gradation, amplify it through social media platforms that prioritize intra-affective tribal cognition over shared infrastructure, and the entire social fabric erodes at scale. The epidemiology underneath this process mechanically reproduces the noise by social contagion – not only do people stop making sense, they also stop participating in the process of sense-making with others, and instead opt for the intermittent gratification that ironic detachment gives them. In any

informational exchange space, this tends to resemble a pattern: bad faith engagement, gaslighting, sealioning, projection of one's beliefs that they accuse others of, deflection of one's own integrity by defensive posture, and a generalized autoimmune response towards receptivity to information at all. We are gradually witnessing a society in which burnout and alienation are regularized, but signification floats freely into personalized narrative dominance without boundaries. As a result, we are upholding every resource we have against a technology of domination that does not lead with logical integrity built in, nor does it assume it needs those constraints to outmaneuver reality. The mimetic infrastructure and surveillance technology underneath it begins to make a fully mechanized autopilot way of living feel like the only truly liberating way to live, and for those who build their world on a trail of grievance, predation, ego, avolition, unresolved trauma, repressed eros, meaninglessness, and resentment, this freedom is deeply liberating.



Late in his career, Wittgenstein presents the concept of hinge propositions: fundamental assumptions that you do not need to prove because they are accepted at face value, rather than something you need to perform justification for against skeptics and true believers. We do not govern our lives merely through hinge propositions, but more broadly through hinge conventions: the common sense agreements of an ambient space of rules that are assumed epistemic boundaries without justification prior to downstream interpretive authority. Common sense is partially defined by James Gregory's description of procedural intelligence, by which he defines common sense as a habituated responsiveness to environments. We extend this further into the space of procedural esemplasticity, in which hinge conventions are only as durable as whether the conventions of a social system and its infrastructure continue operating, and whether those conventions are responsive to repair at the scale of

pathology without collapsing under contradiction. Without the capacity to adapt and repair harmful interactions and crossed boundaries, hinge conventions are susceptible to destabilization. Hinge conventions are socially stabilized assumptions that modern social media ecosystems may predictively enforce in workflows, norms, and procedural defaults without requiring an interpretation beyond what media environments already select for. Our current media and capitalist ecosystem is built on the incentive to destabilize and systemically erode the hinges if it assures that authority is maintained and the stock value remains stable enough to keep the machine going.



Hinges may not be shared by users within a social media platform, but they can be enforced through proprietary algorithms as long as the rules and norms of the platform are accepted to keep the userbase active. One may simply encounter wrongdoing and identify patterns that reframe how people think or propose an alternative in the current informational ecosystem, and it may look like having to demonstrate to a family member they caused harm and then being dismissed with a non sequitur or a learned helplessness. If someone responds to lived experience and reason with conspiracy and hostility instead of deeper inquiry, there is only so much one can do short of refusing to encourage the system that has no guardrails to prevent the hinges of reality from folding inward into distortion. The infrastructure is built this way and cannot be reformed, only replaced with a system that can handle complexity without collapse. The infrastructure of surveillance and alienation consumes people slowly, and they begin to reason mechanistically rather than psychosomatically, converting entire populations of people into automatons who can only extract themselves from the machine by refusing to surrender agency. The environment filters for automatons – collaborative sense-making often gets buried underneath the machinery, and the environment rewards the same mechanical reproduction of patterns that filters downstream

into lived experience. The environment conditions its participants not to process information, only to react to it, converting our sense-making into an input-output model not unlike that of a syntactically consistent machine. The machines that facilitate these outputs do not require authentic self-correction or holding complexity of competing narratives without logical explosion, so there are no surprises when we start to see our lovers and our friends inhabit this playbook by opting out of the process of sense-making entirely. The infrastructure accelerates its capture through the success of its conversions.



If the pattern begins to click, it's because the post-Fordist era in the Information Age has extended the financialization of capital in the 20th century to the financialization of language. Words become social currency: you can trade in high engagement volume for credibility, or gain purchase on ideas regardless of whether those ideas have utility beyond the performance of the ideas and circulation of the signs that signal these ideas. Participation in information exchange is commodified into the lowest common denominator that is digestible for mass circulation and virality, and our attention spans are conditioned accordingly to our consumption habits. Our shared capacity for sense-making atrophies in such a model because there is no incentive to make sense at all. You can either use language as a game of status or a game of connection, but you cannot do both. Once we recognize the game is everywhere and we are always playing regardless of actual beliefs or choices, the distinction between the use value of an idea and the exchange value of an idea becomes clearer, as well as the agency to choose which game you want to play. Even if you opt out individually of the game of status rotation that reality is structured on, you cannot opt out of reality itself; rather, you can only opt out from the responsibility of participating in the coherence of reality. The illusion of a tech oligarch like Elon Musk pursuing acquisition of the majority shareholder and owner of a social media platform to

protect “freedom of speech” also obfuscates what they are really getting at, or what a lot of the myriad reactionary advocates of free speech advocate for, which is what they’ve alluded to the entire time: they’re not interested in freedom of speech for other people at all. They are interested in only the freedom they can own and enclose upon others. Speech becomes a *ceteris paribus* assumption within the epidemiology of ideas, which is a phraseology that DARPA is intimately familiar with because they researched it decades ago. The late modern period is paying the consequences of refused sensemaking by revealing the saturation within entire populations of social life into deep loneliness. People inhabiting the Information Age are not uniquely isolatory from community, morally culpable, or historically illiterate; rather, they are uniquely plagued with the effective loneliness of a world that selects for the inadmissibility and inaudibility of boundaries, care, relations, or limits. People sometimes speak, and can sometimes receive auditory signals, but even when they retain a sensory channel, they are uniquely pressured to hear themselves and not other people. Narcissism does not describe this phenomena, clinically or subclinically, because underneath the scarce responsiveness of the self is the selection pressure of solipsism: We can hear ourselves in the primacy of our subjectivity, but the response required by this indulgence precipitates into brinkmanship between people that cannot accept misalignment. Subjectivity becomes a stable reference frame in an environment where no other signal is reliable other than inexhaustible expression, whether in technology, work, or social connection.



The premise instantiating freedom of speech requires discourse to be answerable to harm, invalidation, or exploitation. Free speech absolutism assumes an environment where all perspectives are admissible as testimony, the load distribution of intellectual labor is shared even when knowledge is asymmetric, and the circulation of knowledge matches the storage of knowledge in practice. Speech does not diffuse

ex situ, but filtering the logic of violence and invalidation through admissible speech drives distortion beyond just discursive trajectories in the expanse of reality. For as long as there is a gap between communicability and admissibility, speech is neither libre nor gratis. Free speech advocates may only be understood retroactively as the ones who decide the dispossessed can speak without the entrapment of inadmissibility, without the threat assessment of their knowledge falling prey to subjugation. The oligarchs are interested in protecting their fantasy of premature closure and optimizing the world of context that we live in to facilitate alienation and extraction under the pretense of infinite resource depletion. Even if you present information to an abusive or fascistic person that is true or contradicts their worldview, they defer to manipulating the rules of the exchange to maintain their control over others, and thus have no interest in maintaining their illusion of receiving information as long as they can maintain the frame of admissibility. The antisemites of Nazi Germany or European colonists that competed for partitions of Africa maintained similar mechanisms of control: they were unperturbed by the reality that their rhetorical enclosure was also dangerous and unsustainable to themselves, and would rather mediate through rupture as the regulatory band. Frantz Fanon articulates in witnessing the prevailing dignity of colonized people in solidarity with one another: "But sooner or later colonialism realizes it is incapable of achieving a program of socio-economic reforms that would satisfy the aspirations of the colonized masses. Even when it comes to filling their bellies, colonialism proves to be inherently powerless." All authoritarian regimes in the world system fundamentally fail to offer a meaningful and satisfactory reality that doesn't depend on the subjugation and exploitation of others, and recognize that devoting their resources to protecting themselves at any cost, no matter how irrational or expensive the cost is to the public or the planet, is the only salve that soothes the probability that their predations will fall into relative obscurity. These systems recognize they are structurally self-terminating whether they accept it or not, and thus project the desire for their termination

onto others to manipulate into submission. As these systems amass resources to maintain their predation, they also gravitate into the probability that they will eventually be toppled by those who renounce themselves as hostages of a captive system.



Giordano Bruno wrote extensively on the art of memory in conjunction with his claim that the cosmos had no center, and part of his work on memory palaces entailed the inquiry into how memory distributes and survives across absence. Bruno's mnemotechnic work across *Seal of Seals*, *Song of Circe*, and *On Links in General*, Bruno hints at the construction of deities, demons, and idealized forms as real cognitive artifacts, but contingent on imaginal bondages that persist across time prior to the circulation of doctrine and belief. Bruno defines the practice of how gods are both created and expired through the concept of *vinculum*: a semiotic linkage that binds image, desire, and combinatorial repetition through an existential-gravitational field as a medium for minds to synchronize attachment around symbolic form. The *vincula* may be understood as a procedural archive for the persistence of memory and the remainder of imaginal bonds that are interaffective and operational. The *vincula* is engineered to produce cognition residually across time even when referents no longer persist, and Bruno articulates that control over mnemonic images is how gods are made, but also how gods are exhausted. Bruno similarly takes the position that to dissolve a *vinculum*, cognition requires a scale-dependent reconfiguration where madness or confrontation of stability conditions is inhabited, even though the cost of modification is metabolically expensive. Bruno's execution was partly precipitated by the implications of this conclusion, by which religious institutions and other mediums of organized propaganda are technologies that use the production of memory as an operating system, which would consequently imply that gods consist of finitude in an infinitely complex cosmos. Throughout recorded history, humans needed to build

survivable memory as a way to extend signs and bonds over time. A combinatorial set of rules, an alphabet of primitives, a syntax, a finite set of relational loci, and stable linkages to affect, image, and sensation is all one may need to engineer a mnemotechnic graph of their own.



Bruno's conclusion leaves us with the task of continuing what deities do and how deities are made, by binding worlds and generating a joint stability through a confrontation with instability without dependency on an institutional authority. Once a vinculum is created, the imaginal field persists as a self-sustaining vortex that people orbit around and think through; in fact, the late modern period is rife with vincula factories through the composition of nation states, platform algorithms, market fundamentalism, ideologies, brand identities, unprocessed trauma, deepfakes, skepticism as a moral posture, and gendered hierarchy to name only some of the vincula that bind us to specific habits. Social media feeds in particular are vincula accelerators that selectively repeat what the algorithm already benefits from binding the userbase to as a way to encourage ongoing engagement and predictable patterns of cognition. Vincula reorganize our classical understanding of how minds carry beliefs by the framework that cognition is produced as a trace artifact, and beliefs have minds of their own as stabilized cognitive patterns that outlive referents through manufactured continuity. The production of cognition lives us in a position where neutrality is a luxury affordance in a system that is actively producing selection pressure for industrial gain, but underneath this insight is the capacity for anyone to reproduce their own vincula, and choose when the cost of remaining in a cognitive world exceeds the decision to exit the cognitive environment that cannot repair a harmful pattern. To reconfigure away from the habits of a vincula, opposition through counter-rebellion or counter-vincula in opposition to the trace of a vincula does not resolve the contradiction of inhabiting a vincula; in fact, to dissolve

a vincula, we are required to dissolve participation and attention in its field of affect entirely, developing replacement environments and affective linkages that reorient us around the redistribution of archival binding. The mnemotechnic archive precedes the formation of the subject through a distributed semiotic ecology of admissibility rules for memory, and our capacity to recall is secondary to the persistence of mnemonic structure.



Unsurprisingly, this collective rigidity we live in widens the gulf between stability and semiosis, conflating noise with shared signal. In this hallway where information travels, the data of life is constantly ambushed by meaningless or distorting information, tearing one slowly away from the meaningful acts of relating to one's neighbors and instead promulgating alienation and overwhelm. Such is the nature of the spectacle, as the totality of irony as mimetic pathogen: the replication of meaningless and ironic detachment which recognizes everything is simulated and performative, and thus the performance should be entropic and not musical. There's no harmony in this performance, no autonomy to distinguish signal from noise, only distortion on distortion's terms. There's no semiotic redemption arc, only a deference to recuperation by the spectacle where access to power, like access to truth, remains itself esoteric. Guy Debord lucidly writes: "In the spectacle's basic practice of incorporating into itself all the fluid aspects of human activity so as to possess them in a congealed form, and of inverting living values into purely abstract values, we recognize our old enemy the commodity, which seems at first glance so trivial and obvious, yet which is actually so complex and full of metaphysical subtleties." The spectacle, in its purest form, is metaphysical estrangement. There's no concept of society to defend, no life to share amongst equals, only the fatalism that assumes the powerful are the clairvoyants who have achieved control over perception. It should thus be no surprise that imagined communities, as Benedict

Anderson would put it, have found refuge for those who have adopted the most extreme conclusions of this irony: the cancer of nihilism. As meaning becomes so inaccessible to many, nihilism has sunk its talons into the most bleak rotundas of cultural cache, in which the barrier to access towards nihilism has dissolved and the perverse incentive to share kinship through nihilistic detachment. Nihilism is irony-as-necromancy: The embodied conjuring of the charnel house to make the dead walk. The simultaneity that was proliferated through the expansion of print capitalism that Anderson once wrote about has found even deeper ground in a more chronically disempowered, yet digitally interconnected social sphere, in which the advancement of cable and digital media has facilitated an imaginary sphere of network semiotics, where such an abundant amount of signal can only fraternize with such an abundant amount of noise, to the point where there are increasingly creative ways to replicate meaninglessness and irony poisoning at seemingly no cost. Nihilism acknowledges existentially that not only is there no concept of society, but that there's nothing to sacralize in life or death, because the only ritual is apocalypse.



In practice, we may see this in both the digital and analog world as irony poisoning: the contamination of social life through ironic detachment and avoidance of genuine meaning-making. Irony poisoning often looks less like boosting the social hive mind of one's own echo chamber, and looks more like the viral replication of irony in social space, as a sort of self-referential isolation from the norms of good faith engagement. The playbook of irony poisoning is usually the same: thought-terminating clichés, concern trolling through rhetorical inquiry that dodges the substance of a situation, and retreating towards avoidance or manipulation of social rules as though honest shared inquiry is beneath them. Irony looks more like a shield and a sword, because it's often both simultaneously: Through ironic detachment,

one can attack other positions without having to defend their own, signal kinship through shared adversaries, and evade accountability by projecting the illusion that anyone outside of one's ingroup is treacherous or craven. One can assume a lusory attitude, as Bernard Suits would put it, that a life is a game that one can accept the arbitrary rules of and expect others to participate in the game of reason without expecting others to contribute to the rules of the game. By assuming through irony a lusory attitude, one accepts the illusory attitude of other players in the game, where the illusion of not playing the game is accepted upon participation with other players. In other words, one is always playing the game of irony even if they are not making moves on a board, and through this self-reinforcing pathology of distorted play, one is being cheated out of the capacity to set the rules of engagement that the other player would refuse to participate in. Without the practice of sincerity to oscillate into, irony practices a self-reinforced loop of self-defense; in other words, the player refuses to lose because the player refuses to play the game sincerely without cheating or manipulating the rules, thus rendering the entire participation in the negotiation of reality a meaningless and future exercise. The mimetic replication of irony and nihilism becomes its own interdiction regardless of host, creating a performance of clarity to an audience that already selects for one's separation between reason and responsibility. Irony is a feedback loop stripped of homeostasis, a noise that confuses signal with itself, severing sincerity and self reflection from self-reference. We cannot have shared rules of admissibility in reality when entire swaths of people are frozen into irony without honesty and others are frozen into pure sincerity without boundaries, given that the presence of both enables the power vacuum that converts epistemological crises into sites of exploitation.



Nihilism also remains a gradient in the algorithmic amplification of signal and noise within an experiential landscape that remains

completely hostage to information overload, manufactured outrage, irony poisoning, intensification of reality tunnels, and denial of a prosperous future that doesn't involve sacrificing the masses into the planetary wood chipper for the benefit of the oligarchs and despots. Although cells of exterminationist groups proliferate online, the overall pain points that these cells expose are ubiquitous at nearly all segments of the population. As the coordination-based economy accelerates its computational capacity, it will also accelerate its foreclosure upon the possibility of futures beyond the one it currently imposes, in which the nihilism underneath these disaggregated exterminationist cells will gradually pollute a disempowered population of later generations. We cannot imitate affective desire or lack through a projected derivation of a real experience, only the integration of a shared contact. Ecological justice movements remain rife with perspectives of the climate that the planet is completely doomed and the rubicon has been crossed for the eventual heat death of the universe. There's no longer a future where one can be self-sufficient for long, and there's no future to fight against that reality for one's children. Political economy is rightfully diagnosed as a deckhand to systemic fascism, but resignation foments the notion that we are disempowered to organize cohesively against it, despite previous generations organizing in much more stratified and in destitute conditions where information was less accessible to them. Nihilism chokes the world in an ambient dread by imposing a closed system which logically cannot hold the potential for renewal beyond it, creating a default lens by which life filters perspectives through the narratives manufactured by an externally imposed factory setting and acts accordingly.



The structural conditions that fostered collective nihilism cannot be confronted by the same framework that created the problem in the first place. Benedict Anderson specifically pointed out that mediums of communication have the capacity to proliferate meaning

and solidarity amongst equals, and we know this because print media and oral tradition has at times made it possible: "This new synchronic novelty could arise historically only when substantial groups of people were in a position to think of themselves as living lives parallel to those of other substantial groups of people - if never meeting, yet certainly proceeding along the same trajectory. Between 1500 and 1800 an accumulation of technological innovations in the fields of shipbuilding, navigation, horology and cartography, mediated through print-capitalism, was making this type of imagining possible. It became conceivable to dwell on the Peruvian altiplano, on the pampas of Argentina, or by the harbours of 'New' England, and yet feel connected to certain regions or communities, thousands of miles away, in England or the Iberian peninsula. One could be fully aware of sharing a language and a religious faith (to varying degrees), customs and traditions, without any great expectation of ever meeting one's partners. For this sense of parallelism or simultaneity not merely to arise, but also to have vast political consequences, it was necessary that the distance between the parallel groups be large, and that the newer of them be substantial in size and permanently settled, as well as firmly subordinated to the older." The possibility of coherence through an imaginary social sinew that bonds others across the world through story could not be asserted through the necrotic tissue of nihilism, or else media could never develop as a technology that connects people through infrastructure rather than consumption. It is not enough to simply confront nihilism itself on nihilism's terms, because nihilism is only a vegetal sapling from a bitter root deeper into the horticulture of decay. Our reality has been enclosed upon, distorted, manipulated, and stratified by power because power seized control from an earlier position in the queue. A logically simplified and closed system begets enclosure because it cannot freely explore reality on reality's terms, and thus must explore reality until it faces distortion or is born with it.

The insistence that a simulation designs the outcomes of a world is no less exploitative of a crisis than Paley's watchmaker was to Victorian England before Darwinian evolution previously shaved off the metaphysical surplus of consolatory science. Unlike what may be interpreted from the Matrix, we do not inhabit a simulation that is externally imposed by someone else, and thus there is no imaginary plane one can transcend or assume separation from the affairs that others must work through in their daily lives. The Wachowski sisters themselves admitted the Matrix trilogy developed as an allegory for the transgender experience, disclosing the relationship between a given identity and its transformation in the world. In a 2012 interview with the A.V Club, Lilly Wachowski clarifies how the Matrix trilogy and subsequent franchises like Cloud Atlas meditate on power dynamics and the relationships that constitute their unspoken obligations: "You see power dynamics trying to be understood in *The Iliad*, and you see them in *The Master*. It's still the same excavation of power. Foucault gave us insight into power in the postmodern world, and now we understand it in a different way than Homer did, but power will be a subject in the human story, I think, as long as we're human. And so when we first read David Mitchell's book, I thought it was an unbelievable examination of incredibly varied perspectives, and also the relationship between the responsibility we have to people we have power over, and the responsibility we have to the people who have power over us. Are we meant to just accept their conventional construct of whatever they imagine the world to be? Or are we obliged in some way to struggle against it? In the reverse, what is the obligation of the person whose life we have power over? Are they obliged to struggle against that conventional relationship?" The failure modes of a given regime that wields information as a technology of subordination does not merely flatten to aesthetic drift or cultural trends, but instead demarcates the nature of meaning that ceases to be governed by selection pressure on informational systems that choose consumption over coherence. Whether one chooses to accept the autonomy underneath this fact is entirely their choice, and the entire world and all of the people

around them will continue to feel the impact of our inertia should we choose to accept that distortion of information is the status quo of reality. Our purpose is thus both foretold by the continuum of memory and generative by our extension of memory, and our understanding of that is not a requirement for how knowledge emerges in practice. We choose to forge ourselves in defiance of the models of life that assume scarcity and fear, or be swept away by life, but we cannot choose both.

DEMOLOGIA · 150°



Utah Phillips at one point conveyed what he thought was the most salient innovation that America offered through his experience as a musician and as a testimonial to the struggle of the working class: "...the long memory is the most radical idea in this country. It is the loss of that long memory which deprives our people of that connective flow of thoughts and events that clarifies our vision, not of where we're going, but where we want to go." The notion of the long memory goes beyond the notion of institutional memory, because it goes beyond institutions. Memory is decayed data when it is not shared, remembered, or sustained in the acts of unnamed and often invisible people throughout history. The long memory is memory that is lived, renewed, and regenerated in its fullness and continuity, recognizing that reality contains memory that is always accessible for as long as it is remembered by life. We can conceptualize the long memory as the throughline that proceeds from memory and threads into history, then philosophy, then media, all the way to lived resistance and back, regenerating and closing the loop through shared self-mobilizing activity. The capacity to have sovereignty of our own stories when we are alive, dead, or deadened by life is a lifelong struggle that loses its continuity when we cease to devote ourselves to the cause of affirming life on life's own terms. There are never static truths, only continuous regeneration of truth. Western modernity

somehow produced the most amnesiac civilization in recorded history because they determined that knowledge is unambitiously venerated through bureaucratized fragmentation and abstraction, as opposed to letting ideas develop in the corridors of contradiction with one another. Since the Age of Discovery, the West made a point to engineer amnesia by colonial conquest through the entire developed world, severing entire lineages of ancestry, ritual, craft, linguistics, and the intergenerational sense that produced complex infrastructures of agriculture, weather, timekeeping, and structured learning. The premodern civilizations prior to our epoch resolved developmental constraints with a more sophisticated *ars technica* than the present because they embedded their knowledge in the world that people lived in, as opposed to warehousing knowledge into priestly coffers. We develop amnesia through severance of historical continuity, and anamnesis through the integration of memory. Maimonides and Ibn Sina did not build the cultural and intellectual architecture that sustained global civilization for hundreds of years by specializing in an intellectual monoculture, they instead resolved contradictions across domains to develop comprehensive integrated systems that reveal invariant structures underneath. The coherence and utility of the truth was the gift, not the citation volume or monetary value. The sooner we transition out of sequestered department monocultures, status anxiety, citation incentives, and tenure portfolios into a shared field of open inquiry is the sooner we stabilize the world.



The concept of demologia is deeply buried behind the Imperial Roman impetus to centralize power and knowledge production into institutional authorities such as the church and state, who needed the mythology of a populace as something they needed to manage as opposed to hear from directly. Latin languages needed to standardize hierarchy, doctrine, authority, textual fidelity, and priesthood, so including this parlance implied a liminal space of people speaking to each other

between power structures. Unsurprisingly, this deliberate omission has regimented social knowledge as dangerous because it suggests that truth may not have a concept of private ownership, institution, or administrative office. The concept of democracy gave us the concept of a demagogue to pathologize democratic practice and vernacular knowledge, but we never inherited the concept of demologia directly: the movement of socially generated knowledge as the movement of life itself. Demologia implies that lived knowledge is circulated through enactive use rather than through a fossilized legal archive, and that cognition is distributed through the collective production of knowledge rather than through the bureaucratic funnel of institutions. Demologia is the social media of the public knowledge commons, which prioritizes library over Senate, learning as mutual aid rather than royal decree, and the epistemology of shared semiotic ecology. The omission of demologia in the Latin grammar, in contrast, signifies a culture that conditioned wisdom as what people know because of what they are told they are, as opposed to what people sense because they share life through knowledge. This raises another fundamental question about the narrative of history: knowing that history is historically narrative production rather than shared narrative coordination, how do we read and understand history in a transhistorical sense? R.G. Collingwood, part of the 20th century wave of British idealism, offered a context-driven lens: that history is a record of historical thought, and must be treated as such to relate to the context of the present. Collingwood was part of the postwar British idealist cohort who acknowledged that thought constitutes reality rather than reflects, but situates itself within a bedrock of material dependencies. Collingwood's historicism applies this heuristic to the reenactment of history, which Collingwood diagnoses as archaeological sediment rather than moral arc. However, in Collingwood's vision, history remains in the realm of reason, in which the task of the historian is made to rationalize the narrative of history that often is written by authoritarian sources. Understanding how and why Napoleon thinks in a historical sense is not the same as

understanding how the actions of Napoleon shape historical precedent and shape the ethical dimension of history that is always present.



To fully understand history, we interrogate what constitutes a historian, given our own experience is historically shaped, and we also interrogate what history we're studying and why we're studying it. Napoleon is just one node of thinking in a systemic network, underneath which an entire epidemiology of history emerges through a constellation of embedded patterns and narrative replication. Collingwood is focused on history as form, and history can be best characterized as social contagion, subject to the same practices of how ideas spread, how they mutate, and what constitutes their transmission dynamics. The historian is then a physician who asks: how do you prognose when and how the long memory dissipates? The assumption that history is man's organ is dangerously backwards. History is the connective tissue of life as opposed to the canvas of historians. Once we strip away the armor of the modern historian, the departments they write in would inevitably reorganize themselves as doxographers rather than historians, and anything more consolatory than that would be immediately suspect in choosing to speak for the war chest that so often tempts its archivists to writhe in avarice. When history demarcates to the cataloguing of competing viewpoints rather than the mythogenesis of sovereignty and tragic wars, the allure of a narrative wrapper on the past unravels. Historical actors are both symptom and vector of the trajectory that converges through history by the consummation of people and events that compose history, not the saints who survived in print. Assuming the latter as some tabula rasa that we paint over implies that we are not actively destabilizing the living substrate of history itself, whether it's the ecosystem we live in or the inescapable cycle of imperial conquest that perpetuates erasure and destruction. Much of narrated history is an aging landscape of open inquiry retroactively held in significance.

In practice, a living interaction of perspectives cannot be reduced to any single narrative, rationalization, viewpoint, or organ of man.



The contemporary amputation of philology from the modern intellectual continuum, in no small part, compounds exponentially with the debt we have accumulated in Western civilization by denying the public the autonomy to create their own operating system to organize and reconstruct the knowledge they produce. Up until the turn of the 20th century, there was some throughline by which knowledge shared enough symbolic grammar between disciplines so that philologists knew philosophy, mathematicians knew astronomy, and historians knew literature. The earliest recorded philologists in Hellenistic Alexandria were grammarians in the original sense of *grammatike*: stewards of language whose task was to adjudicate the infrastructure of history, signs, and thought by tracing how language evolves over time and excavating what later epochs decontextualize. Philology is the structural engineering method of linguistic systems and the bioarchaeology of language without a medium. In practice, this entails philology as the forensic audit work of sense propagation under continuous transmission, since semantic drift is governed by the decay variable of unavoidable degradation over memory and time. Historically speaking, philology spoke in the language of comparative archival technologies for grammatical sense-making, and when specialization was monopolized in the turn of the 20th century, philology deteriorated as a discipline despite its implications touching every discipline of media technology. Anyone who has had to produce a fan translation in English for a video game untranslated in Japanese is explicitly deploying a philological method whether they realize it or not. A philologist understands the material architecture of thought and how it evolves through history, because they recognize language as a lived archive of cognition, culture, memory, and semiosis within a given historical context. Any genealogical method that composes

the machinery of structural dialectic for contradiction repair, and the civilizational excavation of structural discontinuity and rupture through the forensic architecture of philology, is inevitably the most radical method of all, because it refuses any boundary to diagnosing the pathology of power. By learning how to reverse engineer the knowledge we are denied about ourselves, we become immediately threatening to anyone whose sovereignty depends on disciplining us through forgetting. Without philology as a medium of civilizational diagnosis, the ability to read history on its own terms is completely lost, and even worse, we lose the ability to reconstruct the load paths that connect us back to our ancestral knowledge that we unconsciously inherit through the evolution of the semiosphere. In other words, philology perishes when cultures lose access to the long memory.



Reasoning to the contrary and tepid ambition has led to the domestication of philosophy as a way of managing the affairs of liberal democracy. Jurgen Habermas is easily one of the contemporary moment's worst offenders of this trend: in order to rescue civility and modernity from totalitarianism, Habermas reduces philosophy to a customer service desk, in which intersubjective communication standards are the grounds by which we may salvage the arena of public discourse. The discursive sphere that Habermas locates in liberal democracy has distorted any notion of democracy prior to its structural transformation into the public sphere, through violent force at the symbolic, material, and temporal dimension. If Habermas is taken at face value, all distortion is communicative distortion as opposed to structural distortion, placing the primacy of the discursive sphere as the ground by which democracy prevails against contamination by authoritarian forces. Communicative distortion, however, is only one subfield of symbolic distortion, which is only one layer of distortion in a multi-layer process. The external limits of discursive procedure as the pathology of the public exhaust their

significance in relation to the formative capacity of cognition, by which Suzanne Langer contests against an administrative chamber as the site where thought develops: "The limits of thought are not so much set from outside, by the fullness or poverty of experiences that meet the mind, as from within, by the power of conception, the wealth of formulative notions with which the mind meets experiences." Philosophy that only seeks to manage debate in late modern society is a sclerotic philosophy where private individuals and public institutions are both unaccountable, but also unable to persist without immobilizing the mediums and expressions that shape thought. Even within a communication environment, meaning and cognition do not depend on a predetermined order to survive. Vilem Flusser defines communication as the remainder of cultural survival for a given sign system, in which communication is what happens that jointly produces cognition within dialogical interaction. Flusser emphasizes, within a given communication environment, the distribution of codes precedes interpretive signification in terms of governing what can be expressed openly and metabolized to determine what scope of signification is even possible. Codes as communication technology are reconfigured as media forms evolve and transition, including but not limited to computer devices, cameras, stationery, ritual technology, and cultural norms. Additionally, Flusser distinguishes human communication through gestural variance (writing, making music, crafting) as an expressive contingency for the modification of sign systems beyond a signifier/signified binary, even within a deterministic environment of codes. Dialogue depends on gesture regardless of whether the gesture is shaped by a code environment, which leaves us with the interactive extensibility to create meaning through remainder. Gestures are what allow living systems to convert pressure into circulation by way of expression, reorienting tension between body and medium or activity and apparatus.

Stuart Hall, in *Policing the Crisis*, provides a lens on what he calls “consensus reality” - the phenomena by which the dominant media classes, including major newsrooms and print publications like MSNBC, Fox News, and the Wall Street Journal, socially construct reality through their own chokehold on narrative production and meaning making about information. Hall observes that meaning-making is often a social phenomena, but that information circulation itself is a mirror of how social relations are mediated hegemonically from above throughout the world. The 20th century manufacturing of social consent to ideological control and narrative control is imposed through shaping the window exclusively to what may be considered a “common sense” approach to problem solving. Primary media sources do this frequently, such that what we may interpret as reality is filtered through the grip on narrative production from what major newsrooms may determine is the acceptable narrative. Anything that may threaten the dominant folklore or civic religion of the nation state becomes a threat to be neutralized, one that does not require your consent to resist but it does require your consent to accept. Hall explains the mechanism by which media produces consensus of the public, but does not represent or reflect the consensus of the public: “In either form of editorialising, the media provide a crucial mediating link between the apparatus of social control and the public. The press can legitimate and reinforce the actions of the controllers by bringing their own independent arguments to bear on the public in support of the actions proposed (‘using a public idiom’); or it can bring pressure to bear on the controllers by summoning up ‘public opinion’ in support of its own views that ‘stronger measures are needed’ (‘taking the public voice’). But, in either case, the editorial seems to provide an objective and external point of reference which can be used either to justify official action or to mobilise public opinion. It should not be overlooked that this playing back of (assumed) public opinion to the powerful, which is the reverse of the earlier process described of translating dominant definitions into (assumed) public idiom, takes the public as an important point of reference on both occasions (legitimation), while actually bypassing it. By means of a

further twist, these representations of public opinion are then often enlisted by the controllers as 'impartial evidence' of what the public, in fact, believes and wants."



Hall extends his analysis of consensus into two categories of narrative production: primary definers and secondary definers. The primary definers, in Hall's view, are those who have exclusive purchase and media access on defining the narrative of consensus reality that others interpret, often creating a dominant sphere of influence of the nature of media production by way of exclusive access and public perception of credibility. Secondary definers are all of those who may be thought of as interpreters of these primary definers in the mass media, who therein become the replication mechanism of dominant media narratives. Hall emphasizes that the amplification of media sources or emergent phenomena is reinforced through the monopoly that primary definers uphold in the production of information: "The media do not only possess a near-monopoly over 'social knowledge', as the primary source of information about what is happening; they also command the passage between those who are 'in the know' and the structured ignorance of the general public. In performing this connective and mediating role, the media are enhanced, not weakened, by the very fact that they are, formally and structurally, independent both of the sources to which they refer and of the 'public' on whose behalf they speak. This picture may now tend to suggest a situation of 'perfect closure', where the free passage of the dominant ideologies is permanently secured." Primary definers are the privileged observers who determine how meaning in reality is shaped by proximity to the arena of power, including a constellation of nation states, wealthy corporations, private foundations, and elite universities who are collaborative in maintaining their status and exclusivity not unlike the high society of Victorian England.



The development of germ theory was built off of the detritus of Victorian era England, which contrary to popular perception, had the exact opposite perception of cleanliness, filth, and social status. High society in this time period was not bathing regularly or concerned themselves broadly with exchange of fluids at all. Victorian era England associated filth with high society, and its most opulent socialites were rankish and unhygienic in ways that people would associate in nouveau riche repulsion today with someone who is unhoused and has no easy access to a shower, let alone the capacity to audit their body hygiene. The transition to common acceptance of germ theory was as much of a socially and semiotically mediated shift as it was a practical shift – concepts such as beauty and hygiene often tethered themselves and evolved in accordance with the socioeconomic perception of the society one is in. Having access to soap, fresh laundry, and choosing to bathe was coded as proletarian concerns that the rich chose to distance themselves from to keep the fair paleness of their skin. In Victorian England, lack of hygiene signaled excess and status, but if one looks in the poorest neighborhoods of San Francisco or Los Angeles, one may find that lack of hygiene and foul odor just signals dread and repulsion, and often leads you to immediately alienate yourself from someone who literally offends your sensibilities. The notion of sensibility, if one peers into a window to situate themselves in the England that was written about in *Pride and Prejudice*, was about following the secret code and manners of high society. Not having access to this secret handshake signaled you as the outgroup. Having your own cultural identity and secret handshake that only your kin understand is not always a harmful thing, but somehow, poverty implies you no longer need to be in high society to be denied a secret handshake, you just have to be vulnerable enough to be flushed out like filth in a society that designates you as surplus to everyone else. The anthropologist Mary Douglas calls this the notion of “matter out of place”: the idea that dirtiness and dirt are not necessarily conceptual absolutes but

socially mediated depending on the historical context one lives in. Filth could be “in place” in one’s home in Victorian England but “out of place” on the sidewalk or an encampment anywhere in the San Francisco Bay Area. Poverty is a single-channel dependency, which has nothing to do with lack of income or effort. The visibility of poverty is the target here: data, hygiene, class structure, and status are all codes that are manipulated by a power structure in order to drive a wedge between one’s allies and one’s adversaries. If the afterlife of Victorian England were to admit any fault and arrest its own development, then it may capture its own legacy by declaring that its chief contribution to civilization was teaching the world how to read a newspaper and a pamphlet, and if they were to purge themselves of their interior miasma, they would rise from the ashes as if they were to inhale phlogiston.



If meaning is something by which the primary definers of reality assume your consent, it is also something by which you do not assume their permission to assert the meaning of the world. Narrative coordination, as one of many logistical tools, emerges from below if we choose not to conflate primary sources with primary definers. Part of reclaiming the long memory of history is by reclaiming the sovereignty of information and narrative as it comes from below, refusing to let any dominant media source define a generation or a culture through its own totalizing lens. The movement becomes a liberatory source of narrative, in which journalism, narrative production, and pedagogy unify under the same insurgent process of meaning-making as a defiant act. In the 1990s, Hemant Shah discussed the idea of “emancipatory journalism” as a counterlogistics alternative to a logistically coordinated media consensus that is produced for compliance. All shared struggles, fundamentally in coordinating their sense of counterlogistics, also require coordinating the narrative production that challenges the production of public opinion and reclaims it as a reflection of what the

future actually needs. Shah considers three core tenets for effective emancipatory journalism and cultural-historical media production in general: that emancipatory journalism “is concerned with social, cultural, and political aspects of development, in addition to the economic aspects”, that this journalism is “democratic and bottom up”, and that it is “pragmatic and unconventional in its reporting.” From a counterlogistical perspective, emancipatory journalism requires a fourth core tenet: visibility through leverage. To truly negotiate and bargain against power, one produces meaning making defiantly and decisively, but also through highlighting when refusal against power is located and where it is found. This kind of cultural production distinguishes reporting on a performative mass march with no demands from reporting on an uprising or direct action that targets the logistical chokepoints of media production outside of what is legible to the halls of power, with the assumption that media sources will follow and attempt their own counterinsurgent narrative. The fact that the media sources do so demonstrates that the leverage is working, and they are capitulating to what they cannot control. When counterlogistics is elevated to the level of semiosis and cultural production, the public reclaims its own communication channels from below that have been stolen from them, forcing primary media sources and the institutions that maintain them to acquiesce to reality that they cannot curate through a consensus they produce as privileged representatives of the public. This is also separate from reforming a narrative from within to rearrange a generic notion of cultural hegemony, where one must assert and replicate a narrative that cannot be subjugated or suppressed whether by force or by consent.



The Situationist underground and tactical media outfits of the 90s understood that narrative production is a power play, and that often producing narrative meant blurring the lines between cultural and historical production through social activity that are often assumed to

be neatly filed away from each other. The Situationists and Letterists popularized the concept of culture jamming, in which the tools of media circulation are playfully subverted through the same technology that produced them. Variants of this tactic existed in the Billboard Liberation Front and adjacent groups throughout the 20th century, centering the participatory nature of communication as social activity and cultural production. The Electronic Disturbance Theater in the 90s, for example, popularized the tactic of “virtual sit ins”, which executed a coordinated DDOS attack on the Mexican and American governments in support of the Zapatista rebels in Chiapas. The EDT created a tool called FloodNet which would reload the url for a website several times on a server with finite bandwidth, facilitating a coordinated website crash when enough participants kept reloading the tool on local devices. This technique is not unlike the template of organized phone zap campaigns that are leveraged against ICE or CDCR phone lines, for example, in which communication chokepoints are congested for the purposes of tactical ambush. This creates a fifth tenet of emancipatory media: reporting is ritual and activity, not just dissemination of narrative.



Media conglomerates and social media algorithms, like all regimes of industrial media, all serve the same purpose of amplifying the process of fragmentation that exists amongst individuals, forcing them into accepting narratives that blame themselves and blame their neighbors for a system that drives a wedge between both of them. It exists both in conservative news rooms that invent a strawman in their imagination through blaming the most marginalized segments of the population for their problems, and the centrist news networks which invent a strawman of their adversaries, insisting that the arena of civil liberties will lead us to salvation in democracy. These systems within media and representation ultimately serve the same purpose of needing authoritarian control and domination in order to survive. They are not unlike different expressions of the logic of the market

economy in this way. Carmen Hermosillo perceptively observed in her essay, *Pandora's Vox*, that Silicon Valley was doomed from the start to adapt their fantasies of technological utopia to serve the interests of a few dominating institutions, such as the current FAANG market segment in their monopolization of search engines, e-commerce, social media, and software suites to serve the needs of every person on earth. Hermosillo observed, in 1994 prior to the height of the dot com boom, the separation between the physical and virtual world is never as cleanly separable as it seems: "Almost every discussion in cyberspace, about cyberspace, boils down to some sort of debate about Truth-In-Packaging. Cyberspace is a mostly a silent place. In its silence it shows itself to be an expression of the mass. One might question the idea of silence in a place where millions of user-ids parade around like angels of light, looking to see whom they might, so to speak, consume. The silence is nonetheless present and it is most present, paradoxically at the moment that the user-id speaks. When the user-id posts to a board, it does so while dwelling within an illusion that no one is present. Language in cyberspace is a frozen landscape." Although citing Nietzsche and Baudrillard in her thesis, Hermosillo reveals something apophatic about cyberspace similarly to how the medieval mystics revealed parts of God that were silent when you shouted at them: there is nothing more visible about cyberspace than how cyberspace is used, who benefits most from its use, and how its use reverberates throughout the physical world through its extension of it rather than their assumed isolation. The silence, in both cases, just reveals what the infrastructure actually is and what it mediates. If you assume God is silent, you are forced to assume that only your grace can save you. If you assume that cyberspace is silent, you assume that only your digital postcard to someone can connect with them in their inbox rather than the sales pitches they receive in their spam folder.

A system cannot regulate its impulse towards chaos and desire to control for long before it completely falls apart. Signal transmission is contingent on what information is transported and under what normative constraints information may be admitted as data. The manipulation of data in baroque cloud data architectures imply a stratification in a social hierarchy where sovereignty is designated to databases and data center resource concentration. The optimism about technology as the path to human utopia flounders on the gap between who has access to technology, information, and resources to mediate social relations. Silicon Valley's old guard was not concerned predominantly with how to use technology to liberate human squalor, and neither was the generation of tech conglomerates that cartelized the market for tools we use every day: search engines, social media, generative AI, software tools, and file sharing. The shadow accounting of financial rehypothecation is the outcome of a feedback loop with no restraint against extractive excess. The reality is that media production is in and of itself, a technology that has spanned across eons of history. Industrial media regimes ultimately serve to manufacture public opinion by monopolizing the production of narrative, as opposed to truth being intuitively felt in our shared collective experience of being alive. The primary distinction between different stages of development of media technology, from the print newspaper to social media platforms, has been through the diffusion of information, reduction of barriers to access in how information is distributed widely, consolidation of power between epistemic regimes, and recomposition in cognitive architecture based on how information is distributed through media forms.



The print media of the 20th century wasn't uniquely less partisan relative to the 24-hour cable news cycle, and social media drops the illusions almost entirely on anything but narratives that are distinctly partisan. The transition from print to cable, and cable to social media,

instead, reflected a media ecology that became more transparent about its partisanship with each successive stage of technological development within the context of information production. Marshall McLuhan observes that within the genealogy of print media, this was by design: "...the author felt title pressure to maintain a single attitude to his subject or a consistent tone to the reader. In short, prose remained oral rather than visual for centuries after printing. Instead of homogeneity there was heterogeneity of tone and attitude, so that the author felt able to shift these in mid-sentence at any time, just as in poetry. It was disturbing to scholars to discover in recent years that Chaucer's personal pronoun or his "poetic self" as narrator was not a consistent persona. The "I" of medieval narrative did not provide a point of view so much as immediacy of effect. In the same way grammatical tenses and syntax were managed by medieval writers, not with an idea to sequence in time or in space, but to indicate importance of stress." Print production amongst publishers or authors, for many generations, is a matter of playing with syntactic arrangement rather than playing with semantic detail. The latter requires an idea to situate in place based time, whereas the former just requires time to be sequentially consistent.



A paradigm shift, in the way that Thomas Kuhn describes in scientific method, comes with tradeoffs rather than intersubjective moral calculus. A phase shift in technology does not morally adjudicate on its own, because they instead reconfigure the space where adjudications occur. The technology of the printing press disciplined and linearized the production of narrative into a singular perspective of the author or publisher, creating a precondition for the kind of temporal consistency which Hall later writes about in the context of crime in England. The linearity of print-oriented cognition is situated in a regime of industrial mass production that signified a break from the highly distributed networks of communal knowledge production that were

commonplace as far back as medieval prior to the introduction of the English common law system around the 11th and 12th centuries. Prior to the 15th century invention of the printing press in Germany, it was not uncommon through the oral traditions in Catholic, Jewish, and Islamic corridors of the world to source material for legal commentary through the interactions between jurists in their respective cultures to the communities that people lived in. In order to maintain textual integrity and provenance for legal commentary, it would not be uncommon in the medieval period to find halakha or canon law with extremely technical classification schemas prior to the advent of the folio as the standard for publishing. With only parchment, ink, and a scribal network, legal scholars in these traditions built infrastructures of hyperlinked, cross-referenced, version controlled multimodal semantics to distinguish between authoritative textual renditions, commentary, marginalia, gloss, and citational grammar. The heterogeneity of tone is lost in the homogeneity of voice that text conveys in written work, and in a digital hypertext generation, we are conditioned to only process the homogeneity effectively given the normalization of text as linear, sequential, and recto-verso numbering for printed works. The transition from oral to print exchanged the customary architecture of communal learning, tonal glossalia, and modal frame semantics for the commodified distribution of textual objects. The oral tradition conserved a generational norm of reading text aloud to each other, and writing commentary that circulated outside of the hierarchy of the proprietary publishing guilds while still preserved through the channels that text was distributed. The cognoscenti of oral and manuscript cultures instead redoubled their efforts into exercising control over people and how they thought outside of manuscripts, given that the circulation of text had not yet matured into the accelerated reproduction caused by the publishing industry. By the 20th century, the distribution of knowledge in lived practice collapsed into the metric of citation volume, editorial standardization, and book sales. The homogenization of editorial voice after the printing press resulted in downstream epistemic conditioning of the public into

the contemplative ritual posture of individual enlightenment, risking compromise of semiotic plurality and feedback when that ritual is not spoken in community with others. Narrative voice in print collapses perspective into a singular privileged narrator that can be owned and circulated as an authoritative source, erasing the stress-based tempo of oral tradition that maintains the participatory and relational structure of meaning-making. The problem of the oral tradition was that knowledge production was frequently centralized into bourgeois theological regimes governed by class hierarchy and status games, in which producing your own thought outside of what was admissible to the institution was highly dangerous, and in the case of Jan Hus, speaking against the institution against the consolidation of clerical power could risk execution.



Walter Benjamin points out that lineages of media technologies tend to fossilize as an atlas of the cognitive architecture generated at a given era, leaving behind the residue of what was obsolete, what was lost, and what was exploited, as well as the shift in the relationship between media consumption and media metabolism. The only place in contemporary America where oral tradition presently maintains continuity is through the adversarialism of the Lincoln-Douglas debate tradition, which is why so much American debate culture feels performed for absolution rather than understanding. The problem of contemporary knowledge production today is a perfect storm of at least a few factors: the disciplinary siloing of academic domains, the colonial mode of production, and the monopoly of the publishing industry on physical artifact distribution and typographic authority. Within the current social media epoch, we are all privileged narrators that compete for narrative dominance in a media ecosystem that rewards engagement and reaction over shared meaning. Underneath the semantic collapse of the development of the printing press typography was a collapse of meaning and definitions for how we

could ever conceive of stable thought patterns. Although people associate Shakespeare with inventing an entire lexicon out of whimsy, his responsibility to his plays was philological in the ancient sense: he needed to reconstruct language to match the affective depth that his writing demanded. Shakespeare emerged as a liminal sage between worlds in late 16th century England recovering from the Reformation, the dissolution of the medieval cosmology of God, and the transition into Enlightenment era discovery, scientific method, and imperialism. The advent of the new form of medium, the printing press, could only be understood backwards into the past: a technology not unlike the internet or artificial intelligence that destabilized all media forms before it. The advent of media technology stabilizes the cognitive architecture of the world that comes next, while rupturing the world before it. Thus, Shakespeare needed to develop a vocabulary from piecemeal which did not exist prior to his extension of the English grammar. When new invariants in thought and conceptual space emerge through forms of media technology, language evolves and mutates between epistemic phases to adapt to the new terrain of knowledge. In moments like the present of civilizational rupture, the language of the past is incomplete, creating the window for the language of the world to come. In Shakespeare's case, he reconstructed a crumbling English lexicon that the Latin scholastics were unable to extend, and through his morphological process, he developed a new semiotic ecology that could maintain the infrastructure of thought. A significant proportion of the discontinuities between media forms, throughout successive generations, exacerbate through the administration, provenance, and authority of how media is distributed, and the scoped sources of truth for citation and collaboration. Media forms tend to solve one problem by creating another, historically situated in a complex cognitive architecture of institutions, class, affect, custom, access, and technological distribution. Between media forms, the rupture of a new technology and its ability to shape cognitive affordances and sensory ratio can truly be understood through the liminal space of what remains of ourselves when meaning deteriorates.



The uses of data are very much codes of the semiotic lingua franca that both society and capital speak. C. Thi Nguyen notes in his essay *The Limits of Data*: “Here is the second principle: every classification system represents some group’s interests. Those interests are often revealed by where a classification system has one resolution and where it doesn’t. For example, Data must be something that can be collected by and exchanged between different people in all kinds of contexts, with all kinds of backgrounds. The International Classification of Disease (ICD) is a worldwide, standardized system for classifying diseases that’s used in collecting mortality statistics, among other things. Without a centralized, standardized system, the data collected by various codes won’t aggregate. But the ICD has highly variable granularity. It has separate categories for accidents involving falling from playground equipment, falling from a chair, falling from a wheelchair, falling from a bed, and falling from a commode. But it only has two categories for falls in the natural world: fall from a cliff, and an “other fall” category that lumps together all the other falls—including, in its example, falls from embankments, haystacks, and trees. The ICD is obviously much more interested in recording the kinds of accidents that might befall people in an urban industrial environment than a rural environment, note Bowker and Star. The ICD’s classification system serves some people’s interests over others.” It is impossible to imagine a world in which information, and data, has no political dimension – the classification of data, the collection of data, and the application of data are all socially mediated by a highly stratified society. The methodology of data itself, as Nguyen writes, requires a certain amount of contextually situated information to be stripped away from the actual data transformation and data lifecycle process. Even within a highly automated cloud architecture, data entry is never separable from its production environment – data often goes through numerous transformations between when it is staged and when it is queried for reporting.



Nguyen calls this process decontextualization: the act of quantitative editing so that data can traverse between domains and audiences. The consequences of this asymmetry in understanding of how quantifiable phenomena are situated in social life reflects in how institutions manage the tension between accuracy, opacity, and conveyance of knowledge: "Behind such shifts is the pressure to be objective in a very particular way. There are many different meanings for "objective." Sometimes when we say something is "objective," we mean that it's accurate or unbiased. But other times, we're asking for a very specific social transformation of our processes to our institutional life. We are asking for mechanical objectivity—that is, that a procedure be repeatable by anybody (or anybody with a given professional training), with about the same results. Institutional quantification is designed to support procedures that can be executed by fungible employees." In a logistics and supply chain oriented political economy, the question of data sovereignty is fundamentally a political one, because it deals with the autonomy of information and the distribution of knowledge. These are tensions in any era of history regardless of who punctuates and controls knowledge production. Most importantly, data deals with the question of how one understands how much data about them is collected, where it is collected, who is collecting it, and for what purpose. People have accepted that Silicon Valley product suites such as Google and Instagram are collecting information about them all of the time through software and hardware, and that anything posted on the internet is there to stay on the internet. What remains less apparent is how, on a deeper level, we maintain autonomy over our sense of time and our capacity to share information and resources mutually in ways that do not reproduce surveillance architecture through unaccountable data platforms.



Data centers, cloud data architectures, and surveillance technology today operate on this sort of compositional opacity: the actual system itself is an unverifiable, unauditable, black-box junction where information enters, but we do not know how it is sourced or what happens to it in its lifecycle. Current data systems fail to be compositionally transparent and formally verified predominantly because nobody can audit them. The opacity of cloud data center architectures, in a sense, shifts the cryptographic burden of privacy away from the interface and onto the activity of end users directly who are not expected to learn how to quarantine what information online is extracted from their participation unless that information directly threatens the financial integrity of a corporation's asset portfolio. Upon the publication of the PGP source code in 1995 through MIT Press, Phil Zimmerman insisted that if a government could regulate cryptographic practice a weapon, they can also regulate speech as a weapon, and narrowly avoided prosecutorial sanction for his PGP public domain release on account of sufficient public exposure by people having access to the PGP cryptography protocol. In order to ensure full integrity of the entire system, ports with the plug doctrine assume exposure of themselves to each other through full transparency and accountability to the larger system. Otherwise, systems remain logically and epistemically closed, which also encloses the rational flow of resources and information to those who actually need it, as well as the distribution of knowledge to the self-determination of all in common. The Amateur Packet Radio network (AMPRNet) instantiated such a congruent practice in the A.X.25 protocol in the 1980s partially through the packet radio approach, where any node in a network could appear and disappear at any time without central routing or permissions. ARPANet bypassed phone signal carriers and state telecom regulation through such a system, rejecting the expectation that telecommunications were mediated by border regimes or nation states.

In fact, it's precisely by the scale of the ubiquity of surveillance regimes that the line between the real world and the synthetic world is blurred, by virtue of how often our data is contextually controlled from above. Johan Huizinga, a Dutch historian from the early 20th century, describes the concept of the "magic circle" as a sort of bounded space by which the real world and the game world are separated; in effect, Huizinga imagines a world in which the life we live cleanly separates from the structured agency of the games we play or spectate. His depiction of the game world is a temporary one, not unlike a suspension of disbelief one imposes in theater: "Just as there is no formal difference between play and ritual, so the 'consecrated spot' cannot be formally distinguished from the play-ground. The arena, the card-table, the magic circle, the temple, the stage, the screen, the tennis court, the court of justice, etc., are all in form and function play-grounds, i.e. forbidden spots, isolated, hedged round, hallowed, within which special rules obtain. All are temporary worlds within the ordinary world, dedicated to the performance of an act apart." Inside this magic circle, players accept an alternate sense of reality, partly because they have an altered sense of time where, despite deterministic rule sets, consequences in the game world do not matter in the real world. Edward Castronova's research on synthetic worlds presents a completely different narrative that aligns with how we experience contemporary reality: that the lines between what we think of as a "real world" through our vernacular and quotidian decision making and administration over our lives, and the "synthetic world" where cyberspace facilitates a virtual microcosm of the everyday real world, are often highly porous, and without forethought, often bleed into one another. Castronova notes that in reality, people often want to play games and gamify the world: "Thus the game-like character of life may come from a deep-seated motive to play: how do we know that the activities we engage in out of a self-expressed joy (buying and selling stocks for thrill rather than profit, for example) are not moments of play? And it may also stem from the insertion of play institutions into ordinary life: how do we know that a given social institution (the

stock market, for example) is not a game? Thus for both cultural and developmental reasons, it makes sense that any given activity may be play or not-play, depending on the judgments of both the players/users and the broader culture. And this in turn shows why aspects of daily life can often be compared to a game.”



Games are fundamentally interactive activities with rules that we accept by participating – one could play chess against a computer, a friend, or a stranger, and regardless of the participants, games are socially mediated by the world that creates them. Furthermore, play is how people explore themselves and their relationships, and it would be functionally impossible to assume people do not bring their lives with them inside the game world and bring the game with them when they return to the real world. There are no partitions between realms, whether imagined or created – the interactions we have in virtual space ultimately impact everyone else, whether we assume that certain rules can be manipulated online that they cannot in real life. Assuming otherwise also presumes there is no feedback loop that closes when you play a game and one that opens when you exit the game. Game developers, for instance, often use a trick called the magic pixel in games like DOOM or Marvel vs. Capcom, where the heads-up display (HUD) “health bar” of the player, prior to hitting zero, often has more health padded on the back end than is visually represented on the screen, creating this visceral tension in the player where they feel backed into a corner to make a stunning reversal. Developers use a trick like this to reveal nonlinear stamina in seemingly linear game mechanics, in a way that often feels more psychologically stimulating than physiologically constraining. This visual layer adds a simple stress test on the player to what often feels like a game with fixed rules, and often when we are in the real world, we realize rules are usually not as linear about what they reveal under the chassis. Automobiles use this trick all the time to stimulate corrective activity from the driver:

the HUD of the driver's dashboard might signal a "low fuel" warning when the gas tank is empty, or the "service needed" light flickers after a certain mileage checkpoint is reached on the odometer, even if the car may have multiple gallons left in it when the fuel gauge actually hits the outer perimeter of E, signifying that the driver urgently needs to fuel their car.



Nguyen also previously wrote in regards to the idea of what games represent in a sociological sense: a phase space where agency can be freely explored through play. Nguyen notes, in a sort of homo ludens approach as Huizinga did, what happens when a game is played on its own terms: "Games are structures of practical reason, practical action, and practical possibility, conjoined with a particular world in which that practicality will operate. A game designer designates this as the goal of the game player, these as the permitted abilities, and those as the landscape of obstacles in which that game player will operate. The designer creates not only the practical world in which the player will act, but also constitutes the practical agency of the actor within that world—their abilities, and their goals and values. This is why a well-designed game has the potential to more finely manipulate the sorts of practical harmonies and disharmonies we experience in our actions. Game designers can engineer agency and world to fit." Nguyen conceives of games as a place, whether alone or with community, where freedom is artificially constrained by the game designer to encourage the player's own exploration of agency, identity, and play. The problem of a clean separation of agential fluidity within games and the real world is the same problem that the magic circle creates on an environmental level: the game is always being played, reality is gamified, and in the freedom we get to play the game, the opposite problem happens in contrast to the game world. Instead of a game that artificial limits freedom to explore agency, the API-mediated platform world artificially limits agency to require

freedom. In Byung Chul-Han's words, this is what one may call the post-disciplinary society: "The achievement-subject stands free from any external instance of domination [Herrschaftsinstanz] forcing it to work, much less exploiting it. It is lord and master of itself. Thus, it is subject to no one—or, as the case may be, only to itself. It differs from the obedience-subject on this score. However, the disappearance of domination does not entail freedom. Instead, it makes freedom and constraint coincide. Thus, the achievement-subject gives itself over to compulsive freedom—that is, to the free constraint of maximizing achievement."



Because our sense of time, agency, and informational integrity is always filtered and controlled and manipulated by something else, we have no choice but to accept our freedom while also accepting that our agency and capacity for choices to influence our environment is heteronomously pressed upon. What Masahiro Mori discussed as the uncanny valley often describes this ambiently dreadful experience where human and nonhuman blend in aesthetically grotesque ways is not so much about whether man blurs into machine, but whether our experiences, or the experiences of another, are metaphysically repressed; that is, when something is so contextually discrete from its environment that it ceases to resemble truth or meaning. This dread is part of the horror submerged in everyday life, where things do not participate as equals or symmetrically within the game of life, or as they are purported to do in the game world where we assume a space of equal participants. Whether you are dealing with digital or the immediately sensible world around you that is not mediated through technology, we are always inseparable from the environments that we co-create with others, the physical spaces we create in our homes, and the memories we steward through the annals of lived history. The uncanny is just pure noise living in a feedback loop that never closes, because it never acknowledges the reality of the relationships

or reciprocity of the world they live in, and thus reproduces the ghost in the machine that acts automatically without listening.



The embedding of machines into the hierarchy of industry aligns closely with the etymological origins of the word “robot,” which originated in a 1920 science fiction play R.U.R. (Rossum’s Universal Robots) from the Czech playwright Karel Čapek. The play depicts the eponymous island factory where robots are not metallic automatons, but instead as synthetic biologically constructed servants that resemble humans despite having no autonomous capacity to reflect or infer thought, and therefore no independent thoughts of their own except what is programmed into their system by the industrial assembly line. Linguistically, the word “robot” is derived from the Czech word “robota”, which incidentally derives from the term for work or forced labour in Czech. It is important to note that both Czech and Russian share the same syntactic alliteration for this word, given that the Cyrillic scripting of the word for work in Russian is работа (rabota). Both of these words demonstrate the society the word originated in based on the etymological origin: both the Czech territory under the Kingdom of Bohemia and the Czardom of the Russian Empire were majority peasant societies that maintained a tyrannical feudal order over centuries through enforced serfdom in exchange for the right to live on the land. Čapek’s robot is exactly this omen smuggled through the backdoor, in which the robot represents a type of domination and arrest of autonomy that the Fordist factory line can industrialize at scale through mass commodification and authoritarian rule. This conceptualization of the robot characterizes the omen of our own time, in which technology is something we assemble to extract from others but not something that evolves alongside us as sensitive to its own resources and environment, even if biologically engineered as a veneer.

In contrast to the fatalist narrative about hypertext presented by Carr if read as literal, McLuhan also discusses in *the Medium is the Message and Understanding Media* that the development of a new medium is interpreted through the lens of a rear view mirror: "When faced with a totally new situation, we tend to attach ourselves to the objects, to the flavor of the most recent past." What McLuhan highlights underneath is that in the context of an inchoate new medium, such as the transition from oral to print or from print to digital, the form of the new medium is socially treated as unintelligible through the content of its present form because it is interpreted through the context of a past form. For example, the development of the radio resulted in print culture interpreting radio as a form of print, television is interpreted by radio as a visual talking radio, and the internet being interpreted by cable and print consumers as "electronic mail." As media technology advances, cultures generally inherit assumptions about technology or forms of knowledge that are unfamiliar, but the one thing they do have is an inherited tradition that they filter assumptions about the new medium through an old medium. Benedict Anderson, on the other side of the coin, points out through his framework of imagined communities how the culturally situated development of technology gives people a shared sense of community through the imagination that technology gives them when the tools are socially mediated. Media and technology can only expand when cultures can autonomously expand through media and technology, and contracts when cultures contract through media and technology. The advancement of media is understood through this lens because each partition in media technology also socially meditates the cognition of the next generation. Print cognition is incredibly linear, deterministic, static, and often assumes cognition is developed from Point A to Point B based on hypertext. Within the development of the internet, hypertext cognition is nonlinear, distributed, and stigmergic; that is, information through the internet is valued through its engagement, and with the

advancement of novel mediums, our cognition adapts in ways that are more embodied, somatic, and relationally aware. A printed book can move you internally, but even the premodern oral traditions understood that learning was a shared practice that required embedding in the situation of a given era. The mimetic quality of vernacular knowledge distribution on the internet is not inherently pathological, but becomes pathological when the medium rewards and amplifies alienation and epistemic fracture over shared inquiry and contradiction repair. The next generations will inevitably be shaped by a fully digital media ecology, which will require us to broaden our understanding of how media ecologies shape cognition and how ecologies of cognition shape the world. That said, the cultures that develop and evolve regardless of medium are the ones that persist through the next generation by the adaptation to new media if we approach them in good faith. Even Plato, when the printing press was developed, insisted that print would ruin children, and the development of the calculator received derision from the academy when they became commonplace.



Following the analytic phenomenology of Alexander Pfänder, activity is structured in the first person through temporal sedimentation. Action becomes automated by periodicity unfolding along a trajectory, modifying itself through orientation without the guarantee of a veto. An action is already in holonomy before it is reflected upon, and any norms that habituate them are kinetically mediated. Reasons within activity loops stabilize only when motivation is rendered explicit: the practice of reason modulates action when motivations are articulable, the normative velocity of an action is witnessed, and motivation ingresses into a stable motivational environment. Moreover, we know from the experience of life that computational throughput does not cause or even correlate with wisdom and insight. The biologist, Stephen Jay Gould, carried this thought into a clear distillation: “I am, somehow, less interested in the weight and convolutions of Einstein’s brain

than in the near certainty that people of equal talent have lived and died in cotton fields and sweatshops.” Einstein’s mind, however brilliant and generative it was in his time, himself admitted that the work of his *annus mirabilis* papers was driven by his own capacity for curiosity and exploration, as well as simply just having the spaciousness and agency in his line of open inquiry to be able to intuit the vastness of life through accumulation of percepts as opposed to simply computing equations with competitive speed. Simply put, Einstein’s own curiosity and creativity drove his explorative process into the unresolved contradiction of the Newtonian paradigm, as opposed to simply his computational capacity. The hagiography around the genius of Einstein actually disrespects the deep ancestral memory that informed his toolkit: he accessed a deeply Tosafist method of contradiction repair and textual scrutiny, except his domain of contradiction resolution was the relationship between Newtonian mass intrinsic to an object and the distribution of matter throughout the universe. The classical Talmudic textual scrutiny is a cognitive architecture that gets passed down through the distribution of knowledge across cultural genealogies. In Einstein’s case, he read the napkin note equivalent of a contradiction presented by Ernst Mach against Newton and decided the universe’s laws needed to be rewritten with geometry to adjudicate the threshold of Newton’s constraints. This is teachable through cultural development and load-bearing infrastructure, not a sorting hat of intellectual achievement that blesses people sporadically as if ordained by an Empyrean angel.



In fact, the Weil siblings – Andre and Simone – revealed something invariant about how we think of genius that cannot be reduced to intelligence, creativity, or domain knowledge alone. Andre Weil’s work in mathematics was monumental to the Weil conjectures, which established a throughline in number theory and topology and revolutionized the entire field of mathematics. Simone Weil, although starting as a

political anarchist and transitioning into mysticism later in her life, wrote an extensive corpus of work that completely changed how we think about spiritual experience, the relationship between social force and grace, and the concept of affliction as a medium to strip away the structure of reality without illusions. Both Andre and Simone worked in entirely different domains seemingly far away from one another on the surface, and despite this, they employed the same method: stripping away at the abstractions of a problem until the solution or problem became more transparent. There's a shared language even beyond their respective domains on how to approach a problem by refusing to compromise themselves intellectually and a commitment to first principles that shifts the frontier of their knowledge domain. What we have canonized as geniuses throughout history are typically people like Einstein or von Neumann who we sit on the shoulders of in their respective fields of study, but these are people who typically sit isolated as intellectual giants within their family system, even going so far as to overshadow their own children and everyone around them. When siblings do achieve notoriety together, they typically do so within a singular domain or without sharing a methodological kinship, ranging from the Wright brothers in aviation to even people like William James and Henry James, who despite working in psychology and literature respectively, were mostly in adjacent fields academically without a lot of immediate family resemblance in their methodology. The Weils are different: one is a mystic, and the other is a mathematician, and if you couldn't tell the difference in content, you certainly wouldn't be able to tell the difference in method. Andre and Simone revealed something more fundamental about genius that cannot be reduced to genetics or environment alone, partly because they reveal something about genius that you can actually teach to anyone. An action that contains no unresolved future collapses into form without transition, completing its bargain with loss without the phase lag of decision.

The Weils demonstrated a sensitivity to structure and intellectual integrity through their own nurtured curiosity about the problems of the world, and they both elected to strip away a problem of all of its excesses to reveal the essential structure underneath them. Their approach is about how we can identify and see the invariant structure beneath a problem that makes its categorization and conflicts obsolete, and that is not something you can necessarily develop by becoming more intelligent, educated or creative, because many people go their entire lives with the best of all three, and still find themselves compromising their ethical and intellectual integrity all of the time to advance in their lives without ever revolutionizing their field. Lucidity of compunction and instantaneousness of action are forged from attention to timing under pressure, not by agile cleverness or intellectual exemplar. This framework requires a more perceptual dimension in how we compose the relationship between ingenuity and cognition, in which we can see through symbolic systems to reveal underlying structures beneath them, and such an approach can be learned and trained at any age or any circumstance. This way of thinking is how a chessmaster, for example, may see a board differently than a novice chess player, or how someone may speedrun a video game once they figure out how to exploit the intended structure of the game they're playing, because they have a domain-agnostic approach to nurturing expertise that transcends ideological and epistemic silos. The Japanese fighting game savant, Daigo Umehara, argues that there are a handful of universal skills needed to cultivate fluency in competitive gaming for any fighting game franchise, the most important of which being the "power to construct strategies", which he describes as a meta-level framework of analyzing the playstyle of the opponent and strategically adapting one's own playstyle based on what they know about the rules of the game and the terrain of the match itself. Daigo emphasizes that mastering one's playstyle is not as important as mastering the terrain itself, which includes the game mechanics and the playstyle of the other people in a tournament. If one reads the earlier Japanese samurai literature, such as the Hagakure or the

Book of Five Rings, one would find similar teachings which are less about sword technique and more about structural encounter, except back then, this was entirely practical knowledge for swordsmen who either adopted the binding of decision to execution or would die in combat. A blade forged into laminar flow only transfers injury because shear stress has nowhere else to go. What is often called human potential may require a cultivated posture of structural sensitivity, by exporting failure only to the point of contact where no buffer exists between repair and fracture. This narrative of cultivated sensitivity and epistemic appetite contradicts our typical genius narrative because it does not reduce individuals or families to their circumstances or genetic heritability, and in fact mystifies the typical genius narrative by suggesting that maybe a phenotype or encephalization cannot explain away why people can deeply sense the structural iniquities around them despite being told they should actively not try to know or understand them, or most blasphemously of all, try to change them.



The abstractions of society and its conceptions of value, be they coordinated through commodity exchange, adjudicative practice, metrics, and bureaucracy, go beyond the realm of cognition entirely. This is the core claim behind what Alfred Sohn-Rethel calls the real abstraction: the abstract configurations of society are materially enactive to how living systems function, regardless of whether or not they are agreed with. People do not necessarily believe or commit to abstractions for them to administrate life, prior to any symbolic realization of conscious activity. People ultimately live inside the abstractions of the symbolic order and are conditioned by them, and these abstractions coordinate activity first and confer belief systems second, if beliefs are accepted even piecemeal. Proceeding from the conditions of abstraction that we inhabit whether we internalize them or not, Helmuth Plessner insists that living systems are governed by positionality, which in Plessner's terms, situates living beings

through how they mediate their own limits. Plessner acknowledges that organisms relate to themselves through their relationship to their boundaries, which are materially pre-perceptual and thus outside of a constitutive connection to subject or object. The expansion of life, along these lines, persists initially through the continuous embodiment and repair of the boundaries endogenous to life, in contrast to prioritizing interpretive sovereignty or reflection. As life remains isolated and passively fragmented by disconnection, life also remains actively fragmented by the accelerated volume of information that we are expecting to process at the subconscious level throughout our entire lives. Incidentally to the informational noise promulgated by the present social order, systems can comfortably abstract past any notion of feasibility, and the social organisms within these systems fracture under the weight of stimulation and signal velocity based on how institutions coordinate information and material exchange. The use of technology in a given society simply follows how systems coordinate amongst themselves, and when lived meaning is governed by abstract computational metrics, the relationship to computation and cognition mutates in accordance with the abstractions valued by the status quo.



Peter Putnam articulated something foundational about the brain as early as the 20th century, although chose to remain obscure in his scholarship and his lifespan. His papers offered a completely different perspective on the primacy of subjectivity for mental phenomena: the brain itself is an induction machine, evolving its own heuristics through environmentalized interaction. Unlike the mechanistic models in which cognition is processed sequentially and dualistically through some body and mind feedback loop, Peter Putnam argued against such complications at all. Instead, the brain simply repeats the most familiar state it knows in parallel with all other excitatory and inhibitory facilitations that allow for the brain to search automatically among

all possible variations and field states. Putnam presents a model of mind in which the mind scaffolds all known responses to excitatory or inhibitory phenomena to approximate a familiar neural state: “The compounding of elementary act controlling sensory groupings occurs on the sensory side without need of feedback from below (once the link is formed). Motor response to a cue, once established, is not effected by cutting sensory inputs from that limb, or associational inputs to the sensory side that come from lower centers. The pre-engaged acts link with images related to motor sequences following the acts. They return to the starting point via elementary learning cycles. Imagination is closely bound to locomotion in young children. It only begins to break up into more abstract forms at ten or so.” In this 1978 lecture, Putnam formalizes a model of associative cognition that cycles autonomously without the need for continuous sensory feedback, and the imagination observed in children follows an embodied exploration of possible action sequences.



Putnam is careful also to note that abstractions can outrun in scale how a body develops psychophysiologically, such that the action loops that harden are rigorously pressed upon by the abstractions that systems coordinate. Whether we realize it or not, action stabilizes before meaning or semiosis necessarily does, and when ideological abstraction divorces from embodied constraints, we are conditioned to evolve in the trajectory that prioritizes systemic instability regardless of limits. Putnam acknowledged that brains are not sterile central command models of computers that process symbols without context, and are instead the sum of all the contextually significant connections an individual makes to the environment they're in. Through such a model, Putnam argues that cognition is subject to evolutionary processes and the brain evolves with the environment they are in, an insight that many neuroscientists are beginning to converge upon several decades after his papers were drafted. Cognition in such a model stabilizes

for continuity over accuracy, and when you admit abstraction outruns embodiment, we recognize that social systems at macro scale select for specific traits of cognition that benefit the maintenance of the social system. Once loops of activity ossify into place, change at micro level is profoundly expensive for any cognitive architecture, not just a specific lineage. It would behoove us to clarify scope by admitting cognition is not conceptually pathological when administrative regimes are practically pathological in how these regimes historically and socially organize cognitive architecture at a macro scale through selection pressure. Admissibility precedes inference, which consequently delimits the inferential space that cognition thereby operates in. Thus, the task of any organizational system is to determine which action loops are terminable by the extent that they deny boundaried care and reciprocity.



Speed and efficiency without boundaries and reciprocity, in contrast, is merely authority made kinetic. The fascist idolatry of speed is one where velocity becomes the master, and the conspiracy becomes the mass mythology of salvation. Accelerationism is just the totalizing logic of speed at the expense of reality, of velocity over eurhythmia, where entropy ceases to become the residual of action and instead becomes the organizing principle of social activity. Throughout historical configurations, accelerationism has tended towards at least two invariant patterns: the instrumentation of life as fungible, and a laicized hastening of an eschaton whether theology provides a robe or not. Time becomes a badge of identity that authorizes the self, and inevitability is just the vainglory performance of a self under this model. The idolatry of speed is not a historical aberration, but remains an echo from the old matador of 20th century fascism that refuses to entreat the bull, that chaotic force of decayed ideas within history, with the dignity of death as it charges into the present. The pale rider of modernity trails the bull, and in its weariness, clears

its wardrobe for new regalia with each passing generation. As social and technological acceleration both destabilize autonomous meaning making, reactionary forces exploit the power vacuum and inundate reality with an addictive image of coherence: a sort of mirage in the desert masquerading as an oasis by which drinking from it at the exclusion of others will enable survival. The French *Annales* historians evaluate this interstice through the *longue durée*, by which event and place-based time measures the longitude of change in the context of history. A conspiratorial mind is one that only accepts the propaganda of kinship in a desperate battle for shared meaning when instability is too much to metabolize, and settles assiduously to maintain a sense of stability on a brittle foundation of order. We are able to spectate in a coliseum, as if under the enchantment of gladiatorial sacrifice.



The least understood facet of mythology and symbolic architecture as a driving force is that the grammar of the living world system always collapses myth into the architecture of thought. The palingenetic ultranationalism that defines 20th century fascist and ethnonationalist movements can only facilitate atrocity under the assumption that they will never be adjudicated in history if they push the boundary of the symbolic order onto the subjects they create through subjugation. Georges Sorel, incidentally more attuned to this contradiction than most of the fascists who appropriate his work, understood that myth was fundamentally a finite cultural instrument that organizes decisive action between one world to the next. Mythology develops not as belief formation, as a creative performance of maximal, scale-dependent tension that stabilizes a social system or an associative configuration of shared reality, including a state or a tribal network. Vyacheslav Ivanov further clarifies that cultural myths are distributed machines of cognition, as opposed to symbolic codes, and machines either update through collective maintenance or decay under archival ownership. A mythology can only expand insofar as life expands the mythology as

a way of cohering the symbolic stability of cultural norm. Fascists control systems through myth and display myth, but they cannot generate myth. The fascist and reactionary movements of history have deployed myth as jurisprudence, but often collapse into the fold of the dying world they attempt to resurrect through the factory of entropy. Sorel's limitation was one in which befell the gratification of myth as a creative media for world building, which resulted in him cycling between Marx and Mussolini without losing a contradiction of his thought given that he inherited the notion of myth as irrational will to power, through the latent influence of Bergson's irrational will. Before Bergson, however, Jean-Marie Guyau articulated the deeper wisdom behind myth as generative, which was that life expands myth into the overflow of new form, not that myth expands life. If you assume that social decay is inherently a pathological thing to repair through creative cultural development, then myth can be appropriated by fascists. However, cultural development of creative form leads the transition between worlds, as McLuhan himself admitted. Life inherently wants to expand through relationships and collective social development, which clarifies why fascism always deteriorates outside of the conditions of social decay that precipitate the fascist myth. Myth is just semantic infrastructure for the expression of living systems, and the process of convivial demologia produces produces symbols in their distilled substrate: organized instruments of form and action. No matter how much fascism attempts to steal symbolic forms, they cannot access the process that generates myth, only extract from the process and eventually wither when they realize that their survival is entirely dependent on a host.



Building off of Derrida's writing on the postcard, Hiroki Azuma describes the concept of postal space: a fully constructed communication ecosystem in which the infrastructure of sending messages mirrors the reception of their content. In other words, the topology of how

a message is routed determines the meaning behind its content prior to the interpretation from the recipient of the message. Azuma applies this insight on his own musings in the informational economy of internet subcultures, which focus more on the shared space between the initiation of an email delivery and how the email lands for the receiver rather than what the email actually says. Azuma recognizes that virtual infrastructure, like analog infrastructure, mediates activity of the user of a given tool depending on how a platform or software is structured: "However, computers have characteristics essentially to make the invisible visible immediately, if given the correct environment. It is easy to see the program behind the interface of an application, by acquiring appropriate software and decrypting the applications. (This is known as "decompiling," an operation often forbidden in reality.) We are not aware of these things when we use computers normally, but we should not ignore these fundamental characteristics if we are to consider the new culture based on computing, including the Web." Azuma opens up the possibility that our relationship to tools and the information ecosystems that they live in can, in fact, lead to rupture when they do not work as intended. Through this rupture, the user realizes not only are they one of many participants in the virtual world, unconsciously recognizing together that there is a disconnect in the communication system they're embedded in, and they also have found that physical reality mirrors this disconnect. When we begin to understand the media form as subsumed by the jurisdiction of its sign value (such as a fictitious commodity, as Polanyi would put it), the consumption of media reflects the consumption of the system that conceals its juridical shape behind the aesthetic presentation of its form. Eiji Otsuka defines this phenomena as narrative consumption and defines its terminus: "At this future point in time, the commodity producers [okurite; literally "senders"] will become excluded from the system of consumption and will no longer be able to manage the commodities they themselves had originally produced. For this reason, the final stage of narrative consumption points to a state of affairs wherein

making a commodity and consuming it merge into one. There will no longer be manufacturers. There will merely be countless consumers who make commodities with their own hands and consume them with their own hands. Let us be clear here: this would mark the closing scene of the consumer society that saw the endless play of things as signs." The perpetuity of sign system play as symbolic social order relies upon the collective probate of a world where people consent to compressing their multitudes into a singular dimension quantified by their ordinal position in a queue. The stability of any system loses its thaumaturgy when its routing machinery becomes visible, and requires esoteric opacity to dominate through exclusion from the social order. If our relationship to our own memory is any indication, technology only derives stability from how it is used, and thus any informational ecosystem that does not immediately consider the routing mechanism of the message as opposed to the data that it can harvest from its user should be immediately filtered through the fragility that its sovereignty rests upon.

PNEUMA · 180°



Eugene Gendlin locates meaning in situational encounter, which sharply contrasts with the conventions of meaning being exclusively construed as symbolic of representation. In Gendlin's case, meaning is simply something that either carries forward or does not carry at all. In this regard, continuity is the only ethical consideration that situates meaning as a custodial task. What Gendlin calls implicit intricacy sets the following parameters on how felt experience feels and what meaning can do: experience always carries more texture than we say or think, both in a physiological and psychological sense, and language eventually reaches a limit where it exhausts the capacity to make sense out of our experiences. Either way, we walk away from someone changed, either by metabolizing the encounter or letting it remain unresolved within ourselves. In the absence of our understanding or repair, our encounters arrive at a hinge where we are simply repositioned, regardless of whether we console ourselves into an internal place of intellectual agreement. Rarefaction occurs at the point when breathing sheds weight, because breathing either continues or condenses through our labored deferral. The Greek pneumatic engineers such as Philon of Byzantium developed self-regulating systems that extracted air and water to automate temple doors, wine dispensers, temple rituals, feedback water clocks, talking statues, and prototypical steam engines for reaction propulsion. Greek automatons

represented one of the early configurations of a cybernetic feedback system, which for the Greeks was rooted in the concept of breathing itself. Early Greek cybernetics was an embodied cybernetics and a prototypical science of cognition, for which they determined that the soul was a self-regulating engine that needed to metabolize the feedback of its surroundings. Alexander Bogdanov later generalizes the Greek pneumatic ethos by determining how collective social systems themselves practiced embodied feedback at scale through the social ecology of thought and activity. Bogdanov's tektology and Greek pneumatics were early attempts to draft an understanding on how systems develop and how systems heal themselves in the felt phenomenology of the living system and atmosphere. Fundamentally, our conception of healing and our conception of breathing are questions that go beyond interiorized life and begin to look more like how the Greeks saw air as infrastructure, precisely because they saw breathing as infrastructure for the living.



The notion by David Chalmers of p-zombies, which suggests a thought experiment about a sentient individual lacking qualia, presents a false problem to an illusory hard problem of consciousness. The analytic notion of p-zombies assumes a clean ontological subtraction of experience from the individual, where consciousness is always reducible to physicalism and behaviorism. Individuals do not ever lack qualia because they never lack context or truth; rather, individuals can lack epistemic openness through a complex dynamic interaction of psychosocial conditions, stages of development, socialization and social circumstances, and a variety of other factors that ensure our perspectives are never linear in their development. Zombification is a process rather than a static condition one eventually crosses over into, and the process leads in one precise direction: the foreclosure and active enclosure of epistemic openness. Zombification imposes a condition of consciousness under psychological constraints, where

we are gradually emptied of agency, meaning, entrainment, and the capacity to influence the relational field that we are always in no matter how precise we are with meaning. Zombies are more like automatons – they behave through some mechanistic determinism on scripted autopilot as opposed to just an unconscious consumer in a particular stage of capitalism. Early depictions of zombies in culture and film more closely resembled this context of which zombies developed, not as some grotesque flesh eating human parasite but as a mechanistic automaton puppeteered by something else. The 1932 film *White Zombie* was overt and distinct in its influences from Haitian voodoo, depicting Bela Lugosi as a zombie master from Haiti who transforms a young Madeleine Short into a zombie automaton, appropriating her into a sugarcane mill to endlessly drive factory production alongside other zombies. The Haitian concept of zombie was something perhaps even more eerie and uncanny than just depicting a slave on a sugar plantation, because at least a slave had autonomy and will that could be politicized and nurtured into emergent agency.



The Haitian zombie has no emergent property of agency or contradiction at all, because they are agents that are grafted to structures and completely inseparable from deciding on epistemic proximity to these structures or openness beyond them. Their capacity for independent thought is fully colonized and domesticated into pure unmediated compliance rather than emptying their capacity to experience life. Frantz Fanon explored this psychological posture throughout his work, finding precise intersections between stolen spiritual autonomy and colonial domination: “The colonized subject is a persecuted man who is forever dreaming of becoming the persecutor. The symbols of society such as the police force, bugle calls in the barracks, military parades, and the flag flying aloft, serve not only as inhibitors but also as stimulants. They do not signify: “Stay where you are.” But rather “Get ready to do the right thing.” And in fact if ever the colonized

subject begins to doze off or forget, the colonist's arrogance and preoccupation with testing the solidity of the colonial system will remind him on so many occasions that the great showdown cannot be postponed indefinitely." Haitian voodoo recognizes that zombification is a spiritual problem rather than a behavioral problem, where one's capacity to develop or entrain themselves towards autonomy or self-sufficiency is spiritually manipulated and held captive by someone else. The depiction of zombies in Western media transitioned after the 50s into the contemporary Romero-era depiction of zombies, which are more like parasitic flesh-eating hordes that consume endlessly without discontinuity, gradually stoking an environment of collective dread until society empties itself of meaning and the capacity to consume life. There's a distinctly alchemical transition between the Haitian voodoo zombie and the Western Romero-era zombie which presents two different contrasting narratives on power, society, and agency, albeit the Romero zombie suffers from abstracting away the distinctly Afro-Caribbean analysis on how power psychologically and spiritually dominates: not just through authority imposing their own force of will, but by holding another willpower completely hostage and creating dependency on meaning-making through distinctly colonial mechanisms of erasure. Gaëtan de Clérambault, whose work is inseparable from his deeply colonial gaze through his "drapery studies" in exploitatively photographing women in postwar Morocco, proposed a theory of mental automatisms, leaving behind extensive clinical documentation that surveyed psychological automatism as the primary driver of psychosis, with delusions as a secondary symptom. The automatism framework describes how involuntary symbolic activity persists beyond the agency of the patient, either as intrusive excess (positive automatism) or inhibitory absence (negative automatism) even when psychophysiological control wanes.

The historical contingencies of alchemy as a practice date back to the furnaces and bread ovens from which alchemy was culturally associated with. The Arabic root of alchemy, *al-kimiya*, was scoped in connecting the practical technique of transforming an object under a pressurized vessel, inseparable from bread ovens, glassworks, and kilns. Newton's pursuit of a magical philosopher's stone that could transmute into gold was metaphorical about the actual magic behind the process, since the alchemical process was never about a substance; rather, alchemy was historically rooted in the regulated thermal infrastructure that facilitated the recombination of dough into bread. Newton, and later Jung in the symbolic register, shifted the burden of the process of alchemy to the surface of alchemical substance, for what was ultimately a question of what survives heat and what decomposes under thermal pressure. The corpus of Jabir ibn Hayyan discusses the science of balance (*ilm-al-mizan*) as a conserved proportionality law of processual change, in which living substrates are composed of measurable quantities of intensity (such as heat and moisture), and all transformations are recombination of these intensive quantities. The Jabirian lens of knowledge as an alchemical process assumes that all knowledge is grounded in stoichiometric ratio rather than addressability, and that knowledge requires active rebalancing rather than propositional declaration. The balance of quantitative regularities survives through the agonism of what resists perturbation; that is, a mineral resists erosion through thermodynamic recomposition without the presupposition of a surface description. Reality, under rebalancing, simply tracks what remains invariant under continuous transformation within the tolerances of pressure. The notions of symbol, transmutation, cyclical renewal, the harmonious mirroring of microcosm and macrocosm as a measure of health rather than separating individual from universe as poison and pathology, were fundamentally about how to create balance in oneself by ensuring the social context of one's health was also integrated within that balance. The individual and the community transform each other in this process if they choose to, and if they do not, the

instability is felt if one summons themselves as exceptional to the laws of thermodynamics. Paracelsus understood that the notion of macrocosmic harmony mirroring microcosmic harmony was not just a hermetic riddle to be solved, but a practical approach for a physician to prognose a sick system just as much as they diagnosed an individual patient. The decision to remedy only at the scale of local pathology in human bodies assumes a remainder of harm at the broader scale that continues without repair.



Western healing culture has broadly attuned themselves towards the dread of transformation and confrontation towards the unknown. Traditional CBT methods and talk therapy are largely about how to give shape to our feelings and how to label our symptoms, but therapeutic interventions frequently encounter constraints in actually navigating how to prepare us for contradiction, complexity, conflict, and danger when preparation is absolutely needed. When one is in a dangerous situation whether in relationships or in the neighborhoods they live in, we are always navigating questions about how to metabolize the pain that others launder onto us, rather than how to prepare in real time for combat and preparation for conflict when wrongdoing is inflicted upon us. In such a model, our capacity to metabolize pain slowly erodes, to the point of which we no longer have a psyche or a soma to process, only a wisp that floats incandescently through reality in hopes that it will drift somewhere safely. The contemporary drift into the failures of Western talk therapy to integrate nondual and somatic approaches are a reactive anodyne to a deeper structural wound that has been ripped open and infected by late modernity. Somatic approaches have become particularly in vogue in many conversations in healer-oriented communities around how to respond to the ineffectiveness of just feeling one's feelings out by giving them a linguistic syntax and instead attempting to access a deeper sensible layer – the notion that we have forgotten how to feel things out in the body and we must

pay attention to our nervous system attunement and activations. The notion of “returning to the body” not only risks sloganeering for a type of therapeutic capitalism, it risks enforcing a more insidious and subtle disconnect, where somehow our minds have become unreliable narrators that interrupt some primordial sensuousness we always have access to, and somehow these things are in conflict with one another. Privatized somatic achievement cannot resolve a systemic load misdistribution problem under the guise of making regulation the responsibility of a single nervous system. Bodies are always embedded in a larger stress rotation ecosystem that equally shares labor for coregulation of load distribution across autonomic, ecological, and social layers of interaction.



The 21st century has been arbitrarily split between what the body knows and what the total institutions like states and academia refuse to conceptualize, but this is ultimately not a burden that the body carries on its own with more sophisticated regulatory mechanisms. The boundaries between reason and experience, like they are between psyche and soma, are ultimately porous and thus frivolously policed by assuming rigid compartmentalization. Tyrannical social structures and institutions do not need to return a body, because they recognize how to embody and launder control through capacity that we do not have solely through somatic regulation. There is no hierarchical distinction between body and mind, psyche and soma, or self and other beyond the hemispheric disparity in mirror image perception; how we theorize the connection to ourselves is how we practice the connection ourselves, and how we practice our own connection to ourselves is how we practice our connection to others. Without the contextual tools of how to not just to process, but also how we decisively act, therapy and psychology writ large compromise on the notion of healthy confrontation and generative antagonism as a way of asserting one's dignity when it is necessary to confront the dreadful reality of the world one lives

in. If we confront reality and reality invalidates us, this is a deeper structural problem that simply better breathwork or self-auditing does not resolve. Sometimes feeling your feelings out or connecting to your nervous system as a coping mechanism is insufficient when we are in dangerous family systems or live in a dangerous, semantically saturated world where we cannot freely feel anything out without the weight of life sinking its talons into our spines no matter how clearly we articulate our thoughts. The civilizational wound that the 21st century will wrangle with, by necessity, goes beyond mere political or cultural schisms, because those are more generally a symptom of a structurally atomized, epistemically fragmented, and somatically overheated world. People could feel the collapse of institutions before the institutions could embody the reason behind why they are devolving into reactive alienation and chronic attention fatigue. The knowledge to resolve these schisms, for generations, have been locked away in attics behind inherited trauma, 20th century geopolitical hedging, and extreme academic siloing where the status anxiety and risk aversion precedes cross-disciplinary integration. These were not problems that civilizations have inherited for millennia, because the boundary between local phenomena and the cosmos were not assumed until they were colonially enforced.



The dream is a hatched egg that inhabits the life of the unconscious. What the indigenous societies, such as the Aboriginal Australians and the Peruvian Shipibo, have already figured out and the Western Enlightenment somehow bifurcates into something more obscurantist, is that our unconscious is just a place we visit, and dreams are just events in that place outside of time. Numerous indigenous cosmologies, such as Aboriginal Dreamtime and Polynesian wayfinding, ritualize dynamic reciprocity between experience and world, because any enforced partition between experience and world naturally defers the maintenance burden onto the future to pick up the fragments

at the scale of disrepair. The immediate encounter in our dreams of events, whether we are prepared for them or not, have something to share with us when we wake up, and we either respond with absence or with presence. Often, these events are completely randomized with some pattern based recognition underneath as a structural safety net of reason and as a harmonic trace of intelligibility. Randomness is exactly how we are tested and how we are taught. Dreams function more as experimental tests of the unconscious, where the active layers of our cognition relax their waking filter to slowly reveal what we may not choose to encounter. A dream is never a passive sequence one receives; rather, dreams actively generate form in the laboratory of the unconscious, revealing the structures of reality and how we resolve contradictions internally. The place that our dreams live in is one where we encounter other people, that we either know or do not know, in scenarios that we either respond to or don't. The mystery of the unconscious lies in the stochasticity of this process— but our integration is determined in part by how we build ritual around dreams, whether with others or ourselves. The Freudian encounter of the Dream as symbolic fixation projects what Freud himself may have needed to encounter, but they don't speak practically to how dreams actually work in reality. The subject of the dreamer is the dream.



This insight is something that Fyodor Dostoyevsky in his most raw works, namely *The Idiot* and *Demons*, stumbled upon in the theological register, and shares spiritual company with through Simone Weil. Meaning is built from below through the acceptance of entropy and disorder in the world, and inhabited through the autonomous creation of systems that are actively harmonized with the world. Myshkin's holy ignorance – that is, his refusal to participate in the self-interested moral calculus of the social order – is threatening to the entire world precisely because it presents as unusual – we cannot call Myshkin a jester or a saint, but something else created from the interplay

from both. Myshkin's saintliness is just a mirror that reflects the psychological fragility of its moral universe back to the encounter, but his failure to survive reflects his duty to not adapt to the violence of the world around him. Dostoyevsky uses this character to explore the concept of *sobernost*: the emergent spiritual togetherness of people who jointly coordinate it amongst each other and the world despite the world's capacity for violence and segmentation. It is important to highlight what makes this such a necessary statement, because it advocates neither for free will or determinism but something more stochastic than either one exclusively, and that stochasticity emerges from the double-edged boundary interactions amongst shared social life. Dostoyevsky wrote his work from a carapace against 19th century Russia's growing disillusionment and collective nihilism, not unfamiliar to the contemporary moment, and his writing in *Demons* escalates this to a collective madness of the social fabric, in which the entire social landscape of nihilist conspirators is depicted through the metaphor of demonic possession, in which the social body is corrupted virally by ideology. Dostoyevsky diagnoses nihilism as a contagion, one that replicates widely when there is no stabilizing anchor to metabolize the contradiction of social rupture.



Mikhail Bakhtin notes, for example, Dostoyevsky inherited the tradition of the carnivalesque in literature, in which his universes are often ripe with contradiction between the sacred and profane in societies that carry a totalized ritual (or lack thereof) with them, and perhaps more explicitly, a subversive freedom in which ideas can be tested to their most indulgent degrees: "The most important characteristic of the *menippea* as a genre is the fact that its bold and unrestrained use of the fantastic and adventure is internally motivated, justified by and devoted to a purely ideational and philosophical end: the creation of extraordinary situations for the provoking and testing of a philosophical idea, a discourse, a truth, embodied in the image

of a wise man, the seeker of this truth. We emphasize that the fantastic here serves not for the positive embodiment of truth, but as a mode for searching after truth, provoking it, and, most important, testing it.” Underneath Bakhtin’s literary theory is his notion of answerability, which defines meaning as a lived asymmetry in an irreducible non-coincidence. In Bakhtin’s case, meaning is possible because positions in lived experience do not coincide without remainder, and ethical responsibility is the price of this asymmetry. There is no way to close a gap or attempt a substitution between answerability(which is positional) and visibility(which is distributive) without harm. In a biosemiotic sense, affect is not content or signal but a fielded deformation of form that constrains cognition, and meaning precipitates only as the residual stabilization of unresolved tension.



In *The Double*, Dostoyevsky interrogates the concept of multiple selves with varying personalities that navigate a bureaucracy, and towards the end of the story, the socially awkward protagonist known as Golyadkin fails to adapt as deftly to his doppelganger with more social fluency and eventually, Golyadkin descends into madness given the totalizing structure of the bureaucracy is itself collectively maddening to navigate, even though his younger doppelganger can usurp his social status effortlessly. *The Double* inhabits a world governed by what Franz Kafka describes as the bureaucratic superego: the internalized conditioning at the systemic level of people within a bureaucratic system by the space of rules and procedures that govern that system, regardless of whether those rules are useful or meaningful. What makes this work potent is not Dostoyevsky’s advocacy of liturgical values or his screeds against atheism, but something he intuited about a society driven by determinism and mechanistic ends, where people cease to love and live meaningful lives and fail to recognize why. Dostoyevsky’s psychological posture is inseparable from his literary method, and because of this, his pulse on Russian society interrogated

the loss of psychological stability when people lose autonomy over shared meaning and ritual. He acknowledges throughout his work that revolts and upheavals will happen, but what he cares about is that we do not forget the act of relating to one another in the next world that we build. Whether one chooses to ascertain Dostoyevsky's own anti-communist anxieties, what remains underneath the disdain is a fear of nihilist degradation regardless of the character of the social fabric.



Galen defines health as eucrasia, which conveys an agonistic balance rather than a harmonious equilibrium. If we are to consider that politics never really stops at psychology, then the entire field of medicine is similarly susceptible to the contagion of the bureaucratic superego. Rudolf Virchow broadly understood that medicine is the continuation of politics by other means, and that our models of care often mirror the contradictions and coherence of society, whether locally or globally. The social determinants of health, insofar as they are habituated rather than diagnosed, are only as metastable as the capacity for any environment to distribute care in conditions of asymmetric necessity, and when privation is tolerated, the expiration of the system is already underway. Xavier Bichat rejects the idea that there is a unified body norm or universal standard of care, only a negotiated coexistence of instability in a living system. Allostatic load and diathesis-autonomic asymmetry dynamics are carried regardless of homeorhetic stress circulation, but include exposure over time and structural iatrogenesis, where intervention can either smooth or worsen a shrinking regulatory environment of viability. Medical coordination assumes healthcare resource accessibility, which also assumes a shift in medicaments as a distributed resource coordination rather than regimes of market production. The binary accessibility of the general hospital conglomerate model and the insurance-bound fragmented private sector retail telehealth model is an aberration

stabilized by market fundamentalism rather than an evolutionary standard of care tailored to the needs of the populations they serve. Karl Polanyi calls this embeddedness: the degree by which economic activity is constrained by non-economic institutions. The healthcare world is completely ruled by the embeddedness of market logic on a thermodynamic problem beyond human longevity, even though the notion of market exchange for medical intervention has never been as totalizing and entrenched as it is today. We cannot say with confidence that the pharmaceutical profit motive, vampirism of private equity, or bureaucratization of care have ever explicitly served the medical needs of the public, but they do implicitly serve each other. Metastability precedes equilibrium as a barometer of organized life, in which risk asymmetry is constitutive and care is improvisational. Restoration is not a promise following the premise that there was never a stable origin. The Hippocratic Oath leaves us at a juncture where swearing to do no harm is preceded by the question of what harm is already authorized. Hippocrates even himself observed that nature heals through a tension between excess and correction, which is time-dependent rather than controlled. There is no balance or equilibrium achieved by being alive, only a negotiated persistence against dissipation.



The sequential and temporal biases of reality and knowledge reconfigure the continuity of social systems at appropriate scale, but for children who are born into the world, the family system is the first city-state they inhabit. Adler's notion of birth order is general as birth hierarchy; that is, the conceptual model that the family system is a micro-level representation of macro-level social relations, and the children who are youngest are in negotiation or cooperation over disparities status in the birth order. In particularly traumatized families withstanding the unique stages of development between family members, tensions that go unresolved eventually crystallize into implicit forms of hierarchy, where the elder of the family unit is

an authority figure who metes out the social harmony of the family system. The youngest children have to navigate the hierarchy with some understanding that the family acknowledges their stages of development and invites them in to enhance mutual understanding, or the family unit will invalidate them when they speak up. This is not so much an economic dependency hierarchy as much as it is a social hierarchy; a child depends on the family for stability and resources as they develop into adults, but they also learn from the family system how to metabolize conflict, how to collaborate and play with others, and how to build their own systems of emotional resilience through honest communication and boundary setting. Sometimes that also involves socializing children to learn from dysregulation and invite them into safer and more sustainable ways of living, as opposed to simply shaming them for having a voice.



Children, especially if they are last in the family birth queue by no choice of their own, absorb all of the relational tension, sources of play, and problem solving that is modeled for them to relate in ways that are healthy to others, including when they inherit developmental barriers of their own that require more precise scaffolding than a parent can muster at a given point in time. But ultimately, what we teach children about communicating to parental authority is what we teach them about communicating the challenges of authoritarianism or how to creatively navigate danger without collapsing under pressure. The contextual invalidation of a child's experience begins when they are young and forced to doubt themselves at the behest of the emotional needs of their parents and broader family unit. If the youngest child receives messaging that they are not hungry when they express hunger, they will be conditioned into doubting their capacity to be hungry, and if they are dismissed from articulating that something a parent does is hurtful, they will be conditioned into numbing their capacity to metabolize harm until the body harms itself, because a child also has

an allostatic load regardless of whether they have the words for it. The family is fundamentally the first laboratory of discipline: some families make their rules authoritative and direct, and others diffuse invalidation into children by creating a sense of freedom that can be guilted and shamed into submission. If a child is not empowered to advocate for themselves and play with the world creatively, the exploration that comes with childhood will decay into passivity and melancholy for a childhood they don't have but are told by someone else they should accept. If the youngest sibling speaks for themselves, but they are repeatedly told by their older siblings that their experience is all in their head, that is an invalidation of their capacity to speak, and a form of gaslighting that conditions them into dysthymia unless they regain the capacity to recognize when healthy environments are not like this through future exploration, and then the child has to close their gap in the healing journey between how they adapted to unhealthy environments and how they navigate healthy environments now. The irony of such treatment is that it inadvertently reveals a latency one might call the wounded healer's paradox: those children in the family who are the most fragmented by life also have the capacity to see the fragmentation most clearly and integrate across multiple registers, both within themselves and in others.



Beyond the pop culture of the notion that there are “no bad parts”, the wisdom that Internal Family Systems gives you is that we often inhabit a multiplicity of roles and selves within our family units and these roles maintain custodial duty internally in a control loop. The family system is the first social training ground, and the first village within the larger village where a child navigates and receives stories about the world and themselves, building the capacity for relational authenticity and conscious awareness at once. Families are transparently political and ideological even if they don't talk about politics, and children are always politicized by their interactions in the family system.

Adler's birth order theory was overly sequential and essentialist, implying that elders in the family were always the responsible ones or that the youngest children were iconoclastic and rebellious, which conveniently assumes that the parents the children get are always the same parents across each child, and that the children themselves are in the same stages of psychosocial development between family and society. More often than not, each sibling is raised by different parents within their family of origin, with some family resemblances in the Wittgensteinian sense, such that there are certain trait traits which are freighted over time between children but the actual parents themselves are developmentally different depending on circumstances, and depending on the structure of the family itself, given that divorces are exceedingly common. Siblings may find and express that they are in orbit of overlapping constellations of parental social environments and circumstances with some crosswalk in similar experiences and dispositions from the parents. This does not even scratch the surface beyond the nuclear family, given that queer families of origin and polyamorous households often have radically different models for relationship pedagogy and internal patois despite having the same challenges of socialization and modeling communication for children. Children may not have equal authority in any of these arrangements, but they discover they have an equal say in accepting their experience and being included in the process. Each member of the family unit contains up to a multiplicity of contradictions they must navigate and reconcile within themselves which mirror the roles they simultaneously play within their family unit. Each subsequent role fragments the ego of the family member further within their family system, such that if a person plays four roles within the family system, that can translate to four parts of themselves that are fragmented from routing to each other unless they develop an awareness of the vincula that glue these parts together. The roles imposed by our social relations within the family system both generate new parts of us and split ourselves into the complexity that rebinding these parts often requires. At the core of it, IFS is not strictly about healing inner children at all; rather,

the accumulation of parts are binding sinks of memory that persist because they once kept us safe, and stability between these parts requires tuning the linkages between parts so they can coordinate routing pressure under allostatic load.



The concept of an individual as an atomic social unit does not really apply in practice, given that any living system shares the same underlying survival condition of resolving stress over time prior to identity formation. B.F. Skinner’s notion of behaviorism dominated the field of 20th century Western psychology and even philosophy, with soft models of behaviorism through theorists such as Gilbert Ryle. Skinner’s model of behaviorism is a particular artifact of its time in 20th century modernity, mirroring the modernist notions of discipline by directly imposing external force and stimuli to impose compliance. Skinner’s model reduces humans to wild animals that are conditionable by stimulus-response chains and not by the complex interplay of internal experience and external reality. There is no concept of the soma here, meaning there is only a psyche that is collapsible into a system of mechanistic control. If we treat this concept as exactly what it is, a particular historical artifact, Skinner incidentally reveals a theory of folk behaviorism, where behaviorism is not so much a science or a comprehensive psychological model as much as it is a social mythology of discipline and control. Aaron Swartz actually coined this term when he was 14 years old at his 11th day at Stanford, in which he deliberately chose to subvert the legitimacy of the linear chain of command that insisted on the folklore of him staying in high school to get a job and an education. Aaron Swartz wrote in his blog at the time: “Just before I left for college, I think I realized the answer. School is just one component in a system of institutionalized control that stretches from the family all the way up to capitalism. And the entire system is based on folk behaviorism, the idea that people need to do this to get that. Saying I was going to get that

(an education, a life) without doing this (following the rules, going to school) was a radical statement that challenged the legitimacy of this whole worldview. To protect this worldview, they had to deny this was possible.” Folk behaviorism is not so much a behaviorist view of how individuals are conditioned, but more of a procedural training regime for the recognition of authority under conditions of asymmetric risk. The grammar of this apparatus is a simple transactional “this-for-that” model, moralized as a necessary belief you must comply with or you will be disciplined into compliance. Hierarchy is naturalized in this model as a reward system that may be reinforced through the language of care, conditioning the narrative that safety, belonging, and survival are conditional on obeying the procedures of a system that metes out charity to their followers, rather than the baseline of all mutual social interaction. An ideology manufactures justification at the level of one’s beliefs and theories about the world, but folk behaviorism manufactures compliance at the level of how we actually choose and practice the beliefs we hold. Authoritarian systems, be they family or institutions, do not depend on legitimacy to survive if they can administer the capacity to absorb or deflect consequences for harm. At the purely epistemic level, one’s reality is always a threat assessment in the context of folk behaviorism, in which experiences are inadmissible unless they pass through the gate of compliance and linearized rule-following. Folk behaviorism polarizes the psychological shock field by flooding meaning with conditionality and oversaturation of meaning. Our desires are conditioned to submit legitimacy to only the conditions authorized by someone else in power, and children often learn this when they are maturing in their family system and making choices for themselves. An organized system that has a contradiction it cannot integrate eventually needs a carrier to displace the burden onto.

Folk behaviorism also acknowledges the meaning of power and the meaning of authority, given that the consequences of disobeying authority are genuinely simulated in these systems when confronted with the consequences of laundering harm or exposing their unresolved contradiction. A contradiction is irreducible, and within any organized living system including a family, they are tasked with either bearing the cost of them honestly or exporting the spillage onto someone who can. If a system appears stable on the surface despite internal dysfunction, they only need one person to carry their contradiction even if the carrying destroys them. The costs of disobedience are often disproportionate to the power dynamic at play, where the consequences against the powerful are nowhere near as sanctioned as the consequences for the vulnerable or disempowered in any given authoritarian system. Hierarchy and order can require sacrifice to survive, and when a contradiction is stable in a family, consequences are only distributed to what is rendered susceptible by inadmissibility. Notions of cancel culture as steeped in grievance politics and the indiscriminate ruining of people's lives always sinks in the water of reality: consequences for rule violations always disproportionately impact the people in any power dynamic who are more vulnerable than those with adjudicative authority. Black communities understand this through their archaeological processes of documenting police violence in how force and exclusion are disproportionately wielded by disproportionately powerful structures in society on communities of color, whereas white communities throughout America experience a muted and softened response by police despite potentially equivalent or more severe infractions. Power is often racialized in the spirit of the law, and disparate sociological standards may attune responses to different communities depending on who the law is tailored to protect, despite claiming to uphold the same letter of the law. A racist society protected by the compact of whiteness may choose soft lenient law for white populations, and spectacularly violent hard law for others. Similarly, a highly gendered and patriarchal society may impose brutal hard law and martial discipline upon women and

transgender populations, whereas men with a pattern of occluding and harming these communities can often trapeze through life with a slap on the wrist. In this way, folk behaviorism adapts and drives its own self-preservation by attaching compliance to racialized and gendered myths of who deserves leniency and who deserves violence. These social compacts are not upheld in relation to those they externalize harm onto, they are upheld purely in relation to themselves. Punishment in highly authoritarian systems is more about who can socially or financially afford to protect themselves from consequences rather than how fairly consequences are applied to the people involved. It is easier to destabilize a person who calls out predatory behavior than it is to hold the predator who violated them accountable, so long as the predator has enough guardrails, egoic reflex, and resources to protect themselves. The transfeminine game designer Porpentine beautifully encapsulates this phenomena in their essay Hot Allostatic Load: "Punishment is not something that happens to bad people. It happens to those who cannot stop it from happening. It is laundered pain, not a balancing of scales."



Behavior, in extending what Rodney Brooks wrote, is the exposed distribution of interactions between a social system and the natural environment. Intelligence precedes linguistic development in how social systems distribute capacity across resource gradients. The developmental psychology traditions, marked by theorists such as Piaget and Erikson, understood the significance and nonlinearity of psychological development by organizing it across stages of development, but also grappled with questions about how that development is driven, which could be through a container or a prison depending on the context by which one lives their life. Erikson, Piaget and Maslow struggled through this question and tended towards the notion that developmental stages were rigid, although people tend to inhabit their stages of development fluidly and sometimes oscillate in nonlinear developmental

ways depending on their specific experiences and needs. The Siksika Nation, also known as the Blackfoot, developed an indigenous model of basic needs that contrasts heavily with the more widely known model in the Western world from Abraham Maslow, even though his theory was informed by his own exposure and residency in an Albertan Blackfoot reserve during the 1930s. The particular tragedy and tension of this experience is that Maslow chose to invert the Blackfoot model towards an overly individualistic lens, which canonized him in the Western world and the K-12 science textbooks, rewarding his appropriation at the expense of contextual erasure. In the Blackfoot hierarchy of needs, self-actualization is actually at the very bottom, as opposed to Maslow's hierarchy which puts self-actualization at the top of the hierarchy under psychological needs, safety needs, and belonging needs. This perspective on needs runs the risk of compressing temporal perspective and insight orientation into a singular self-oriented scope of history and reality, one that is culturally conditioned throughout much of the colonized West but not necessarily shared at all amongst many indigenous communities throughout the world, let alone in the First Nations context. For the Blackfoot, the hierarchy of needs reflects a conceptual framing of time and self as not sequential and linearly progressed, but as situated in a larger scope of nonlinear time and shared development of reality across multiple dimensions of personal, community, and historical development. The hierarchy straightforwardly progresses from self-actualization → community actualization → cultural perpetuity, with self actualization at the bottom of the hierarchy. This acknowledges a more inclusive and sustainable conception of healing which incidentally fosters a deeper sense of belonging, safety, and psychological openness than individual self-actualization achieves in isolation. Individual self-actualization in isolation can become perpetuity of isolation, which habituates avoidance and atomism by treating one's peace as a finite currency that is emptied through interaction with society, rather than a dynamic exploration of one's needs and constraints based on a social fabric they acknowledge they co-develop no matter how many degrees of

separation they impose upon it. The Blackfoot model acknowledges this because cultural perpetuity is at the top of their pyramid, establishing the relationship between individual transformation and collective transformation in a way that scales from the individual to the systems they are always inhabiting.



Lev Vygotsky's work during the Soviet era on cultural-historical activity theory reflected an effort to integrate the individual with the social structures they inhabited, and recognized the significance of the teachers and elders in the process to scaffold together the youth in their unique stages of development. Learning is relational in such a model and is scaffolded by those with expertise, whether in families, communities, schools, or work environments. Vygotsky noted the necessity of mediating as core to supporting the healthy psychological development of individuals and their emergent capacity for kinship, where free play and exploration of interior experience could be scaffolded by others with more experience and knowledge through what Vygotsky called the zone of proximal development. More precisely, we seek to refine Vygotsky's own theories to nurture the emergent properties that are possible when individual development is mirrored through the pedagogy of others, where no individual despite their current stage of development learns how to develop in the world to their fullest potential by foreclosing their exploration and capacity to learn from experience. The individual, the community, and the systems they inhabit are always in dialogue with one another and develop this collaboration emergence through mutual exploration of all possibilities and field states in a relational field as opposed to situating their healing or development through the burden of any one individual. Everyone is always developing and evolving in their life in ways that are nonlinear, and what remains possible is through the entire system and all of its inhabitants developing a dynamic posture for deeper complexity and exploration and developing awareness

around static foreclosure. Papert's principle applies here as well – the computer scientist Seymour Papert proposed an idea later formalized by Marvin Minsky that children developed not just through learning and acquisition of new knowledge, but also by the exploratory use and administrative fluency in how knowledge circulates. Children and adults develop through a continuous field of activity in which they are free to play reciprocally with others, and through their exploration they learn about themselves and the world.



Papert's work on human-computer interaction and child development is particularly striking because it operates in a liminal space of its own: the period of the 20th century when computers were not yet mass produced or widely accessible, when devices were not ubiquitous in all sectors of life, and when learning was largely an analog endeavor rather than a digital one. This allowed Papert to advocate for computers to serve as objects that could scaffold and potentiate learning and development rather than sites of addictive scrolling. This particularly lands in how he describes the spatiotemporal role that computers dwell in: "the computer stands betwixt and between the world of formal systems and physical things; it has the ability to make the abstract concrete." One recalls Ilyenkov's own explorations of the ideal and the concrete, in which the universe of logic is motorized by a constant of activity: "In other words, what takes place here is the same living mutual transformation of the universal and the particular, of the elementary and the complex which we observed in the categories of capital, where profit emerges as developed value, as a developed elementary form of commodity, to which profit is continually reduced in the real movement of the economic system and therefore in thought reproducing this movement. Here as everywhere else, the concrete universal concept registers a real objective elementary form of the existence of the entire system rather than an empty abstraction." Ilyenkov departs from the Hegelian dialectic of subjective thought and abstract universality

by asserting that thought emerges as an objective form of social practice, and contradiction is worked through the activity of the real world rather than sublated into a predestined conceptual outcome. The concept of objectivity does not differentiate through separation from lived experience and living systems, as Ilyenkov carefully argues, but as independence from any particular living system entirely. This approach defines objective forms within systems as existing entirely between the lived interactions in these systems, situating ethics and truth not as relative or private but as structure determined by shared practices, material constraints, the lived continuity of memory, and the enactive coordination that structures the world.



Papert and Ilyenkov both circle around the possibility that objectivity is a real thing that exists as collective social practice crystallized into form, which does not depend on the subjective primacy of mind, matter, or any subjective transcendental representation. An important overlap then occurs, with important contrasts: Papert and Ilyenkov, without necessarily discussing the same domain, are working at the application of self-mobilizing activity as an engine for change in the context of lived reality and the tools accessible to us in social practice, yet Papert does not anticipate the mass commodification of the computer, and therefore its elementary form as an object of capitalist society. However, Papert does take the form of the object a step further than Ilyenkov because he recognizes the computer as a medium for the activity that connects physical and virtual environments: “As computational objects, turtles and sprites stand on the boundary between the physical and the abstract. In some ways both are like physical objects. You can see them, move them, put one on top of another. But at the same time, they are abstract and mathematical. Ambivalent in their nature, computational objects can be approached in different ways. Hard-approach programmers treat a sprite more like an abstract entity – a Newtonian particle – while soft-approach programmers treat it more

like a physical object – a dab of paint or a cardboard cutout. Because of this ambivalence, computational objects offer a great deal to those whose approach requires a close relationship to an object experienced as tactile and concrete. Computational objects offer a physical path of access to the world of formal systems.” The object is not just an ambivalent abstraction between the physical and virtual, given there are layers of conscious, unconscious, and structural considerations that these devices inhabit in how we relate to them. The virtual media form generates infrastructure for our lived relationships through our digital interactions, which share an environment with physical interactions in terms of how they are structured by social practice and how they are actively used to mediate feedback within living systems. Our proximity to an object extends beyond our experience with objects because proximity also shapes places and events, regardless of the objects used within them. Something more fundamental occurs in the range of people, environments, noise, quiet, and pattern languages that we develop in.



Whether mediated through tools or through shared material life, temporality appears to us as inherited structure: a history whose passage cannot be reversed and whose effects persist beyond immediate control. Sometimes, this history accumulates before us, and sometimes it sediments into structure. The duration of time matters insofar as the structure can bear the phenomenological weight of continuity. Suhrawardi describes the nature of things through knowledge by presence, in which we do not begin life by inferring our judgments but by radiating ourselves out into the world through absolute presence. Presence arises as a disclosure of a living system through its own continuous stewardship of memory. Paradoxically, presence develops through exposure to absence, in which we metabolize the thickening of contradictions and the passage of deep time. In contrast to this definition of existence, Keiji Nishitani describes the condition of

nonexistence or absolute nothingness as the pure undifferentiated field of relationships that are ultimately full of structure through our recognition of interdependence. Nishitani diverges from the Western conception of nihility as an incorrigible clinic of lack that attempts to fill the void of an absolute groundswell of existence. Nishitani admits that lived experience arises with the world and not before the world, and that experience itself is a field of relationships with no independent phenomena rather than a substance. Interdependence precedes existence and thus essence in this lens, given that we are not born subjects accessing a world but as a field of mutual arising into lived existence. However, Nishitani later even admits the concept of nonexistence or nothingness still assumes a concept of self, and he admits replacements of this assumed monotheism of being: that nothingness is the door to the house of a field without a developmental horizon, and after nihilism and beyond the concept of emptiness, all things manifest the other from their own ground. Thus, the stance of nothingness and being as a noun dissolves because there is no dependence on there being anything but a mutual ontogeny of negations that negate their negative stance, revealing onto the luminosity of relationships across time. Nishitani aligns closer to the Huayan Buddhists such as Fazang through the concept of Indra's Net, in which each being begins as a jewel in a web of jewels that through stripping away the excess of independent phenomena, reveal that the boundary between object, mirror, reflection, and ultimately luminosity dissolves.



Without the free float of orgone as energetic metaphysics, Wilhelm Reich's concept of armor operates as a mechanical phenomena rather than a psychic one: armor, in a social-somatic register, is just chronic load misdistribution in which rigidity across psychic and physiological systems coregulates into pathology. Rigidity is stress immobilization within a system that fails to rotate stress continuously between

autonomic regulation and skeletal tension. Stress can either surf as an orthodromic or antidromic impulse compatibility, but there is no outside of the redistribution of stress, only the acceleration or deceleration of living velocity through it. Lacan introduces the idea of the Borromean knot later in his work: the concentric overlap between the Real, the Symbolic, and the Imaginary as contingent knots, but also registers that they are distinct and inseparable: if one of these knots tears from the other or unglues from exposure to reality, the entire knot unravels leading to disconnection from reality, which itself could be very dangerous because that can lead to a form of psychic decompensation where one's perception of reality is deeply disconnected, losing the capacity to focus on what is real and what is not real. Schizophrenia's positive symptoms of delusions and hallucinations could be thought of as a world that simultaneously believes everything is true and nothing is true at the same time, where connections between phenomena lose coherence and contradictions between phenomena circulate without symbolic containment. The "influencing machine" described by Victor Tausk, in this context, operates prosthetically within delusion as an effective pressure deterioration of an orthogonal boundary between symbolic representation and causal reality, persisting even in the absence of any existent objectual pressure. In this sense, Lacan points to a structure of the psyche that resembles the binding constraints of DNA structure: the binding rules of the double helix encode the stability of the entire DNA structure, and once the base pairing is violated and torn, the entire structure collapses. Adjacent to this, the psyche's capacity to cohere metaphysical information about reality (the Real), the symbolic-arithmetic rule structure about the coherence of reality (the Symbolic), and the simulatory projection and compactification of reality through our lived expression (the Imaginary) enable us to coherently navigate the psychosomatic tensions within a lossy projection of reality, even when reality is heavily distorted as well as oversaturated with meaning and relativism.

Lacan does not promise that the Borromean knot will not deform or tear over time; in fact, he is more often than not asserting that no psyche survives deformation without remainder, insofar as the psyche is exposed to the world by explicit contact. When Lacan expresses that there is no metalanguage, underneath that statement is the reality that there is no privileged archon that adjudicates the use of language and its impact from an immutable analytic role. A metalanguage is a bandage confused for surgery, marking an irreversible rupture. Any attempt by a subject to install a metalanguage marks the point at which discourse has already broken symbolic consistency, functioning as a patch over the discontinuity left by the symbolic order. When such a role of the use of symbolization is held in excess to whether it stabilizes or repairs an interaction, then the only outcome of symbolic meaning is what it circulates in the world and whether that circulation diffuses into stability or injury, in a world where integration is not a guarantee but deformability always is. If reality is disrupted of its epistemic, ethical, or informational integrity, the entire helical structure begins to unglue, slowly tearing away our capacity to precisely induct meaning or metabolize reality. The clinic diagnoses a structural inheritance, such that the tears and repairs are visible through history and transmissible through experience. Trauma is always structurally originated, historically situated, and contiguous with our capacity to transfer or process it, through our temporary episodes of history where there is trauma to be experienced or inherited. Subjectivity arrives in this world by inevitable fracture, and there are many examples in reality where we fail to disinherit the tearings of traumatic experience and circulate the aftermath of this tearing onto others. The conditions for matter and psyche to survive coincide with the same invariant restrictions: the finitude of boundaries, the path-dependency of continuous damage, the irreducible interaction between periodicity and limits, and the incapacity for closure.

Lacan reduces the center of the Borromean knot to a structural pessimism and impossibility: the object petit a marks an irreconcilable tension between desire and lack at the center of the knot, where stability is only piecewise and conditional. The center of the knot implies a precise coordinate, such as a way of adjusting the viewfinder on the photograph so one can actually focus and perceive the screen properly through the discernment of noise. The analog film camera gives the user the autonomy to adjust the aperture at will, making the user an active participant in mediating the representation that the photo creates, given that the amount of shots on each film roll is finite. In reality, we are often abrogated of the capacity to focus and mediate the imaginal on our terms, given that reality is often forced and distorted against our will, and the freedom to easily adjust the viewfinder of the psyche and soma requires us to know what repairs need to be made inside or outside of the camera to properly adjust the aperture as intended. The development of the digital camera gives us unlimited freedom to take an often infinitesimal amount of photos, but never the discernment of finite images to enable not just precision of image, but also precision of meaning behind which image we choose. The digital production of images on contemporary digital cameras is endless, such that we have the burden of freedom to choose images, but the actual discernment is scarcely mediated and perceptually shallow through this freedom of overproduction.



What grounds unconscious thought is not the externalization of local contradiction into symbolic tyranny, but of what Coleridge described as *esemplastic*: the unconscious that accepts contradiction as metabolic load, placing agency in generating form as irreducible multiplicity prior to symbolic representation. Coleridge acknowledges that contradiction is a permanent condition rather than an external given, which tasks us with developing the disciplined capacity to hold contradiction together without expecting reconciliation or dissolution. We can also say that

the concept of negative capability, proposed by John Keats, structures desire through uncertainty. Although Keats applies this to artists in their embrace of mystery that cannot be logically described or defined, we extend this framework to the concept of desire in general, in which the aperture of desire is structured precisely by its comfort or discomfort with mystery and the unknown. The mysterious tension one either experiences or builds actively in desire between themselves or their lovers is one that acknowledges the self-moving activity of desire, collapsing the object of desire into the active process of desiring. The irreconcilable hole in the Borromean clinic becomes a site of aperture that is not closed, but in Wilfred Bion's terms, contained by the capacity to navigate developmental tension. Aperture is luminal, in the sense that encountering fantasy recurs the possibility of novelty as we move through the dense fog of our unconscious. However, in the austerity that characterizes the *A Shropshire Lad*, A.E. Hausman acknowledges that ineffable mystery does not consume our lives indefinitely, and that uncertainty within ourselves eventually becomes an honest terminus. The embrace of mystery is the embrace of play, in Donald Winnicott's terms: the unconscious is always in a transitional space where meaning and desire are negotiable through a field of admissible play, possibility, and transformation that is always happening regardless of participation in the game of life, just at different integrations of information and time. This approach reframes Lacan's unconscious as grammar into the unconscious as experimental semiospheric interface, where desire is located not through the syntax, but through the active emergent process of writing and developing the syntax through semiosis. The unconscious is where the self reorganizes around patterns of experiences, evaluations of distortions, autonomic nervous system appraisal, harmonizations of contradiction through encounter, and spontaneous novelty in patterns of meaning.

Proceeding from this framework, Freud and Lacan assume a core constraint: they inherit Schopenhauer's pessimism of the unconscious will as a blind and insatiable force that cannot be reconciled or fulfilled, which are then projected as sources of universal psychological fact. In contrast to this insatiable will, Maine de Biran did not occlude the effort of interior experience through an egoic mastery, but through an experienced dependence. Biran does not deny interiority, but posits that the felt resistance of effort precedes symbolic representation as the first datum of thought. Our interiority is real and irreducible, but only through transitioning from an asserted effort to consensual reception do the limits of our understanding disclose themselves. The operating cost for metabolism of the unconscious is the maintenance of an internal balance under contradictions that will never reconcile or make sense, and choosing whether to dynamically stabilize or dissipate at the edge. Lacanian psychoanalysis is in a sense an inherited metaphysical narrative that provides a picture of postwar France split by the Cold War, but not necessarily of the unconscious in all of its complexity. Lacan speaks from inside this academic climate where the metaphysical picture of his psychoanalysis has useful context as a particular sign lineage, but not a complete narrative on how the unconscious responds to lack and ambiguity. By asserting the tyranny of the symbolic order as a given structural necessity and the primary contradiction within one's perceptual system, semiosis becomes pathological in this worldview as an engine to selfhood, and alienation becomes a given for one's identity development. The Prague School linguists such as Jan Firbas worked from a place where language dynamically reorganizes itself around communicative utility, resource sensitivity, purpose, and responsiveness to context. The theme-rheme tension of the Functional Sentence Perspective highlights a particular application of language as a technology of archival retention, by which language condenses mnemonic infrastructure downstream from joint activity based on how we use the tools of linguistic expression. Similarly, Enric Vallduvi and Elisabet Engdahl's 1996 linguistics publication on information packaging points to how variations in sentence structure

and intonation can still deliver the same propositional content within a distributed linguistic ecosystem, wherein the enactive use of language survives through contextual coordination under continuous philological decay, rather than syntactic predetermination.



If we accept Lacan's Seminar XI thesis that the unconscious is structured like a language, then the syntax of this unconscious is symbolically deterministic and teleological. However, Lacan drops the fatalist veneer in Seminar XX, where he begins to hint at the shadow of his earlier thesis by conjecturing that the unconscious is shaped by what he calls the *lalangue*: the shadow play beneath the clarity of language rules, where the unconscious speaks plainly of its desire and lack through affective density. This is Lacan revealing that the unconscious is structured like the music of language rather than the grammar rules of language, through stutter, sound, eurhythmia, indeterminacy, felt sensation, and slips of one's tongue that feel unambiguously glossolalic through the pull of gestural expression. Language survives through vowels after syntax, semantics, and grammar impose their cuts. Our unconscious, if grounded as a process that transports resonance rather than a fixed object to defer indefinitely through repression, goes beyond deferred linguistic play into the terrain of what Schiller calls the play drive: the dynamic negotiation between negative determination of experiential constraint (the sense drive), and the positive determination of reason (the form drive) through experimental play and integration of experience and reason in contradiction with one another. Ironically for Žižek's own integration of Hegel and Lacan, Lacan is anti-dialectical; Schiller at least articulates that a perceptual system is refined by the movement of contradictions and tensions into deeper stages of psychosocial development, which Lacan diametrically opposed through an anti-developmental posture. Contradiction is ineluctable for approaching the rhumb line of development. Schiller acknowledges that when the process of the play

drive is continuous and when sense and form are held in dynamic equilibrium as opposed to imbalance of one over the other, a perceptual system develops extensibility of its receptivity to new experiences. The unconscious then encounters beauty as internal harmonization rather than indefinite acceptance of distortion from outside, and through this encounter with contradiction, the path of development emerges beyond illusion. The esemplastic unconscious does not assume a final harmonization of contradiction, only the developmental continuation of plasticity in cognition without an exit destination.



Where Lacan becomes especially useful is through institutional psychoanalysis, which incidentally requires structuralism rather than the clinic of post-structural pessimism. When carefully scoped, Lacan's anti-developmental posture looks more like a study of system-level psychodynamics. Authoritarian power structures maintain symbolic order through constitutive lack, semiotic arrest, structural inhibition of who they signify as threatening to their perceptual system, and repression by any socially acceptable means, whether by maintaining narrative or developmental control over sign lineages to assert semio-spheric dominance. Such power structures cannot generate meaning from symbolic structure, but they can freeze semiosis through control of meaning and display of symbolic order. The split between an institutional signifier and who they signify is an implicit compact of predation and dependency, rather than the inherited pathology of who they signify. Lacan concerns himself with what happens when symbolic systems produce subjects and when they produce pathologies that subjects must carry for them, and through this asymmetry he interrogates when the symbolic cannot bind without exacerbating instability. The signifier-signified split that the symbolic order maintains is an extractive relationship that paradoxically depends on there being scarcity and docility that they manufacture as deferred maintenance, but not a structural necessity that we can reduce to

fatalism and endless language play. If Lacan is understood as making people responsible for the debts that their symbolic systems externalize onto others to pay, then suddenly he clicks as a diagnostician of institutions and power structures that reorganize dynamically around their inherited lack and symbolic rigidity, partly because they benefit psychologically from this rigidity. These are systems that perceptually stabilize around needing to split themselves from their environment by imposing a split between signifier and signified, in which they maintain symbolic order by arresting the semiosis of others as a survival mechanism in the global semiosphere. As a bog standard therapeutic practice for traumatized individuals, Lacan's symbolic determinism flies in the face of modern neuropsychology and enactive cognition frameworks, and even the developmental psychologists of his time through activity theorists like Vygotsky and Luria. The capacity to modify apperception that allows us to sit in witnessment of the world beyond ourselves is we steward in continuity, but this process is contiguous on whether we can coordinate our own lives without managing distortion around us, and whether others can receive and reciprocate our knowledge as peers, and whether we can make obsolete the pathological systems that distort the entire fabric of meaning making when they demonstrate themselves to impose survival by force. Thus, Lacanian method excels when demarcated within the scope of analytic diagnosis for the systemic psychopathology of institutions that destabilize the environment around them, but not specifically as a clinical modality for individuals struggling to survive in this world.



William Shakespeare's Sonnet 55 meditates on memory, desire, and fleeting gratification from power, and the bard leads with the phrase: "But you shall shine more bright in these contents / Than unswept stone besmeared with sluttish time." Here in the larger sonnet, Shakespeare does not describe desire through history, but desire through process, often not distinguishing between the thought of desire and the form of

desire. The notion of sluttish time in some ways is what it sounds like on a page: biased time derived from the exploration of pleasure is separate from time that refuses eurhythmic process. The access of pleasure as if it were an object that one can never strive toward resembles the “wasteful war that statues overturn” which Shakespeare writes about, where desire reflects the unstructured path to an undifferentiated thing in which we disconnect from our own differentiable process. Rather than structuring through a thing we cannot own or possess, Shakespeare writes about a process of eros that recurs its own emergent tenor, one that we either fully surrender ecstatically towards or resist through our own avoidance of process. Eros and Thanatos are thus oscillatory tensions within the same morphodynamic eurhythmia that is structured by esemplasticity. Freud’s notion of a death drive as a separate urge towards self destruction implies that our own process is two discrete phase switches that activate without rhyme or reason. Eros drives the container of how we may navigate the contradictions of desire and finitude, and Thanatos drives our desire to complete the cycle, operating as the transitional unconscious state by which the contradictions of desire approach their present constraint. Thus, Eros and Thanatos as unconscious drives are not necessarily in opposition as much as they are the baseline enabling conditions within a phase space for any conscious experience that is always actively transforming its relationship to desire and finitude.



By putting Vygotsky and Lacan in dialogue, for example, we develop a framework of proximal development through activity and process, while also situating activity within the symbolic order that delimits developmental trajectory. The Real becomes a place where moment navigates the contradiction within a socially mediated activity chain dependent upon the tension of encounter and stabilization. We are produced by historical memory and phased development, but fragmented by the gaps between activity and material constraint that

we repair through process and scaffolding. Lacan was always clear about who he was in his lecture diagrams: knots, rings, toruses, and invariant structures were all objects he used to visualize the machinery of limitation and lack. By Seminar XXVI, Lacan is explicit about the temporality that precedes subject formation and signification, whereby intrapsychic consistency comports with topological consistency and modes of association that persist. The subject, as the only object that refuses topological coupling, is the structural lag by which time insists. In other words, the subject does not oppose or resist anything, it simply does not resolve into symmetry. Symmetry is the condition of field behavior, which subjects inhabit through noncoincidence, the condition under which time appears. Lacan witnessed how predatory systems regulate and dysregulate others, operating his clinic as a structural topologist of sign patterns. Ideology becomes not just a bundle of fantasies, as Žižek describes, but a post-hoc narrative compression of belief-shaped residue generated by the procedures of a pathological system. This conception of ideology within socially mediated activity recognizes that ideology can be situated in pattern recognition and pattern rupture in how activity, tools, and communication within a developmental topos both structure and bias our desire and development. Ideology functions as an interaffective lubricant for the rigidity of anti-developmental systems that regulate perceptual intelligibility, developmental admissibility, and the interior space of desire. Ideology tends to fall out when the procedural intelligence of a system is mistaken for conscious assent. Practices produce ideology when those practices harden into irreparability, which ironically thrives in the rigidity of a system that permits expressive autonomy as the sediment of symbolic exhaust. The engine of development is always entangled with the space of rules, and never feels as separable as it seems as we move through desire and development with curious simultaneity. The possibility of development, as it were, is primary as an ethical category. For us to retain something tractable beyond the dull glimmer of consciousness, the only responsibility is to carry something forward, even if that task

does not include us in its unfolding and cannot be reduced to the
hoarding of a mind.

The things that are perish into the things out of which they come to be, according to necessity, for they pay penalty and retribution to each other for their injustice in accordance with the ordering of time.

—Anaximander (DK 12B1)

disc three

OIKOPOLITEIA · 210°



Prior to the advancement of the modern political economy, which implies a composition of administrative states and the markets they subsidize, the concept of governance had a very specific genealogy: not representative governance, nor markets, but of the governance at the scale of living systems and their organized networks of care, domicile, labor of social life, family dynamics, and resource sensitivity. The concept of political economy did not enter the common lexicon until it was attributed directly from the classical political economists such as Adam Smith and David Ricardo. Even within this tradition of moral philosophy, the phrase “politics” was derived from the concept of the polity, which is the collective structure of a people organized by their social relations to manage their resources, and the phrase “economy” was derived from the Ancient Greek term “oikonomia” which translates roughly to household management. When you put these words together in the linguistic schema they derive from, the concept of modern political economy looks more like the self-organized governing principles of a collective whole of people to distribute resources amongst themselves at the scale of life. Centuries later, the regimentation of academic domains into silos bifurcated political economy further into political science and economics as separate domains, further reinforcing the partition between the process of governing autonomously and the implied mandate of representative

governance by the Westphalian world system of nation states. If we were to derive what we call both politics and economics back into a more ancient root structure, we would have something akin to oikopoliteia, but it is not a phrase that was ever coined in Ancient Greece, because the meaning of such a term was considered common sense in how people governed their lives. The technology of modern state formation depends on these concepts not talking to each other; in other words, to consolidate power at the level of the nation state, the institutions of statecraft depend on the extracting governance from living systems, resource distribution from lived knowledge, care from kin structure, semiosis from the public, and boundaries from the world. For centuries before Smith and Ricardo, the politeia (world structure of collective life) and oikos (internal structure of home life) were never considered to be separable, because the repair of this artificial separation would reveal statehood itself as an aberration. The use of political economy as a term implies a state and a market system that lords over how people live their lives, and the separation of market and state in the academy implies a system that needs to hide its own compositional pathology behind a smokescreen of knowledge domains that are assumed not to talk to each other. Oikopoliteia is the invariant pattern language underneath the modern grammar of political economy: how life self-organizes in shared dwelling, and how repair alongside reciprocity compose the world. The politeia ultimately refers to the shared protocol of distributed systems that convivially shares the commons, ritual cycles, seasons, mutual aid, resources, kinhood networks, and the long memory of historical continuity.



The concept of political economy is not just unethical or inadequate, it commits a grammatical mistake, and when you cannot repair a contradiction within the grammar rules of a system, you would have to admit surgery in order to rewire the firmware of civilization. You cannot reform an ungrammatical system into repair, but the system

must follow once its grammar is repaired. At the origin point of early civilization, the concept of the life system was one of subsidiarity: to repair the contradictions at appropriate scale so that stability is restored, whether by smoothening or surgery. Ancient civilizations governed only at the scale of dwelling and social ecology as opposed to kings, borders, and nation states. In parsimonious terms, oikopoliteia as a guiding physical law operationalizes how the local home glues to the world home in the field of relationships, and how to patch contradictions that do not suture given semiotic interoperability. The Rivash clearly adjudicates in Responsum 177 that the custodial duty of land does not assume division between language or cultures as primary metric, but explicitly by sharing the task of stewardship. Land is the functional substrate of social life, and by not sharing it in common so that all can dwell on land as a material infrastructure for continuity between home and world, we thereby deny the historical fact that custodial duty predates fee simple ownership. Reducing to rigid rule systems reduces the scope of life to decay and precipitates entropy through disparity. Modern political economy, thus, is an inversion of how oikopoliteia was historically practiced since antiquity. Modern statecraft is defined by how state-classified administrative protocols constrain the development of living systems to govern their lives, whereas the root of the politeia presents a world in which living systems develop their own protocols that adapt to the needs and resource constraints of appropriate scale. By separating life from world system, we destabilize the hinge of household survival to communal responsibility, reducing both to what Le Corbusier writes on cities: "Our world, like a charnel house, is strewn with the detritus of dead epochs." Herein, our inherited sense of despondency and fatalism has thus been laundered to us and imposed by force. The dominant sign lineages of our age—price signals, commodity exchange, artificial scarcity, fiat currency, transcendental rule, enforced austerity, empire, petroleum refineries—did not survive through evolutionary fitness. They survived through enforced violence, dispossession, and containment. These are systems that persist by cloaking their evolutionary viability with the

void of their dominance and predation. They survive by concealing this emptiness, by insisting their dominance proves their fitness, and by laundering their brutality into purported necessity. If they ceased to dominate, they would reveal what has always persisted beneath them: the deeper lineages of cooperation and stability that have defined the long memory of human civilization and beyond. Carl Jung writes: "There appears to be a conscience in mankind which severely punishes the man who does not somehow and at some time, at whatever cost to his pride, cease to defend and assert himself, and instead confess himself fallible and human." Our current epoch rewards the opposite of this assertion. Monopolistic control, structural inhibition of feedback, social alienation, and egoic defense are more abundantly rewarded than the possibility that we are fallible, and that we could build deeper relationships through mutual understanding rather than inherited enmity. We have been tasked with mediating this enmity instead of letting it expire, and we will continue to be for as long as it circulates without reprieve.



Michel Foucault famously left his project, *Truth and Juridical Forms*, in an incomplete state around 1973. Even in an embryonic shape, the content of this project presented a radical break from the architecture of Foucault's worldview that reduced the scope of subject formation through discourse. Foucault decided to take a step further without the pressure of the academy inveighing him and explore how legal systems shape the architecture of power and authority within the context of the worlds they inhabited. Foucault compares the legal systems of Greek, Roman, and Germanic law to distill the cognate grammars of how these systems adjudicated conflict and how they produced the world through their adjudication. The juridical form, in a sense, produced its own alethurgy for how society mediates through social rules: "Finally, there were the famous corporal, physical tests called ordeals, which consisted in subjecting a person to a sort of game, a struggle with his own body,

to find out whether he would pass or fail. For example, in the time of the Carolingian Empire, there was a famous test imposed on individuals accused of murder, in certain areas of northern France. The accused was required to walk on coals and two days later if he still had scars he would lose the case. There were yet other tests such as the ordeal by water, which consisted in tying a person's right hand to his left foot and throwing him into the water. If he didn't drown he would lose the case, because the water didn't accept him as it should; and if he drowned he had won the case, seeing that the water had not rejected him. All these confrontations of the individual or his body with the natural elements were a symbolic transposition of the struggle of individuals among themselves, the semantics of which would need to be studied. Basically, it was always a matter of combat, of deciding who was the stronger. In old Germanic law, the trial was nothing more than the regulated, ritualized continuation of war." Foucault breaks from the popular Western narrative around the subject and admits that the subject emerges from the form of judgment. In our historical context, the subject of empire emerges from price signals, the subject of neoliberalism emerges from the commodity form grammar of the Washington Consensus, and in the Bronze Age, the subject of their early civilization emerged from hydrological cosmology. The fingerprints of these seemingly ancient Greek and Roman legal systems contaminate all configurations of social life that touch them with any mode of adjudication that admits combat, subjugation, humiliation ritual, and destitution merely formalizes adjudication as a gladiatorial remedy. The legal system simply regulates these ritual expressions through the performance of judgment, but any laundering of pain and dispossession through law assumes pain and dispossession as the social norm. Eyal Weizman discusses the concept of forensic architecture as a means of detecting the archaeology of violence and death through the ruins and sedimentation patterns of a ruptured society, which in a more general form, extends into the archaeology of grammar itself; that is, what remains submerged beneath the ruins of thought, when do seemingly formal systems collapse into violence, who determines a dignified

death, who deserves legibility in the afterlife, and why do structures of thought perish until someone restores continuity fastidiously enough to put the arbiters of destruction and violence through the ritual of justice?



Early Islamic and Jewish systems of jurisprudence, for example, handled the grammar of law through Talmud and fiqh, which were communally situated forms of legal infrastructure that generated repair and knowledge through the collective input of the local community that these worlds were situated in. More specifically, these legal systems operated with degrees of what Michael Oakeshott calls adverbial conditions (how activity is performed) as a guiding casuistry principle, in contrast with law as a verb (what to do) and a noun (what ends to pursue) as baseline, which inevitably requires a state to enforce with asymmetric discretion, but without limits on domination over their subjects. Adverbial conditions are how we may implement runtime guarantees for any codified infrastructure without prescribing ends or centralizing authority. Oakeshott similarly argues that cultural norms and traditions, insofar as they endure in memory, function not as fixed authorities but as mutable stores of situated knowledge, whose value lies precisely in their negation of rationalist bureaucratic abstraction. This inverts the boilerplate paradigm of legal positivism conserved by H.L.A. Hart, which argues obligations are primitive, legitimacy follows from recognized obligation, and revision (or what Hart calls rules-about-rules) are secondary. In practice, the revision of rules is primitive, obligations are conditional, and legitimacy is provisional and durational, upstream from local determinations and nonlocal stability. By what is determined, we assess what negations we can live with, and for how long we can live with them. The Talmud was not concerned with citation schemas and the prestige economy, they were concerned with admitting all forms of provenance that would resolve the contradictions of a given legal situation rather than reducing to literalist pageantry.

The medieval posekim of the Maghreb, including figures such as the Rif, adjudicated through a halakhic sensibility that treated *din metzi'ut* as a governing constraint: halakha presupposes ontological realities rather than legislating beyond them. In this framework, law follows the facts of the world as they are, and legal ratiocination operates within the boundaries imposed by human embodiment, social practice, material conditions, and natural limits. Rather than constructing a closed formal system, halakhic interpretation in this tradition remains embedded in lived reality, allowing concrete conditions such as medicine, travel, human capacity, relationships to the natural world, communal organization, time, memory, material resources, and physical circumstance to shape legal application. Contemporary legal naturalism, as articulated by Olúfemi Táíwò, further clarifies that legal legitimacy is inseparable from the conditions under which decisions are made, including who is structurally present to shape them. Táíwò acknowledges in particular that laws are provisional to the dominant modes of institutional configuration that mediate material norms within an epoch, and thus concepts of natural law jurisprudence are indeterminate outside of the boundaries of social formation. What Táíwò defines as “being-in-the-room privilege” describes an untracked asymmetry in legal authorship and institutional access that stabilizes outcomes without explicit mandate. Within an adverbial jurisprudence, such asymmetries must be rendered legible as part of the runtime conditions of law itself, rather than displaced into moral discourse after the fact.



Once this premise is accepted, law becomes austere routine maintenance on background constraint propagation, which begets the assumption that law is ultimately weak by design, unless specifically engineered to govern through a juridical sovereign and gladiatorial tension. Laws as symbolic rituals of power asymmetry and formal closure are inevitably brittle, unable to adapt to common necessity

without catastrophic failure, generating the rigidity that makes rupture feel inevitable. The theater of courtroom drama belies the reality underneath that law is an ongoing collective refinement of how we coordinate amongst ourselves by admitting what the law cannot control. Legal analysis thus proceeds on the assumption that law is not self-grounding but rests upon an extratextual substrate of reality that defines the scope within which interpretation is possible, and outside of which legal formalism cannot coherently operate. The psak received its influence from the legal realism of the Geonim, which asserts that reality itself carries juridical authority, ontology constrains hermeneutic interpretation, and law operates within existence rather than in abstraction, which in turn prioritizes lived experience over conceptual symmetry, grants the authority of expert knowledge, and treats the context of material conditions as integral to legal response, all of which compose into a method of facilitating coherence of life prior to symmetry of abstract legal form. When identity is constructed as an ideological form rather than a network of concrete obligations to kehilla (community), makom (lived place and geographic circumstance), and minhag (practices and customs), the concept of identity departs from a jurisprudence oriented toward lived existence as it is inhabited rather than imagined. The alethurgic form of a given world determines the scope of its courthouse, the admissible evidence admitted into a court as legible, and who gets access to adjudicate themselves and thus set boundaries on harm in a field of equals. In other words, in Foucault's assertion, the ancient Greek and Roman legal systems were the structural skeleton that produced the world of rules shaping how conflicts and boundaries are asserted, and more importantly, who gets to legibly assert them in the view of the alethurgic form availed to the spectacle of a court. Within the Germanic or Greek legal systems, war was how justice was ritualized; in other words, the strategy of tension admitted within their respective settlement processes was one of spectacular violence and adversarialism, where debt was settled through the theatre of combat and humiliation ritual as penal remedy. The modern Western

carceral regime inherited the ghost of this particular alethurgic form, just with more technologically sophisticated rituals of surveillance and regulated war between prisoners as a class. Foucault's analysis is remarkably congruent to the commodity form theory of Evgeny Pashukanis, who similarly states that the commodity form shapes the legal system by enforcing the symbolic architecture of the commodity form. The institutions throughout history produce environments of reason rather than simply distort reason, and the production of reason surrounds us in the epistemic selection pressures of law, bureaucracy, algorithms, metrics, computation, and infrastructure. Our common sense of cognition is governed by the categorical rules of grammar before it is represented through symbolic architecture, and the symbolized vessels of the present order do not constitute neutrality despite presenting otherwise. The inferential space of rules changes the contours of thought itself, not the other way around. In modern Western society, we are ruled entirely by the tyranny of price signals as the only way to be legible to the legal positivism of the capitalist social order. We assert, invariantly, that casuistry admits the grammar of the world as an admissible case to adjudicate when the natural law of the cosmos is violated by malignance.



We concern ourselves with the outcomes of necessity rather than its premises, by determining under what conditions certain necessities of reality persist and when to negate conditions that no longer survive contact with the rules governing their use. Propositions have no standing prior to the rule space that determines their use, and when admissibility is not applied symmetrically, the question becomes why some boundaries can be crossed without repair and others cannot. The poet, Paul Celan, described his relationship to German after the Holocaust as that of an estranged relative, defining his German as, to paraphrase, outside of the German that the Germans spoke. He believed that inside the sublimity of pure unadulterated emptiness

that he was forced to interrogate in Nazi Germany, there was meaning in the interstice between pure horror and the unknown. He once argued, "there is nothing in the world for which a poet will give up his writing, not even when he is a Jew and the language of his poems is German". Celan, more than most, fought arduously to maintain the meaningfulness of language and ideas even in witnessing what is most wretched about how they get instrumentalized. From this vantage point, we extend Celan's lineage of meaning-making outside of the symbolic weight often attached to knowledge, and we similarly interrogate the notion of political economy past the 20th century paradigm. It is life that persists in what has happened and the possibility space of what could happen next, and the grammar of the next world is determined by what we do in between the reality of the past and the actualization of what comes next. Our commitment to total liberation of life is as Celan would say, "reachable, close, and secure amid all losses." Words have meaning as do ideas, and listening to these ideas is what gives them their shape. Even if their shape is haunted, potentially beautiful, fragmented by time, but still a word that comes from a tongue and is moved by it.



What we understand as capitalism and what we understand as the fulcrum of control in society has evolved and adapted over generations, and it is our task and responsibility to adapt with the agility that the systems of capital have chosen to adapt to. The global market sticks to the drywall and tends not to come undone unless the entire house is replaced through the development of its cisterns. The political economists at every iteration of historical development, whether they are the Physiocrats such as Turgot, the Ricardians such as George, or the materialists such as Marx, have understood that their insights were real time observations to the patterns and trends of the moment. They understood the mercantile or industrial capitalist machine before them was an android slowly decaying into the shape of humankind,

and they chose to reclaim this tension into a deeper vitality than the moment understood in their given time. The current stage of historical development has advanced past the chokeholds of the modes of production in the factory line and concentrated its chokeholds through the modes of coordination and logistics. Given everything is mass produced, but not mass coordinated, we recognize that there is a gaping hole in analysis of how the economy transitioned from one heavy on manufacturing to one heavy on logistical coordination.



In the development of capitalism throughout the 19th and 20th century, we can observe four major stages of development that regiment the actual adaptation of the capitalist machine. In the hinge period between the 1880s and 1910s, Taylorism began to apply engineering and scientific principles into the creation of a managerial class, which facilitated the transition of craft production into mass production through a central command structure on the shop floor. In the early 1910s to roughly the 1940s, the dominant Western capitalist mode was the Fordist model, which remained the boilerplate archetype of class antagonism for decades. Fordism was a highly centralized command model of which its core was highly regimented labor time, vertical production integration and hierarchy, and mass production along the factory line. The line between Taylorism and Fordism was a clear one, in which the transition into mass production and assembly line manufacturing was normalized through the development of the managerial class in the industrial ecosystem. The Fordist vision of industrial capitalism was obscenely direct in its authoritarian command structure, to which Mark Fisher aptly describes this vision of the factory as “spatially and socially partitioned” between blue-collar and white-collar workers, factory floor and managerial class, in which class antagonism was a highly visible phenomena located within these sites of production. The strategy of organizational mass as a counterweight to the Fordist paradigm was, in part, an artifact of

this era, given the wide gap in technological production cost and computational economy had not yet matured by this time. Kevin Carson points out: “The emphasis on mass, hierarchy and central coordination to which the traditional establishment Left is so attached is very much an industrial age paradigm. There has been a tendency in much of the Left – especially the Old Left (Marxist-Leninist, syndicalist and social democratic) – to equate size, capital accumulation and overhead with productivity, to view the gigantism fostered by capitalism as “progressive,” and to equate “Revolution” to putting capitalism’s hierarchical institutions under new management. The mission of revolutionary conquest, or reformist capture (a la LaSalle, Bernstein or Atlee), of the institutions of the old society presupposed countervailing institutions of equal mass. The Old Left model of revolution, and its survivals in the verticalist/establishment Left to the present day, are direct analogues of the mass production industrial model of Schumpeter, Galbraith and Chandler.” The challenge with this framing, of course, is twofold: that the weight of collective leverage and social cohesion through reciprocity is not the same as confronting a giant, identifying their Achilles heel, and felling them from terrorizing future generations. Carson mixes a strategic method, sociological form, and political imagination in the same wordplay, which from a strictly philological perspective, conflates the physician with the cure. The factory was one such giant of sociological form, like the wyverns of fantasy lore, that crushed their dissenters under the weight of industrial might and economies of scale. The other challenge, of course, assumes revolution is a singular format of seizing a hierarchical form that mediates a specific economic organ and not a paradigmatic movement that breaks through the yoke of catastrophe. The lineage of authoritarian rule persists even if the commodity form has evolved into less immediately perceptible forms of domination.

The Fordist model metastasized throughout various sectors of industry, embedding the market logic of hierarchy, centralization, and competition through sectors as wide as education, groceries, and healthcare, and its lineage was actively regimenting the entire social fabric by which people lived. The Fordist paradigm facilitated the ubiquity of big box stores over community merchants, as well as the hospital model that Kaiser Permanente became synonymous with. Darina Lepadatu and Thomas Janoski also note the cultural homogeneity and regimentation that such a model facilitated: "the production process then created a mass market for homogenized products, whether automobiles or hamburgers, by molding tastes for the same things (Ritzer 2019). The results led to the spread of automobile dealerships throughout the country with accompanying repair shops and gas stations. Later, it led to cookie cutter houses and fast food restaurants. All of this, of course, presumed the creation of a large road system that was capped off by the interstate highway system created by President Dwight Eisenhower. Fast food restaurants and inexpensive motels were then built at every exit." The expansion and segmentation of the managerial class into more distributed command was a direct adaptation to the Sloanist turn in the mid 20th century, in no small part following the transition between WWII and the Cold War. Alfred P. Sloan went in the direction of what we call "strategic planning" today and diffused decision making authority to a more decentralized layering of middle management over production and distribution in order to accommodate the scaling problem across product lines and franchises. This allowed the factory owner to diffuse any key command-and-control responsibilities as well as any individual liabilities for worker-owner interactions when they can just as easily filter through the entire index of managers between them and the line staff. Class structure is still visible, but made opaque through the labyrinth of organizational charts that are mediated through the middle management translation layer. Sloanism just adds a multi-dimensional structure with a centralized public relations command structure to the Fordist paradigm, diffusing organizational accountability onto people within the organization, which coincidentally

diffuses culpability to workers if anything goes awry. By decentralizing the failure mode of a corporation and centralizing its communication infrastructure to mediate its risk tolerance, the social fabric atomizes into an organizational labyrinth, isolating workers who aspire to build kinship or collectivity amongst themselves. Robert Jackall, in his sociological study of corporate managers, identified the consequence of this dense social mystification, by a sort of manufactured ideological complexity which he describes as a dexterity with symbols: "The indirect and ambiguous linguistic frameworks that managers employ in public situations typify the symbolic complexity of the corporation. Generally speaking, managers' public language is best characterized as a kind of provisional discourse, a tentative way of communicating that reflects the peculiarly chancy and fluid character of their world." Jackall observes, beyond just a material order one corporation may embody through the force of the factory or a big box store, the advent of Sloanism introduces a technological gambit through the mediation of the symbolic order within an industry, in which the business class maintains an ideological porosity anchored in the survival of the business itself, in which an elaborate internal sign language mediates the relationships of workers within the firm. These highly patterned public relations protocols, that may show up as calling someone a team player or not meeting performance expectations, are contagious and endemic to the survival of these embedded institutions.



The last of the transitions leading up to the 21st century was what some called the Post-Fordist turn, which subsequently also came at the heel of the Cold War, the era of the New Left in the US, and the expansion of Third World liberations all throughout the world. The transition from Sloanism to post-Fordism came under the aegis of a particular boon to the Sloanist communication infrastructure: the military's development of ARPANET in anticipation of nuclear brinkmanship from the USSR. Back in the 1960s, access to the

internet was a top-down coordination protocol that enabled the military to exchange information between research universities, the state, and private corporations, and was among the first to implement the TCP/IP protocol suite that the internet is known for. The fluid and decentralized network communication protocols facilitated by this early iteration of the internet created a hinge point for the coordination chokeholds that the post-Fordist stage of capitalism exploited to their remarkable advantage. The coordination between nonprofit or for-profit corporate organizations and the state over incipient social mobilization similarly echoes this coordination between elites and the state in the transition to post-Fordism, but what makes this stage distinct is that the administrative bloat that cemented the Sloanist transition was expanded into service coordination, finance, IT, logistics, and all of the coordination layers that can be mediated by black-box algorithms or protocols. Moishe Postone calls to mind the concept of abstract time: the impersonal degree by which time and labor are socially mediated by structures of social domination. Postone writes: "the transition in time reckoning to a system of commensurable, interchangeable, and invariable hours is very closely related to the development of the mechanical clock in Western Europe in the very late thirteenth century or the early fourteenth century. The clock, in Lewis Mumford's words, "dissociated time from human events." Nevertheless, the emergence of abstract time cannot be accounted for solely with reference to a technical development such as the invention of the mechanical clock. Rather, the appearance of the mechanical clock itself must be understood with reference to a sociocultural process that it, in turn, strongly reinforced." The evolution of the relationship between abstract time and social discipline creates bookmarks at each stage of capitalism to contextualize the structural shifts between the eras, and power concentrates successfully because it becomes less visible and more abstract with each successive era. The Post-Fordist era particularly specializes in the enforcement of the temporal order, in which our sense of time and temporal perception is no longer just distorted when one enters or exits a disciplinary institution like a

prison or corporation; in fact, the global supply chain has severed our relationship to time and thought from places and events, creating entire worlds mediated by apps, digital services, data centers, and impersonal communication. In this new era leading up to the dot com boom and the democratic access to the internet, managerial coordination diffused into the entire continuum of software, cloud logistics, API protocols, scheduling, and resource coordination throughout the global economy. The diffused opacity of Sloanism transitioned into virtualized abstraction in the Post-Fordist era, creating a world with more access to information than ever, but also with less access to resources than any other point in the 20th century. It is no longer enough to diagnose the managerial turn in the corporate command structure when this managerial structure has been virtualized and abstracted into things that manage the logistics of the economy regardless of where you are working or where you live. In the Internet of Things, you rent your toothbrush through a SaaS subscription, which is actually the frantic refrain that its proponents leveraged as a critique of communism.



When the capability to coordinate our own lives is mediated at every vector(temporal, material, and symbolic), then we are perpetually disconnected from the process of autonomous meaning-making, and thus perceptually disconnected from our capability to discern signal from noise. That, in a sense, is a domination of total institutions over every aspect of our lives, ranging from how we think to how we communicate, not just what we can produce for ourselves. The imposition of a total institution that controls the semiosphere at this scale cannot be reformed from within. The trouble of authoritarian architecture and withholding of information and power from collective life has plagued societies for epochs even before the advent of the capitalist economy and the Industrial Revolution. The Soviet Union and PRC, among other communist countries, tripped over their laces in maintaining an authoritarian grip over their respective

societies in favor of a materialist analysis of the conditions and contradictions in society. This simplifies the overall problem even though the spirit of the diagnosis was insightful: societies cannot just abolish capitalism without abolishing the authoritarianism that disallows people to be able to organize themselves and participate in generative insight into how to optimize social organization and rational planning. This kind of insight requires distributed communication that cannot be centralized and engineered into one party, institution, state, or corporate firm. The state-owned Soviet factories were still producing commodities, and accelerated the industrialization process through forced economic collectivization, but the resource and information drain that authoritarianism causes impacted the longevity of the USSR beyond just the Cold War tension that fomented between the Western and Eastern bloc. By centralizing how or what someone can communicate through the nexus of API-enforced digital infrastructure, we also centralize what they can think, say, or act, because there are no guardrails on disinformation and segmented polarity beyond our participation in these platforms of surveilled social activity. Democratizing technical literacy, for this reason, would agitate an entire mass of people who realize how the machines that run their lives actually work and how they could be outpaced by machinery that serves collective life as opposed to accelerated collapse of social stability. Having a tool library where people learn how to self-coordinate their lives and share knowledge on the tools they use as an ubiquity would threaten the opacity that the current digital economy depends on, given that heads of industry need to protect their status before they absolve themselves of the scarcity enforced through renting their tools to the public. For this reason, SaaS, IaaS, and PaaS, among other forms of technological mediation, gain purchase rapidly in the current economy where declining literacy is encouraged in reading, writing, and thinking. More than anything, asserting that people should have autonomy over their lives, and that the resources of nature are sensitive to constraint, is a dangerous worldview to this economy because it threatens the fictitious authority of the entire rulership. Jeff Schmidt, for example,

defines brainwashing not as a control mechanism over one's mind by an impersonal transcendental force, but a deliberate withholding of education and learning about the world: "Why choose critical thinking as the litmus test for brainwashing? Because it is what makes a human being an individual. People are individuals biologically, of course, but they are individuals socially only if they maintain an independent perspective, and doing this is an ongoing creative process based on critical thinking."



Proceeding from the definition that imperialism is the global repetition and renormalization of capitalist competition and accumulation through states, blocs, and conflict laundering, the United States emerges as the most entrenched expression of a capital-dense interstate accumulation corridor, where logistics, military projection, finance, and production are routed forcibly as organizing circuits for the world system. In the aftermath of WWII, both the USSR and the US, aside from being on the same side in the war against the Axis Powers, were also both involved in the Allied reconstruction effort to revitalize the economies of Germany and Japan after they were ravaged by wartime production and their respective bombings of Hiroshima and Dresden. Within this process, the USSR focused on extracting resources from East Germany as reparations for the war, by shipping its industrial equipment back to the USSR and demanding nearly \$14 billion in 1938 dollars as reparations for WWII. In contrast, the Western Allies didn't ask for a cent from West Germany. In the USSR's case, they needed revenge for the Nazi regime, and also just needed to revitalize their own economy to support their industrialization efforts. Whether one concedes or disputes the subjective intentions behind the United States or the USSR in supporting postwar reconstruction, whether as a means of drawing states into spheres of influence or as a reparative response to systemic harm, the underlying context exceeds the symbolic weight assigned to individual states or spheres

of influence. At the interstate level, gaps congeal where internecine resource enclosure ripens probabilistically across the possible strategic moves in the global arena, while convergence occurs where institutions infer sources of stabilization under conditions of instability, whether through postwar reconstruction or pre hoc brinkmanship. On this basis, the contextual difference between the Marshall Plan and the invasions of Iraq and Afghanistan is less a matter of moral contrast than of exposure management: the former operated as a stabilizing inference within a devastated capital corridor, whereas the latter were constructed almost entirely through the architectures of propaganda and imperial ambition. The distinction between these interventions operates not from moral calculus, but of narrative consumption substituting for structural assessment. What makes this contrast particularly striking is not even so much that the US and USSR had a shared interest in navigating the post-WWII landscape, but that the track record of the United States participating in this kind of economic or social policy towards states or individuals is exceedingly rare. These structures occasionally need to produce narratives to feed their history books and maintain the civic theology that the US is a morally righteous container of fascism, while continuing to maintain a consistent structure of exploitation of all life it has deemed beneath them.



States in the international plane function as coordinates on a field in a system they have no control over. A state never chooses its trajectory; rather, the positional relays of a state are carried along gradients of resource accumulation, security exposure, supply chain logistics, and narrative legitimacy. If we choose to accept Schopenhauer's premise about the illusion of will over how the world appears to our perception, then states are not actors and they have no agency over planetary affairs. The concept of will, insofar as it admits existence at all, regulates the system through volitional equilibrium under

incommensurability. States maintain their continuity through flight paths which travel in an interstate highway system that produces their trajectories when the world system exceeds the capacity of its existing stabilizers. In Schopenhauer's words, they would just be stones in the air: "Spinoza says that if a stone which has been projected through the air, had consciousness, it would believe that it was moving of its own free will. I add this only, that the stone would be right." If the spirit of America would be defined by a lasting legacy beyond its settler violence and industrial slaughter in the imperial core, it would be as such: America's prophets are the ones who taught us to say what we mean in public, test it under pressure, and refuse the benefits if others pay the costs. That's the soul of America in Thomas Paine, Mercy Otis Warren, W.E.B. Du Bois, James Baldwin, George Rawick, Charles Sanders Peirce, Henry George, Wilfred Sellars, and John Dewey. The slaves and indigenous communities as a class who took arms to disrupt the plantation and expansion of the frontier are the ones who decided for themselves if America gets to survive on borrowed time or if the imperial core will finally erode. America is what John Brown, Harriet Tubman, Eugene Debs, and Marsha P. Johnson risked their life and limb for, if it meant that the stability conditions of the republic could finally be audited past their expiration date. The imperial business model that trades diplomacy for frontier sovereignty and dollars for colonial dependency will gradually lose its arbitrage as an empire of extraction. The substrate of rentier arbitrage eventually exceeds the cost of its solvency. If America were to go the way of the British Empire, it would be an unremarkable fade into the background of the next chapter.



It is evident that the genealogy of the American project of sovereignty, since its inception, rents its language from the territory of Hugo Grotius and Emer de Vattel. Grotius gives the American project license to declare that sovereignty is a legal personality naturalized by property

and authority, which in the contemporary American ethos, suffices as infrastructure in a world where America sees itself operating in a world administered by juridical equals that share its dispensation for hierarchy and survival. George Washington borrowed *The Law of Nations* from the New York Society Library in 1789, returned to the Mount Vernon staff 221 years later, and his reading gave him the blueprint of a juridical order where the necessity of sovereignty judges only itself. Vattel gave America the gift of licensing legitimacy from the recognized capacity to act and adjudicate, and the laundering of scales produces exactly the kind of reason that international systems organize around to stabilize themselves if they can afford to do so, as long as instability lives elsewhere. It is documented history that the Nazi legal and territorial theorists drew explicitly from the doctrines of manifest destiny and racialized sovereignty of the United States to inform the Holocaust for this reason: the US proved through de facto exercise of force that scale of brutality was possible and necessary, and once sovereignty is defined by lawful exercise of necessary force, the admissibility of violence is only dependent on scale. If America could maintain the consistent narrative that the prosperity it claims to establish as a constitutional federal republic was consistently engaged in collaborative reconstruction of a prosperous world as opposed to a high-throughput corridor of occupation and violence, it wouldn't have built its historical legacy on slavery and indigenous extermination. However, America is legally fluent in what it needs to survive, and its constitutional infrastructure is more like Cicero's Rome: it has an aesthetic illusion of democracy and liberty, but it accommodates oligarchs first to keep its republic stable. In the same way that Thomas Ferguson invokes investor management, democratic process in America is the regulatory layer of the state's alignment with capital, and participation in the system is narrowed by the people who can pay to stabilize it. Grotius and Vattel expose underneath the civic ritual that those who arrived first on the Mayflower set the rules of the game, and have thus made it almost impossible to reform from within if you didn't arrive on the land first and enclose it by force. Somehow, we

have invented a magistrate out of the doctrine of dominium in Roman property law, aggressively enforced as land theft through the enclosure movement, coded the extraction as a balance sheet through double entry bookkeeping, and centralized all commerce through the price signal as fiat currency. As a result of this, we have decided that we have created a science out of rent seeking as ritualized as a gladiator duel, but at least the latifundium can afford to watch as sinecures for the praetorian guard. The modern economic pater familias of the Western world devolved from a more functional and sophisticated cosmological system, and they remain cursed by the ruins of their imperial decay.



The historic tension between anarchism, socialism, and communism requires situating the tension between time complexity, space complexity, and appropriate scale. These are not problems of political label or faction as much as they are about dynamics, boundaries, circulation, and metastability. Within the epoch of the post-Enlightenment world, the earliest revolutionaries such as Babeuf, Marechal and Buonarotti were not arguing from the angle that a world free from sovereign domination or private property enforcement were achieved through a specific event, faction, or political program. Babeuf, similar to Galois, in particular argued that material equality was an absolute expression of conditions rather than rights, and that in Buonarotti's inheritance of Babeuf's legacy, he acknowledges that this symmetry of conditions could only be acknowledged through revolutionary continuity. Buonarotti encountered Babeuf during the French Revolution and in spite of his police surveillance and the guillotine coming for Babeuf's head, he chooses to exile himself to Geneva, form a Masonic Lodge in order to coordinate the legacy of this encounter, and develop an egalitarian creed in a place where he was free to write and think. Buonarotti treated the Masonic Lodge the way one discusses security culture within social movements today by using them as a secure network to extend the continuity of radical ideas without the fangs of

the post-Thermidorian state breathing down his neck. The "conspiracy" in a sense was revolutionary stewardship as the extension into the next world, without the obligation or sanction by state or tribal interest. The bridge between Babeuf and Buonarotti developed through Auguste Darthé, who organized under a practical ethic of what it means to preserve continuity under repression through fidelity to life rather than party line. Darthé operated under the assumption that movements were tasked with staying coordinated and staying alive without the assumption that history was on their side.



Time as a custodial duty, as Buonarotti and Darthé intuited, was an ethical and jurisdictional shelter of equality on a cosmological scale regardless of the possibility of persecution or personal catastrophe. These were not thinkers who thought in a historical context of industrialized repression, communication turbulence, or mass movements evaluated by social legibility, because they thought in terms of lived mnemonic duration rather than a conjectural event horizon. Thus, they were able to articulate a stance of shared ethical memory, radical struggle as the duration of the next world, coordination under repressive constraints, and positioning as a hinge for what comes next without the comfort of narrative redemption. The lineage of society and social transformation left behind by Babeuf was a fragile one, transmitting fragments through the social anarchism of Gustav Landauer, the convivial expansion ethics of Guyau, Kropotkin's mutual aid as evolutionary advantage, and the synthesis anarchism of Volin. Landauer in particular attempted to carve out a social anarchism in 19th century Germany, which was already an anomaly at the time, but in a 1895 *Die Zukunft* article he argues against unconscious historical development as teleology and in favor of conscious, purposeful, and community-driven anarchist socialism, by the concept of *Gemeinschaft* (community as living organism). Landauer understood that society was an interdependent web of relationships and infrastructure rather than

an abstract object, anchored in the unfolding of history as process through lived action. As workers' movements begin to fracture at the turn of the 20th century amongst communists, syndicalists, and anarchists, Volin takes a very distinct position: that shared principles filtered for ethical fidelity and extended time through the duration of social cohesion, rather than ideological fideism. To this point, his project of a "united" or "synthesis" anarchism was not intended to be a syncretism or popular front that compromised core principles, but as an infrastructural hinge to filter out anyone who organized to advance their interests above coordinating the work of solidarity with all of those crushed by violence and power. Syncretism dilutes the meaning of how specific practices and intellectual load paths can cohere, and the contemporary popular front model trades away the notion of ethics as infrastructure entirely in favor of legibility as infrastructure to the status quo.



Material conditions, whether lived by humans or pressured in metallurgy, are phase-dependent given the conditions of finite response time and separation of timescales between storage and dissipation of stress. Along these lines, stress is either repaired within a band-gapped load regime or fractures superlinearly under amplified strain. Regardless of outcome, no dissipative system with finite relaxation time responds to stress without delay or loss. By the time the 20th century arrives, social movements are selected for speed, doctrinal fidelity, and command, resulting in bifurcations of struggle along factions, programs, events, and interaffective consensus. The combination of 20th century mass industrialization and 21st century mass surveillance results in a constellation of movements that are crunched into extreme interpersonal constraint, compromised both methodologically and ideologically by operating more comfortably as atomic units rather than shared ethical infrastructure and boundaries. Anarchism, socialism and communism have exchangeable principles that positively augment the another in

a larger network based model: the utopian spontaneity and immediate experience of the commune and the act of communization, the intermediary stigmergy of socialized self-organization, and the scale and systemic rational planning that communism advocates towards a universal emancipatory register, are all expressions of the same ontological continuum which bridges the concrete and the ideal. Anarchism is expressed through immanent experience and autonomous immediacy, which allows for deeper exploration of best practices at the local level of society in shared decision making and mutual aid. Communism, in its non-vanguardist, non-party centralist formulation, emphasizes a collective systemic modeling of social reproduction from toil and squalor regardless of deservedness or ability. Communism, in its systemic sense, corresponds to planetary-scale coordination, and anarchism emerges at the local level of individuals and trees of relationships. Socialism therein is intermediary as mezzo level modeling of stigmergic trace methods of social organization, reciprocity, and convivial autarky. We can conceive of these three intercommunal varieties of political forms as nested concentrically within each other: social anarchism resolves the feedback loop most effectively at the local level for localized affine charts of resources and knowledge, socialism provides a nonlocal network mediation layer to translate and socialize reciprocity, and communism is the global infrastructural glue for planetary resource circulation dynamics and constraint compatibility. In this regard, communism is a global constraint dynamic for thermodynamically bounded circulation of resources in common, surviving as commonweal once the infinite basin sink of capitalism depletes its course. These are specialized tools of idiographic algebra and nomothetic geometry, which orthogonally require nomological networking under shared constraint relations in order to facilitate transport of interoperable principles without eradicating their identity through programmatic transcendentalism.

Hoarding resources under conditions of managed scarcity is what kills faster than sharing them, and no linear end state will survive utility if it demands belief in exchange for squalor. All emancipatory political projects, be they communism or anarchism, do not admit their constraints by striving towards a predetermined eschatology by way of a closed narrative of history. Some disagreements can be irresolvable, some shade of reality can be incommensurable, and some rules of engagement can be irreconcilable. Our space of reason is not presupposed by a universal tribunal, and consequently we have no cause to determine a state of nature beyond what is admissible and what is reparable. If we accept Ibn Sina's conclusion of a necessary existent but decide to replace God with memory, then history is always contingent on what has happened and what could happen next, and no authorship guarantees or prevents convivial thought from asserting the continuation of life. History is fundamentally chaotic, stochastic, mysterious, and often beset by the symbolic load that weighs heavily on the present and future in all stages of historical development. We can dance with the cadence of the twilight, but we cannot trespass through darkness by fog of war. Attempts by some of the Hegelians and Russian historical intellectuals such as Aleksandr Dugin's Fourth International Theory and Peter Turchin's cliodynamics have often lurched into a sort of totalitarian palingenetic utopia in which the retrocausality of history can be rode on horseback into the sun. Utopia implies a deviation that can be rigidly enforced through authoritarian shortcuts or orthodoxy to doctrine as opposed to shared values amongst all that come now and after. In chronicling the utopias of history that have included Fourier's agrarian commune and Thomas More's proposed utopia with slavery, we ought to assess a claim of any society that designates itself as utopian as particularly suspect. Engineering a utopian society that's particular to its time would not only be a potentially fascistic project, it also would assume an abstract aesthetic of sovereignty that admits susceptibility to exploitation. Continuing Nelson Goodman's use of the term, worldmaking is plural by default the moment there is more than one person living in a world together, and no privileged reconstructions

of the world exist beyond the actions of those who decide to instantiate them. Utopias cannot persist as historically specific teleologies by definition, given that the continuity of the world is transhistorical and thus incommensurable.



Temporal precedence is the primitive source of privilege across land, labor, and capital, and rent is its invariant expression regardless of economic mode. Time imposes a spatial monopoly on land, a coordination monopoly on labor, and a planning monopoly on capital. In all factors of production, time imposes a marginal arbitrage that separates present value from future realization of returns. With capital, there is a planning monopoly by scale of firms that captures the difference between present valuation and future investments. With labor, there is a coordination monopoly by owners of firms that extracts the premium between wages and the coordination of labor time. With land, there is a spatial monopoly that gains access privileges based on historical enclosures and exclusion of prime land to others, of which the margin of production is determined by the value of excluding others from using the land itself. Profit, interest and rent are simply extractions to a sovereign tribute in this regard, concentrated through the infrastructure of regulatory asymmetry conferred by states and markets. If not for the planning monopoly of financial markets, fiat currencies are functional only through local exchange for finite craft goods, subject to postal demurrage as if perishable foodstuffs. Beyond this, there is no outside of where power circulates other than how power reconfigures and who decides the next reconfiguration. Ludwig Gumplowicz argues through the framework of syngenism that society is a sediment of prior conflict, in which combat precedes stabilization and state reconsolidation simply ossifies conquest through juridical authority. Domination is a historical contingency that we either displace or reconfigure, where resource asymmetry simply documents past recombination of ruling class order. Material equality is the

operative limit condition for as long as dominance is in rotation, and the decision to renormalize around symmetry is one that requires a transition out of the low-intensity conflict of peace or the strategy of tension.



By extension, Ibn Khaldun clarifies that 'asabbiyah (coordinated intragroup solidarity) eventually decays; more than just a cycle of empires, Khaldun expresses that conquest already dissipates social stability of a given group as default, in such an arrangement where domination recombines into status maintenance during high gradients of intragroup cohesion. In Khaldun's case, society precedes material norm formation, and any assumed notion of social order carries a half life in contact with reality. Domination records sediment, but also failure to survive, and in Khaldun's own recollection, domination is thermodynamically finite. Empires may smoothen their state of exception over time, but their decision to concentrate their abundance dissipates the conditions that generated stability in the first place when instability is exported. Economic rent happens no matter if it's mediated by prices, in kind calculations, goods and services, party loyalty, affordable housing waiting lists, mob rule, village lotteries, or ritual sacrifice. It is functionally impossible in any society, no matter how equitably or equally you develop over land and finite natural resources, to value all of the land on earth as though it were infinitely accessible or replicable, regardless of planning and population growth. The law of rent exists outside of the capitalist system, hence why you can have rentier privileges in any economic system and why those privileges were observable even in pre-industrial and pre-capitalist world systems. The law of rent persisted even in tribal systems, feudal systems, communes, remote villages, and ancient empires, prior to being formally articulated by the early modern economists. Any firm in this sense is just another organization that happens to transport resources and planning concentration that

otherwise would be handled in tandem by common specialization and organizational constraints. Beyond cultural differences, organizations share non-equilibrium thermodynamic constraints around coherence, stabilization, decomposition and recombination regardless of how a global price signal drives value. Rent and monopoly are simply effects of coordination in an economy, and any social fact that declares them necessary is coercing exclusion by fiat. The machinery of supply chain logistics, resource circulation, and credit adjudication simply follows as the loci of where coordination authority is distributed, as well as how infrastructure mediates the distribution of resources.



Infrastructure condenses time, and the exclusionary consolidation of authority over resource coordination results in an amplification of temporal asymmetry, and thus resource asymmetry, between the planning authority and those who participate in the economy without planning authority. Time becomes a machinery that freezes past decisions into future constraints, resulting in resource exclusion on account of access and timing. The creation of value in a centralized price system of a global market economy, beyond just the traditional labor theory of value, emerges from the temporal arbitrages of all coordination monopolies in tandem. There is an invariant reality that the only strategic positioning within factors of production is the earlier one in history, and therefore all marginal extraction is an expression of the same temporal asymmetry across different expressions of time, whether they are in capital planning, labor coordination, or locational access. If an oil firm or landowner is strategically positioned earlier in time, prices then come with a premium relative to its temporal advantage over competing firms or claims to tenure. Conversely, if a firm is positioned earlier in time, firms can behave irrationally in planning and production for as long as they have additional access to infrastructural coordination over the surface area of economic activity. Time becomes its own enclosure on price setting in markets, in which

artificial scarcity can be manipulated during economic downturns or crises to gouge prices regardless of the cost of production. Each margin of coordination assumes exclusion: by excluding planning access, you assume the interest in your financial returns is entirely based on the privilege of capital planning in the present, and not on the historic gains from socially and historically created value of capital. By excluding coordination access, you assume the profit of coordinating labor time is not socially and historically created by the objective value of labor itself. By excluding spatial access, you assume that the rent on land is not socially and historically created by those who are denied access to land tenure by virtue of being born in time to access land.



The calculation debates between Friedrich von Hayek and Otto Neurath have set political economy back a century. Hayek's argument in *The Use of Knowledge in Society* correctly identified that centralized economic planning creates lossy compression of local knowledge—no singular chokepoint could coordinate an economy of scale because information about preferences, conditions, and capabilities remains distributed. Price signals, he argued, could aggregate this dispersed information more efficiently than any central planner given market competition and the law of comparative advantage. Hayek's argument ultimately depends on the constraints of computation in 1945, in which the technology of in-kind economic coordination did not yet exist. Neurath's advocacy of in-kind calculation proceeded from his observation that the public could coordinate their own affairs with richer data at scale of what is actually needed when distributed in accordance through the diverse multiplicity of necessary goods and services as opposed to a singular price signal imposed from above and wasted profusely at the level of state and industry. The advocates of capitalism have for centuries advocated for the mysticism of the invisible hand, and yet in the contemporary moment of actually existing capitalism, global heads of industry and heads of state have

already coalesced into a planned economy for oligarchs by maintaining the centralization of price signals into a consolidated rulership. They coordinate their affairs perfectly well through backchannel communication, supply chain centralization, contractual cartelization, exclusive fiefdom over the use of technology, government subsidies, fee simple ownership, and regulatory capture, while imposing price discipline and mass surveillance on everyone else. The expansion of the Internet, mass production of computation, and the accessibility of personal devices to access the web has closed this gap immensely.



We have inherited this mythology for centuries that only centralization of states and markets could govern the affairs of civilization and the planet more studiously than civilization could self-coordinate, under the 20th century assumptions that a centralization of price signals could somehow surpass all other systems in providing for society, and that the prevalence of squalor managed by this system is entirely necessary. Neurath understood what Hayek obscured: the public can coordinate their own affairs with richer information than any price signal provides. When you know what goods exist, what production capacity is available, what people actually need, and what ecological constraints bind us, you can coordinate directly. Price signals destroy this information by collapsing multiple dimensions of value—use, ecological impact, social necessity, temporal provenance—into a single scalar that optimizes for shareholder return, concealing dynamic resource circulation behind an abstract fiction of equilibrium. Scalar commensurability is an operationalized iatrogenesis: the system that optimizes for it is actively injuring itself and everyone that submits to it. The only use case in a modern economy that could warrant the efficacy of localized price signals is through rationing genuinely inelastic goods such as land, carbon emissions, oil, and the finitude of natural resources in the commons that one cannot regenerate, and even if priced and held in common, the rental value and compensation

for negative externalities of these resources should circulate equally to the public for as long as they are held in common. Prices survive in this localized damping-coefficient role as right-of-way sentinels that modulate uncertainty and irreversibility, indexed to demurrage for strictly inelastic resources in the commons; whereas, circulatory goods otherwise coordinate in-kind through vector-valued routing.



The reason you would price these resources as held in common is not because the layperson would waste or extract from it, but because landlords, states, and industry barons would disproportionately monopolize and capture its value at the expense of the public, excluding publicly created value through privatized capture. This is how pricing the commons should work to mitigate pollution and exclusion from use, as Pigou stipulates through the polluter pays principle: By pricing these resources, we can trace where waste is occurring and where monopoly is visibly hoarding value at the expense of all. Everything else—food, housing, energy, transportation, education, childcare, postal savings, medicaments, tools, information, etc—can and should be coordinated in-kind. These are producible, renewable, context-dependent goods whose value emerges through use and circulation, not exchange value. Coordinating them through global price signals systematically destroys information about what they actually do, who actually needs them, and how they relate to resource constraints or waste. Otherwise, all other resources on top of the bounty of nature can be circulated in kind and nurture value through use. The commons is an intensive good, where prices just serve as boundary setting from predatory institutions, and which value does not scale from trading or exchange, not unlike a marine layer, work of art, or a sacred site. Extensive goods are all the ones you can calculate in kind and coordinate based on what people signal as necessary for real-time allocation, and thus can scale appropriately to what is needed based on local informational granularity and global network routing. Extensive goods derive value

from quantity, measurability, and circulation, whereas intensive goods derive value from quality and finitude. Any socioeconomic system cannot trade intensive goods or commodify extensive goods without losing coherence and accelerating instability through misallocation, which is as plainly thermodynamic of an economic law as possible. In the Information Age, technology is more globally accessible than ever and far more computationally efficient than any central planner in the 20th century, and thus distributed computational systems mediated by interoperability can globally coordinate resources in kind with exponentially more circulation and less misallocation than a highly centralized state, market, or central planner that maintains the primacy of scalarized price signals.



The post-Y2K epoch of ongoing polycrises and the ontological turn facilitated a decisive bifurcation condition that produced a shared polarity for a mutually reinforcing dynamic: the primacy of the subject, and the totalitarian metaphysics of optimization as commensurable sovereign. In the contemporary era, computers and virtual interfaces are available everywhere and have become a common mediating layer that coordinates informational processing and resource transport. The caveat of this computational proliferation is: information is everywhere, dashboards are everywhere, and platform KPIs govern through what survives benchmarking and industrial velocity. In a world where optimization is given a sinecure of rulership, every interaction reduces to a variable or externality subject to private quantification for institutional gain. Information requires metabolism, whether you are dealing with trees sharing a mycelial network or how ants use pheromones to signal colony building despite never meeting each other. Shannon entropy specifies very clearly that the content of information is subordinate to the cost of distributing information that eventually falls on someone to pay, regardless of communication medium. The capacity, bandwidth, noise, and redundancy of bit

distributions for information determines the constraint layer of reliable signal transport, and when noise is propagated, the noise comes with a price tag. The current system is essentially an API-mediated feudalism where data is extracted and held hostage by unaccountable corporations in which the shadow prices of waste have been converted into loan collateral. Google and Microsoft are not exactly innovating the markets at this point beyond trend chasing, but they benefit from being in the prime mover position to monopolize on resource-intensive proprietary data centers that cannot freely exchange information.



The tragedy is that all of these companies have already built the infrastructure that global sustenance could rest on, and they have proven that infrastructure could be modularized and built, but are instead using to maintain surveillance capitalism for extractive purposes at any expense to the public. Amazon has completely monopolized the logistics layer of supply chain planning and turned it into a manorial contract architecture with some of the worst working conditions in recorded human history. Google demonstrates that computational capacity could serve the entire global population and instead has optimized their SEO for ad revenue. It is abundantly clear that the tools necessary for global flourishing, which include knowledge graphs, logistics, collective knowledge sharing, and data sovereignty, are not tools that we can solve through piecemeal technocratic policy reforms like 3D printing, automation, blockchain, and UBI. We are already seeing the transition between classical computing and AI among major Silicon Valley firms in particular, in which the hierarchical layer between man and machine stratifies even further than ever before. Before the acceleration of the AI arms race, the distinction between the blue collar and white collar worker was relatively clear, and in this transition that machine learning has mediated, those lines are far more ambiguous. The Amazon warehouse worker was historically the factory worker located within the logistics

coordination layer, and as AI accelerates, the warehouse worker will slowly encompass even the white collar class, such that the Amazon worker within the firm will find themselves subordinating to become the warehouse worker for the actual data center that is monopolizing the logistics.



The entire system is built on a total collateralization of finances towards a resource that depletes more rapidly with each successive generation. Cory Doctorow speaks plainly to the speculative inefficiency of this expensive and fraudulent scam: “Microsoft “invests” in OpenAI by giving the company free access to its servers. OpenAI reports this as a ten billion dollar investment, then redeems these “tokens” at Microsoft’s data-centers. Microsoft then books this as ten billion in revenue. That’s par for the course in AI, where it’s normal for Nvidia to “invest” tens of billions in a data-center company, which then spends that investment buying Nvidia chips. It’s the same chunk of money being energetically passed back and forth between these closely related companies, all of which claim it as investment, as an asset, or as revenue (or all three).” The entire accounting mirage of internal tokenized spending that is entered in the balance sheet is not a liquidity stream, but it is actually a closed-loop transfer of resources that rapidly deplete until the next round of borrowing happens. By closed loop transfer, this does not refer to a liquid revenue stream that sustains itself over time, but an internal self-perpetuating accounting loop on repeat until the asset well dries out. This model relies on a collateralization of income streams that is as exceedingly fragile as it is extractive from both the public and the planet. The system of collateralization pledges a scarce resource – whether the resource is data compute, server time, raw materials, land, or public dollars – and then upon depletion of this resource, accelerates a financial crisis in which each generation becomes exceedingly less cost-tolerant than the last, while those who master the bond market can always plumb more resources from the drain. There’s usually five

major tenets of such a model: collateralization of finite resources, a closed loop of recycled value, increased speculative amplification in which processing power usually needs to match the computing cost of the speculation, inflow-outflow dependency on external subsidies and public extraction, and an increasingly brittle path to solvency. The latter is the most important detail here, because it exposes a security vulnerability that demystifies the entire system: proprietary systems assume stateless machines, which are ultimately stateful but hide their states into deferred maintenance.



If this is beginning to sound familiar, it is an old playbook of pledging the sum of all negative externalities to securitize a self-reinforcing feedback loop of speculative investment. Whether you are dealing with decades of ransoming the public through housing or education, the same pattern persists in different iterations of the structural pathology underneath the model of capitalist financialization. The subprime mortgage industry collapsed under this model, triggering the 2008 U.S. recession. Since then, the logic has evolved into a cross-border private equity model of speculation, where domestic real estate markets struggle to compete with international firms that can purchase entire neighborhoods at bulk acquisition rates, driving up surrounding land values with each successive acquisition. Each generation of speculation gets more expensive than the next until there are no coals in the mine to burn from the public even though these institutions are flush with cash and resources. The California public university system runs on a similar business model in which student tuition dollars are pledged for cost-overrun causes on construction bonds. Bob Meister writes from the Council of UC Faculty Associations in 2009: "Your tuition is UC's # 1 source of revenue to pay back bonds, ahead of new earnings from bond-funded projects, which do not even come second. The bond interest UC now pays will be \$ 300M this year, and is projected to go way up as UC greatly increases the private

capital it raises through tuition-backed bonds over the next decade. UC should disclose its plans to issue new tuition-backed bonds before you are asked to accept this year's 32% tuition increase, which will automatically become part of the collateral for those bonds. Because UC pledges 100% of tuition to maintain its bond rating, it has also implicitly assured bond financiers that it will raise your tuition so that it can borrow more. Since 2004, UC has based its financial planning on the growing confidence of bond markets that your tuition will increase. (Why? Because you've put up with this so far, and because UC has no other plan. Its capacity to raise tuition is advertised in every bond prospectus.)" To make this connection clear, the business model rhymes, and we may have already seen such a model play out with the subprime mortgage crisis in 2008, and we are seeing it again now with the current Silicon Valley computing arms race. The financial planning of the logistical oligopoly in Silicon Valley is based on a similar model on a macro level, where to ensure they can always optimize their bond rating, they move from one bail out to another by ensuring they always have access to collateral.



Paul Goodman diagnosed the metastasizing of cost-plus clauses in the 1960s DARPA-instantiated military-industrial complex that has since stabilized into the dominant economic model by the logistically-driven economy. The military's creation of ARPANET was a template for this kind of business model, in which academic and corporate partners such as IBM and Xerox provided a circulatory exchange of subsidiary knowledge and material resources to develop the incipient TCP/IP protocol for a hub-and-spoke mainframe technology as a leverage against Soviet intelligence. The government contracts guarantee a profit for the contractor as a percentage of cost markup, which creates its own set of perverse incentives to maximize operating costs instead of sustaining them. Every cost overrun clause ensures that the more you waste, the more you profit, and every additional profit margin

can be bookkept as revenue, and every wasteful planning inefficiency can be written off as a revenue stream. The entire system is based on an internal circulation of deficit, waste, and monopoly: deficit creates the justification for additional contractual obligation, waste increases the cost basis of the cost-plus mechanism, and monopoly creates the congestive bottleneck that excludes others from generating actual value. It's a fully embedded market logic that reigns over the Post-Fordist economy, but there is nothing free about it other than freedom for the dominant coordinating classes to dominate and siphon resources from the commons. Although this business model once suited defense contractors, it now pervades everywhere: health insurance carriers benefit through risk pooling and claim denials, universities benefit through administrative bloat and student debt bloat, financial institutions benefit from bond markets and loan collateral, boutique real estate developers benefit from gentrification pressure and surcharged construction materials, AI companies benefit from pushing their computational processing power, and the cycle continues. The entire system creates its own feedback loop: profit margins are guaranteed, costs can be inflated in perpetuity until there is a crisis, all competition is excluded to remove barriers on spending discipline, contracts run in private circulation, and the public assumes risk on privatized capture. The system creates its own debt that the public shoulders in order to circulate profit that the private sector captures. The waste is fundamentally the business model of the entire economy. The entire postwar economic order is a tumor that is beyond the pale of more advanced treatment methods, and surgery is necessary. Such a system eventually leads to its own demise and cannot be fixed with better regulation, discipline, or accounting, only replaced with an entirely freer operating logic.



By opting for the convenience of remaining in a circular firing squad over 20th century strategy and economic debates over false binary

tensions of vanguardism vs. syndicalism, or labor vs. capital, reform vs. revolution, electoralism vs. insurrection, or AI vs. Luddism, or who the revolutionary subject even is, the possibility of confronting and changing the trajectory of the current economic system will become exponentially more costly for everyone after them, and likely curse the planet to a gradual but increasingly entropic program of extinction and decay. The 21st century is past the point where one confronts 20th century fascism using 20th century techniques or organizational strategies, let alone 20th century approaches to technology, even though it is not completely impossible to change course. Structural pessimism itself implies resigned fatalism and eventually craters into mass nihilism in which people become passive participants of their eventual demise. That said, the global technocratic monarchs are moving quickly. The leading hardware manufacturers, including IBM and Google, are developing quantum processor technology which would exponentially accelerate the processing power of the leading Silicon Valley firms and potentially augment the capacity for weapons manufacturing towards a terrifying level of efficiency. Quantum AI algorithms are being developed in conjunction with quantum computing, which would result in massive efficiency gains in both AI and hardware manufacturing that will benefit the tech industry's current coordination monopoly in ways that are indescribable before any such models reach the public through broad commercial use. It is important to note that the financial sector was one of the first to adopt quantum processing technology, similarly to how it was among the first to benefit from the US military's advancement of the internet, both innovations of which have proven to be the ultimate boon to insider trading.



Each successive prime mover advantage the financial markets receive through early adoption of computational processing efficiency also boosts their insider queue positioning on the trading floor beyond

what any ordinary consumer can ever hope to achieve in their own financial planning. Beyond just a SaaS driven-economy, the next stage of modernity could resemble a Contact Center as a Service(CCaaS), Platform as a Service (PaaS), and Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS) driven economy, where communication and information will be centralized into proprietary AI-powered communication suites with black-box cloud data center maintenance that would accelerate infrastructural capture for the captains of technocratic industry. All human coordination would be privatized within the contours of nation states as a subscription model in which information is fully monetized and productivity tools are rented but never held in common, only monopolized by industry. Such terrain would not be marked by logistical coordination through SaaS but by a mass algorithmic abstraction of social relations that will outpace human logistical coordination through an unholy prime mover advantage on account of market position. We will either become pliant automatons that have no concept of autonomy outside of their own or nihilistic and mad at our own powerlessness, driven towards accelerationism and collective dread. This is separate from just simply claiming we are headed towards a technological singularity, which is a teleological claim, but rather, we are headed into an era where meaninglessness and saturation of meaning will be heavily enforced from above, and the choice to organize against this acceleration of entropy will take an exponential spiritual toll. A singularity assumes a paradigm shift or progress, but entropy guarantees mass degradation.



George Jackson spoke to the immediacy of struggle and clarity of action: "Settle your quarrels, come together, understand the reality of our situation, understand that fascism is already here, that people are already dying who could be saved, that generations more will live poor butchered half-lives if you fail to act. Do what must be done, discover your humanity and your love in revolution." The system benefits from

facilitating our atomization and determinism, but has also advanced past the point in which we can debate whether reform or revolution is necessary, or debate ambiguously what these terms entail and who is involved in creating them. Different paradigms across the ages have been challenged and overthrown under much more scarce conditions and stoked collective response from collective injury beyond what was considered possible. We are beyond the comfort of debating between the implications of reform vs. revolt, vanguard vs. horizontalism, socialism vs. barbarism, centralized planning vs. decentralized cooperation, or even state vs. syndicate. We can either accept what is incorrigible or choose to walk away. There is only one decisive action that does not perpetuate the status quo: the choice of refusal. Bassel Al-Araj says precisely that: "The beginning of every revolution is an exit, an exit from the social order than power has enshrined in the name of law, stability, public interest, and the greater good." At this juncture, the exit through the gift shop requires us to prefigure the collaboration, coordination, and mutual reciprocity that the next possible world is built on. This also requires us to decide urgently if we want our future to be held under more suffocating captivity or the possibility of reconfiguration for all who come after us. We either leave or stay.



A system that indexes access to marketing budgets, commodified advertisements, and litigation budgets for private property sovereignty enforcement is ultimately draining finite resources more efficiently than any local state phenomena could through personal consumption habits, and we would expect machines and institutions to proceed from these constraints rather than above them. Any system that enforces resource sensitivity for individuals and unbounded inference for itself demonstrates its survival depends on solvency, and that its expiration depends on participation with its own jurisdiction. Indeed, any adjudicative authority that perpetuates its survival through its own legal exemption is living on borrowed time, measured by the expectation

that their subjects will eventually no longer route through them. The authority that requires its own exemption has already admitted to the chronometer of history that it cannot survive symmetry. We are in the most technologically advanced era of history, where land, logistics, infrastructure, and resources are plentiful to go around for everyone who needs it, but they are irrationally concentrated in the hands of a few who happened to be near the gold rush of the dot com boom. The giants of Silicon Valley have already figured out how to recuperate these ideas and drive global poverty and disparity further while benefiting from the informational overload that cascades at every segment of the planet, whether one is dealing with irreparable loss of biodiversity or entire generations of people lost to poverty, war, and state violence.



Capitalism has evolved past the need to dominate people in a factory when it can dominate people anywhere in the world remotely from the comfort of their laptop. The chokepoints of 20th century industrial capitalism was the brick-and-mortar factory, but today, the chokepoints are located throughout the global supply chain, mediated by API infrastructure, data centers, and surveillance technology. Land has already been so immensely enclosed to the point where just capturing land value is no longer enough, because the business classes have capitalized on time. The networks of knowledge sharing and logistics coordination need to be universalized because they reclaim the actual problem of being the prime mover in the first place. It is not enough to just build class consciousness or a worker's movement, when there is really a wider movement of people who are disillusioned, complicated, and can be organized into building the next world by tomorrow if they choose to settle their hostilities and confront the coordination monopoly that chokes all of our possible epochs into asphyxiation. The revolutionary movement is to build the technical architecture of what comes next to ensure a system of rational planning is possible and reciprocal, rather than to theorize that capitalism is bad and what the

values of its replacement should be. The actual replacement needs to be built over time.



The decision to monopolize the coordination of resources is ultimately a choice that distributes costs onto someone, and those costs usually come at the expense of the public to resuscitate the consolidation of the global market economy. Any system that coordinates goods, resources, and information with the tyranny of a price signal is deferring its own expiration and magnifying the cost of replacement. The paradigm of global market fundamentalism is living off of borrowed time, sacralizing price as the only admissible signal of value. No structure that coordinates goods is exempt from a reality that justifies exception for its claims to asymmetry. Any organizational system coordinating its own resources has historically never depended on markets as gospel for the value of goods and necessities. In Karl Polanyi's recollection, he specifies where the impetus of economic competition as selection pressure: "In the case of Ricardo, theory itself included an element which counterbalanced rigid naturalism. This element, pervading his whole system, and firmly grounded in his theory of value, was the principle of labor. He completed what Locke and Smith had begun, the humanization of economic value; what the Physiocrats had credited to Nature, Ricardo reclaimed for man. In a mistaken theorem of tremendous scope he invested labor with the sole capacity of constituting value, thereby reducing all conceivable transactions in economic society to the principle of equal exchange in a society of free men. Within Ricardo's system itself the naturalistic and the humanistic factors coexisted which were contending for supremacy in economic society. The dynamic of this situation was of overwhelming power. As its result the drive for a competitive market acquired the irresistible impetus of a process of Nature." If we take the old adage of Baizhang Huaihai, stating that "a day without work is a day without

food” as a disciplinary principle, it is predominantly a thermodynamic law rather than an ideological interpretation.



The Zen doctrine of samu implies joint distribution of labor to maintain the monastery, rather than externalized coercion of labor into managerial sovereignty. This is not a moral, punitive, or disciplinary adage, only an austere declaration that metabolic throughput requires dissipation. When there is no dissipation, there is no replenishment, and when there is no replenishment, there is only breakdown. Work is a distribution of resource dissipation across gradients (not as toil or wage peonage), food is just a free energy storage required for infrastructural maintenance, and a day is a finite time window of irreversible process. A system at equilibrium extracts maximum work from available capacity in accordance to the minimum action needed for resources to circulate towards deficits along least-resistance paths. Denying resources to circulate where they are needed creates a pressure gradient that requires dissipation, and a system that does not dissipate energy stores cannot be provisioned indefinitely. It follows from non-equilibrium thermodynamic regime constraints that maximum energy production (contribution proceeding from capacity) resolves minimum action (allocation from feasibility and the admissibility environment), and survivability is the only criterion for persistence. Value is a multifactorial distribution across interacting constraints, which includes care, skill, knowledge, and mutual coordination capacity, only decohering when contribution and provision are decoupled from one another. The collapse of value into a singular symbolic scalar of wage extraction freely floating over material throughput refuses thermodynamic coherence entirely by severing gradient dissipation capacity from survivability constraints, and institutions that facilitate this severance are implicating themselves in accelerating thermodynamic entropy through blocked gradients in order to justify arbitrary coercion. The substrate of the biophysical coordination of any given

system of activity is joint labor coregulation of load distribution under continuous stress rotation. The survivability of any social system is only as materially metastable as the autonomic distribution of stress under mutual boundary adherence.



The last century has conflated software with industrial production, and hardware with consumer commodity, and the burden of this technical debt has been frontloaded to the public as a result of this category error. Software complexity scales linearly with intensive goods, whereas hardware complexity scales sublinearly with ubiquitous circulation of extensive goods. Software should be thought of as craft, because it lives in the semiotic and intensive domain where correctness, meaning, and coordination matter. Hardware is infrastructural as a public utility, because it lives in the extensive domain where continuity, safety, and circulation matter. Shifting complexity burden from post-hoc exogenous correction to amortizable technical correctness is a recommitment to predictable, type-safe, lifelong operations that can support the resource sensitivity of the economy without collapsing into the tyranny of price signals. The enforcement of the market as gospel is wildly ludicrous in hindsight; the authority of a 17th century esoteric pseudoscience given 21st century machinery is not unlike choosing Ptolemaic epicycles over general relativity. Capitalism assumes linear supply/demand curves that are only as mathematically up to date as Newtonian mechanics, differentiable equilibria, exogenous shocks, discrete time steps, and zero endogenous coordination semantics to handle local complexity. The market ultimately needs the profit margin of information asymmetry and the deification of a nation state to function, and it does so through chronic resource inefficiency, access asymmetry, cyclical conquest and warfare, infinite extraction of finite resource gradations, and arbitrary gratuitous violence in the service of artificial scarcity, opacity, monopolies, rentier extraction, and positional advantages based on historically contingent time horizons.

They can only survive on their own through periodic recessions, mass inequality, information hoarding, developmental arrest, and chronic resource misallocation. They mediate coordination, but at the planetary scale, they are hundreds of years behind schedule by using discrete agent metrics and brittle attack surfaces for extortionate amounts of exogenous correction.



Pyrrho of Elis is driven by the motor of he calls adiaphora, in which the moral state of exception that drives asymmetry between concepts or people loses its justificatory standing. Although ethical schemas in modern parlance only sort between a binary model of virtues and vices, adiaphora reflected a third mode on a ternary axis that kept ethics regulated as infrastructure: rather than virtues (what one ought to do) and vices (what one ought to avoid), adiaphora does not express or mobilize, only regulate the space of admissible moves in a strata of activity under irreversible constraints. Any sovereign entity rules because they have not yet expired, not because they claim exceptional purchase on moral necessity. Adiaphora proceeds from ontological non-authorization: a boundary condition that withholds necessity and moral accounting as justification to legitimacy to all bulk structures by default. If any bulk structure, such a market economy or a state, requires exception to justify itself, it forfeits its claim to survival by default. Structures do not sanctify themselves by assertion alone or by the overdetermination of appearances with necessity. Any system exists by persistence, but no system claims a right to dominate. Adiaphora, as a principle, is the refusal to let coherence masquerade as consent. An institution that justifies itself through rights or needs to ration rights as contingencies for admissibility has already annihilated its own sovereignty and its own state of exception. Interchange is never free, regardless of institutions that may claim otherwise by assuming administrative authority, and this goes beyond the entitlement of markets and goods; everyday practical life in which items, ideas, or

information circulates is a regularity with a cost, and nature charges rent to anyone who denies that this cost can be justified through exclusion. Nothing authorizes itself by adjudicative authority, and any adjudication only lasts as long as procedures which extend care through action. What persists are only those actions which repair and which distort, and mandates are morally subtracted from this equation beyond the decisions to coordinate without the entitlement of law or property as sovereign, or the precipitation of actions that outrun reason.

DOULOPHRON · 240°



Time has not always been materialized as a clock. Epictetus hovers over the idea that no person is free if they are denied mastery over themselves, and we extend this notion to generalize that no person is alive if anyone is denied the affirmation of life. When institutions engineer this approach to facilitate internalized coercion, subjugation, and absence, then cages are no longer inside of you because it thinks with your voice. Any institution that facilitates this condition by design, be they an algorithmic platform or the carceral system, is a system that commits the soul to death, which is the most dolorous system of all. The disparate fragmentation of both our conception of time, our relationship to others, and our relationship to ourselves has reached a particularly unique pressure point in which time itself is desecrated. By desecrate, we mean that time is instrumentalized by privileged institutions to meet arbitrary deadlines, respond to harm, withhold information and resources, invalidate the contextual durability of our experience, and deny ourselves autonomy over ourselves and anything we deem sacred. The concept of doulophron describes a very specific experience and among the most deteriorating injuries of all: the bondage of the interior life of our subjecthood by coercion to an external archive. It is one thing in this world to not have access, but it is another to absorb so much routing pressure from organized control that we do not get to have facts. In Walter Benjamin's own words,

the "enemy" is not a person, but an extremum of what constitutes authorized authorship when self-authorship collapses as standing: "Only that historian will have the gift of fanning the spark of hope in the past who is firmly convinced that even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins. And this enemy has not ceased to be victorious." This goes deeper than material subjugation because it describes a felt phenomenology of structural annihilation through our own internal spatiotemporal orientation. Such an experience goes beyond the pale of alienation or even dispossession, because it describes a sensation of forced psychosomatic filtration to the point where we no longer recognize our thoughts or our autonomic nervous systems. Losing a relationship to self-oriented temporal continuity is losing a relationship to breathing that does not match the tempo of something outside of ourselves. This systemic logic of invalidation is highly complex and gives clarity to the deeply networked structure of institutionalized control and withholding of mutual care that touches our experience at every scale in society, from before we were born and throughout our entire lives.



The psychological concept of mirror-image perception provides an engine for how organized invalidation works in practice. Mirror image perception on its own is not pathological: it is a perceptual default under interpretive reflection that economizes semiotic representation, while selectively disaggregated by the constraints of activity, body, and symbol. The experience of mirror-image perception incorporates interhemispheric lateralization and ventral stream object association, where symmetry is the most affordable option under finite resources. Mirror symmetry in a metabolic sense is sometimes necessary to break for adaptation, but symmetry that breaks and then freezes into place by force and exacerbates when lost frozen without repair. Under Louis Pasteur's lens of molecular chirality, mirror symmetry devolves into instability in a world where dynamics and metabolism are at play.

Chirality and handedness happens regardless of what we think or feel about it, and the process cannot be averaged away no matter how much we force people to tolerate a temporary law and order on our behalf. The integration barriers of perceptual mirror-reversed representation plague everyone to some degree, since these barriers are often socialized through mnemonic bindings, trauma ledgers, and attachment patterns that drive the routing schedule of allostatic load in our information transport between ourselves and each other. Neuroceptive reducibility whets the engine of perception-representation asymmetry, where the semiotic pressure of symbolic density overruns the capacity to metabolize it. The world becomes easier to fragment through invalidation, where complexity shrivels and binary truth values reign, creating scenarios where right and wrong are relative but disconnected from the relational web that is mirrored locally and invariantly at scale. Healthy relationships move beyond judge and judged, inviting perceptual symmetry that evolves beyond the reproduction of mirror-image perception patterns. The fragmentation of the mirror refracts locally and at appropriate scale, reflecting back the fragmentation that occurs at scale amongst ourselves and each other. We learn by necessity to recognize systems that facilitate chronic invalidation, and enforce fragmentation at an industrial scale.



We can define detemporalization as such: the erosion of lived capacity to sustain temporal orientation intrinsically to ourselves. A detemporalized regime is one of which local rhythm ceases to survive long enough to orient action, events occur without accumulating into a future. No future can be stably held under detemporalization, resulting in orientation around crisis and reactivity rather than a static state. Detemporalization is the process that stifles our temporal orientation in all directions, and distorts experience through trauma, noise, scarcity, waste, and urgency. The violence of detemporalization unifies all of the other forms of violence under its mantle, but

maintains a family resemblance as a building block as opposed to a flat equality of different categories of violence. It can thereby be understood as a contextual space in which violence has a root, and branches into any permutation of violence that context reveals. At the base metaphysical level, detemporalization in all permutations contains epistemic violence, ethical violence, and simulational violence. Epistemic violence, typically described in the domain of postcolonial scholars, can be best described as an artificial hierarchy of knowledge imposed by contextual invalidation and force. This is the distortion of how knowledge relates to others and how knowledge relates to the larger contextual ecosystem of the world. Epistemic violence distorts the objective contextual truth under which all knowledge rests, the objective cardinality of knowledge and shared knowledge production, and the capacity to perceive or be receptive to the truth of others. Ethical violence is purely a violence of relationships and relationality between individuals, individuals and communities, or communities and systems. Ethical violence imposes a distortion upon the relationality, reciprocity, and mutual recognition of living beings that is inherent and inviolable to life regardless of power or perception. Simulational violence, broadly speaking, distorts the representation of reality. This is the immediate, somatic dimension of violence, distorting one's embodiment of reality, sensuousness, and capacity to process or inhabit the ecosystem of information that constitutes reality. Together, these forms of violence are inseparable from one another in how violence manifests in the world, and also how deeply violence can distort experience and perceptual reality on a daily basis.



Violence has both an invariant metaphysical layer and an invariant physical layer that presents in how we are shaped by our experience and also how we are shaped by the daily transgressions of lived experience. At the physical level, violence takes on a more embodied and lived in form that trespasses at the temporal, material, and symbolic

level. Temporal violence is the distortion that imposes discontinuity of time from ourselves. Temporal violence fragments time, forces processes to always be outside of history, disrupts eurhythmia, erases ritual, and disorients the intergenerational current of experience. Temporal violence by its very nature enforces urgency and scarcity of time, and imposes amnesia over the act of remembering history and genealogy. Material violence is violence through material conditions: it obscures and obstructs the conditions of flourishing, deprives us of pleasure and desire, disrupts security and sustenance or renders it conditional to asymmetry and concentrated power, and ensures that bodies are completely disposable if they cannot produce for society. Symbolic violence imposes the perceptual split between self and others, mind from body, hierarchy and dominance as natural order, difference as domination, and monopoly over legitimate forms of cultural or linguistic production. Whether in the metaphysical or physical layer, there is a structural overlap that mutually shapes both dimensions of violence: Temporal and epistemic violence both distort the conditions of reference in truth or time, moral and material violence distort relationality whether as basic material needs or community care, whereas simulational and symbolic violence both distort reality, representation, and the sensuous immediacy of our lived experiences into an abstraction of meaning and disconnection from our ability to sense or process the information available to us.



What remains important to note here is that there's no metaphysical dimension of violence that isn't also physical, and violence has a circulatory cadence of its own that operates across all domains and all facets of life, while being modular to the specific context of the violence itself. What we experience as physical harm from other people shows up as all three forms of metaphysical and physical violence, while also extending into psychological violence, physiological violence, and cultural violence depending on the context of the physical harm we

experience. Similarly, when we are being invalidated or manipulated by others in our lived experiences, that violence is similar in how it extends across multiple registers, while never being fully localized to body or mind in some Cartesian sense. Violence metastasizes in its scope and shape, and never fully reconciles until we discern how we process violence or understand our disconnection from it when it happens to us. At the individual level of every expression of violence is a structural invariant that glues it all together: violence is decontextualizing, and thus all violence is contextual violence. What violence does at every level is tear individuals or communities out of context of themselves, forcing them to either accept representation of contexts other than their own or float into pure amnesia. Individuals are forced in this reality to either accept a hegemonic narrative that is socially constructed to serve the powerful, or they languish in resistance to the reality that is doted upon them. But the result is the same either way: individuals, without access to the context that makes them distinct, will always feel disconnected from themselves whether they recognize why or not. Violence is a process as opposed to an individual incident or phenomenon; it is the universal format of our disconnection from reality, abstraction from the world, and alienation from ourselves and each other. This makes context the processual glue that makes all forms of violence mutually intelligible to one another. Hence, if one were to articulate the task of life is to contextually generalize what is abstracted in isolation, detemporalization imposes the opposite operation, where violence abstracts individuals away back to isolation from themselves and others. Once the initial survivable transformation of violence occurs, violence has expanded the frontier of possibility towards tearing reality, and also mimetically replicates across a contagion of fibers: ecological, cultural, psychological, economic, political, spiritual, repeat ad nauseum. These are not so much separable phenomena from each other, but rather the projection of the same decohering operation that occurs across domains. Contextual violence is an ontological injury prior to subject formation, whether someone is born a slave, debt peon, or a replacement child, and an ontological injury is an

extractive technology for any institutional entropy refinery to produce. An ontological injury implies we were predetermined to be inadmissible to the people who configure us, prior to physical or psychological injury, and that even the formation of a subject is entirely symbolized through concentrated load routing.



Violence is a processual operation that decontextualizes across time, not as mere episodic inevitability or accidental tragedy. Prisons are just one of multiple examples across history of entropy refineries whose primary product is instability, harm, and collapse. For any authoritarian regime, procedural neutrality is just the most efficient transport mechanism for violence, and the late modern period has various tails of this continuum in nonprofit mediation, stakeholder engagement initiatives, transparency modifications, and symbolic moral theater that overruns civic institutions. Authoritarianism is, fundamentally, a root cause of control dynamics where decision trees are left ambiguous for exploitation in a power vacuum, and one bottlenecks the decision tree by force or violence to strip away boundaries when someone must authorize them to be managed. The authoritarian system or personality fundamentally requires ambiguity and opacity to function, and when they are denied these things, they desperately grasp for any gratification that control over the reality of others gives them to survive. Without this survival mechanism they can manipulate, the war chest of authoritarian rule exhausts its capacity to persist. The despot is an anti-informational architecture thriving on deliberate underspecification of reality, preserving the blockade that dams the world in its inscrutable vortex. The complete control architecture of detemporalization is the control of information, control of resources, and control of time. The production of fear is what binds prison to the common memory, in which an institution extracts the fear of the public and converts it into privatized distance. What remains as a metric is just the residue of violence produced by an institution before it is

ever measured, and by the time harm has been industrialized as care, the irreversible threshold has already been trespassed and instability is already generated into the environment. Our decision to justify the carceral institution as necessary proceeds from a question that the institution refuses to answer around what is done when serious harm is caused and we cannot morally disappear the aftermath of harm. In response, the prison has chosen to substitute incapacitation for repair as the tragic necessity and disappearance as an accountability mechanism as anodyne, which exposes only that the environments that justify the existence of prison have deliberately chosen not to answer the question of how to repair and set boundaries on irreversible harm. By justifying the prison as necessary, we reveal that this question has never been answered by the societies that maintain them, only warehoused away in an attic where the question cannot be seen. The prison is the purest distillation of a stabilized administrative grammar of how violence is industrialized as the first class export. Prisoners as a class can always feel this even if they don't immediately recognize it, and the production of the prison also depends on them not recognizing it, because if they were to recombine and withdraw from the bulk of the prison operation that depends on their participation, the prison itself would cease to function stably as a system.



James C. Scott initially drafted the idea of infrapolitics in the 1990s, to which he describes the limitations of politics as declarative action: "So long as we confine our conception of the political to activity that is openly declared, we are driven to conclude that subordinate groups essentially lack a political life or that what political life they do have is restricted to those exceptional moments of popular explosion." Infrapolitics is how we might describe illuminating things in the darkness, a way of creating an interpretive layer of cultural production and stealth forms of resistance that are not themselves limited to physical revolts or direct actions. We may think of this as tactical

media, movement journalism, or even just politics as stealth and camouflage. This does not mean one puts on a ski mask, but more of the opposite: one maintains full radical transparency of their experiences as diffused through their political expressions, while maintaining semantic irreducibility and traceability to anything beyond what the actual experience shares. This is part of how prison movements, for example, have been able to clarify and share their own experiences through epistolary relationships on the outside. As a class, prisoners are some of the most notoriously resourceful groups of people, and often will explore conditions of extremity in order to develop forms of kinship on the inside or outside despite commissary and outside communication often constrained by prohibitive costs, asymmetric risk, and finite time. Prisons maintain leverage through asymmetric risk by weaponizing both solitary confinement and transfers, which Stevie Wilson describes as a form of load routing when prisoners attempt accountability for harm by prison administrators: "Routine transfer is most insidiously practiced on those convicted in the federal system. With prisons spread across the country, federal prison officials are able to use transfers as a regular disciplinary tool. It is almost a given in the federal system that people will be incarcerated far from their homes, often in quite remote locations in Appalachia or the Great Plains. Federal prison officials use "diesel therapy" to discipline imprisoned people who file grievances, lawsuits, and organize. Diesel therapy entails routinely and swiftly transferring a person from place to place. The person is never able to get settled, to get connected to others. Often, the person is transferred too quickly for family members to know where they are. As soon as the family discovers where their loved one has been caged, prison officials ship the person somewhere else. The person's property often never catches up with them. And because the federal system is sprawled across the country, the transfers can go on for years." Routine transfers by diesel therapy are just the deferral logic of the prison as a refinery, in which its own instability that it produces needs a constant routing pressure across a landscape that prisons are embedded in as nodes. Prisons as a system function

with their own allostatic load, except that the production of instability as a first class operator ensures that this load never repairs, only exacerbates the basin geometry of any environment that maintains a carceral institution as a mediating source of entropy throughput and load localization. When the prison dissolves, this entropy does not resolve, it must merely be survived by anyone who produces the prison and the people who are captured by them.



Prisoners demonstrate what we may call survival intelligence in a lethal system that needs to spiritually and socially annihilate them. In a sense, prisoners, like anyone held captive in an abusive system, demonstrate how to remain spiritually and socially adaptive despite extreme abiotic evolutionary pressures from the system around them, and in doing so, they reveal how prisons often feel like an anthropomorphic zoology of offstage captivity. Prisoners demonstrate survival intelligence in ways that laypeople who have never experienced struggle often do not: they make informed decisions on how to deftly navigate a system of ambient predation, how to build kinship and alliances that deescalate strategies of tension, how to develop autonomy through leverage, and how to adapt to scenarios of extreme deprivation. Infrapolitics is just the practice of this survival intelligence in real time, through politicized acts of satellite communication in analog within the enforced social discipline that prisons require. Prisoners develop autonomy precisely through these seemingly offstage political acts, in the sense that there is no theatrics behind what is being done to elucidate life inside, and everything outside of the prison is onstage because it is made visible to the public. Survival intelligence is practiced everywhere, whether you're dealing with prey in the animal kingdom, or predation in abusive households, given that the conditions of extremity often facilitate immediate conditions of emergence through premeditated evolutionary pressure. The lethal system nomenclature is intentional here, because it signifies exactly what it means: these are systems that need people

to be broken, and launder suffering as a way of reproducing the suffering needed to maintain the system in the first place. The notion of solitary confinement still appropriates the fantasy that a prison could be repaired into something more humane, not unlike the Quaker inheritance of penitence. Instead, prisons are regimes of industrialized immurement, in which the architecture of walls actively redefines the scope of interiority, and time within immurement does not pass but accumulates as damage—more specifically, as live entombment. This is exactly what is meant when Ruth Wilson Gilmore says: "Prisons get built where there is already abandonment."



During the Pelican Bay hunger strike in 2013, competing sects within the prison banded together to initiate the Agreement to End Hostilities, a peace treaty that transcended tensions between segments of the prison population in order to organize prisoners as a class against the use of solitary confinement, which threatened the entire infrastructural and legal order that CDCR built off of fomenting conflict between factions of prisoners. Following the organized hunger strike activity in 2013, the Ashker v. Brown settlement was implemented in 2015, which dramatically reduced the scope of programming around indefinite solitary confinement in CDCR facilities. The prison administration adapted quickly to this new legal blow, and instead of opting for an offensive vector around just solitary confinement, they opted for a separate attack surface entirely: conflict amongst the organized prisoner class. In 2018, word slowly broke out to the public that rival segments of the prison population were forced into shared yard time, which naturally served as an accelerant for conflict and violent skirmishes between prisoners that allowed guards to wash their hands clean of responsibility since they could just as easily sanction prisoner behavior. These "gladiator fights", as they are colloquially known, leaked to the public as a consequence of the series of prisoner work stoppages and strikes between August to September 2018 which characterized

the national U.S. prison strikes, focusing squarely on the cause of prisoners as a class against the carceral regime which engineered both their isolation and their conflicts on the yard.



Dan Berger and Touissant Losier clarify the repugnance behind the isolatory and often maddening conditions that prisons have created throughout their history in the West: “Beginning in the late eighteenth century, American jails and prisons utilized austere tactics of solitary confinement and forced labor that produced mental illness and physical abuse. The first things called prisons emerged in New York and Pennsylvania. Their designation as “penitentiaries” reveals the religious origins of their first designers: in eighteenth century Philadelphia, Quakers hoped that prisons, specifically solitary confinement in which prisoners were denied all human contact or interaction, would cause people to reflect on their wrongdoing and repent. Instead, many of them were driven mad from the prolonged isolation. Meanwhile in New York, the early prison at Auburn mixed social isolation with forced labor to promote discipline among the captives. And, reflective of their criminalization, African Americans were amongst the first group of prisoners sent to the early penitentiaries in New York and Pennsylvania.” There are no surprises about who the prison population often represents, and overwhelmingly, the most vulnerable segments of the population are the ones most susceptible to incarceration, regardless of individual penitence of behaviors that diverted them there. Meta steals at least 80 terabytes of books to train their AI models, and leading AI models are trained on at least 150 terabytes of image-text data, which in simple terms encompasses billions of images they plunder and plagiarize from a plenum of dead artists, yet their legal teams and financial resources give them all of the cover necessary to defraud the rest of society and extract resources against their will.



In terms of how we think through a system that exhaustively keeps a lid on things, whether you're dealing with the warehousing of prisoners or the caste enforcement of the peasantry, we have to conceptualize how speculative these systems actually are, and how most maintenance goes into forcing compliance upon the subjects within these systems. In the case of the modern prison, for example, these facilities are often social laboratories for some of the most iniquitous forms of surveillance technology and black-box torture out there. To clarify, these are totalizing institutions where obedience is coerced, isolation and atomization are encouraged as behavioral modification, and the prison staff have carte blanche to starve, physically violate, or degrade prisoners at their discretion. There is no profit motive or "prison labor" for outside contractors needed to uphold such a system, because it primarily relies on speculative leverage over a surplus population that can be rendered docile and destabilized through containment from outside social life. Prison is an entirely speculative enterprise and relies on sealing off the prison population from the outside world in order to keep atrocities private, and strip anyone subject to incarceration from having any sort of autonomy on their own conditions inside, or even outside if they were to participate in civil society with a stamp of vilification on their foreheads. Prison is where temporal orientation goes to die, and where life is abstracted into decay.



A prison is something that forces you to move or isolate within its confines given timescale separation, defining the interaction between the form of a total institution and local interaction. Not unlike a plantation, an abusive household, a concentration camp, or a refugee corridor in an active warzone, a prison is a system where slow, premeditated coercion facilitates an abrupt internal collapse. Once a total institution such as a prison drags a captive past a

threshold, which they frequently do all of the time without their consent, a local behavior feels a discontinuity happening where their sense of reality ruptures and thus the field around them intensifies with entropy. Prisons are entropy factories as a default setting that purposefully destabilize the geometry of reality at the cusp fold, which inevitably propagates for as long as prisons are maintained and their surveillance machinery expands. The prison is a laboratory for surveillance technology before such technology broadens its scope to public domain. The collapse of time in late-modern societies, and abstraction of time within highly repressive systems, has a particular qualitative and quantitative cadence: periods of compliance under austerity that are punctuated by irreversible shifts where collective deliberation or action results in immediate activity, compressing all horizons into a perpetual present in which change requires immeasurable and often speculatively priced amounts of force to maintain regardless of outcome.



Prisons and detention centers are a kind of total institution in which they represent a particular compositional pathology. These institutions create conditions of catastrophic coupling where the entire social system that maintains them is perpetually destabilized by their implementation. In terms of a public investment, prisons are demonstratively negative-sum value: they're extraordinarily more expensive than just providing funding directly to communities, they often worsen recidivism than comparable material support through housing and healthcare, and prisoners themselves walk away with potentially a lifetime of trauma, perpetual closure on career or social opportunity, and fractured family relationships. They're glorified concrete warehouses where the poorest and most vulnerable populations of society are internally displaced as surplus, and the carceral institutions depend heavily on routinized alienation in order to maintain control on both the prison population and the public. By forcibly denying prisoners any autonomy at all,

they deny that an alternative reality is possible that doesn't involve subjecting people to highly invisibilized forms of violence that nobody outside would ever have to process or witness. These are institutions maintained by enormous resource waste to enforce artificial scarcity on the rest of society, in a concerted effort to impose psychological scarcity on the people within them.



The surface of the prison is an entropy refinery, but mathematically underneath this entropy is the primary operational mode: prisons are engineered irreversibility engines that convert social variability into persistent structural entropy. Prisons function solely as destabilizing sinks with delayed feedback that attach parasitically onto vulnerable environments, such that many American prisons are embedded in isolated local economies, and confine those systems until all that survives is damage. Prisons and other panoptical regimes that reify subjugation and surveillance function as not only producing entropy, but also rectifying entropy through continuous circulation and dynamically immobilizing the dissipation of entropy into repair. Without any narrative moral surplus, the prison survives because its only function is stabilizing a highly speculative social order by generating irreversible entropy somewhere else. Part of the larger picture is through Michal Kalecki, a Polish economist in the 20th century who wrote work that bridged post-Keynesian schools of economics as well as the ongoing schools of Marxian economics. Kalecki wrote a relatively short and prescient essay titled Political Aspects of Full Employment in which he points out that the problems of achieving full employment under capitalism are not necessarily related to economic benefit at all, but are almost entirely political constraints. Kalecki named the feasibility problem of Keynesianism explicitly: "Discipline in the factories and political stability are more appreciated than profits by business leaders." Full employment is deemed politically intolerable mostly because a fully employed society would tip the scales towards

labor as a class, compromising any disciplinary or bargaining power that captains of industry maintain over workers. Thus, a capitalist society needs a reserve army of labor to ensure a permanently managed condition of scarcity, creating an industrial safety net of disciplinary control where employers can always leverage class hierarchy as an avenue to discipline labor. This context especially matters for how Gilmore chronicles the transition from public sector Keynesianism to post-Keynesian militarism in the post-Fordist era, where the decline of public works as an employment mechanism led not to a dissolution of the state, but a redirection of its productive capacity. The same tools, including public debt and state jobs programs, were instead focused on latching to mostly isolated, rural and suburban peripheries disconnected from core urban economies as a way to absorb and contain surplus populations, building systems that revolve around organized abandonment and deprivation.



This model of racialized discipline in the service of state or empire draws not just from Keynesianism, but also from the entire political orbit that Keynes came from. Keynes was highly connected to the Fabian Society, collaborating closely with the classical Fabians such as Sidney Webb, George Bernard Shaw, and Hugh Dalton. Webb was very explicit about what he believed were the barriers to socialism: "...wrong production, both of commodities and of human beings; the preparation of senseless luxuries whilst there is need for more bread, and the breeding of degenerate hordes of a demoralized "residuum" unfit for social life." The Fabians, along with Keynes, were highly influenced themselves by imperialism and eugenics, and Robin Murray notes in an essay that Fabian planning represented a response to capitalist production through "circulation rather than production." Shaw shared his imperialist aspirations openly through a manifesto he authored called *Fabianism and the Empire*: "...what is needed now is a definite constitutional policy to be pursued by the Empire towards its provinces.

The real danger against which such a policy must be directed is not the danger of attack on the Empire from without, but of mismanagement and disruption from within. The British Empire, wisely governed, is invincible. The British Empire, handled as we handled Ireland and the American colonies, and as we may handle South Africa if we are not careful, will fall to pieces without the firing of a foreign shot.” The racial hierarchy and foundation of job security through exported social control gave the entire Fabian model its justification that could glue the project together while promising socialism to the masses at home by managerial reformism. The Fabian model revolved around a mixed economy in which socialism would be achieved through a coordinated cadre of elites and experts as a way of engineering society through “evolution rather than revolution.” In the context of the application of the Fabian model, which took root in England, the Fabian model for full employment required an immensely exhaustive network of outside colonies for the British metropole to extract value that could fund their welfare state project. Fabianism was essentially a racialized imperialist jobs program that appealed directly to the white British working class, in which colonial administration gave the Fabians a business model for their intellectuals to extract abroad. The racial hierarchy, appreciation for eugenics, and commitment to empire was part of how the Fabians engineered the political economy of their model, and the parallels to modern society are particularly apparent in the entanglement of carceral society in the present.



The modern penal archipelago is in many ways an outgrowth of the Fabian Society ethos which Keynes came from, and in this mutation to post-Fordist society, the carceral state adapted quickly to the limitations that Kalecki pointed out decades ago. The entire system is built on racialized Fabianism turned inward: nothing is produced, only contained, through an import of deprivation and control rather than an export of imperial domination. Prisons provide a promise of

“full employment” for highly isolated rural and suburban peripheries by which the prison can become the primary employer in the city or county they’re situated in. Not unlike police officers, prison guards are often the most cushioned jobs by virtue of higher salary than other local jobs on average that do not require a specialized degree, while also having a prison guard union that maintains their institutional leverage. Unlike public works programs, there is no production or productivity happening in these prisons, and their entire currency is valued through the laundering of trauma upon prisoners and their families. Not unlike the Fabian model which creates a jobs program via racialized domination and colonial extraction, the modern prison creates a jobs program through racialized captivity and ambient catastrophe. Racialized populations are extracted from their communities under this model and subject to a spiritual, social deadening that chokes them out of society. If the basic technical architecture of this model is ever violated through autonomous social insurgency or empowering the autonomy of prisoners as a class to refuse domination, the entire state and capitalist apparatus is threatened by their autonomy. California’s prisons function as an archipelago of domestic colonies rather than international ones, ensconced by cycles of public debt and a protected bureaucratic caste of prison administrators, with a belt tightened by the constellation of CCPOA and county sheriffs who operate entirely in opacity. The terminus of this project is exactly as it seems, which is an entire surplus political economy of trauma as stimulus, surveillance as care, and scarcity as managerial science.



The entire nonprofit industry plumbs the public drain and privatized capture, giving the state a cheaper and easier avenue of managing care by simply outsourcing it to an entire nexus of competing nonprofit service providers and civil rights organizations. The logic of racialized Fabianism maps out elegantly to the upscaling of nonprofits and administrative bloat within them, in which funding from state,

foundations, and private donors could be rationed through a perpetually underfunded and underpaid network of agencies that need to survive by constantly bidding for contracts with the state or private sector. As a result of this path dependency to sustain their operations, nonprofits function as a structural intermediary between the state and the service constituency that nonprofits claim purchase on. The dependency is mutual between nonprofits and the state: nonprofits receive institutional access to powerful interest groups, resources for private sector job creation, and organizational stability as long as they comply with the needs of their funders. Meanwhile, the state needs its nonprofit network to handle mediation between them and the communities they would otherwise have to confront directly, provide a cache of public relations victories that the state can claim for social problems, and managed scarcity through managed care. The nonprofit sector provides the affective labor that governments cannot do through their own departments, and the abundance of nonprofits throughout an economy are no accident; they provide an entrenched professional class of privatized means testing. The nonprofit industry is a private arm of racialized Fabian capitalism, providing a soft power approach on the outside in contrast to the hard power approach deployed within the prison system.



Dylan Rodriguez notes how much of this systemic coordination lives in the shadow of the Hoover administration's unspoken convergence between state and philanthropy: "During this era, US civil society—encompassing the private sector, non-profit organizations and NGOs, faith communities, the mass media and its consumers—partnered with the law-and-order state through the reactionary white populist sentimentality enlivened by the respective presidential campaigns of Republican Party presidential nominees Barry Goldwater and Richard Nixon. It was Goldwater's eloquent articulation of the meaning of "freedom," defined against a racially coded (though nonetheless

transparent) imagery of oncoming “mob” rule and urban “jungle” savagery, poised to liquidate white social existence, that carried his message into popular currency. Goldwater’s political and cultural conviction was to defend white civil society from its racially depicted aggressors—a white supremacist discourse of self-defense that remains a central facet of the US state and US political life generally.” The stakes are fundamentally different now than they were in the mid-century, given that the post-Fordist state needs a lot less force publicly to maintain discipline over their subjects. The interiorized repression of the prison is an interiorized repression elsewhere, such that the state mediates segments of the population to encourage internecine conflict and crush dissent that suggests a deeper solidarity between classes of people against the powerful. The state requires an ambient dread to permeate throughout civil society, just as they focus test directly through the machinery of the prison system. Nonprofits give them a diffusion mechanism by creating an aristocracy of social movements, and prisons give them a warehouse to ship away anyone deemed categorically inadmissible to capitalist society.



The important alignment between prisons and nonprofits lies in the ideological DNA and historical lineage that threads them together, which is a holdover of the old Fabian ideal that society needs to be administered by a class of experts, while withholding the autonomy and self-determination of the people who are immediately affected by the artificial scarcity that these systems maintain by design. Kalecki’s foresight that full employment is structurally improbable is what resonates here, knowing that neither nation states nor markets could either risk compromising the integrity of their entire business model by a collectively liberated society that reclaims their autonomy and holds resources directly in common. The primary driver of detemporalization is the domination of the state and market society, but nonprofits only serve as a secondary driver, functioning not as

the final adversary alongside any socially just cause but simply as a structural intermediary that depends on state and markets to survive. Thus, nonprofits are not fought against directly, since they structurally cannot change their position unless the structure changes. They instead can be bypassed in order to build the next world and create something more emancipatory than the chains that shackle resources from those who directly need them. Threatening the legitimacy of the state as a caregiver threatens the legitimacy of the entire system writ large, and that care is modeled directly through prefiguring relational structure rather than through the managed scarcity of markets and the state. Genuine liberatory practice ultimately has material and historical stakes, and is not soothed by capital or shielded by institutional enclosure. The people that pursue an honest liberatory struggle do not do so with the expectation that they can depend on the structures of society to compensate them for it. This is the difference between a movement that leads with solidarity of the dispossessed, and those who manage their dispossession. This is also the difference between prisoner struggle that supports prisoners or any mutual aid network in building collective autonomy with direct material support, communication tools, and legal aid, in contrast to those which can sanitize their image for brand identity and call themselves “abolitionists.” The former proceeds from a genuine love of the prospects of reciprocal life and convivial knowledge, while the latter steals this knowledge, separates the jaw from the skull, and sells the aesthetic of the struggle to a philanthropy venture. In cloud data architecture, we call this an ETL (extract, transfer, load) pipeline. In politics, we call this expropriation.



Perhaps even more damning than the Fabian legacy of the modern penal archipelago is its cursed generational inheritance of institutional conservatism. The Fabian appetite for colonial elitism is one not just warmly handed off by their liberal forebears, but from Whig

historiography itself, and namely Edmund Burke as par exemplar. Burke's conservative screed against the French Revolution in defense of tradition offered many intellectual justifications for a conservative ideology against revolutions and rapid change from below, but chief among his concerns were what Michael Oakeshott may call "preferring the familiar to the unknown" as the backbone of conservatism. For Burke, the possibility of rapid change outside of risk aversion signals danger and collapse: "There they commit the whole to the mercy of untried speculations; they abandon the dearest interests of the public to those loose theories, to which none of them would choose to trust the slightest of his private concerns." The Burkean ethos is one of multiple core tenets which serve as a linchpin even to modern conservatism: a pathological distrust of the masses against the elites, tradition over reason, and society evolving gradually through the proper institutional channels such that they go at the pace that the intellectuals allow them. Underneath this worldview lies the continuity that shapes all changes deemed illegible or too soon by the elite: a sort of paternalistic commitment to preserving the present order against anything that would be too liberatory too soon. It is no surprise that both Burke and the Fabians, despite contrast in their political programs, have found metaphysical kinship in their preferences for incremental adaptation through inherited institutions. The control of time as a moral rationalization, whether through the colonial England witnessed by Burke or the Fabian Society, summarily reveals the rot behind their shared genealogy: the colonized or fugitive subject is always waiting on the clock for a moral evolution from their masters that is never scheduled to happen. Time is a constraint in this political theology, but the constraint is laundered as a division between those who live in the future of history by the will of their inheritance, and those who remain contingent to the historicism of the master.

Burke's litigation against British colonists is perhaps most revealing of the genealogical overlap behind this worldview. Warren Hastings was known for being a colonial administrator of the British East India Company, and was put on trial for a long litany of charges, ranging but not limited to bribery, brutal executions, property theft, and military coercion. From the minutes of the trial directly: "The company's own servants admitted that they had been parties to acts of extreme corruption and extortion at Bengal and Oude, and had enriched themselves to a vast amount by contriving the contracts which now form the ground of accusation." Burke was one of the primary adversaries to Hastings around this time, leading the charge in prosecuting Hastings during the trial period. Most evidently, Burke did not prosecute Hastings for necessarily being too paternalistic, but by not being paternalistic enough, as his speech in the impeachment trial indicates: "But the obedience of a barbarous magistrate should not be compared to the obedience which a British subject owes to the laws of his country. Mr. Hastings receives an order, which he should have instantly obeyed. He is reminded of this by the person who suffers from his disobedience; and this proves that person to be possessed of too independent a spirit." By Burke's own admissions, the missteps of Hastings were largely by his own excess of free will, by not upholding the virtues of being a British colonist administering their subjects. Burke, not unlike many other British elites of his time, inherited the abstract ideal that the managerial expertise of colonial expertise could be a force for spreading British diplomacy and commerce, and believed the ailments of this approach were in the colonists themselves tarnishing the reputation of this ideal. Empire was something that Burke advocated to be morally reputable as a way of admonishing both the colonial subjects that he could not trust to govern themselves and the administrators who did not competently manage them. The concept of whiteness in the Western world is a civic classification for admissibility into the court of the Westphalian episteme. Racism functions not as a relationship from one racial category to another, but as a compact that stabilizes the edifice of a civic liturgy. The concept

of a national identity is what institutional conduct subtracts from cultural survival. We cannot conceptualize whiteness as an ethnicity, but instead as a membership ritual for participation in the project of Western sovereignty.



Incidentally, Edmund Burke's historical relativism and emphasis on historical continuity was the backbone behind the German historicist school and eventually his ideological adversary, Karl Marx. The core of each author in advancing their personal values is the same, in using history as a fulcrum for moral authority. Ironically, the person to make this argument against Burke's emphasis on historical contingency is the conservative intellectual Leo Strauss himself, who used this point to argue for a return to values grounded in the natural rights of the world located in all people, beyond just a reflexive defense of traditional values and historic familiarity. Strauss argues in favor of the role of philosophy to destabilize belief by upholding inequality of access to information. Strauss argued fervently against historicism, proposing that some ideals transcend their historical context and that some natural laws are transhistorical. Strauss can only use this concept to interpolate Plato as a representative of the elite that uses philosophy to lie to the masses and concentrate truth in the exemptions of the elite. Strauss still fundamentally claims that a return to nature is the antidote to modernity, and that society can only be governed by a salutary myth where elites know more than the public. Strauss defers to history as the arbiter that justifies exemption, which belies the reality that history is not an estate held in escrow. History does not carry responsibility for present action, and any justification to asymmetry has already failed to transfer agency. The only difference being that Burke and Marx were at least honest about the historical relativism of their work, while Strauss needed to parrot the same noble lie he interprets as a lifelong task to project his own contradiction of lying to the public and hiding behind his institutional elitism. Like

all of the fascists in the world he softens his stance on, he confuses crypto-historicism for truth.



Underneath Strauss's position on the virtue of the noble lie, however, remains a core tension he venerated within his reading of the Ancient Greeks: the power of inherited rule, and the wisdom of authority. Dating back to the age of Athens, one recalls Thucydides and his history of the Peloponnesian War, partly as an archetype to not just modern realism in international relations, but also the narrative that might makes right as asserted by the Athenians against the Melians: "Instead we recommend that you should try to get what it is possible for you to get, taking into consideration what we both really do think; since you know as well as we do that, when these matters are discussed by practical people, the standard of justice depends on the equality of power to compel and that in fact the strong do what they have the power to do and the weak accept what they have to accept." The Athenians have drawn their line in the sand and made their point clear for 2400 years: the powerful do not justify their rule over their subjects, nor do they engage in dialogue to be understood, and only by a field of rulers equal in power and leverage can true recognition actually occur. The Athenians do not claim that the Melians are beneath them at all, not too dissimilar to how Burke may portray the colonial benedictions of England despite extorting the resources of their subjects. The Athenians simply accept the premise that power justifies power and nothing else. Those with power exist in the present, unfettered by those who anoint their conscience with a holier visage towards the despots that rule their land. Those who are dominated or subordinated to the powerful are waiting for a change that will never come, unless it is taken from them by the same audacity that wrested their autonomy in the first place. The Greek alethurgy of musculature as civic ritual haunts the walls that echo throughout centuries of a narrative conveying sovereignty as a church built on

top of an existential wound, and the zealotry of violence makes for anodyne as the rite of communion. Carl Schmitt, of all people, admitted that sovereignty is fundamentally an ecclesiastical institution, and by having a sacrament, the sovereign institution has cultivated an ossuary that repetitively haunts their songs.



The machinery of prison and surveillance technology is the latest ritual tumor of an antiquated civic theology unable to metabolize its own void. Time is thus a constraint only to those who the powerful deem impermissible to power, and only by perpetual deferral of the future and the control of the present do the powerful maintain their grip on the world. The system is completely unfalsifiable in such a reality in which the decision to be freed by captors rests upon the decision by captors to grant freedom on their timeline. The powerful control the present, but those not favored by power live distantly from a future they can never fathom, because that future is always designated as illegible. The prison is no different in this regard: both time and space are socially mediated and controlled, and one's freedom depends entirely on the state's assessment of how free they can actually be. The powerful are always insisting that the time has not yet come for the dominated to be autonomous, and those who are dominated are always messaged that they are not ready for their freedom, and that their freedom is something they must long for but can never fully grasp. The political theology underpinning the powerful, from Athens to the modern penal colony, remains an ancient Western tradition regardless of state formation or economic paradigm, in which time is managed and controlled by an organized elite that seeks the preservation of their control above all other gains, developments, or efficiencies. Following the pace and designated channels of the experts instead of learning to become an expert yourself is what illustrates the machinery that makes the folklore possible. Detemporalization is just the mechanism that threads their tactics together, in which time is seized by force,

rationed by history, and held captive at the exclusion of everyone else not yet born. The prophet, Simone Weil, speaks from the wound etched into the angst of Athens: "The true hero, the true subject, the centre of the Iliad, is force. Force employed by man, force that enslaves man, force before which man's flesh shrinks away. In this work, at all times, the human spirit is shown as modified by its relations with force, as swept away, blinded, by the very force it imagined it could handle, as deformed by the weight of the force it submits to." The Roman consul, beset by a craven affliction, has subjugated their unconscious through an addiction to violence that has bruised them since they were humiliated by the Germanic pagans in the Battle of Teutoberg Forest. The fossil of Roman imperial pageantry corrodes at the root of their descendents in Anglo-Protestant Britain and contemporary America, but we know they all eventually collapse under the weight of the same humiliation ritual that originated them: the intoxication of an empty vase from which its wilted flowers dry in the desert wind. The latest petal of this flower is the American civic subject, the projected shadow of a civic DNA it inherited from Rome that denies its spiritual and intellectual defeat to Jerusalem and Greece.



The empire of Rome is a cadaver drinking from the mirage of the Mediterranean basin, and in this parched imagination they have forged an orrery out of a lighthouse that frightens itself to death. In order to defy 2400 years of enforced waiting, the powerful have to deny that this waiting is necessary if the tools and knowledge are available. This is part of why uprisings over George Floyd and Oscar Grant, or the Attica prison riots, or the breakfast programs of the Black Panthers were all considered so genuinely threatening to authority. Additionally, one may find amongst labor unions that the bargaining agreement for highly established unions under the AFL-CIO umbrella contains a no strike clause to effectively curtail any wildcat strikes or organized direct actions outside of the scope of what is authorized through the

guardrails of one's collective bargaining agreement. Autonomous action that prefigures the future, has a blueprint, and decisively acts to build the infrastructure of the future are the things that endanger power, because they directly liberate the sanctity of time from captivity. The antidote to detemporalization is simpler than it seems: build the future, design the blueprint, let them follow you, and do not ask for their permission or validation. The CIA's main anxiety regarding the breakfast program of the Black Panther Party, in part, was their defiance of the image that the state serves as a caregiver, and that an autonomous community with their own locally situated knowledge could not just figure it out with enough resources and shared wisdom. The political theology that enforces these constraints is the one that insists that history needs decades to achieve what could be done in days without intermediary approval. Making people wait for freedom and flourishing comprises the logic by which people are subjugated by time, and it is by refusing this subjugation and organizing themselves through the circulation of knowledge that they restore the rhythm of time's passage.



Prison abolition is ontologically necessary and inevitable to stabilize the world to a less destabilizing condition. Any society that creates the conditions for arbitrarily designating its own surplus of adversaries also creates the conditions for its own deficit and waste, and these conditions are compostable into something that creates the possibility of repair. The physical prison is the brick-and-mortar of this archipelago, but the algorithmic substrate of confinement and surveillance technology as sovereign ritual of alienation and dread go beyond this spectacle to ensnare the world in the theater of the panopticon. In discussing the tendencies and contradictions of the incarcerated lineage of Black radical movements, Orisanmi Burton expresses in a 2020 roundtable the limit condition that prison abolition poses: "For me, prison abolition is about breaking this dialectic of

rebellion and counter-rebellion, which has been so central to U.S. carceral development.” Abolition, in practice, exposes a phase inversion, outside of an arena where power asymmetry is already sedimented into place prior to morally opposing an institution with a finite time horizon, by decisively reconfiguring an expiring stability condition by which a world cannot survive otherwise. The regime of total surveillance shares a grammar with total confinement, both of which admit themselves to be not just carceral geographies, but factories that produce geographies of irreversibility as primary export. The sovereign creating its society of friends thereby creates its abyss of enemies that reach from the abyss to declare that they, too, belong to a family. We understand intuitively that we are undoing the systemic logic that makes imprisonment possible, including the temporal constraints that make people conceive of themselves as separate, scarce, and threatening to each other. The irony behind the liberal utilitarians such as Bentham and Mill rankles one’s conscience once they attempt to reconcile that their glorified competitive betting market for ethical decision making required the creation of an instrument that was so suffocating in its surveillance that no ethics remained except for the betting market itself. There are no rational choices to be made in a system that demands, in its final incarnation, to monitor the choices of all and expect rational ethics in return. The panopticon models the totalization of the prison’s logic in our world. If the site of the prison is the motte, the panopticon is the bailey at which we are surrounded by detemporalization.



Prisoners as a class have operated as politicized actors in conditions of extreme restraint, and given the irreversibility of harm often laundered to them in the institutions that keep them isolated from the world, they are not strangers to exposure from audiences who treat their suffering as an audition for charity, rather than letting them speak and organize for themselves. Fred Moten and Stefano Harney

capture this recuperative tension in the history of the Black Panthers specifically: “The Panthers theorized revolution without politics, which is to say revolution with neither a subject nor a principle of decision. Against the law because they were generating law, they practiced an ongoing planning to be possessed, hopelessly and optimistically and incessantly indebted, given to un-finished, contrapuntal study of, and in, the common wealth, poverty and the blackness of the surround is confronted not only by the brutalities but also by the false image of enclosure.” For Moten and Harney, they recognize the generative antagonism that presents the core challenge of political institutions: the monopoly of sovereignty, the state of exception the sovereign creates, and therefore the monopoly of control around who can speak versus who is silenced, and which mouths get fed. More importantly, the false image of enclosure emerges through the expectation that the institutions entangled with the state, be they the nonprofit industry or the media conglomerates adjacent to the state, could garner legitimacy by latching onto the suffering of the carceral nexus. More frequently, these institutions follow where prisoners move, reacting only when they sense their control system is losing its grip. The runaway slaves and collective revolts in history, or the revolutions that deposed the monarchies of Europe, or the collective victory against the French colonists in Algeria and Haiti, or the perseverance of the Palestinians despite displacement, blockading, and encroachment of the lands their ancestors lived on, were not aberrations to this system but the most assertive expression of politics in practice.



The joint labor of colonized and enslaved people is a deliberate expression of an ongoing negotiation against a world that has localized instability onto them, but they also recognized within themselves and within each other that their struggle was towards autonomy from institutions that extract time, memory, and judicature, no matter how desperately these systems fought to maintain their grip on

the world. In connecting his building of collective struggle against the Portuguese colonists with the struggle against all authoritarian regimes throughout the world, Amilcar Cabral said: "The Vietnamese say that they will win the war for certain, because if the Americans are ready to fight for ten years, they are ready to struggle for ten and a half years; if the Americans are ready to fight for twenty years, they are ready to struggle for twenty and a half years." It is important to note that this framework also provides context for how easily liberation movements can be immobilized by detemporalization, especially if stuck in the hamster wheel of institutional entreatment. Western movements of mass protesting and marches against specific American presidents, for example, without recognizing the continuity of their policymaking across presidencies, reveals the placidity of liberal humanism in the face of systems of violence that outlast specific presidencies. In the aftermath of the September 11th attacks, President George W. Bush had created both the Department of Homeland Security, as well as Immigration and Customs Enforcement, both of which have become synonymous with a growing authoritarian regime that violently targets immigrants throughout the country and suspends any illusion of dichotomy between legal and illegal immigration, since the entire legal category can be shifted by the state at will. Since the creation of DHS and ICE, not only have ICE arrests scaled upward with every respective presidency, including multiple Democratic presidencies, no leaders who claims to oppose the Republican Party agenda has ever dared to wrest power on their terms, resulting in an unmasking of the systemic fascism that upholds the entire state, in which both major parties uphold the same power dynamic. Only shared transhistorical values and shared strategies built collectively amongst people, that are connected with the struggles against systemic violence and domination no matter where they are happening around the world, can provide a lever against fascism, not the performance of specific demonstrations against specific individuals. As Malcolm X famously quipped in 1964 in his address to the Organization for Afro-American Unity: "As long as we think that we should get Mississippi straightened out before

we worry about the Congo, you'll never get Mississippi straightened out." The struggles that happen elsewhere are inseparable from the struggles happening around you, regardless of sphere of influence or geographic distance.



Amidst the rupture of global fragmentation, lies the possibility of authoritarian violence to extract the blood from the injury. Beyond its implications as an expression of totality of unified state and corporate power, fascism is fundamentally a detection condition. Fascism is the stealth mode of a system under duress when its camouflage no longer disguises its face. Institutions do not wear the aesthetic of fascism on the surface, only through the infrared of the night when they can no longer hide their latency behind the telemetry of control. Fascism derives its power from sadomasochism in both sharing and receiving injuries no matter how wounding they are or how powerful the fascist entity is that chooses to injure. In assuming the inertia of piecemeal reformism, George Jackson carefully points out that even on its face, reformism and recuperation serves the fascist spectacle, since reform only repairs the camouflage that a system already cloaks itself with. Jackson refuses, in his own words, to reduce fascism to appearances: "I think our failure to clearly isolate and define it may have something to do with our insistence on a full definition — in other words, looking for exactly identical symptoms from nation to nation." Fascism assumes the boundaries of an interaction can be procedurally suspended by fiat, and can be unraveled by autopsy and not identity; in other words, fascism recognizes only the sociology of its uniforms and the psychology of its machinery. Fascism, as a condition, reconsolidates the vacuum left gyrating in the collapse of stability, and substitutes subjugation as the primary stabilizer. Like all other artificial forms of domination, such as markets or colonialism, fascism actively requires violence and control to maintain itself, because without either of these things, it recognizes that it will dissolve. When the failure mode of a system

and its participants approaches disaster, the fascism latent to an institution does not impose desire on itself, and more often than not will even present as a caregiver to recruit obedience through repression, shame, mystification, and the moralization of authority.



The American prison system will benchmark its public narrative that claims care and safety for the public interest on one hand, while raining down its fist in secrecy on another through the administrative exclusion of care when it needs no such narrative. The former is evidence of a refinery leak, the latter is what the system is actually engineered to do at the scale of what it can get away with. Writing for the Hastings Women's Law Journal in 2002, Amy Petré Hill documents California's own historical track record around incarcerated women in labor: "To put this in perspective, there are pregnant women who will carry and deliver their babies inside the walls of California prisons. Being forced to wait three days, much less three months, for adequate care during pregnancy condemns both the prisoner and an innocent child to unnecessary injury or death. It is irrefutable that there are specific and vital issues concerning women's health care that are intimately time sensitive. In its haste to enact the PLRA, Congress failed to consider how this legislation would interact with poorly written or poorly enforced administrative grievance procedures by state prison systems. As a result, Congress has inadvertently given the CDC the power to kill women inmates and their unborn children through administrative indifference." The prison, within the broader state machinery that houses the prison network, operates deliberately by electing what not to share or receive, which tolerances it can quietly widen without scrutiny, and which tensions within its jurisdiction they can administer. In February 2025 alone, CDCR signed contract #C5611826 using the California State Department of Technology's standard agreement template, receiving over \$189 million dollars to contract out their communication technology to Securus

Technologies, LLC. The contract stipulates asset tracking, retention of telecommunication data for a seven year period, database storage for devices issued to prisoners in the contract, revenue tracking based on the trace call minute metrics, service request protocol for the contractor service desk, documentation of missing call detail records, cost workbooks measured by use case of communication device, and dozens of pages that encompass data retention, exemption clauses, and contingency plans for implementation. CDCR functions through a seemingly inscrutable web of administrative contingencies, any of which would expose the institution if the building could no longer meet its cabling requirements; however, these institutions primarily have their accumulation of resources to protect them. CDCR issued a regulatory action that went into effect in October 2025, stamped by the California Secretary of State, in which their most recent addition to the dangerous contraband list included "wearable technology" such as a "smart device or a smartwatch" sharing its connection with any network. The institution of prison survives through the rear view mirror of the larger state apparatus, and its exclusive access to the logistics network that centralizes communication.



Despite dehumanizing tropes normalized in popular media around prisoners committing sexual violence in shows such as Oz and Sons of Anarchy, the actual metrics on sexual violence convey a completely different story. When looking through the Prison Rape Elimination Act (PREA) reports every year that are published on CDCR's website, the same structure repeats with minimal statistical variation: every reported year, between 2024 and 2015, the PREA data documents staff-on-prisoner sexual violence incidents as the dominant category of reported violent incidents, across facilities and custody levels. The 2023 PREA report even specifies: "In 2022, the number of allegations for Staff on Incarcerated Person Sexual Misconduct was 392. In 2023, the number of allegations for Staff on Incarcerated Person

Sexual Misconduct was 802, which equates to an increase of 105 percent.” Although institutional data receives an audit across an annual review period, the category of “ongoing investigations” spiked from 0 in 2019 to 648 in 2024 for “staff-on-prisoner sexual misconduct”. The substantiation rates of reported incidents also consistently remains stably low, even dropping from 16 in 2019 to 4 in 2024 for “staff-on-prisoner sexual misconduct”, despite claims of PREA compliance and changes of training or leadership, using the same rhetorical framing of one-hour mandatory training across facilities, improved reporting mechanisms, zero tolerance, and commitment to outcomes in future compliance reports. Regardless of the inputs or rhetoric, the grammar of the outputs remains invariant, because the output distribution of sexual violence to prisoners never materially changes in conditions of cross-year stability, cross-facility repetition, and categorical dominance indexed to the adjudicative authority of the carceral system. There is no moral narrative to be found about the depravity of these institutions and their commitment to violating the bodies of prisoners; rather, the proof pipeline of verification, classification, and compliance procedure is endogenous to the source of violence that precipitates the prison landscape. The system reports on itself when it needs to serialize and document the payload of the harm it has already mediated. PREA breaks nothing in this case other than documenting the behavior of the machinery and the expectations of its fiduciary responsibility. The custodial authority of the staff that administrate the prison cannot be redeemed by their own inspection protocols; rather, we could only terminate the machinery of violence by terminating the juridical discretion of the machine that regularizes violence in its custody, and amortizing the machine entirely over the half life of a diminishing fraction. When an institution such as a prison persists only through facilitating the production of violent instability, it already writes its collapse off the books, and the only question at that point is deciding when and how to excise it completely, and how much death is admissible before that termination happens. The continued operation of a prison already budgets for death and

destruction, meaning that moral accounting for postponement happens anyway either explicitly or in silence.



The actual events of a fascist system that testify to harm matter little to the machinery of a fascist system. Fascism can afford to retain administrative indifference because the protocols, classifications, reporting specifications, contractual obligations, and ultimately the policy documents of the regime that signs off on the infrastructure of an institution, all assume jurisdictional invisibility by design. Fascism recognizes its grammar, accepts its outputs, and assumes that keeping up appearances on the surface is just the cost of doing business. Anywhere that power dynamics circulate may expose susceptibility to a fascist regime writ large, and anywhere that the language of care is spoken can also expose a place where care is procedurally excluded. Any system surviving off the routinized violation of people within it does not need moral consensus to survive, given that these systems cannot collapse through reason alone. Sometimes, a system of violence stabilizes through the strategic localization of instability, and changing a system that is operationally stable requires a redistribution of instability when the localized shock absorber no longer participates. This is how fascism, historically in the 20th century configurations, defined the nation state as independent and its participants dependent on the state as a source of legitimacy, as even Mussolini admitted in his own doctrine: "For Fascism the State is absolute, individuals and groups relative." If Durkheim and Bonald were to be reduced to the granular substrate of their social facts thesis, Mussolini then asserts in the administration of state over individuals that there is no pretending to justify with science or religion, only the technology of the state as the only independent entity. States, like national identity, are made up of bundles of constitutive elements that compose the whole. States are not just governments, but also prisons, police, markets, neighborhood associations, nonprofit organizations, and other

institutions that collide on the basis of power and institutional control, predicated on the fiction that the only way to live is to follow their lead and consent to the massive widening gulf between individuals and themselves on the basis of asserting dominance earlier in time. In his letter to Cardinal Fornari, Juan Donoso Cortés asserts in his diagnosis of the collapse of meaning that Catholicism cannot solve collapse through deliberation, and dictatorship transcends narrative identity as emergency intervention when sovereignty has failed its task. Cortés plainly denies that there is any conceptual gap in dictatorship between political authority and theological authority when justifications are no longer externalized, for the syllogism of power dynamics already assumes that only procedure preserves order when moral consensus no longer stabilizes the system without force. Underneath the appearance all of these aforementioned institutions, however, are ordinary people who never wear uniforms but manage the reporting requirements of a system that is working exactly as intended when they no longer mask domination in silence. The ontological incoherence of these masks are known to themselves, and therefore they are desperate to maintain control at all costs, artificially conditioning life to believe itself to be scarce or unrecognizable.



This is why Enlightenment era liberalism has failed to address the problems of the present and ultimately capers to the fascist spectacle without an effective counterweight against it. The medicine of fascism is authority stabilized through extraction of a host, which does not require justification or narrative, only survival tactics and surgical tools when its systemic pathologies are exposed. Liberalism emerged from the era of Westphalian sovereignty in the works of Mill and Humboldt, in which there were not immediate and egregious disparities between individuals and entities such as states and private corporations. The adverbial spectacle of the liberal social order has already begun to erode once systemic scarcity and hunger become a

debate in need of justificatory argument. Mill's harm principle, which outlines a negative constraint on authority, developed in a context of relatively uncomplicated social interactions between civilians and bureaucratic state forms, which begets inversion into justification of legitimized harm as unavoidable tragedy. The Humboltian liberal paradigm diagnoses harm as a cost structure to be managed as if episodic harm is the limit constraint on politics. In the present Westphalian order, harm is just what a system produces as its throughput target when indexed over time, and the maintenance of this system is just the condition for its continuity. In applying Humboldt's Limits of State Action to the present or the future, we assume classical liberalism is in fact, a fatalist fantasy of human rights mediated by an impartial state, under equal liberty and equal law. However, such a state does not exist outside of the imagination of its historical proponents, and there is never such a thing as equal liberty or equality under the law, since liberty and law in such a system are mediated by expressions of low intensity war on its subjects.



When the adage of war as continuation of politics by other means is repeated, we are implicitly accepting that war is what the system produces when intention and personal exposure qualify as sufficient remedy for gratuitous harm. In aviation or nuclear systems, harm invalidates trust as baseline, repetition of harm decommissions the system, and justifications are evidence rather than alibi. These systems proceed from a rigid expectation of decaying legitimacy when harm is predictable and invariant, which no amount of liberal humanitarian rhetoric could ever alleviate beyond the discretion of the state that decides the scope of disposability for those harmed by its systems. The same logic applies to all humans held in captivity by captive systems, whether those systems send them to prison, or debt peonage, or cycles of poverty and homelessness. The symmetry of scale and opportunity dreamed of in the imaginations of liberal intellectuals is an illusion

that has never existed and can never exist as long as the inevitability of harm remains the limit constraint. In such a system of justice mediated by a fictional impartial state, resisting the mosaic of legality as legitimacy thereby instantiates a trespass that undermines the legitimacy of the entire system. Liberal humanism wears the aesthetic of moral standards firmly on its sleeve. Care as a convivial technology develops through what Manual Callahan and Annie Paradise previously called fierce care: the refusal to protect injurious systems through the waiver of intentions. Fierce care as a principle recognizes that care has limits when harm is reproduced as output, those limits of care contain boundaries, and violation of care waives any alibi as a pass for extractive relationships. We assume through this principle that the reproduction of the carceral model in a capitalist world system violates any purchase that its systems attempt to claim on the logic of caregiving, and that care is something that happens as if these systems are set to expire and are unauthorized to participate. Enlightenment era liberalism largely cares how you perform morality, whether through the most convincing argument or most legible civic rite, but it fundamentally cannot confront fascism on its own terms on the epistemic insolvency it expects the world to run on.

PALINTROPOS. 270°



The moment that you treat politics as a dipole (with a pro or anti camp), you automatically entrench the system that you are attempting to dissolve. Dipoles have a positive and a negative charge tethered by stable tension between them, and the dielectric field between them exists only because opposition exists. The abolition of the pathology in a present system occurs only by discharge of the entire coordinate system that the system admits a meaningful bifurcation. Polarity that assumes a fixed duality is also a polarity that assumes tension exists to be held in suspension. This means that you are not pro- or anti-anything you want to replace, you are simply giving yourself permission to work beyond the exit gate. There is no neutral dimension between what you theorize and what you practice in the real world, since your theoretical understanding informs and shapes your relationship to everything around you, even in isolation. There is no hierarchical order between understanding and application. Prometheus bears fire and Sisyphus pushes a boulder because Zeus strikes them all in a flash of thunder. Creativity necessarily participates in its renewal through the ordinary creativity of life. Most importantly, lived experience enables the mirroring of theory and practice. The Johnson-Forest tendency of Marxist humanism in the 20th century articulated and understood this clearly, because they cut through the frigid tundra of Stalinist

totalitarianism and Western capitalism to articulate a uniquely complex perspective rooted in the lived experience of struggle.



The problem of Marxism in the 20th century is that everyone chooses a certain era of Marx's thought to interpret and uphold as the correct interpretation. For the Johnson-Forest tendency, they tended to focus more on Marx's early humanist writing through the Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts of 1844, which situate Marx in his exploration of Hegelian dialectic, the experience of alienation in capitalism, and the need for collective flourishing through communist social organization. By contrast, the Italian left communists, represented by figures such as Bordiga, emphasized the fidelity to both Marx and Lenin, opposing democratic centralism in favor of a "social brain" in which the party maintained the fidelity of the program. Meanwhile, the Dutch left communists, such as Pannekoek, opposed Leninism entirely in favor of a decentralized worker council approach to decision making. The Autonomist tradition, such as Negri and Tronti, tended to focus more on the notion of the "general intellect" from the Fragment of Machines in the Grundrisse, emphasizing the currency of information in a society where the internet formed in generations after.



The problem of applying Marx imprecisely to the 21st century is assuming that the world that Marx writes in is the same world, the same stage of modernity, and the same problems that one lives in today. We cannot temporally displace the dead from their graves and disinter their corpse without situating them in the historical context by which they lived, the problems they diagnosed, and the solutions they offered given their particular resources and structural constraints. Therein, we propose adaptive fidelity— as modernity itself has stages of historical

development that are historically situated, so do the individual theorists that inhabit these periods. All theorists and people generally evolve their views throughout their life, and often in ways that are nonlinear and do not themselves reflect more proximity to truth or relevance to the present, but simply the exploration of all possible field states within their ideas and conceptual models. Marx, for example, has three distinct eras that the aforementioned tendencies tend to gravitate around: his early humanist Young Marx era, his experimental intermediate era of the Grundrisse, and his later writings on scientific socialism along with the volumes on Capital.



Similarly, Fanon and Lacan have their own stages throughout their lives that certain readers tend to gravitate around or pull from based on their circumstances. Early stage Lacan explores the mirror stage and the imaginary, whereas later stages of Lacan more explicitly focused on the language of the unconscious as well as *jouissance*. Fanon's earlier *Black Skin, White Masks* era is more situated in the exploration of the psychology of colonial domination, and his later *Wretched of the Earth* era focuses more on the questions of insurgency and liberation struggle. However, these different eras, given their unique stages of personal and historical development that these theorists lived in, often present a continuum of works that are in dialogue with each other, and by extension, dialogue with the reader. Thus, they benefit from the flexibility of integrating across eras and registers to the specific historical context that the present occupies, as opposed to a rigid sectarian orthodoxy that argues for a singular fidelity of method while dismissing others as revisionist. Fidelity is often more field-situated rather than chronological, posing a question of how the present may have dimensions or features that resonate more closely with a specific era of a theorist rather than assuming all eras are equally applicable in some eclectic relativism or isolated from each other in linear chronology.



All of these aforementioned tendencies, despite their own distinct benefits and vantage points, stoke core tensions because the evidence based practices and relational questions of how to organize against the scarcity of a capitalist society vary in the historical context of the societies in which these different tendencies developed, which themselves do not hold a candle to how many times Maoist and Stalinist parties in the Eastern Bloc and PRC-affiliated states have splintered and broke their wrist over revisionism and suspected betrayal to the social organizations they created. They also do not hold a match for the candle in how many times these tendencies, by forcing or even exploring the questions of how to optimally organize for a better world, were brutally sidewinded by sectarian infighting and ersatz compromises on deeper structural transformations that need to be made. The workers movement of the 20th century has been defanged and demilitarized through the centralization of labor aristocracy, and even if it were to defiantly resurrect itself from the dual track fronts of the organized elite and disorganized society, it would be just one of many classes of living beings to politicize into decisive organization and action. What the tensions here reveal is that regardless of commitment to fidelity towards a specific political program or doctrine, theory is always lived, and social knowledge either circulates or withers as the relationships and expertise we build through struggle mirror the world we build through struggle. When we build a map of how social organization develops and how expertise is reciprocally shared and circulated, there is always a probabilistic risk of failure by some force external to our own, but we also recognize this is a more generative success than passively accepting internalized defeat by failing to reproduce either relationships or expertise.



Although Lenin's legacy is mostly poisoned by the legacy of the USSR and the power vacuum exploited through the Great Purge, the late bookend of Lenin's career remains an open question. Lenin has spent most of his time in the context of the Russian Revolution deciphering the essential formula of how change is executed and sustained. Early Lenin, as depicted in "What Is To Be Done?" focused on the tactical question of seizing control of the state, in his case, through an organized proletariat. Later in his career, as "State and Revolution" was disseminated, the question shifted because the transition of the Bolsheviks already happened, and the question was then about how to dissolve the need for a state by diffusing decision making and skill sharing through a decentralized council model that respected local knowledge and decision making that was situated to local context despite nonlocal mediation. Towards the latest end of Lenin's tenure, he wrote marginalia in his personal notebooks on Hegel in what he attempted to conceptualize about how change becomes self-sustaining and self-sufficient without the armor of crude historical materialism weighing it down. Lenin wrote initially in his notebook: "It is impossible completely to understand Marx's Capital...without having thoroughly studied and understood the whole of Hegel's Logic. Consequently, half a century later none of the Marxists understood Marx!" Had Lenin articulated any of these thoughts publicly while also alive in the mid-century USSR after Stalin passed, he would have probably been tried and flushed out by the party leadership he created for being too idealist and revisionist. Trotsky's ideological pipeline to latent neoconservatism and Stalin's brutal dictatorship would've looked severely antiquated if the organizing logic of a post-revolutionary society had circled around the prototypical systems theory that Lenin was articulating but never fully crystalized in his lifetime.



The accusations of idealism were actually what ended up happening to Evald Ilyenkov, who continued this thread left as raw material

in Lenin's notebook, and proceeded to articulate a philosophy that was emancipated from the materialist teleology that once constrained Lenin in his tactical questions about how to organize society without replicating old methods and pathologies. Ilyenkov's core distillation can be summarized through his notion of an objective idealism: "The ideal is the form of the object that exists outside of the object, in human activity." We extend this notion beyond just the subtle subject-object idealism towards a parallax view of the ideal as a structuring force that mediates the field of all relationships, whether they are human or nonhuman, animal and biome, or tree and fungus. The ancient bristlecone pines of the Great Basin in the Eastern Sierras of California stayed erect for over 5,000 years, and remain the oldest living non-clonal organisms on the planet. The Methuselah tree has far outlived the development of human linguistic syntax in terms of its capacity for resilience, adaptation, and self-preservation despite extreme constraints over millennia. This tree is a form whose generative pattern exists completely outside of itself in the arid climate, soil topography, microbiome, and passage of time. We should assume that information and its transformation are inseparable, socially mediated, and self-moving as an asymptotic process that encompasses all possible transformations and all flows of information that harmonize or distort reality. The ideal is just a structural mediating logic that operates on all appropriate scales of local phenomena. This also reveals that the notion of a revolution or revolutionary subject is an emergent field of transformation that becomes apparent through self-organization rather than through a fixed identity, runaway symbolic excess, or rigid organizational structure.



The questions of locating the revolutionary subject are fundamentally different now, not just because of the transition from production to coordination failure, but because they were always an open question about a moving target. If you refuse to accept the subject-object

distinction, the notion of a revolutionary subject ceases to become coherent, because now you navigate questions about revolutionary process and revolutionary self-generation in a continuous dynamic field. Sylvain Marechal wrote in the Manifesto of the Equals in 1796: "The French Revolution is nothing but the precursor of another revolution, one that will be greater, more solemn, and which will be the last." Marechal and Gracchus Babeuf understood that any revolutionary event is a prelude to a continuous historical and cultural process. Babeuf argued for something more primordial and invariant that purposefully had no party or faction: "Disappear at last, revolting distinctions between rich and poor, great and small, masters and servants, rulers and ruled." The corridor of French Revolutionary thought that included Evariste Galois and Gracchus Babeuf was not prescribing any medium for revolution through the movement of revolutionary republican thought, because no such labels existed until after their time, but also because he sensed that there was a world in which egalitarianism preceded domination, and that life itself was the first commons. The Conspiracy of the Equals proposed a phase inversion into a world that collapsed the concept of sovereignty entirely, diffusing the radical republic as the symmetry of the world system. This is the conspiracy that Babeuf wrote for: egalitarianism as felt cosmic order, the republic as the mediator of universal knowledge and mutual aid, and global sovereignty through shared conditions. Egalitarianism, like gravity or matter, does not negotiate. Against this limit condition, Jacques Roux looks prescient: the First Republic, in spite of rebalancing the clerical regime, was dephased as out of order even when material asymmetry only ever returns to collect its debts. Material reorganization occurs within the delay window of intervention rather than outside of it, and coercion loses its purchase when disparity is held in suspension.



What remains unspoken about Babeuf is precisely the stakes raised in his proposition that any deviation from equality of conditions

necessitates a dismantling of the possibility that deviations could occur. Babeuf expresses a lens of equality that would be unsettling to anyone seeking to dilute it, by grounding equality in necessity, ethical symmetry, and the constraints of nature that authorize excess for nobody. Babeuf does not mythologize equality or means required to impose equality, leaving ultimately no escape hatch to the consequences of his worldview beyond the process of a revolutionary transition as a purely procedural activity in its refusal to tolerate moral surplus. When read alongside Louis Auguste Blanqui, another theorist often pigeonholed by competing interpretations, they present a theory of change that remains inexorable by its lack of romance; in fact, Blanqui does not assume that history, ethics, or social development will ever do the work of revolution for anyone, and accepting that assumes more honesty about what revolutionary changes require if neither masses nor parties can come to the rescue. If we are to take Blanqui at his word, we would find that he states this clearly in his late meditations on astronomy: "One cannot demand the impossible from nature. The uniformity of its method is visible everywhere and precludes the existence of infinite and exclusively original creations. Its number is bound in principle by the very finite number of the simple bodies. They are, as it were, type-combinations, whose endless repetitions fill up space. Different, differentiated, distinct, primordial, original, special, all these words express the same idea and therefore, to us, they are synonyms with the expression type-combinations. Establishing their number would be a task that algebra could fulfill if only the lack in data didn't make the problem indeterminate, that is to say unsolvable. Besides, this indeterminacy is not equivalent to the infinite any more than it leads into it." Blanqui argues that in the context of all possible outcomes, the cosmos is spatially infinite but combinatorially finite, and all configurations within this space recur endlessly. Without modern scientific tooling, Blanqui realized through his own lived knowledge that recurrence is a stochastic expression of finite-state transitions in an infinite domain, where time is on

nobody's side and no alibis exist that privilege one outcome or event over another.



As a consequence, there are no teleological guarantees of history or legitimacy that can comfortably defer themselves to future conditions, let alone any expectation that the universe ever fully resolves all of its contradictions. Blanqui does not pretend that equality or reason produce rupture on their own, and if history were to vindicate anything, we can observe more often than not that paradigm shifts in history have proceeded frequently from the concerted efforts of rupture not always obliged by mass movements or democratic process, even if made visible by them later. When read this way, Blanqui does not present a theory of insurrection as a fantasy scenario, but instead more closely resembles a ritual practice of indefinite preparedness that does not depend on institutional follow through or historical development. Blanqui does not position legitimacy as justification, and in fact assumes transformation could be perceived as illegible before it is perceived as morally sober. Together with Babeuf, both currents of thought approach a posture that if total transformation is necessary, it will be fought for unceremoniously and without spectacle, because on the other side of the transformation of the world, power has changed hands without a narrative of redemption or heroism. If we are to treat Babeuf's demands seriously, then equality becomes non-negotiable, presenting a limit condition on politics itself rather than a program; in Babeuf's case, there is not a moment in time when equality is achieved or when inequality accumulates that results in the dust settling. By refusing to naturalize inequality or confuse justice with temperance, Babeuf treats equality as something that renders brutality as utterly juridical and administrative in its commitment to egalitarian continuity. Equality then becomes an operator that generates obligations, and the price of obeying those obligations only becomes transparent when we refuse to lie about the cost structure.

The needle that threads Babeuf and Blanqui in thought can be traced back to Étienne de La Boétie, who makes a point as far back as the 16th century, before we ever considered the idea of revolutionary subjectivity, that tyranny as a condition is fragile. Boétie clarifies that power depends on habituated coordination and the infrastructure of obedience rather than possession, legitimacy, or ideological appeal: “Obviously there is no need of fighting to overcome this single tyrant, for he is automatically defeated if the country refuses consent to its own enslavement: it is not necessary to deprive him of anything, but simply to give him nothing; there is no need that the country make an effort to do anything for itself provided it does nothing against itself.” Boétie does not abstractly muse about liberty or servitude, instead posing the only remaining question after all alibis are disposed of: why do people consent to structures that do not need to exist if nature does not exceptionalize anyone? The revolutions up until the present have not assumed domination of the status quo as a metaphysical foundation for the world, and have instead acted without any guarantees. The distinction between the revolutions in America and Europe lie acutely in the legacy of settler colonialism and the pressures of enclosure – the fertility of revolutionary thought in France and Germany was guided by the adaptive pressures of bottlenecked access to land absent of freehold tenure by the wealthy, whereas the American frontier was considered the guiding ethos by which the newly arrived colonists could carve out their enduring legacy by the afterlives of slavery and manifest destiny. It is also important to note the stark contrast in the historical development of organized causes: The perspective of Marx and Engels were shaped in part by the structural conditions of Germany, a major European power that, unlike Britain or France, lacked overseas colonies during their lifetime and did not have frontier opportunities comparable to those in the Americas or the Antipodes. Germany’s rapid industrialization concentrated labor in cities, but access to land was tightly constrained by entrenched fee simple

property systems and the transition between feudalism to Gründerzeit in the German Empire, marked by corporate consolidation and stock market volatility.



In contrast, settler colonies such as the United States, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand offered relatively abundant land for European settlers, to which they expropriated from indigenous populations through violent dispossession and cultural expunging. The imposition of slave colonies and sugar plantations in the Caribbean represented a particularly heinous conflagration by which the European colonies converged both slavery and colonial rule in highly remote, isolated territories that were uniquely susceptible to exploitation by geographic scale and proximity, enabling an exceptionally brutal machinery of settler-colonial control. Within the Russian Empire, the particular task of the revolutionary movements was similar in scope to that of Germany – the vast majority of Russia’s population was agrarian and rural despite Russia’s own colossal landmass, and revolutionary momentum was galvanized through mobilizing the peasant population against the monarchy, as well as the entrenched feudal order that concentrated land title into the clergy. Throughout this constellation of empires and settler colonies, the entire structure was glued together through legal systems that enforced the sovereignty of private property and the interests of the landed aristocracy. Pliny the Elder echoed this malady in presaging the collapse of Ancient Rome: “The latifundia (landed estates) have ruined Italy, and are now proving to be the ruin of the provinces.” It was easy for the American slave owners in particular to position themselves against the British when they perceived themselves as having an endless expanse of land to occupy and perceive the current indigenous stewards of that land as not being human enough to remain on the land or to learn from their relationship to it. However, these distinctions did not compromise the epistolary channels between consecutive insurgent movements, by

which not only did the Karl Marx write on behalf of the International Workingmen's Association to Abraham Lincoln in the onset of the Civil War, Lincoln's ambassador also responded in kind: "Nations do not exist for themselves alone, but to promote the welfare and happiness of mankind by benevolent intercourse and example. It is in this relation that the United States regard their cause in the present conflict with slavery, maintaining insurgence as the cause of human nature, and they derive new encouragements to persevere from the testimony of the workingmen of Europe that the national attitude is favored with their enlightened approval and earnest sympathies." The phrase "insurgence as the cause of human nature" remains the key element here: these were completely separate causes that chose to coalesce and correspond with one another through the shared solidarity of all liberatory struggles regardless of their local contingencies towards a "reconstruction of a social world," as Marx wrote in his original letter.



What we think of as insurgencies or uprisings are just historical course corrections about a broken system in which collective harm begets a collective response to harm in the problem space of self-sufficient organization. Insurgencies in this context do not necessarily seize infrastructure to coordinate activity as a predetermined end goal; in fact, they diagnose the fault zone by which symbolic abstraction outruns lived material normativity and they decide to close the gap. In the case of the French Revolution, the Jacobins were a historical contingency that completely disrupted the entire fiction of a divine right of kings that previously seemed unshakeable because it was previously enforced as unthinkable. Even just local articulations from the peasantry that exposed the delusion of such a system were summarily crushed, whether they were through the Diggers of England, the plural cosmology of Giordano Bruno, or the lunar cheese of Menocchio. Marx even adds a footnote to this question in the Dietz Archives: "Has anyone ever accused the early Christians of aiming at

the overthrow of some obscure Roman prefect? The Prussian political philosophers from Leibniz to Hegel have laboured to dethrone God, and if I dethrone God I also dethrone the king who reigns by the grace of God. But has anyone ever prosecuted them for lèse-majesté against the house of Hohenzollern?" Every local expression of the world system throughout history has thought about how broken the system is and how to replace it, and every authoritarian institution in the world system has thought of how to enforce the unthinkability of replacing the system, even if the cost of enforcing this foreclosure completely dissolves under scrutiny. It's not about understanding Marx or Hegel with perfect fidelity, but about understanding how to move beyond explanatory schema as gospel or the social dimensions of conflict as fixed grammar, regardless of the models a theorist gives you. If a problem's boundaries remain ambiguous rather than precisely defined, the debt of this ambiguity compounds until the cost of resolution becomes exceedingly prohibitive. The concepts of "left" and "right" wing ideologies in politics, for example, are just discrete artifacts from the post-Revolutionary parliament of France, in which the physical placement from the seating chart designated your ideological coordinates. Revolutions are not concepts run afoul in which you are marked perpetually as a terrorist because that's what a state designates you as when you revolt. They're actually just tactical questions about how to get to the root of the problem in which your full sovereignty is externally violated in perpetuity, whether by a market, patriarch, settler-colony, or an empire. Any structure that forbids the cessation of obedience, under conditions of coordinated failure, begets the necessity of coercion for its persistence.



What we propose is inside-outside solidarity: building a mutually reinforcing process in which the inside collectively exits and the outside convivially builds. Those inside the maws of the institutions, whether they are the captives of the prisons or the administrative

halls, exit by refusing to uphold the legitimacy of the institutions and coordinating inside context for shared outside knowledge. By exit, this does not imply physically leaving an oppressive institution as escapism, but about refusing consent to oil the gears of the machine by organized refusal of legitimacy within the machine. This strategy is a closed loop approach to change, in which seizing the central command is one approach of many rather than the penultimate approach. How we think of dual power is less about organizing to seize a party or an institutional structure and more about how to prefigure the system that renders their entire paradigm completely obsolete. In other words, it is not a contest over seizing broken institutions or systems and fixing them with more principled leadership, but about developing the next system to metabolize the obsolescence of the old system. The practice is built and scaled interactively, and the halls of power may attempt to bargain power back on their own terms, but they ultimately follow where power dynamics are reorganized. This requires the transition into the next world to come with builders of the architecture rather than just conjectures about why the old architecture failed, and everyone shares responsibility for building the next system in accordance to their own potential and constraints. What we are building instead of just imprecise revolutionary seizure is a practice of mutual apprenticeship, in which expertise is scaffolded in a way that encourages shared development, shared knowledge, and convivially generated technology, building the next world to flourish as the old one slowly decays.



At its core, this practice is the connective tissue that translates covariant forms of collective organization—whether a party, a union, or a cadre— by way of a coordinated pedagogy rather than a popular front or a big-tent coalition. The work of a movement judges itself over time, and the expansion of social life persists through what survives transmission. A collective social form knows one lasting gesture: the *ars technica* of cultivating a movement

that constructs, transmits, and repairs collective capacity given the decisions that flow outward from the work. This connective tissue is not an umbrella for grandfathered institutions or nested power dynamics, but instead a scaffold for the very method, structure, and cohesion through which collective activity emerges, self-organizes, and adapts across scales. Democratic process and organizational composition are not contingent on whether this method is applied unless an organization prefers those tools internally, since those tools may facilitate coordinated activity within an organization that chooses. Organizational systems committed to movement development function through precise clarity of a shared code and a shared epistemic discipline amongst those who voluntarily associate, scaffolding for participation that determines what is materially necessary based on the commitments of participants. The code of an organization functions as glue through its core unifications, operating as boundary conditions to stabilize collective action. Organizational systems proceed from how they mediate continuity of knowledge and interpersonal repair given the admissibility of all possible moves an organization can act upon. This is not an ideology or a party to join, but a structural process about how change actually happens and how bridges are built across coalitions. Instead, one builds the ambient mesh architecture on the topography of the soil itself, creating a system that lifts everyone through the rising sea, rather than a boat with limited capacity. This approach reveals that we change the problem by changing the framework that the problem rests on, rather than raging against systemic logical constraints that will never accommodate you in your fullness and complexity. The creation of the next world begets a prefigurative system through shared activity and convivial development of infrastructure rather than concessions to the terrain of power.



The act of refusal is how maroonage during the height of the slave trade presented the most threatening leverage against both

the imperialist colonial administration of England and the settler colonial slavocracy of the American plantation. Maroon communities presented a bottom-up reclamation of autonomous social life that deserted the state of captivity that was enforced by slavery-driven societies across the Atlantic. Orlando Patterson observed in Jamaica, for example, the 18th century import of slaves and European colonists created a particularly strained chain of conflagrations throughout the century marked by armed conflict between organized slaves and white colonists. After one such treaty was attempted between the Leeward Maroon signatories and the white colonists, embitterment ensued: "The slave population, however, was not prepared to take the treaty lying down. A mood of restlessness ran like a quake through it. They complained, with cutting irony, that freedom had been granted to those who had rebelled, while the mass of the loyal continued to suffer enslavement. More directly, they viewed with great alarm the elimination of the only real avenue of escape from the barbarity of their masters. Dissatisfaction "grew to such a height among them", that throughout the island, but especially in Spanish Town (St. Jago), they gathered into groups where they made preliminary plans for revolt. The restive and mutinous spirit increased in intensity with each moment." George Rawick describes what this looked like at scale amongst slaves in America that politicized as a class during the Civil War: "Either the oppressed continuously struggle in forms of their own choosing or they are defeated by life. Only they can know what they can and must do. The black community, slave and free, South and North, made itself, and in so doing brought about the abolition of slavery. It did this not out of a belief in ideological abstractions, but out of a felt inner necessity. Only when the slaves, through their own struggles, saw the necessity and possibility of freedom, could they struggle to overcome, to transcend that bondage. The slaves went from being frightened human beings, thrown among strange men, including fellow slaves who were not their kinsmen and who did not speak their language or understand their customs and habits, to what W. E. B. DuBois once described as the general strike whereby hundreds of thousands of

slaves deserted the plantations, destroying the South's ability to supply its army." The organized slave revolts throughout history understood that the autonomous rights of slaves could not be won by appealing to the state or industry, but by generating autonomy from the inside out, allowing slave societies to break free from enforced timeless captivity through an emergent futurity that only they could force the hand of the world to accept. By collective spiritual kinship that slaves developed through building collective leverage as a politicized class, they demonstrated that among the largest threats to their captors was through collectively bargaining against the American slavocracy by force and by mass desertion, no longer consenting to waiting on the slave master's clock for a change of conscience that never came.



In terms of the concept of refusal, the distinction between an individual boycott and systemic boycott requires a necessary intervention. Individual boycotts – that is, policing others and establishing individual moral standards over specific consumption choices – are insufficient at best and dangerous at worst. Boycotts at the systemic level are supply chain disruptions, ranging from coordinated collective action, targeting the chokeholds of the supply chain, and creating collective bargaining leverage against institutional power wherever it rests unadorned. The measure of any boycott can be captured in the pressure and leverage the boycott creates, not just by escapism but also by forcing the hand of where power actually flows in the global economy, in the freight lines, the shipping routes, and the logistical chokepoints themselves. Systemic boycotts are periodically slow, deliberate, coordinated, and require a spiritual practice of building infrastructure, self-organization of people as a class against their captors, and creative convergence of strategy and implementation. The ubiquity of individual boycotts as a strategy signifies a severe lack of strategy, and in some ways signifies total defeat. Jasper Bernes emphasizes, with the integration of supply chain logistics,

capitalism is no longer a fight on a single shop floor but a struggle against a planetary-wide factory system that monopolizes coordination by enforcing mass squalor: “The weak tactics of the present – the punctual riot, the blockade, the occupation of public space – are not the strategic product of an antagonist consciousness that has misrecognised its enemy, or failed to examine adequately the possibilities offered by present technologies. On the contrary, the tactics of our blockaders emerge from a consciousness that has already surveyed the possibilities on offer, and understood, if only intuitively, how the restructuring of capital has foreclosed an entire strategic repertoire. The supply chains which fasten these proletarians to the planetary factory are radical chains in the sense that they go to the root, and must be torn out from the root as well. The absence of opportunities for “reconfiguration” will mean that in their attempts to break from capitalism proletarians will need to find other ways of meeting their needs. The logistical problems they encounter will have to do with replacing that which is fundamentally unavailable except through linkage to these planetary networks and the baleful consequences they bring.” Strategically, counterlogistics goes beyond a single boycott of a multinational firm or institutional target, and extends into the entire planetary nexus by which the machinery to coordinate global flourishing is provably available but the access to this machinery and the knowledge to circulate its use are both deliberately hoarded. These are strategic questions about building infrastructure and network logistics now that actually do serve everyone, not neutralize a specific opponent in hopes that the leviathan of capital will suddenly collapse.



Even within the question of organizing, the dual power model assumes that changing the symbolic composition of power will rearrange the material composition absent any modification in rule or resource distribution. Revolutionary interventions, at minimum, follow a joint

phase format: in rupture phases, disciplined cores function as crack initiators and transient amplifiers that open the gate to discontinuity. A core organizational structure is not necessarily a vanguard nor a commune, nor does its format depend on a specific representational composition; rather, it depends only on modulating the amplitude of friction under load. Whenever a revolution occurs, there is always a renormalization phase with finite relaxation time, in which damping is mediated by core organizational structure and networked social systems to coordinate the distribution of amplified shock during the phase transition. Within the renormalization phase, resource redistribution and dissipation produce a joint load responsibility that damps oscillation, redistributes stress, and preserves viability for the next phase. Any revolution is costly when it occurs, and an intervention that maintains the constraints and material distribution of the previous system without a stabilizing process for infrastructure results only in eventual conflagration. Even at a microdynamic level, social friction functionally echoes ecological friction where damping of volatility does not proportionately respond to instability. Choosing to malign and police individuals over their individual consumption choices does a lot of the surveillance work for surveillance technology, while creating minimal leverage in challenging power beyond periodic declines in stock prices which are assumed risk for the stock market anyway. David Graeber calls this interpretive labor: The affective work of having to decipher the intent and impact of individual behavioral choices within ourselves or others in a self-imposed bureaucracy of rule following. This strategy reproduces an old tactic from the 1944 field manual created by US intelligence, and in particular, the eighth and last tactic for how to sabotage the productivity of any organization: "Be worried about the propriety of any decision." We see this logic playing out everywhere in society in how we police the propriety of our individual consumption choices, whether they revolve around how one eats, where one goes shopping, and which analog or digital tools are ethical to use based on who implements them. These choices assume there are no disparities in conditions between classes of people which would create a structured

bias on how they navigate the social problems of the world, and that there are certain choices they can make by individual boycotts which they can afford to make in their own lives. The pattern is often the same: distill structural problems into individual moral choices, atomize individuals based on their consumption choices, and paralyze us against the structures of power which go unencumbered from building and maintaining infrastructure because they do not have the constraints that everyone else puts on their conscience. The key of refusal is fundamentally about leverage, rather than appealing to the conscience of power and assuming they will surrender to the goodwill of moral atomism. The rule of systemic fascism knows how to build and act without any ethical restraint, and those who seek to confront them can either choose not to burden themselves or resign to their own devices.



War is a system state indicating prior failure, in which the procedural mechanisms to maintain the prior configuration of order collapse and violence becomes the only operating mode to rebalance the scales. Any asymmetry of power should assume periodic war as the logistics of doing business, when the existing order of operations cannot reproduce itself without violence and residue. Clausewitz's position on war is actually more modest by insisting that war continues politics as a rational instrument of diplomacy; in fact, by the time war has escalated, politics is already over. War is the persistence of procedural breakdown by the aegis of brute force. We can assume that, forsaking conditions of material equality between nodes in a system, war is just deferred maintenance procedure of the symbolic order, and systems will reproduce violence as logistics if they cannot reproduce themselves peacefully. Any global system is really only as stable as the least stable or open local node in relation to the wider network. Should the lived experiences of one community in how they self-organize their resources and knowledge be externally contained

or processed as meaningless, the possibility for distortion extends through the entire network. How we think of ideological labels and their own symbolic baggage contributes to this lens, especially as we discern between the moving targets of ideology and the logistical architecture of power. The forms of material circulation are everywhere across the global continuum through seaports, freight lines, rail yards, and air cargo warehouses, but there also persist forms of circulation that are captured by monopolistic control of information technology along with logistics, through communication tools, personal devices, and enterprise hardware. It is no secret that communication is now a chokehold predominantly through proprietary black box cloud data architecture and surveillance machinery, and no value is necessarily being produced by these communication bottlenecks, given that value is generated from monopoly access over communication technology. The tactical consideration here is that the global supply chain is trending away from just-in-time (JIT) lean production techniques with minimal inventory overhead and towards military style resilience and procurement strategy by investing in buffers and warehouses, aspiring to keep supply chain logistics reliable and redundant rather than just efficient. Data centers and Amazon warehouses are filled with consolidated resources and information, and exclude access to all by controlling access to both vectors of coordination. Thus, we should not anticipate proprietary data and supply chain inventory to diffuse coordination capacity unless this capacity for resource autonomy is built without asking for permission from the state or industry.



The centralization of the global supply chain does not signify stability or efficiency, especially given the exposure by the COVID-19 pandemic that the global supply chain admits excessive fragility in its industrial centralization and adaptation to climate or pandemic. The vertical consolidation of power and capital in the global supply chain is also its most salient liability, given that distributed organized response came

from people reflexively coordinating amongst themselves rather than through the logistics conglomerates of multinational corporations. The constellation of merged corporate power functions purely on extraction from the planet and exploitation of living systems, and thus in financial crises, supply chain exposures, or public health pandemics, they are willing to submit the public to a mass ritual sacrifice for the sacrament of financial stability and shareholder value. The corporations and states choosing acceptable thresholds of death and destitution through pandemics, natural disasters, and financial panics were not immediately considering neutral calculations of risk exposure as a class, they were prioritizing a liturgy redeemed through renormalization of the symbolic order. Not unlike how the United States is the one country where personal bankruptcy is engineered to operate as a conversion rite of procedural guilt for individual moral failure, political singularities in the modern world system are auditions in a ritual sortition carnival of social death. By absolving themselves as a desacralized priesthood, they decided amongst themselves how many lives and which lives could be offered to the calendar of ritual sacrifice so that their ecclesiastical authority persists. If we are to consider that that thought is the embodiment of history, and that learning is inseparable from the pedagogy of adaptation, then it is also imperative for us to consider the current history of thought around models of learning and pedagogy, given that how we nurture feedback as an individual form is connected to how an organized cause nurtures feedback as a social form.



The teacher-student dyad is a historical artifact of a system that needed to scale instruction under conditions of asymmetry. When the pretense of testing and gradated academic hierarchy is stripped away, learning becomes a shared exposure to inquiry in motion, and this practice does not require a classroom to manage, only a participation in social life. The current models of critical pedagogy literature familiar to educators and facilitators in the Western world, often through

examples like Paulo Freire and bell hooks, will often elaborate on who teaches, in Freire's case of dissolving the teacher/student dichotomy, or what to teach, in the case of bell hooks's method of education as a tool for inspiring students to challenge oppressive power structures. There is often a very stark separation between the methodology of social organization, the pedagogy of social organization, and the power asymmetries of social organization, and often these problems are compartmentalized by who controls resources, who has power, and who has access to knowledge. Academic departments, for example, are not prioritized how to organize one's workplace or how to socially organize and develop methodology for the practice of liberating society from squalor. Organizational science is a tool that often carries favor in business school curriculum or military theory, because it often entails access to insider knowledge on how to maintain control over bargaining or leverage against spontaneity or knowledge from below. The stepwise coordination of problem solving around hunger, austerity, and autonomy through joint activity is something we transport through binding form and action.



A salient limitation in the Western linguistic and semiotic tradition prioritizes semiosis as symbol interpretation. In fact, from Peirce to Saussure and even Derrida, semiotics is very much a linguistic universe: a practice of interpretation, of symbols, and the dichotomy between the signifier and the signified. Within certain segments of the mid-century Soviet underground, following the work of theorists such as Ilyenkov and Vygotsky, a different type of understanding emerged in which semiotics was object-first and symbolic reference second. Felix Mikhailov, in his own work on investigating the social genesis of the self through activity, writes: "The "language" of objects, things and practical actions, the "language of real life", which brings people together and guides their efforts to attain a common goal, has objectified the purpose of every object in its structure, in

its “substance”. Only the person who acts practically, who first in movement, in the life-activity of his organism, copies the substantial properties of a thing and, secondly, organises his behaviour accordingly, coordinates it with the actions of other people and together with them uses the object for its proper purpose can really understand this “objective meaning”, understand why this or that social object is needed. This is the first and extremely important aspect of the complex objective reality that we call society and that the individual is obliged to assimilate (even if at first it only presents itself to him as articles of household use). The second (no less important) aspect of material social being is the complex of sound (and other) signalling media by which people communicate.” Mikhahilov emphasizes a pre-linguistic semiotics of coordination that happens when people coordinate through tools and practical objects rather than just through language alone. Along with Ilyenkov and the likes of Batishchev, this entire psychological corpus of activity theory explores how an object encodes a pattern language of coordination through its material form. In some ways how certain outfits or articles of clothing shape our silhouette or impact how we move through garments, the shape of a tool such a hammer or drill shapes the coordination protocol for how one hammers or drills.



With the advancement of the internet and the ubiquity of computers, coordination bifurcates between analog tools and digital tools; for example, an analog film camera shapes how one coordinates taking photos by limiting the photographer based on manual viewfinder settings and finite exposures per film roll and darkroom access, whereas a digital camera may have far fewer of these restrictions, shaping the protocol of taking photographs by removing technological constraints, forcing the photographer to practice discretion in how they select for which photos best represent the ideal image they want to capture through the concrete act of photography. Ekaterina

Vasilyeva points out as an extension of this principle that photography already violates the primacy of the distinction between signifier and signified through the use of a camera, given that the creation of a photograph can include a structure of multidimensional information without reducing semiosis to linguistic interpretation. A camera still can structurally coordinate the process of meaning-making without the dependency of a perceptual system on linear or sequential logic. Through these approaches, we learn how to enact and encode the pattern that the form of the object demands, and converse through ourselves with the object by expanding upon the existing pattern languages that may be possible through the object. This extends beyond just instruments, for example, in how we may think of social space; the chair is not so much signified by being a chair, as much as we sit together in chairs and where these chairs are located throughout the room, which is why a gathering will always be shaped in conversation with how the furniture in a room is arranged. The movement and sensorimotor resonance comes before the linguistic speech in this sense, and the symbolic language we speak may therefore serve as a way for us to transcribe what we learned in our interactions with the environment and its available tools.



The framework of active coordination before verbal speech in the process of semiosis is fragmented and fairly limited in various theories of psychology and mind, although multiple models have circled around this insight. Varela's work on enactive cognition approximates this model of emergent cognition from sensorimotor patterns, but emphasizes the structural coupling of cognition and environment rather than just the stepwise model of the brain as a computational device that can be linearly optimized. Ernst von Glasersfeld's radical constructivism gets closer to this framework by emphasizing that one's experience is held primary in how knowledge is constructed, creating space for learning through correspondence

with the world while embodying one's lived experience as the process of creating models for reality rather than having to discover reality post hoc. The Kharkov School of Psychology is one of the deeper threads connected directly to the activity theorists of the time, emphasizing pure materialism in object relations as opposed to any idealist conceptions of consciousness or will. Galperin defines psychology in shockingly categorified terms, where cognition develops through transformed relationships between subject and environment rather than subject and object alone. More specifically, Galperin articulated a developmental model of "stages of action formation" that diagrams actions from: material-external to materialized-external to perceptual to verbal-external to verbal-internal to mental-internal. More generally, this is a dependently typed feedback loop that diagrams how a living system metabolizes contradictions that they perceive visibly from outside their perception and process internally through an invisible reception. Galperin even predates interpretive frame semantics decades early with the Orientation Basis of Action model, in which he requires all psychological actions to be structurally coupled with a semiotic orientation schema to autologically organize the relational field that activities are oriented in.



These psychological approaches cease to be psychology in the material brain sense and start to resemble prototypical models of human-computer interaction before the term was coined. Zinchenko, for example, emphasizes a mechanistic approach to distributed cognition through the separation between the conscious action of using a tool and the unconscious operation of automating how a tool is routinely used through pattern recognition, in which the practice of using a tool repeatedly imparts us with the deterministic outcome implied in mastering it. The psychology of adaptation, implied through how one emphasizes material objects or conscious thought as a way of learning activity, was very much a contested topic even at this

era, in terms of the broader debates about whether to emphasize idealism or materialism, or to hold them both in conversation with one another. Vygotsky recognized, for example, that meaning emerges in conjunction with our tool use through our connections with others and how we collaborate through each other and build shared meaning through social interaction. Learning through embodiment gives you a chain of feedback: we encounter the world(through tools, spaces, protocols, constraints), we replicate the form of the world in our own continuous movement(the practice of coordination), we coordinate in relation to others around building shared practices for what we use, and language then emerges as a reference point to coordination, interpretable through signs, reference materials, translations, and affect. We are always coordinating no matter how we socially organize a space and organize a social movement, and our practice of coordination can either build shared protocols or withhold them from others. What distinguishes this framework from other known forms of pedagogy is that this is entirely horizontal, and thus can be taught to anyone and shareable to everyone. This coordination-first pedagogy is not a lecture because it doesn't emphasize linguistic processing, it's not a vanguard party because it doesn't emphasize fidelity to doctrine and a party rule, it's not an academic seminar because it doesn't emphasize a concept, and it's not a corporate case study because it's not emphasizing a slide deck.



There are, however, limitations in focusing purely on activity as the metric of a self-moving organization. Even amongst the activity theorists, Batischev broke from the materialist semiotics by planting a more measured injunction against pure, mechanistic determinism and teleological approaches to development: how do you actually accommodate reception for spontaneity, stochasticity, and frankly, creative unplanned encounter as opposed to just transforming someone through focus-tested activity-based learning? In the 1990s, Batischev began to

write about the "limits of the activity category" by describing the need for meaning-making to involve creativity, culture, relationships, and the act of being with other people through our encounters with them. Underneath this cultural and historical approach, Batishev generalizes an object or tool beyond just their property to a category of distributed relationships within a dynamic activity ecosystem. The meaning of an object develops first through its functional semiotic distribution within the activity system that the object is embedded in. The process of circulating a tool generates the utility of the tool through use, as opposed to its exchange value. Tools are not commodity-first at all – they do not move through circulation under the assumption that they start as commodities, because tools mediate social activity. Thus, tools can only be generative if instantiated through their lived active distribution rather than local exchange. What we think of tools or cultural production makes sense in this broader framing when we situate them as praxis: our methods for self-generated activity are more like network ecologies of stabilized relationships between nodes of active synchronization. Cognition is just the social ecology of this enactive continuum, a sort of ongoing process dynamic of symmetry and networked geometry that transforms the world through the ongoing memory web of culture and history. This lens gives you a social organization that actually still breathes underneath its bones and joints without upholding coordination over unplanned connection and novelty. This is where the Situationist International plays a huge part: the Situationist theorists and artists were wrangling with how one navigates not just the geometry and form of space, but also how space actually feels when you're walking through it unprompted. The Situationist ethos was in part about the autonomy one creates through spontaneous cultural and creative production, unplanned encounters, and the act of cultural production as a way to subvert the capitalist spectacle along with the structurally mediated forms of social space and political life. Raoul Vaneigem recognizes there is an irreducible capacity for spontaneous encounter and creative life that people can access even when the capacity for creativity is extorted from them

through life: "Nobody, no matter how alienated, is without (or unaware of) an irreducible core of creativity, a camera obscura safe from intrusion from lies and constraints. If ever social organization extends its control to this stronghold of humanity, its domination will no longer be exercised over anything save robots, or corpses. And, in a sense, this is why consciousness of creative energy increases, paradoxically enough, as a function of consumer society's efforts to co-opt it."



Vaneigem, along with the rest of the Situationist milieu, understood that the capacity for the depth of experience and the creation of art impacts not just social organization, but the structure of social life in general, and that choosing to be creatively honest was a decisive act that created shared safety amongst peers and generative emergence of cultural activity. It is not enough to simply be doing things to shape the terrain one stabilizes through social structure, one also needs to be willing to live through play, through experiential richness, and through the knowledge of continuous living. By reducing spontaneous creative life to a subordinate of coordination and object-oriented practice, rather than a peer, we risk creating an entrenched underclass of people who cannot access their capacity to create meaning from below: "So far, every single attempt to substitute a universal commodity for a vernacular value has led, not to equality, but to a hierarchical modernization of poverty. In the new dispensation, the poor are no longer those who survive by their vernacular activities because they have only marginal or no access to the market. No, the modernized poor are those whose vernacular domain, in speech and in action, is most restricted - those who get least satisfaction out of the few vernacular activities in which they can still engage." Ivan Illich, in his aforementioned writing on vernacular values, discusses on the surface how vernacular knowledge is socially mediated by what society actually holds in esteemed value, which in market societies tends to be those cultural values which are easiest to commodify.

Underneath this observation, there is something else happening in the process of social organization: how communication shapes social relations, and how the medium of technology impacts social organization. Everyone who participates in cultural production that is commercially viable and thus competitive as a market commodity is legible to the state and to capitalism, and everyone else who chooses not reduce themselves to the fungibility of commodity exchange is inadmissible to the market, illegible to the state, and unintelligible to others who prioritize brand identity over insight. An innumerable amount of people are systematically excluded from participating in autonomous meaning-making through an irreducible creative spirit inherent to everyone that nonetheless is interpreted externally by mass consumerism and mass surveillance as things that need to be controlled or reduced to exchange-value, and not only are they subordinating to the logic of the market, they also subordinate to the logic of surveillance technology that strips away their capacity to speak and create honestly on their own terms without fearing how their creations may be silenced.



However, pure spontaneity with no structural anchor risks the compromise of coherence and organized clarity of social activity, which is exactly what happened to the Situationist International and its later offshoots. Perhaps most evidently in San Francisco, the Cacophony Society was very much modeled off of the Situationist ethos of *dérive* (unplanned encounters) and *détournement* (culture jamming) in its commitment to building a counterculture of novel experiences. The Cacophony Society’s archival catalog of programming is vast, whimsical and peerlessly imaginative, opening space for anyone to propose events such as a “Marcel Proust Support Group” and a “Poetry Breakfast In The Woods”, emphasizing creativity and encounter as authentic expression. The stratagem of culture jamming and the tactical media interventions of the 1990s revealed that sometimes you didn’t need

to reason with power structures to bargain with them, you needed them to feel the sting of their absurdity, psychological flooding, and public ridicule. The problem of prioritizing novelty and immediacy in a hierarchy over structured political practice is exemplified by the evolution of Burning Man from Cacophony Society passion project at Baker Beach to neoliberal dystopia in the Nevada desert, where the novelty of experience mutates into directionless Epicurean hedonism in a Silicon Valley retreat spectacle. By inverting the survivalist ethos of radical self-reliance through prioritized inclusion of corporate hobbyists, Burning Man becomes an aesthetic experience purchased by its wealthiest patrons. When the desire for cultural authenticity surrenders political honesty, the force of culture cedes power and terrain to the spectacle. Culture is always asserted as structural survival and coordinated through everyday life before it is produced as commodity.



As we approach a stage of history where mass commodification and mass surveillance are normalized at every scale, the distinction between informational coordination and experiential practice matters immensely in how we encourage conversation between these two facets of organizing practice and social life in general, because they are often bleeding into one another. Even within the cybernetic milieu, there are two major camps that diverged, one more held to historical memory more often than the other. The information-first cyberneticians, often including people like Norbert Wiener and Stafford Beer, in parallel with Claude Shannon's information theory, were focused on feedback and control systems for informational exchange so that organizational systems could be more adaptive and self-regulating. This tendency of cybernetics locates feedback loops as purely informational, and experiential feedback is rarely emphasized beyond the cybernetic theory of Gordon Pask. The end point of this lineage of cybernetics is homeostasis as end goal, with informational exchange as substrate

for hub-and-spoke control systems. While Beer pursued more openly radical projects such as Project Cybersyn in Chile, this model for cybernetic systems was also its downfall, given that Project Cybersyn was still managed through a hub-and-spoke command room that coordinated information downstream to workplaces. With a target this localized, no matter how adaptive the system is, it remains susceptible to any failure mode that severs the mainframe computer from the user, which is exactly what happened when the CIA coup came for Salvador Allende and terminated the project. In some ways, the information-first approach to cybernetics struggled on two fronts: recuperation into a science of organizational management through central command, and the nascent artificial intelligence arms race in the late 20th century in which the British cyberneticians lost to the US in favor of recipients like Herbert Simon. More importantly, if information comes first and experience second, cybernetics is susceptible to institutional capture, where everything is reduced to KPIs, workflows, and performance optimization.



Before Wiener enters the picture in 1948, Alexander Bogdanov wrote from the pulpit of mid-revolutionary Russia as the Bolsheviks consolidate power, and in particular he writes extensively in a register that presages Wiener's highly technical cybernetic literature decades before Wiener starts the conversation in the US. Bogdanov's tektology was among the first iterations of systems theory before it was called systems theory, and his philosophy cannot be reduced to reason or experience alone, but lived process: "If energy constitutes the basis of all things and occurrences, then it exists in nature completely independently of humanity and its labour activity. If energy is only a symbol, then it exists in human thinking independently of nature – the world of resistance with which society struggles in its labour. In both cases, energy is understood as cut off from either of two sides of one objectively indivisible reality. In both

cases, it attains an absolute character – to be precise, either as an absolute real thing or as an absolute ideal thing. However, in reality, energy is nothing but a practical relationship of society to nature.” Bogdanov’s cybernetics anticipates a different kind of continuous feedback that is not made of information or quantifiable metrics, but actually lived social experience as one unified process that refines through shared engagement and shared practice of sociocultural life. Bogdanov’s cybernetic intuition was an organizational realist approach that situated feedback as coextensive within the context of its social environment rather than constitutive. Bogdanov applied this approach in his work through the Capri Party School, which was only open for a few months in 1909, but in that short time, Bogdanov along with the likes of Maxim Gorky and Anatoly Lunacharsky were facilitating education amongst working class communities prior to the revolution in 1917. The Capri Party School pedagogy facilitated learning through shared cultural production, integrating learning through the lived process of cultural creation whether workers were developing art, science, or literature, situating aesthetic practice as organizing practice for shared ethical life. Post 1917, the Proletkult movement of the Soviet avant garde succeeded the Capri Party School experiment, continuing the tendency of integrating shared cultural transformation with revolutionary organizing, expanding membership into hundreds of creative and workplace institutions, prior to being dissolved by Stalin’s imposition of socialist realism. What remains important here is method: the practice of making poetry with others, or about spontaneous play, gives us a path to integrate what we learned about ourselves and how to connect social practice with social organization without uprooting the depth of experience. Cybernetics rarely crossed into Bogdanov’s lineage after his time, and only recently has systems theory begun to catch up on theories that bridge cognition with embodiment.

The classical American pragmatists, including Peirce and Dewey, in some ways experienced the reverse of what the Soviet activity theorists were gesturing at despite highly adjacent theoretical applications. The American pragmatist tradition was, at the root, a philosophy of democratized knowledge as a process coming from working class life and not above it through the academy. Dewey's modality of the "democratic experiment" emphasized immediate action, experimentation, and shared tools as a vehicle for political autonomy over the paralysis of deliberation and procedure. Although the pragmatists themselves were not necessarily workers, their philosophical work was a formalization of the insights that workers were already developing through experience and collective labor struggle. Both the classical pragmatists and the labor movement overlapped in the height of organized labor in the early 1900s, orbiting around similar insights of experiential learning, collective inquiry through socially mediated action, and the practice of work as teaching. This was a philosophy born out of and integrated directly within the working conditions of the turn of the 20th century, leading to its own ecosystem through the worker education institutions such as the Bryn Mawr Summer School for Women Workers, Jane Addams's Hull House, and the Highlander Folk School, the latter of which was an organizing site during the Civil Rights Movement. After decades of ambush by the state and industry against the American labor movement and its militant struggle against capital, along with mergers and acquisitions of the labor movement into large business unions such as the AFL-CIO and UAW, an aristocracy of labor developed that separated autonomous class conflict from organized labor.



The wedge in the 20th century emerged between two competing tensions: on one hand was the the democratic industrial unionism of the Industrial Workers of the World which prioritized direct worker education and cross-sectoral solidarity over skilled trade hierarchy and business agent representation, and on the other hand was the

skill-stratified caste system inoculated through the AFL's reformist approach. The war of attrition against labor in the 20th century, at its core, atomized collective organizing by separating the representation of labor by designation of the business class from the self-representing and self-organized class of organized labor. Mike Davis has pointed out that bureaucratizing the general strike and disempowering the rank and file was part of this plan: "Seventeen years later, and in the wake of hundreds of local strikes as well as two nationwide walkouts (1937 and 1946), the United Auto Workers signed the so-called 'Treaty of Detroit' with General Motors. The 1950 contract with its five-year no-strike pledge symbolized the end of the long New Deal/Fair Deal cycle of class struggle and established the model of collective bargaining that prevailed until the 1980s. On the one side, the contract conceded the permanence of union representation and provided for the periodic increase of wages and benefits tied to productivity growth. On the other, the contract — by affirming the inviolability of managerial prerogatives, by relinquishing worker protection against technological change, and by ensnaring grievance procedure in a bureaucratic maze — also liquidated precisely that concern for rank-and-file power in the immediate labor process that had been the central axis of the original 1933-37 upsurge in auto and other mass production industries." The business class in America knew that the withholding and refusal of an organized working class, and their autonomous capacity to withhold participation in the machinery of the corporation would bring its authority to a halt, and they were willing to negotiate away their power in the long term through short term New Deal concessions, which locked away their collective bargaining autonomy behind no strike clauses and business agent model bureaucratization.



Consequentially, the labor movement as a result of this bargain splintered from its pragmatist, democratic origins in its own organizing practices. In the Cold War era, the New Left movements of the 60s and

70s onward were pulled into several different directions in terms of the vacuum left behind where the militant labor-oriented struggles of the 20th century lost the continuity of a shared organizing grammar, along with the semantic richness of how that grammar is reproduced through the motion of organizing activity. The emerging New Left coalition at the time navigated the terrain of a left-wing movement umbrella that attempted to fit competing political programs as opposed to a unified methodology: this included various anti-war tendencies, the Students for a Democratic Society, various Maoist and Third Worldist currents, anti-war and Black Power movements, anarchists, democratic socialists, Trotskyists, and a smattering of tendencies in between that were periodically competing with each other for programmatic survival in a political landscape partitioned by anti-Communist moral panic and state surveillance. The ideological complexion and class composition of this period matters less in context than what was institutionally quarantined leading up to it: the break in historical continuity between embodied, collectively worker-generated epistemology and solidified forms of ongoing political pedagogy. The ambient McCarthyist tension of the Cold War and the emergence of the New Left incidentally substituted shared, embodied organizing practice with internecine competition for a political program, which is a different kind of problem entirely.



It is not as straightforward to claim the New Left period in the United States simply struggled with the question of democracy or program, because at a deeper level of abstraction, what was lost in translation was the shared organizing practice, shared methodology, and the solidarity-first template that animated the shop floor for decades. Saul Alinsky, infamous for his organizing manual *Rules for Radicals*, was one of the few methodologists of how to organize in the New Left period. Alinsky's community organizing method, despite focusing on emancipatory anti-poverty causes in Black and working

class neighborhoods, was markedly authoritarian and centralized in its approach, playing the exact opposite foil to the early pragmatist framework: a professional class of organizer-for-hire positions themselves as charismatic leader, holding proprietary knowledge on how to organize and represent the class of people they are bargaining on behalf of in order to make a brinkmanship out of piecemeal bargaining. The Alinsky model has created an entire nonprofit cottage industry of a professionalized organizing class, where the business model depends on the bottlenecked autonomy of a self-organized community through a labyrinth of contractual obligations codified by backchannel bargaining practices. Alinsky's model served a specific purpose of appealing directly to liberal reformist tactics that never threaten the structural integrity of the system they bargain against, all while disinhibiting the agency of the working class they claim to represent. Such a practice was exemplified by none other than Barack Obama himself, whose own ascendance into the ruling class order as head of state benefited immensely from the charismatic leadership training of the Alinsky organizing model. The conservative hysteria around the Obama campaign, ironically, benefitted from Alinsky despite pointing to his influence, because it seamlessly transitioned its ethos into the contemporary professional-managerial class structure that enforces the hierarchy within autonomous social movements. There are two tensions to be held in his historiographic arc: the genealogical memory of self-generated political technique, and the continuous movement of self-organized practice that cannot be surrendered to a mediating professionalized class.



We will develop a framework of protocol organizing, where social organization develops mutual intelligibility through multiple layers of feedback that are architecturally chained but do not assert hierarchy over one another. Protocol organizing has four major layers: action, conversation, thinking, and spontaneous drift, designed to be modular

in their architecture; in other words, some organizations may only need two or three of these depending on their scope, but none of these layers have hierarchy over the other and for an organizing project, each balances the other. The action layer is where we choose configurations of activity and practice in adaptive environments, based on tools and spatial arrangements we enter the room with to develop deeper structural perception through shared social activity. The conversation layer is the environment where actors or objects converse with each other through shared receptivity, emphasizing mutual transformation through interaction rather than inputs and outputs of communication. The layer of conversation doesn't prescribe a specific linguistic format or human-human interaction, but can encompass all forms of interaction between conscious actors and their environment, whether in nature or an industrial space. The thinking layer is the reflective space where we integrate learning from activity and conversation, by sharing what the work teaches us and how we develop a shared adaptive memory amongst participants and the environment. Lastly, the layer of spontaneous drift is where an organization introduces novelty through spontaneity and play, where novelty circulates feedback for lateral thinking and direct action. Any social organization benefits not from planned corporate team bonding, but from unplanned encounters for shared social life and cultural transformation. All four layers are nested through a continuous feedback loop between each other, developing memory through spontaneous experience and deliberate practice, while creating spaciousness for both individual and collective integration wherever possible without emphasizing one over the other for the purposes of building autonomous life. Prefigurative politics often needs both togetherness and spaciousness in shared dynamic tension, while also holding both the need for precision and the need for spontaneous rupture in similar tension as part of the process of building the systems where social transformation happens. The elegance of such an approach is that because it's tied to shared values rather than emphasis on a vanguard or a diluted popular front, the organization itself becomes highly modularized, replicable, and

capable of interoperability for shared protocols, so that organizations may coordinate freely and laterally without prescribing an ideal form of organizational structure beyond clear rules for engagement. This organizing format is methodological and thus serves as a versionable template as opposed to a doctrine, focusing more on plasticity and adaptation over ossified rigidity. Along these lines, each protocol is a command structure with a control system, but the command structure is situated in local knowledge and constant feedback, and is thus agnostic to the specific configuration of command structure beyond what is locally situated and globally continuous, since protocols are built to be composable with other protocols.



A concrete application of this format, by which this could be modified with a tuning fork, could proceed as follows: a social organization gathers around a cause, through their agreed upon shared values or points of unity, at a cafe or a space with furniture that could feasibly be customized to meet the needs of the activity. Each participant brings a tool, an object, a resource, or an instrument that they can create with. A facilitator is chosen by sorting hat to lead the activity based on the agreed upon project or scenario to be prioritized on a given horizon. Each smaller group centers around a specific protocol layer, where one table focuses on a set of prompts for action, one table focuses on bridging conversations between tables to share insights, one table focuses on integration of feedback in both directions, and one table simply on a creative practice unprompted that allows them to coordinate an unplanned event or encounter at the space or outside of it, under the assumption that they would return to the conversation layer to share what they discovered. The spontaneous drift layer has the spaciousness to either develop shared cultural material such as art or outreach signs, or they can drift into other spaces independently based on the insight they are seeking. The action layer is where space is created for skillsharing and insight on developing new strategies and

education through an active library of shared tool circulation, and the intention of such a layer is to integrate eventually through the entire group by a self-moving practice of shared methodology and mutual political education. The conversation layer helps create a container for all of the other layers to exchange insight through feedback and mutual conversation, and the thought layer provides a source to archive and scaffold all of the insights to later share with the entire group and develop a provenance for historical memory over time that develops value through circulation. For each scenario or process, if the space has the autonomy to rearrange the furniture and the room to discover new interactive configurations, this matters almost as much as the activity itself, because the environment of an activity matters as much as the participation in the activity. Configuration of tables, chairs, tool placement, and even rules for how to transform the space all inevitably impact the space of interactions where insights develop. A more resilient organizing practice of collective methodological development that connects dynamic scenarios to active development maintains the upside of propagation, where prefigurative politics focuses into the long haul of the work itself rather than the contemplation of the answer. Living the questions of an organized cause, along these lines, is how one develops in motion with the environment they're in rather than an abstraction of the environment.



Incidentally, Milovan Diljas's analysis of the new class was among the most clarifying when applied directly to the American professional-managerial class that upholds the policy consensus in Washington. Although Diljas was largely diagnosing the administrative bureaucracy of Tito's Yugoslavia at the expense of being thrown in jail, his analysis applies anywhere with an administrative bureaucratic class: "The ownership of private property has, for many reasons, proved to be unfavorable for the establishment of the new class's authority. Besides, the destruction of private ownership was necessary for

the economic transformation of nations. The new class obtains its power, privileges, ideology, and its customs from one specific form of ownership-collective ownership which the class administers and distributes in the name of the nation and society. The new class maintains that ownership derives from a designated social relationship. This is the relationship between the monopolists of administration, who constitute a narrow and closed stratum, and the mass of producers (farmers, workers, and intelligentsia) who have no rights." The new class structurally maintains power not through ownership, but through position and status. The new class, in contemporary society, monopolizes administrative coordination, which is why the new class necessarily includes not just the state, but the industry benefactors and thought leaders in the professional-managerial class who depend on enforcement of artificial scarcity and denial of collective autonomy. The new class are the enforcers of the status quo who deny replacement of the status quo, and would rather manage scarcity in society than resolve it. However, they approach society as deferred maintenance on the machinations of their class position, and like all layers of the ruling class, they cascade the status quo by class betrayal. Aside from the Phil Ochs folk classic "Love Me, I'm A Liberal," there is truly nothing that describes the modern liberal and their discontents more than this archetype. Those who crowd the ideological center are like weathervanes of narrative momentum – they will follow trends and go in the direction that the wind blows, much like the retail investors in the stock market who optimize for momentum trading. What may be less understood, beyond just vague claims that they enable fascism, is that their adoption is always first-out, last-in (FOLI) to the bandwagon of social phenomena; that is, the least common denominator of liberal ideology follows from what George Jackson roots the nucleus of systemic fascism: the process of reform. Extending Jackson's intuition that systemic fascism uses reform as an alibi for motion without transformation, the epistemic engine of reform under systemic fascism is satisfied by optimization.

If governance is organized around a scalar objective rendered legible through instrumentation on a dashboard, fascism has already arrived.



Gaetano Mosca theorized about the concept of the political formula as justification amongst the ruling class to organize amongst themselves politically. The political formula serves as a set of abstract symbolic and juridical principles that elites organize around to justify their consolidation of power, such as popular sovereignty or representative democracy. Mosca very clearly expresses that ruling class formation does not constrain elites by moral intentions, but through maintenance of organizational compact: "...it is not the political formula that determines the way the political class is structured. On the contrary, it is the latter that always adopts the formula that suits it best." Mosca recognizes that legitimacy is something that elites supply after they consolidate power to justify their status, because in conditions of material asymmetry, a code keeps you alive and a cause keeps you captive. There is always a class of people who adopt consensus reality and assume that anything but incremental change, no matter in knowledge or social relations, threatens the social order, but more importantly, threatens the organizational glue of an entrenched class of people who benefit from keeping things exactly as they are. However, even Marx (the polemicist) knew Engels (the factory owner), meaning that the capitulation and leverage of the new class emerges downstream from a mimetic cascade rather than reforming them from within or waiting for the turn of their conscience. When the think tanks in Washington or the industry insiders across the globe start to circulate information amongst themselves, they have already started a domino effect because they recognize an idea that threatens them beyond what they can repress. Whether they respond with violence or with institutional marginalization is context-dependent, but they remain fundamentally in mimetic competition with one another over the durability of their status in

the new class, and mimetic conformity follows when the force of an idea becomes impossible to assuage through the current political formula. Thus, autonomous narrative and emancipatory bargaining of narrative control becomes more important, not less, regardless of potential consequences. Class warfare is also informational warfare, not just material warfare, and requires withholding consent for both narrative and coordination capacity in parallel regardless of electoral outcome and professional-managerial class consensus. This is how liberal consensus could claim to support Martin Luther King Jr decades after his assassination despite considering him a terrorist in his time, or how both the US invasions of Iraq and Vietnam could incinerate entire lands and only be rejected as indefensible post hoc despite anti-war efforts on both fronts. An empire can only turn their prophets into mascots after killing them. The shadow of Imperial Rome can appropriate Job and Isaiah just as easily as America can refactor Martin Luther King Jr and Fred Hampton into ventriloquism, but the empire cannot hear any of them without admitting their will to conquest was a lie. The prophets are only read when they leave the city that created them, but rest assured, the cathedral cannot engage with the prophets they quote. Empires manage and enforce their untouchability because anything less requires their honest confrontation with the conditions of the scarcity they require. Once the dominos begin to fall amongst the new class, however, the calculus of the situation changes, because it means the ruptures that their crises cause begin to shift as bargaining leverage. The new class is not reformed, they are simply outmaneuvered into irrelevance. The institutions of this class strata mediate the negotiation of institutional belonging precisely through games of status that imply their own contingency. Similar to how medieval thanes were retainers bound by fealty rather than law, the regimes of the managerial elite and the new class operate as modes of thanocracy: governance by loyal intermediaries whose authority derives from proximity, code, and enforcement. In a thanocracy, the sovereign is abstracted, laws are modular and adaptive to survival, accountability is diffused into guard labor load distribution, and enforcement is

personalized downstream as failure by the governed. Thanocracies operate through the aesthetics of judicature and managerial neutrality, in which loyalty is pledged to the survival of institutional coherence rather than a singular ruler.



What we understand about the contemporary political moment is that the ruling class often sit at the conventional hinge where desire, ideology, and fantasy are irreversibly produced as infrastructure. The prevalence of the homeless or the incarcerated, and the performance of care and cultural authenticity in relating to their suffering amongst the powerful, has a particular cadence to it: the dispossessed sign lineage exists, they create vernacular knowledge and meaning from below in their survival and their cultural experience, and the powerful insist that this is something to extract from and exploit, and something to envy as a fantasy of class betrayal, by projecting our desires onto something that we do not have and that is structurally impossible for us to approximate. Althusser may call this “interpellation” of an ideology (the ego assigning a symbolic identity to the subject), but this has limitations in why the subject enjoys the fantasy of ideology. Fantasy is just produced as a stabilization artifact, and once produced, it can only be recomposed rather than interpreted. In a sense, the fantasy requires the Real dispossessed to remain the Other, the performance to remain relevant despite symbolic exclusion, and the supply of authenticity to maintain enough libidinal scarcity to leverage power over the Other. The powerful need to expunge the dispossessed, because the dispossessed are evidence of the falsehood of the fantasy. For any lethal system, survival intelligence is psychologically deadly, because it demonstrates that a system can be departed from without requiring captivity of the subjects. For this, we enrich Lacan’s signifier to define a nilpotent sign: a master signification whose structural integrity depends on the exclusion of the Real. The object petit a, in this sense, is not so much the whole structural impossibility of the entire psyche, but of

the fear of deprivation the bourgeois subject experiences when the meaning they depend on eventually collapses to zero. Thus, violence is structurally necessary – a state or fascist entity needs to keep the Real compliant by producing desire mechanistically, but never producing a conciliation of power or negotiating their flourishing successfully. Desire produces residue, and only reconfigures when asymmetry is terminated. The system needs to simulate the symbolic importance of narrative and affect through a self-stabilizing desire that eradicates its own conditions of survival. In other words, the signifier's meaning collapses upon contact with the Real that it depends on. We may classify this dynamic through its emergent operational mechanism called the symbolic ideal-deviant splitting: when one performs the behaviors of the predatory system, they are idealized by the system, and when one diverges from the system's expectations, they are conditioned into accepting the predation of the system for as long as they chronically self-neglect their own needs in this system. The bifurcation functions as a behavioral layer of the nilpotent signifier's exclusionary logic and its feedback loop of compliance. We may be able to simply witness this in the world in how the rich perform poverty or cultural authenticity out of lack, and in doing so, the performance of poverty structurally depends on the punishment of the poor. Instability at any systemic scale needs a place to go if it cannot be repaired into symmetry, and sometimes social death can be produced to ensure a contradiction cannot be metabolized. In this sense, we can argue that the ruling class do not unconsciously resent the dispossessed at all, but unconsciously fears them because their existence proves that authority is borrowed and social death is made.



Part of the nilpotent sign barrier requires both understanding of the mechanistic and mentalistic defenses that one may adopt as a way of avoiding confrontation with the Real, particularly in predatory institutions. We can define, for example, the concept of syntonic

stabilization: not so much an identity or being, but a process by which the concept of self clings to all stabilization mechanisms to avoid the destabilization that contact with the Real requires. The process involves a four-layer ego architecture: the egoic identity layer, the syntonic layer, the dystonic layer, and the Real. The syntonic layer is the unconscious processing layer underneath a conscious ego. The egoic layer above the syntonic is concerned exclusively with control over narrative, identity, reality, and refusal to metabolize contradiction at the expense of losing control, and therefore may distort the reality of others to hedge against distortion themselves. Syntonic stabilization as a process is concerned with deployment of ideological signs, intra-affective tribal signaling, and predetermined templates, almost like a menu of mechanistic responses to reality, despite being a purely mentalistic process of ego stabilization. The syntonic layer pattern matches exclusively to their existing template of identity, reality and discourse, but without receiving or updating consciously against feedback, because there's no receptive contact with the Real happening and there is no novel event that updates the point of reference. Overactive ego architectures can often respond to cues without internal consistency checks on information and feedback they receive, resulting in an iterative ungluing within the logical grammar of the unconscious. An affective syntonic preservation attempts to maintain a coherent felt identity when confronted with contradictory stimuli. The egoic layer maintains pure rigidity and frozen processing because plasticity would threaten the structural integrity of the ego. The ego collapses into structure where contradiction is unavailable for alignment, given that the responses an ego receives are entirely context-dependent on its current template library and its current model of reality.



Living systems have guards and defensive mechanisms as long as they have experience and reason, but when the ego is so committed

to syntonic stabilization that it refuses integration and becomes impervious to information, the defensive mechanism becomes pathological and disconnects from semiosis entirely in the absence of boundaries or feedback. The dystonic layer of the ego is the layer of spontaneous defense against the dystonic images of identity and self, those which threaten the stability of the ego. The syntonic and dystonic layers always maintain a crosswalk through the ego on how to stabilize and what to stabilize against. One may find that, when their ego is threatened by conflicting information or narrative, the ego can spontaneously confabulate in real time to protect against the glitching of one's identity. The ego needs stability against dystonic glitching, in which the internal consistency of the ego's templates of memory override the necessity of reconfiguration. The dystonic layer is the sword of active defense and the syntonic layer is the shield of passive stabilization, where the ego may repel injury by any number of survival intelligence mechanisms, including deflection, confabulation, and retaliation while the syntonic layer of the ego stabilizes itself. Whereas the reality outside of a highly rigid ego may be conceptualized as more of a constant feedback loop, the ego's syntonic and dystonic layer, when allowed to metastasize, function more parasitically, siphoning from their host and other hosts in order to maintain control over a situation in which losing control would be threatening. The Real is the fourth and final layer, which the syntonic layer can infer but the dystonic layer can respond through experience. The Real is the untouchable model of reality that the ego can rationalize and respond to but not touch, given that one's ego cannot traverse beyond the unconscious. However, one's ego can control the conscious layer of one's own reality and impose themselves as pilot unless one learns to negotiate with all of the parts of themselves and integrate their identity in full. Part of this negotiation revolves around how one may negotiate through the plasticity of the self, from a mechanistic and mentalistic point of view, and the rigidity of the self in their need to stabilize and maintain identity. This negotiation is dynamic, ongoing practice throughout life, given that the self must

continuously renegotiate as reality presents novel configurations that don't fit existing templates. Rigidity is not a trait but a process of refusing this ongoing negotiation, because a fully rigid ego is one in which no feedback loop is happening. The psyche, when pressed against a contradiction it cannot metabolize, calcifies into the armor of rigidity. When unable to integrate the tension, it constricts itself until rupture becomes its only control mechanism from the humility of release. An unmitigated ego compartmentalizes its own perceptual system and thus its own interactive cognition with the environment, sorting threatening or contradicting patterns into attics and rooms of the unconscious that the autonomic nervous system later has to infer as the straightest path towards predictive processing, resulting in perceptually noisier and less coherently glued models of reality than simply metabolizing contradiction upfront.



Because syntonic stabilization is concerned with medium and not message, the syntonic layer can be intervened by facilitating the conditions of the medium of communication architecture. Social media platforms that optimize for ad revenue, metadata harvesting, and engagement, for example, create every perverse incentive possible for ego amplification, tribal sequestering in echo chambers, strategies of tension between tribes, and terminally online cognition. Facebook or Instagram, for example, reward users with the most followers and engagement over the accuracy or meaningfulness of their content, or the quality of their connections. This allows anyone in bad faith to intervene on the platform by predicting which ideas would spread based on the structural compatibility of their ideas with the platform itself. Early 2000s and even 2010s internet culture, on anonymous IRC channels and websites like 4chan, enable this type of virality when abusive language or behavior can go without consequence because it often functions epidemiologically: the internet has created an entire free virtual space where ideas can be accessed freely, but if one

knows the chokepoints, they can also be transmitted or spread freely as contagions. Thus, ideas in digital spaces succeed predominantly because they are syntonically compatible with the structure of the platform, not because the ideas themselves are truthful. This matters strategically if one conceptualizes virtual space as another site of combat where authoritarian institutions and fascist sects can exploit and extract communication architecture for the purposes of control and demoralization, because that game can be played by anybody, but it also signifies that any platform or virtual space that maintains structural vulnerability to authoritarian capture and algorithmic reinforcement of syntonetic processes on account of commercial gain should be considered an institution one cannot reform by participating within it, but by refusing its terms of engagement and building infrastructure that resists authoritarian capture.



We propose a condition of suprasemy - that is, a quality or condition when a term, conflict, or symbol is so symbolically overloaded with its own weight and saturation of meaning that it becomes impossible to actually discuss anything surrounding the term without the term itself becoming a sort of meta-debate above shared philological understanding around what the term is, the implications of its meaning, the cultural baggage surrounding the term, and a circulatory indeterminacy that prevents any tension from being resolved. Even the mere invocation of a tension or structural term in this condition immediately overdetermines the symbolic field that the structure or tension operates in, thus flooding the field with incompatible meanings and leaving the situation in a continuous state of semiotic deadlock. Certain signifiers become so symbolically charged that there is no way to actually resolve a conflict except manipulate the terrain the conflict is actually on, resulting in tensions that people have to find ways to move around rather than move through. Suprasemy is paradoxical, in the sense that terms are simultaneously over-meaningful and

over-meaningless because they've been diluted, emptied, amputated, and saturated of their own contingencies and etymological purpose. Therein, debates over a specific topic or conflict become themselves interminable meta-debates over the terms and conditions of the topic and conflict, which require circular relitigation over the historical baggage underneath the terms themselves. We distinguish this as a signpost from Freud or Althusser's concept of overdetermination, in which a singular condition may have multiple causes. In this particular stage of late modernity, a singular cause or condition could have multiple simultaneous meanings that contrast with one another, to the point where meaning itself is completely flooded and saturated beyond the pale and concepts themselves become a structural impasse in a larger asymmetric terrain. In other words, suprasemy assumes one signifier with many mutually incompatible operational meanings in semiotic deadlock rather than many causes with one effect. A single term could have so many competing definitions and negotiable symbolic meanings that it ceases to function as a coordinate in discursion absent of its manipulation and exploitation by force.



In contemporary society where the flooding of information and meaning constrain the space of admissible interaction, suprasemy is a weapon that authoritarian regimes in society tend to brutally exploit into oblivion. Tensions are reducible in such asymmetric symbolic terrain to performance rather than decisive action, and the placation of authority that benefits from maintaining the suffocating grip of tension. This is fundamentally a military strategy at its core: instead of just overpowering an enemy with sheer force, one must make a theatrical performance around the enemy's own assertion of their agenda and prior combat training, so that their central command remains brittle, placid, timid, and pliable to external manipulation. This produces a chilling effect in which one cannot resolve tension without risking the coercive marginalization that comes with honestly moving

through tension and questioning the force needed to uphold tension. There is no commonly accepted indeterminacy towards free exchange of ideas and solutions, nor is there a reachable concept of determinacy at all, in establishing that there is shared meaning to be established beyond pure relativism and sectarianism. Any concept that is flushed by suprasemy suffers from the risk of definition wobble as allergic reaction, where definitions lose their steadiness when forcibly wrested and dribbled towards an arbitrarily shifting goalpost depending on the power dynamics involved. The authoritarian institutions recognize that in sports, the performance is the substance. Suprasemy reduces decision making to a game of brinkmanship, where actors involved are always maneuvering in an asymmetric conceptual space on someone's home court in which the team with the superior perceptual skill and firepower wins, except victory in this playing field is shaped entirely by optics, audience perception, and symbolic power brokering. In other words, decision making and exploration cease to become themselves a revealing of situated practice and mutual understanding, and are instead performative and socially mediated to the extent of who controls the playing field.



An increasingly broad corpus of words, some of which are frequently used in this text, have become subject to conditions of suprasemy, where there's no way to resolve the symbolic logjam of conflict without managing or manipulating the conditions of conflict. There is a vast array of terms in which meet the suprasemy criteria in today's society in the present moment, which may as well shift depending on the circumstances and referentiality of the reader, but they include terms like: mysticism, metaphysics, freedom, liberty, socialism, communism, liberalism, fascism, antisemitism, privilege, oppression, racism, gender, sexuality, radical, social justice, technology, religion, anarchism, cancel culture, political correctness, intersectionality, abolition, AI, solidarity, modernism, intifada, revolution, postmodernism, consciousness, civ-

ilization, narcissism, woke, capitalism, unity, contradiction, and an ever-expanding and contracting dictionary of words that are impossible to traverse out of the gravitational quicksand of definition wobble or implicitly shared contextual knowledge of what these terms actually mean and why they're used. These are all terms one would expect to be scanned and flagged by intelligence agencies, fusion center documents, and surveillance contractors as a threat assessment and detection exercise, where words themselves become forensic artifacts in striated space. Terms subject to suprasemy become more like tribal signaling and tagged metadata in a widely dubious and pacified society, where saying them activates a particular symbolic connotation that needs to be managed over the capacity to navigate conflict through shared knowledge and method. These are terms that cease having coherence value, only hash value, because they prevent you from working backwards to understand what they actually mean beyond a preprogrammed response script, which makes words perfectly fungible for ATS resume scanners and surveillance technology.



Incidentally, words in the suprasemy condition are not inherently definitional classifications, but are instead contradictions around shared meaning that are unresolved and refuse metabolism. The prevalence of suprasemy implies a larger societal condition of control over how knowledge is used, which is an existential crisis that philological rigor resolves. For example, if one were to suggest the hard sciences like mathematics or physics to tackle metaphysical or mystical questions like the topography of ethics or indeterminacy of phenomena, many academic communities in the hard sciences immediately respond with an allergy or hostility to such ideas, to the point where they dismissed, ridiculed, or marginalized in academic discursion where credibility is entangled with the publish-or-perish environment of higher education, validation criteria, citational volume, and risk aversion around revenue streams for research questions.

The atomization of knowledge and commodification of culture is a very modern aberration that belies centuries of history that assumed no such contradiction between metaphysical inquiry and scientific inquiry. Academia resembles a hedge fund manager with a sports franchise and a research arm, where their primary concern is ensuring they get a multiplier on their investment portfolio or status against other academic competitors for the products they provide to the public. Therefore, anything particularly experimental or paradigmatic is subject to the same logic of incrementalism or judiciousness around the constant threat of scope creep and status anxiety as it pertains to one's own isolated domain.



The irony of such an approach is that paradigmatic advancements in the sciences have usually been preceded by the macroscopic clarity and focus that mystical and metaphysical insight tends to offer, or just by zooming out of the window of the debate between competing ideas, and there is an extensive precedent for ethical and mystical interactions with the hard sciences. Kepler wrote entire volumes of mystical treatises inspired by the Pythagorean tradition, including the *Harmonice Mundi* and *Mysterium Cosmographicum*. Newton spent decades of his life to the study of alchemy, deciphering hermetic riddles to resolve contradictions about physical phenomena. Grothendieck, the most obvious offender of this trend in mathematics, was very transparent about the mystical abstraction that informed his mathematics throughout his career, such that his discoveries revolutionized the entire field of mathematics because he specifically sought to reveal how to make the symbols speak to each other so that they established relationships and transformations. Einstein was very inspired by his own brushings with mystical experience, and his own belief in a Spinozist god that was “in the orderly harmony of all things”, which themselves informed his theory of relativity to move behind the dominant thinking of his time. Formally speaking, what is described

as mystical experience corresponds to the downregulation of a default mode network under bandwidth asymmetry, with salience and sensory integration remaining online long enough to encode resolution prior to symbolization. If any one of these theorists mentioned above were to participate in academia now, they would be either managed out of their department or derided as a liability unless they conformed to the incrementalism, perception management, and risk aversion that characterizes much of the academy today. This does not nullify the vulnerability of hard science concepts when appropriated or genuinely misapprehended through scope creep, such as the New Age charlatanism of Deepak Chopra and his insidious funneling of precise physics terminology into semantically empty concepts like “quantum healing” and “quantum consciousness” in order to gain purchase on homeopathic medicine approaches, let alone his own capitalist brand identity of pop spirituality.



The template for this kind of disciplinary control, historically speaking, predates the present by multiple epochs. The Protestant Reformation was not much a religious revolt but a structural iconoclasm, which upheld the primacy of one’s individual relationship with God and indemnity towards the organized institutional authority of the Catholic Church. The sola scriptura ethos gave the Protestants a site of leverage against the Catholics, because it allowed them to interrogate ecumenism through endless doctrinal interpretation and claims to fidelity on doctrine that reduced any claim to collective unity with entrenched skepticism and doubt. Within the context of the Age of Religions, this is not so much about truth or method as much as it is about geomancy and manipulation of terrain. The notion of the Protestant work ethic, while gesturing at this problem, needs enrichment by the concept of the Protestant ideology: the active process of derailing organized or collective life by poisoning the well with individualist soteriology and atomized analysis paralysis. The Protestant Reformation destroyed

the systematic penetration that the Scholastics were slowly unfolding, resulting in a dual-track tension of contradictions: The Protestant Reformation modeled the individualist rationalism and skeptic posture against grand narratives, later inherited by the secular academy, whereas the Counter-Reformation insisted on the preservation of Catholic orthodoxy. The Protestants could read, interpret, and write, but they were not building rituals, only critiquing the ritual sites that were built. The Catholics built grandiose, maximalist infrastructure while laundering collective guilt and colonialism, but the Protestants offered no reprieve out of this cycle beyond building local competing churches as a business model that would not look out of place in a market economy. The Protestant ethic did not just give us work – we inherited the Protestant mindset of personalized guilt, faith, and critique, insisting that salvation and enlightenment are individualized gestures that only we can uniquely interpret. This posture, no matter whether it's in divine rule or capitalist empire, breaks continuity with collective world building by reducing us to participants in the capitalist hamster wheel. And the Protestant ideology is seemingly everywhere at once: university systems fully embraced anti-systematic poststructuralism partly because endless critique serves as a useful cultural cache for capitalism, hence why the CIA was so mesmerized in their internal memos on theorists like Foucault. The institutional knowledge production Foucault critiqued that reproduced docility instead laterally moved to become its own institution of insulated critics, who could read and interpret theory but not build infrastructure in lived common practice. In order to liberate life from the conditions of the present, you need to filter for interpreters and require, as Paul Raekstad and Saio Gradin describe, “the deliberate experimental implementation of desired future social relations and practices in the here-and-now.”

Western metaphysical instability, underneath the Catholic and Protestant ideology, lies in a specific dialectical tension: the kataphatic theology of what God is through positive claims (universes of representation, mediation of positive claims, institutionalization through Catholic Scholasticism), and apophatic theology of what God is not (non-representational immediacy, negative claims, formlessness, dissolution, contemplative encounter). Even at the contemporary ideological moment, there are tensions between kataphatic transcendentalism and apophatic immanence, which by themselves are structurally incompatible with the other. These tensions are mere power struggles in dialectic negotiation with one another, both of which require stepping out of their arena and metabolizing the tension into adaptation. Incidentally, this is what Nietzsche was grappling with in his own aesthetic register of the historical oscillation between the Apollonian and Dionysian, but without a metaphysical engine for metabolizing their contradictions: Since Newton and Spinoza, we have evolved from positive and negative claims about what God is or isn't, over to positive and negative claims about what nature and modernity are or aren't. However, the residue of the several-hundred year reign of Scholastic self-reference persists even in a secular intellectual environment. The academic embrace of the Protestant ideology keeps even social science academics and those academics in the humanities focused on analysis and critique while maintaining suspicion against any alternatives in capitalist realism, while the physical, mathematical, and computational sciences have been recruited into the transcendental structural universe of capitalism and empire through their sequestered academic silos. This is the mechanism that ensures suprasemy maintains a foothold on the current power structure— by fragmenting collective solidarity and abstracting away the possibility of alternatives, any heterodoxy can be easily marginalized as cranks and mystics. In some ways, this turn makes sense given historical continuity. The historical revolutions in the 20th century, such as those we have seen of Marxist-Leninism, Stalinism, or Maoism, have presented alternatives to restructure reality in the same vein as what one may call Catholic

ideology: bulk structural megaprojects and iron-fisted centralism imposed by fiat. The tension throughout history, even now, has always been between individualist salvation and brutal centralism, with decentralist solutions offered that still remain within the terms of debate. The irony of this arrangement, regardless of denomination, implies Protestant exegesis or Catholic guilt can mete out solutions that are not entirely horrific or dysfunctional, leading life on the planet down a spiral that eventually collapses into nihilism. This pattern is highly traceable all throughout Post-Fordist society: the neoliberal Washington Consensus turn broke away from the collective bargaining of unions with individual contractors in startups and gig economy workers, the Silicon Valley technolibertarian and Technocracy movement turn following the dot-com boom insisted on permissionless disruption to break collective infrastructure, and all ethnonationalisms fulfill the same role by ethnic partition over collective solidarity with others. Fragmentation of reality becomes the liberation narrative, because any sort of collective liberation would reveal the sham folklore that the entire system depends on maintaining. Ultimately, the entire template is an ancient one, and the only way to break the cycle is to leave the church and find the point of view that fills the entire world with clarity. The invariance of the metaphysical universe upholds stability and coherence through the constant of its transformation, not representation or ineffability of an absolute ideal.



Meaning needs to dissipate to remain usable, and signification is not so much a problem of self-referential stabilization as much as the deliberate refusal to let conceptual signification dissipate or reconfigure. In the current stage of late modernism, the concept of freedom itself suffers from scope creep and definition wobble because freedom often has definitions that are defined psychoanalytically by somebody else. Meaning, moral surplus, historical trauma, and institutional judicature collapse into singular fungible tokens which

can then be manipulated without power dynamics ever needing to differentiate until instability is too visible to ignore. The notion by Sartre that "man is condemned to be free" is interpretable as a blessing in a free society, but in a highly authoritarian society in which meaning is collapsable, freedom becomes a curse, a burden that one can control and manipulate to destabilize one's own notion of freedom into something pliable and unfree. Freedom in such a society becomes freedom for the powerful and freedom for those in narrative control, whereas all others are cyclically enchained to some unreachable symbolic desert where freedom can be somehow achieved by esoteric means. Thus, we distinguish between modernist notions of discipline, and postmodernist notions of discipline, with the caveat that both modes of discipline encode far-from-equilibrium pathologies. Modernist discipline is the classical 20th century model, where the expectations of control are frontloaded and clear: one has autonomy up until a certain limit is crossed by authority, and then they are disproportionately repressed and eroded of their freedom and stability. These are the traffic code violations or HR policies at a company around dress code, in which the sanctionable constraints are clear despite their overt erosion of one's autonomy that they can maintain by force. Postmodern discipline is more insidious and disorienting, by making freedom itself a burden that one must constantly police and self-monitor through vigilance, fear handling, and threat assessment of their surroundings. Postmodern discipline acknowledges that modernist discipline is too predictable and symbolically loaded with cultural baggage, and chooses instead to convey permissive rhetoric in which the language of freedom is conveyed, but is always laden with traps to discipline and disorient a person into subjugation. In clinical literature, terms like double-bind theory, covert abuse, and pseudo-autonomy exist to describe behavioral psychology or rational choices in a game-theoretic sense, but this problem of freedom is deeper and more structural when meaning itself is constantly gameable and susceptible to entropic intensification. Meaning converges on chronic suspension

in a postmodern disciplinary regime, preventing closure by proliferating interpretative labor as an obstructive impasse to differentiation.



Stability is maintained by preventing resolution prior to achieving it. Nothing in late modern society needs to be overtly forbidden because the surveillance of the self is internalized so deeply that you are always responsible for placating the freedom of something else, including the family or a market position. Even pleasure itself rations the Epicurean maximization of *jouissance*, where libidinal experience becomes a privatized transactional ledger of exchange and extraction without repair. There's no concept of freedom to uphold when freedom itself is enforced as a subjective enterprise, which is constantly negotiable whether one is dealing with intimate relationships or a capitalist society that emphasizes you can only have as much autonomy as you can legally afford. When freedom itself becomes interminably suspect, there are truly no free subjects, because freedom becomes a payload that a state deems illegible to its designated surplus population and bioregional resource pumps. This logic replicates downstream into our communities, our lovers and our families, where scarcity and autonomy are synonymous and are meted out by individuals who deputize themselves as psychopolitical jurists in a tribunal of social relations. Freedom is ontologically prior to subject formation. The precondition of subjectivity is situated in who is authorized to administer freedom at all, meaning that any system defining a subject first and freedom second is already a coercive system in designating freedom as a property of subjects after the configuration of markets, law, and identity manage the instability of withholding freedom downstream. Freedom is both pre-juridical and post-cultural, after meaning and identity are sedimented, persisting simply as the invariant remainder under negation. Freedom is not a condition for something, it is simply what cannot be canceled even when rulers or society negate it by force. As a result of this, freedom is

the only constant that persists which refuses negation, which makes it the only possibility to fail or survive at all. Equality, as a limit condition, refuses to be affirmed; that is, total domination or exclusion simply fails to finish the job if neither equality nor freedom are held in common as thermodynamic necessity. Freedom and equality materialize the way gravity does, not as ontological carriers but as indifference to distributing consequence when it fails to transport.



What persists in this world is shared, ungrounded, but unable to be sanctified by anything, as equality emerges when negation by domination no longer survives as justification. Freedom is the initial condition that everything maps from but is explained by nothing, and equality is the limit of composability when asymmetry can no longer rotate or be renormalized. Society is the null object that absorbs the current asymmetric distribution of freedom and equality, where responsibility is diffused but explanation expires. Freedom happens and equality converges, but society is the space of admissible interactions under constraint. Society is the alibi that explains nothing about why equality and freedom are not distributed in common, but they absorb the consequence of refusing to reindex a present composition that fails to return structure. Late modernity, along these lines, is defined by ambient dread. Byung Chul Han carefully diagnoses this trend in his own work, which traces the current hysteria of neoliberalism as one not of externally imposed suffering, but an internally manufactured dread, where a society of implied transparency inundates us with information, projected meaning, hyperstimulus, hypervisibility, and hyperchoice, in a world often mediated by the compressed attention span fomented by hypertext. If the 20th century mediums manufactured consent by external force, the 21st century mediums manufactured dread by internal choice. Given that 20th century industrial societies thrived on mediating disbelief through scarcity of information, the dominant institutions have since adapted their tactics to mediate disbelief on

abundance of information. The modern tyrannical sovereign does not need force at all to disempower their subjects; in fact, the modern informational regime understands that meaning itself is an instrument to be manipulated, so the individual must navigate an internalized surveillance of both self and environment in search of a meaning they cannot easily access. The choice of freedom itself is weaponized in this system of postmodern discipline, in which freedom itself is a burden and thus psychically exhausting, amplifying dysregulation, decision fatigue, and burnout. Hyperbole is the homeostasis of late modernity, meaning that the chaos forced by amplification of the extremes through moral panic, engagement metrics, and the cottage industry of social media outrage all creates a perfect storm of self-stabilizing chaos, a sort of internalized black hole where nothing feels stable and everything feels distorted. Uncertainty, superficial consumer abundance, and consensual mass surveillance result in a society where the cognition of dread as a probabilistic apparatus and freedom is produced by authoritarian regimes. The environment itself is probabilistically threatening and ambiently dreadful at all times, in which there is always a diffuse tension that avoids the compression of structured force that modernity operated with for generations.



The transition from the 19th century to the present has maintained the same structure of metaphysical excess in a reconfigured affective valence, in which the nihilism of meaningless has transmigrated into an optimism of saturated meaning. The interregnum of any metaphysical enthusiasm amputates compunction when the ecology of the world governs the break between action and restraint through the inability to delegate interiority. Christopher Lasch wrote the intellectual foil in the 20th century of the oscillatory tension between the Protestant and Catholic ideology binary that defined his generation. In his work, *The True and Only Heaven*, Lasch gives cover to a petit-bourgeois nostalgia for an inherited past that assumes an ancient viewpoint, not unlike that

of Edmund Burke, that history is a tragedy in which we must accept our limitations at the individual level and return to our ties to community and family as justification for absence. It cannot be emphasized enough how deeply dangerous this worldview is, and how it often leaves no guardrails against either ideological Protestantism or systemic Catholicism. Lasch portrays a world-weary intellectual resignationism dressed as analysis, not unlike the Dimes Square youth reactionaries who mine directly from Lasch's worldview. History does not necessarily imply grand narratives about teleological progress or tragic pessimism beyond the individual projections of their interlocutors, because if the revolutionary struggles in history have taught us anything, it's that history is a negotiation about outcomes that are not yet predetermined. Alternatives are always structurally impossible if chosen by people to build guardrails against them, and limitations do not require accepting present arrangements unless we internalize the narrative that we are forever defined by a moral escrow deferred onto history. The suspension of ethical judgment as alibi for exhaustion only removes justification, but not obligation. Nature persists through processes that do not ask for permission. Responsibility consists only of the exposure of action as the only survivable procedure. Lasch's tragic realism is the beginning of a pipeline that ends in active atrocity participation, often in descending gradient intensity of irony poisoning. The next stage after Lasch's intellectual pessimism transitions into post-ideological irony, in which sincerity is shameful and obligation is withdrawn. Nihilist accelerationism usually follows at the next stage of tragedy in the pipeline, in which irony devolves into acceptance that not only is relationship building futile, world building is also futile, because the world is doomed to collapse, leading some to support intensifying the contradictions so that the world burns faster. The next stage, in which one may find cells like the Order of Nine Angles or CVLT, is within exterminationist activity, in which irony ossifies into certainty and interiority dissolves; in other words, this is the stage where someone decides some people just deserve to die or be violated gratuitously through agitation of collapse as license to eschatology. Obliteration

justifies itself as purely procedural by this stage, in which all means justify the end as a displacement of responsibility into history. Finally, the process scales upward as active participation in atrocity, whether as functionary of the prison, concentration camp, border patrol, or any other form of industrial slaughterhouse that bloodies people for sport, and enforces genocide as the machinery of necessity.



In writing for SFMOMA in 2019 on recognition of the Armenian genocide, Zoe Samudzi describes empathy as a moral technology that rearranges the labor of accountability downstream towards those most susceptible to harm: “What is the relationship between justice and survival? Both justice and empathy are inhered with an “asymmetry of moral duties,” to cite an unnamable friend. The burden of responsibility for forgiveness and the export of empathy rests, like the burden of Atlas, on the shoulders of the oppressed.” Genocide operates, after all, from the administrative cessation of thought. A social order that culminates in atrocity is admitting very plainly it can continue while desensitized to consequence, removing all stopgaps until only the total alignment between procedure and annihilation remains. The completion of procedural collapse in the continuation of atrocity is what materializes in the process of genocide, until no gap between violence as procedure and outcome exists. This line of thinking, if it is not already apparent, is both dangerous and encouraged by the architecture of surveillance capitalism, and it risks an acceleratory rupture towards mass entropy as power and resources are consolidated into the hands of the ruling class unless alternatives are built without expecting them to be handed to us. This recognition functionally requires an exit from the cathedral that capitalism and technocracy as modern feudalism is completely built on, and we cannot exit the cathedral by reproducing the denominational dynamics whether coded in secularism or institutionalized religion. The Black Panthers, better than almost anyone, understood what this meant even if not a single

point of the Ten Point Program has still never been implemented in the streets of Oakland. The Panthers were killed and infiltrated precisely over what they built: breakfast programs, clinics, and autonomous resource coordination that demonstrated the state's inefficiency to mediate resources beyond gatekeeping and means testing. Huey Newton said this of power: "power is, first of all, the ability to define phenomena, and secondly the ability to make these phenomena act in a desired manner." Newton was very clear in how he theorized on his vision of revolutionary intercommunalism, such that autonomy was built from the ground up and self-sufficiency needs to be collectively scaffolded in relational structure in order to truly demonstrate the nation state's limitations. In conjunction with this analysis, Ashanti Alston writes in the Black anarchist tradition: "Oppositional thinking and oppositional risks are necessary." Alston's reflections on the Black Panther Party highlight something important about the experience of building a political project, which is that every organization admits the contradictions of its participants, whether they metabolize them or not, and an organized system can either choose to repair them or defer them. Alston understood that systems, from the family all the way to capitalism, maintain control over phenomena by choice, not just the state, and that in order to change a system, the procedures of an organization modify themselves through exposure. To remain truly antifragile, organizational systems keep the door open to contradiction and tension without collapse, because if a system is lethal enough to kill people for their differences, it risks foreclosure and authoritarian drift if there is ever a power vacuum that can be exploited. Currently, we are surrounded by lethal systems with the fingerprints of capitalism, Westphalian sovereignty, carceral surveillance, and empire all over the world, and nobody is truly liberated until these systems are completely replaced. Beyond just building new churches in the ecclesiastical hierarchy, we are confronted with the question of how to replace the concept of a sovereign entirely that can mete out death at their discretion.

“I’m tryin’ to live life in the sight of God’s memory.”
– Yasiin Bey, Thieves in the Night (1998)

disc four

AISTHESIS. 300°



The aesthetic form is a semiospheric interface, and beauty emerges from the temporary alignment of forms through that interface. Thus, we can think of aesthetic beauty as what happens when a perceptual system and the environment encounter each other with structural resonance. Following what François Zourabichvili articulates, we deny the strict partition between aesthetics and games. A game is a generative space of rules, which aesthetic experience facilitates through the felt transformation of those rules. The perceptual system thereby models two inseparable layers: one, the sensory structure of experiential interactions, and the rule-based logic of transformation that is structured by experience. Aesthetics, in this regard, models the continuous self-modification of a perceptual system by its rule logic, and a game models the space of how those rules are experienced. Our encounters with art transform the space with each participation of movement, in which we are not changed by viewing an object as an independent observer but by the field in between. Henri Edmond Cross understood in the process of blending coordinates, colors, and knowledge in concentric overlap and exploring the edges, that the process of making art was also the process of making the artist speak into society. The choice of message to convey into the medium is purely at the agency of the artist and the society that creates the conditions for aesthetic value.



The Neo Impressionists were a remarkably precise school of artists who valued method as much as they valued the ethical implications of the art they were creating. Each dot in the painting is meaningless on its own, but when perceived from different angles, and as part of the family of color coordinates that glues the painting together, the entire painting begins to take on new life because the colors start to intermingle depending on where and how you view the painting as a whole. The Neo Impressionists built an entire artistic movement out of inviting the person into the experience of art, where art could be purely interactive despite being purely optical, collapsing the distinction between perceiver and perceived in a perceptual rhythm that allowed experimentation between the lines. This is discretely separate from the spectacle of immersive art, which focuses on maximizing the capital of creative production, interaction of the medium, and minimizing the actual meaning-making behind the interaction, or excluding those who cannot accommodate the stimulation that macro-level immersion entails. Truth in the painting emerges when someone engages with the structure of the painting itself, as opposed to the image the painting creates. Paying attention to the creative process is like paying attention to the person interfacing with the creation in all ways beyond the representation of the image, so that they themselves may be able to traverse beyond the medium to find deeper meaning. The artist, in this process, invites people in to relate to the world and each other and reveal something generative in the act of apperception. The pointillism of Cross emphasized that perception is an emergent property that requires one to look beyond the discrete dots of color to develop insight that would be missed without building the canvas for the dots.



Given that paintings can be viewed from the comfort of one's device these days, that level of perceptual inclusion easily loses the optical

subtlety when one actually views a Pointillist painting behind a laptop screen. This highlights part of the problem that the Situationists themselves navigated: there is a psychogeographic filter in how one interprets an image, the representation of an image, and the reproduction of imagery in a spatially complex society in which the spectacle rules over meaning and abstracts away the capacity for meaning to be localized into shared wisdom. How we relate to living things spatially is how we relate to images relationally. In a highly complex informational landscape that is constantly distorted by disinformation through authoritarian sources, attention feels cheap. Society itself has been cheapened and flattened by the web of spectacles throughout reality, which as Debord argues, focus on dominating lived experience through the crushing weight of representations. Representation digitally mediates the information economy, manipulating the metabolic process of creativity and reducing art to meme. The spectacle mediates the meme, virtualizing reality into a game that someone else is playing. The meme in this case is not the Dadaist image macro or pithy ironic aphorism that we share amongst friends, but the cultural virality of the meme itself which the spectacle accelerates for mass replication. The reproduction of art outside of the social context of witnessing art itself reinforces the logic of spectatorship, where we are passive consumers of a reality that someone else mass produces for our participation. The creative productions and media ecosystem which focus on virtualizing reality into a series of representations are themselves reproducing a kind of authoritarian consumerist logic, where life is contextually severed from meaning and instead of experiencing life creatively, we are perceptually distorted into interpassivity, in which we live as passive spectators to a capitalist spectacle. The pedagogy of inviting the artist into aesthetics feels largely discouraged in a society where creativity has no economy but that which can be mass commercialized for the purposes of the spectacle.

Apparent nonexistent or contradictory objects, in the sense that Meinong uses them, are not as ontological excesses, but as mediating combinatorial operators whose role is to preserve and transport structural incompatibility across representational regimes. A round square, for example, encodes the quincuncial operator that mediates between curvature and rectilinearity. Nonexistent objects function as formal joints that encode incompatibility itself as stable structure without instantiation. We are thus not concerned with what objects exist, only what configurations mediate under a jointly coregulatory environment, and what boundaries they preserve. The abstract object theorists of the Graz school theorized about the aesthetic formation of objects that are addressable, but non-existent. Alexis Meinong and Stefan Witasek deploy non-existence as non-doxastic object formation; that is, the object is configured, but removed from the jurisdiction of belief systems, assertion, or instrumental consequence. The question of whether or not the creative object exists is irrelevant when the primary function of the object is to orient cognition imaginally around the object, or to relate the object by linkage to a confluent phenomena. Insofar as objects can reorganize cognition by pointing or orienting imaginally rather than materially, we develop interaffective orientation with objects through deicognition: the attitudinal and modulation of cognition through aesthetic objects as convivial reasoning engines, but without reference to a belief system or assertion.



An object does not have to exist for the object to have enumerable and addressable properties, and thus the capacity for reconfigured attachment. The capacity for any aesthetic experience to modulate affect or esemplasticity at all proceeds from the framing that aesthetic objects may be individuated in structure without reference to existence. The artistic object operates as a medium for ratiocination precisely because an object can move through us in creative process without needing to carry the consequence of action in the process of object

design. Deicognition does not furnish through the material constraints of cognition since perception does not depend on reference or justified true belief, only the interaction of symbol and address. An object, according to Meinong's notion of a jurisdictional exemption outside being, can be determinate, terminable, operative, or relationally anchored within modes of objectual availability without needing admission into belief or truth conditions; in other words, the imagination can generate an object and even modify cognitive orientation through artistic objects, but only because they do not require justification for persistence or change. In the sense that a vincula is a relation that binds us prior to assent, deicognition is the transport mechanism of imagination to recombine our interiorized orientation around what we habitually relate to and what we habituate away from. Attachment occurs across innumerable modes of presentation regardless of whether objects or causes may exist, and we reorganize affective orientation as a regulatory practice without the necessity of a sovereign authority.



When we consider a sign system or its lineage, be they through corporate advertisements or cultural production, a sign generalizes to how we receive unknown knowledge or what one may call null state feedback: something that computes through information and enacted through experience but is nonetheless alienating at its invariant phenomenological core. In the 1990s, Bill Barker experimented with this abstraction through the Schwa comic series, where he depicts a black-and-white universe of signs generated from the command structures of alien lifeforms. Barker's aliens seldom portray the behavior of alien life, and his artwork is skeletal: aliens are portrayed as abstractly monochromatic stick figures over urban architectures, with geometric forms that are more visible than the details of the actual buildings themselves. Some of the pages just depict a rectangle with a + and - charge that resemble a battery, some are just two-dimensional

coordinate systems with dots, some pages contain trees while others contain spirals, and many are grid-based depictions of anti-alien propaganda deployed by the Schwa Corporation, which simultaneously represents a corporate firm, a militant resistance struggle, a cult, and a psychological battery of tests often all at once between nonlinear page sequences. Barker was widely ahead of his time in a way that film and literature can barely approximate, but what lies underneath his deceptively simple technique is a precision engineering for how to abstract away the details of how a concept is represented and demonstrate how it can influence a reader from multiple vectors at once across a field of possible interactions that they could have to the core Schwa universe. At its core, which it lays bare for the reader, you could interpret Schwa as an allegory in comic form about reception to unfamiliar ideas outside of our comfort zone. The Schwa Corporation needs to manipulate the reader aggressively through propaganda and personality tests, but the aliens never speak or assert themselves; rather, we sometimes see them traverse through the space of the city, but we never hear them demand attention and they never announce their presence. Like the actual linguistic structure, a schwa paradoxically never stresses a vowel sound or adds tone, only the propaganda campaign representing the aliens adds the tone post hoc. Barker studied and conveyed information saturation before the modern mimetic information economy proliferated; his entire world is a controlled ecosystem where information is depersonalized, authority is anonymized and seemingly transcendental, and propaganda recurs through compressed but high affect symbols. The phonetic schwa generalizes the semiotic and philological schwa in such a world where a universe of signs forces the reader to metabolize the contradictions that sign systems create through their autological core.



The aesthetics of life at any given time mirror the ethical metabolism and creative autonomy of any given local or global context in which

one experiences life aesthetically. Novalis, for example, recognized that poetry has a thaumaturgical mechanism depending on how one reads or writes poetry; for Novalis, the becoming is the being. Novalis interprets poetry as one medium in which the individual transfigures the values of any given society into a more idealized and coherent shape. Perhaps most evidently, Novalis's meditations on Goethe signify his own traversal beyond the human-scale engine of transformation into the integration of human and world at every scale: "It will not be possible to explain the organism without presupposing a world soul, nor the world plan without presupposing a world rational being. If in explaining the organism no attention is paid to the soul and to the mysterious bond between it and the body, not much progress will be made. Perhaps life is nothing other than the result of this union - the action of this contact." Novalis points to a question of scale and idealism, in which there is no separation between the morphogenetic transformations at a human level and those at the global level, given that all systems mediate transformation through the constant of activity and creative emergence. Novalis is describing a "world psychology" beyond just human psychology. In this universe, Novalis describes mathematics as an "active science" and "all effect is transition." This is not directionless flux at the surface, but a constant mechanism of structured transformation that operates beneath the unconscious - a processual recombination that neither plant nor animal can tamper with, but nonetheless transport through themselves. Linear textual progression can be trivial, in the sense that Foucault can write endless amounts of content before he inevitably gets to the main point that society is disciplined by structures of power. Insight orientation requires you to translate your insight and explore the implications beyond your own analysis. Layers of meaning and scaffolding can be cross-referenced and traversed in ways that blur the line between individuals and interiority, individual and medium, or individual and society. One eventually recognizes in the most difficult parts of the process that they walk away changed, with the capacity to change, and the discernment of knowing the difference between a

container that drives change and a prison that compromises change and immortalizes error. Aesthetic experience, and the curiosity to both experience and practice aesthetic expression, trains our muscle memory in how we share meaning in the world beyond that of our own, and builds inspiration for worlds more gentle than the one lived in the present. This is the framework that allows Novalis to speak from his own practice: "Poetry is the truly absolute real. This is the heart of my philosophy. The more poetic the more true."



Color perception has a pre-linguistic, and pre-phenomenological layer, where an abstract spectral relationship coregulates pattern language as an equal if the aesthetic medium chooses to do so, and one reveals an emergent perceptual order from the spectral relations of symbols whether they are explicit or implicit on a color gradient. Color regulates into decomposition before an object can ever be enumerated or addressed. The color spectrum at each strata of perception scaffolds physical phenomena into stabilized, coherent, interrelated structures as part of a larger space of imagery. One can explore the structural invariance of experiencing color harmonies, given that perception is relativized to the curvature of development, socialization, culture, and history to add the gravitas of context that shapes aesthetic experience. Nobody is ever fully separated from the context by which they live that shapes their preferences and pattern matching capacity, but they also never completely lose the capacity inherent to the practice of pattern matching and harmonization, where structure and participation create aperture that enables vibrancy. Often, the capacity for emergent perceptual development nests within deeper layers of insight orientation when we generalize color to the colorfulness that is possible across domains of life, and often require oscillation between aesthetic preference and aesthetic exploration. We discover through chromatic perceptual emergence that there are perceptual harmonies that occur when someone invites themselves into the subtle

discernment and play between color patterns and shapes. This is how anyone can walk into a lush garden or a forest and immerse themselves in a fully aesthetic experience when there is no art around them, because they recognize the perceptual immersion beneath the aesthetic immersion. Contrarily, when a garden is wilted and a forest is skeletal and barren, one can immerse themselves in the noise and recognize the distortion that appears chromatic. Art offers a scaffold for stable filtration, where perceptual layers preserve their structure no matter if you're painting a mosaic of dots or a mosaic of chromatic layers that eventually reveal the gaze behind the Mona Lisa. Local perceptual phenomena that are layered in a larger dance of perceptual phenomena themselves reveal something in us: there is music in painting, color in pleasure, and familiarity in what one writes about regardless of the time period that transports creative process into materialized form.



Color constitutes a secondary time variable that records survived oscillation (hue), dissipative coherence (saturation), and the remainder of resources that survived erosion (brightness). Color is not an extra temporal dimension or causal force, but a residual archive prior to signal formation. The decomposition of color tracks which accelerations were even possible, encoding bindings of path-dependent memory prior to reflection or interpretation. Within Pontilist art, the optical construction of objects from the filtration of color operates through this transport mechanism without coordinatized points requiring representational emphasis, archiving deformation history regardless of objectual presence. Taken to its conclusion, color is the geometric memory of limits, boundaries, and survival. When this consideration is taken into account, art and creative practice are no longer optional technologies for the production of knowledge, because they are where a living system rehearses survival and repair before formal methods ever crystallize. Without color, cultural production

ceases to survive, which consequently terminates the joint coordination of linguistic form. Variations in color perception exist in parallel across cultures, often with overlapping interplay between the perceptual, the linguistic, the cultural, and the experiential. The Case of the Russian Blues is one particular example in which Russian language has multiple expressions of the word blue: The word for darker blue, *siniy*, and the word for light blue, *goluboy*, are two completely different words entirely, whereas in the English language, we may decide to use light and dark as adjective qualifications to qualify the discernment between light blue and dark blue. These variations are also layered variations on a pre-objectual level as opposed to purely some reducible biological or cognitive level, which is what advocates of the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis may argue in favor of some frail case of scientific racism under the banner of sterile linguistic determinism. Color perception stabilizes the retention of pattern language, that often belies pure chromatic noise, phenomena always have a periodicity to them that both creates the possibility to discover harmony between colors, and also recognizes that harmony has limits before it can be filtered by distortion. Language is a retentive scaffolding rather than a causative process, and in the case of the Russian linguistics which indexes shades of blue, each surviving shade compresses a sharable mnemotechnic archive of joint perceptual labor to convey chromatic expression. Linguistics, color perception, and aesthetic experience are swimming in the lake between perceptual stabilization, periodicity of color constraints, epistemic filtrations of chromatic perception, and layers of stratification for how we organize and interpret color that enable us to recur perception when we discover deeper harmonies behind aesthetic spectra. What remains is the ability to recognize some structural foundation underneath the language and the capacity for exploring resonance when making linguistic patterns that connect word to color.

In this regard, the primacy of objects is not an output of quiddity or haecceity, or a unit of ontology at all, but a stabilized locus in a patterned objectual field. Pavel Florensky introduces the idea of the “reverse perspective” in his meditation on Byzantine iconography. Florensky observes, for example, that the perspective of the painting does not converge into a single abstract coordinate that one views from afar, but by symbolically returning back to the viewer. The vanishing point for Florensky is not the painting, but the actual relationship of the perspective reflected back to the painting. The chiaroscuro one may encounter in classical painting is not so much about the representation of colors at all: “For the task of painting is not to duplicate reality, but to give the most profound penetration of its architectonics, of its material, of its meaning. And the penetration of this meaning – of this stuff of reality, its architectonics – is offered to the artist’s contemplative eye in living contact with reality, by growing accustomed to and empathising with reality; whereas theatre decoration wants, as much as possible, to replace reality with its outward appearance. The aesthetics of this outward appearance lie in the interconnectedness of its elements, but in no way is it the symbolic signifying of the prototype via the image, realised by means of artistic technique. Stage design is a deception, albeit a seductive one; while pure painting is, or at least wants to be, above all true to life – not a substitute for life, but merely the symbolic signifier of its deepest reality. Stage design is a screen that thickens the light of existence, while pure painting is a window opened wide on reality. For the rationalising mind of Anaxagoras or Democritus, representational art as a symbol of reality could not exist, and there was no demand for it.” Florensky describes what one might encounter when one experiences the color gradient of a painting and how they generate shape precisely because the act of brushing gives the paint shape, and the act of seeing gives the paint color. Physical space and local perception establish a mutually intelligible address space between perspective and image, and the image as a whole emanates the world back to us rather than just abstractly mirroring what we project into an image. This motivates a

fundamentally bidirectional relationship with color and imagery, within which one assumes that sense and symbology mutually constitute one another. Florensky understood that symbols were alive and perspective is mutually composed by the participation of both art and viewer.



The Makovets circle extended this reverse perspective ethos in their own body of paintings, playing both with relational structure and local pigments to coalesce art, ethics, and science into the imaginal realm. It is no surprise that Florensky took heed in honoring the work of the Makovets circle in the heyday of the early Soviet avant garde. At a time when Russia was in a particularly fecund creative place following the early days of the USSR, the the dominant movements of the time such as Suprematism and Constructivism, were predominantly focused on how to play with abstract form as play with the ideal, whereas the figurative layer of imaginal representation was competing for attention in the grander scheme of the avant garde art movements within the early Soviet period. Vasily Chekrygin, one of the representative artists of Makovets, believed the artist served a different purpose than just the idealism of the abstract: "The eternal order reflected in all things indicates that their significance is infinite and unencompassable and illuminates the religious essence in the work of the true artist. It is the duty of art-the repository of popular wisdom, rooted in the grey past-to prepare the way for individuals to express themselves through powerful, living images. Art should lead the people to a lofty cultivation of knowledge and feeling, involve them in active, creative thinking, and teach them a sense of values and judgement. Art should permeate life, lending it harmony and cohesiveness. The achievement most worthy of human effort is objective, artistic, constructive work. If life and science are concerned with separate springs of being, then it is up to synthetic, objective art to draw from the welling cup into which both have emptied their waters." This excerpt of the Makovets manifesto signified a departure from what was in vogue amongst the underground

arts scene of the time, and in Chekrygin's case, the ideal was the concrete— the raw, convivial, scientific precision that the depiction of life enchants upon its participants. The Futurist undercurrent that was popular in Russia was focused on the rupture against the past, and in contrast, the Makovets believed that there was a continuity that resonated deeply with an eternal thread that pierced through past, present and future equally to return back to the viewer. Although the Makovets ethos carried some religious tinge, part of that was less a nostalgia for some forlorn primordial past, and instead what they envisioned was a deeper devotion to the future through deep reverence for historical continuity. The Cubist geometry is still there, but through this reverence, the geometry is illuminated by a capacity for generative semiotics that filters orientation through the activity of the viewer, as opposed to the static transaction of the artistic object.



Pavel Muratov emerged in this time as a deep admirer of Italian art and architecture, and to him, the Venetian mirror sang. The Venetian museum was a historical organism that mutually evolved with the people who inhabited the mirror, and part of the veneration that runs through Muratov's explication of Italian art is that he locates the morphogenic structure of Italy through its past, claiming that the soul of Italy can be found not in modernity and certainly not in Italian Futurism which was evoking the intellectual premise of Mussolini's fascism. The continuity that Muratov finds in Italy is what makes its self-differentiable continuity a canonical feature rather than an uncritical yearning for some idealized past. Muratov, like the Mekovets school and Florensky, understood that you could only see the future if you could see the throughline to the future, which meant you needed to see beyond the material form to encounter something ineffable. This is how Muratov can depict what he describes as an Italy in two registers: "...the figure of the aesthete who charges the artist with holding up a mirror to nature and, at the same time,

demanding that the mirror include the private subjectivity of the aesthete observer. Restated in terms of the mnemonic operations involved, this dual orientation requires the elision of memory as a precondition for retrieval of what might be called cultural pre-memory.” Muratov’s meditation goes beyond art and architecture, because it also is about space, time, memory, and how these things constantly interplay with each other in the eyes of the participant. Muratov recognizes in the whole of creation in Rome that culture mediates through the continuity of what appears, prior to what is known or physically sensed, and even what may be remembered in our own context. In doing so, he circles around the felt understanding that beauty is explanatory, rather than merely sentimental. Through the actualization of material life that closes explanation through what appears prior to perception or knowledge, the ineffable gap between the aesthete and the non-aesthete narrows, grounding the fresco in what breathes through a living pattern language.



Part of what Florensky, Muratov and the Mekovets hinted at before their work was subsumed by the concrete material authority of Socialist Realism was an interrogation of the medium of art rather than just the message of art itself. These movements converged around the possibility that art is a protocol rather than a representation or a static image with a unidirectional reception from a singular viewer. The icon is actively mediating in this process so that the sensible and the sublime mingle with one another, transforming art into an activity and a playspace for the unconscious with a set of formal conditions for disclosure and encounter. Artwork serves as its own organizational system by which we adapt to the seams of what pigment and brushstroke reveal through dependence on processual space. Like the Pontilists suggest, we choose to give color and canvas permission to mold the clay of life no matter when we enter and we can revoke that permission at any time through our discretion.

Chekrygin identifies that images can be alive through the artist, and that images are themselves autonomous, moving towards the viewer in ways that transform them. By considering the possibility of art as protocol and permission where life and object are in equal negotiation with one another, we recognize there are structures beneath color, line and point that one cannot just rationalize through, but must inhabit through their emergent capacity to create meaning out of the dough of raw activity. For the Mekovets circle, what makes their continuity particularly significant is that they only gasp for creative emergence for a very brief period between 1920 and 1926, and by then the entire country begins to consolidate around the transition from the NEP period into Socialist Realism, chilling the brief period after the Russian Revolution that aesthetic experimentation could flourish outside of the crude materialism that was enforced at the aesthetic layer by Stalin's ascendance. The pattern here is noticeable: a historical rupture opens the gates for experimentation and identity formation by way of playing with the rupture in a historically precarious period, exploring liminal space, and subsequently experiencing the encroachment and foreclosure of an institutional power structure.



In fact, the dynamic interplay between art and process, and process as dissolution of concrete form through idealized activity is exactly the frontier that the 20th century jazz avant garde was constantly at the edges of. John Coltrane's late career work, especially the Kulu Sé Mama and Expressions era of his work, was the culmination of this sonic journey, in which artist and music are no longer discrete objects but phase transitions within a field of sound. Coltrane understood that there was a deep mathematical structure underneath the sound he was creating, but not through exact execution of scales and notes; rather, Coltrane was subconsciously exploring how to find strange attractors in real-time improvisation. Coltrane never sounds cacophonous or formless, even in his most experimental compositions, and in fact

achieves sonic transformation through precise embodiment of form. Even as one listens to him, Pharoah Sanders, or Ornette Coleman, the virtuosity of their play is consistent even if the sound demands a lot out of the listener. Coltrane's tone circle, released in 1961 on the cusp of the Giant Steps era of his work, reads and looks not unlike a clock or a flower of octaves that preserve their vibrational structure regardless of how they are transformed regardless of interval or frequency between notes. Not only does this portray sound as toroidal rather than concentric, it reveals a more fundamental syzygy about both music and psychology when played at this level: sound and embodiment, when actually stripped of the pretense of their separability, is about how one plays with space, time, tension, and continuous negotiation between them to achieve rhythm.



In this register, the presence of the Saint John Coltrane Church in San Francisco makes perfect sense, because as one develops ritual around A Love Supreme, they recognize they are experiencing a deeply spiritual encounter by which they walk away transformed. There is a reason, for example, Yusef Lateef recorded an album at Electric Lady Studios in 1977 titled "Autophysiopsychic" and referred to his music as such, using Coltrane's tone circle as the basis for his 1981 work in music theory titled "Repository of Scales and Melodic Patterns." Lateef understood intuitively that the human was also an instrument, and that music was not so much about humans playing instruments but about music and self-organized systems in continuous feedback reconfiguration. When Miles Davis enters the picture, the scenery transitions from the interiorized experience to the sonic ecology of sound and space. In particular, his mid-late career bookmark, punctuated by his Aghartha and Get Up With It era, ceases to fall into any genre category between jazz fusion, psychedelic soul, or rock and roll in a way that effortlessly dissolves the boundaries between them, let alone the boundary between music and genre. Several tracks in Get Up With It were written in one

breath as a single performance with deliberate refusal to prioritize downbeat, and In A Silent Way in particular was written largely as one continuous session between two long form improvisations on February 18, 1969. By this point, Davis has fully embodied himself through the continuous relationship between rhythm and transformation, and his template for blurring the parameters of genre are felt beyond this particular era of his music. Whether one is listening to the psychedelic soul of Jimi Hendrix, the long-form group improvisations of the Grateful Dead that defy even rock classification, the greasy funk of George Clinton and Sly Stone, or even D'Angelo's haunted neo-soul in the Voodoo album, the deliberate genre contortion that Davis enacted throughout his time was one of the salient vectors paving the way for entire generations of Black music.



Ornette Coleman developed a methodology called harmolodics which generated the avant-garde free jazz characterizing much of his own explorations of sound. Coleman describes sound as having a more democratic relationship to information than the alphabet, and thus a more generalized relationship to sound and its transformation. In 1997, he and Jacques Derrida sat down for an interview to discuss his methodology in deeper detail. One of the lines that struck Derrida most saliently was when Coleman says during the interview: "Before becoming music, music was only a word." What Coleman describes as music underneath his method is that music as a category could only signify meaning if composed through its transformation of sound. Coleman is talking about sound existing as something you can feel and experience through intonation, harmonics, and tone, but held in isolation, music and sound are conceptually separate unless the two have an interaction. The signification of music only emerges as meaningful in how it transforms sound, and stable patterns in music only emerge through deeply coordinated improvisations, as opposed to score or hierarchy between composer and composition. Coleman ends

the interview with this contemplation on what motivates him to create music: "It interests me more to have a human relationship with you than a musical relationship. I want to see if I can express myself in words, in sounds that have to do with a human relationship. At the same time, I would like to be able to speak of the relationship between two talents, between two doings. For me, the human relationship is much more beautiful, because it allows you to gain the freedom that you desire, for yourself and for the other."



The modal jazz metaphysics of the Coltrane and Coleman era was written from a logic of breath as time, not sentences or minutes. The epistemic water basin of the Ancient Semitic world that Black music accesses through ancestry was a world that colonial time could never access, even if it displayed this art as an instrument for their own inertial lack that they depend on. Miles spoke in a 60 Second interview in 1989 in response to the inquiry that Black music was shaped by suffering: " I haven't suffered and I don't intend to suffer... and I can play the blues." Davis commented that the white artists he collaborated with often lagged behind the rhythm, and when confronted on whether he argued Black musicians were superior, he disagreed. The "in the pocket" feeling of Black music was about music that could drift behind the beat because it was not strictly focused on linear modern time signature or downbeat accent if it compromised the coherence of the sonic field itself. A Questlove or J Dilla drum motif can drag through the meter so that the music may handle unresolved suspension. The grammar of Black musical sensibility is deeply ancient, rooted in a diasporic logic of breath shared by the ancestors as an expression of survival and making the world out of their hands. House and techno, although having been an emergent music phenomena throughout the globe, was predominantly shaped by the likes of artists such as Larry Heard, Robert Hood, Frankie Knuckles, and the myriad of Black artists and participants, who in their own exploration of rhythm and sound,

asserted a kind of cultural sovereignty, mutual community safety, and reclaiming of meaning in Black music that regardless of attempts at recuperation, could never be abstracted away from its roots once you trace the genealogy of the movement and refuse its abstraction. The sovereignty is in and of itself irreducible, and the idea is born autonomous; once you create it, it only expires once forgotten. The memory of a timeless cultural artifact is contingent on transport, even when the present chooses to forget.



In Paul Virilio's meditations on the abandoned military bunkers in Germany following WWII, he observes that the abandoned industrial landscapes in postwar Germany endure as objects that shape an environment long after they actively govern the perimeters of their jurisdiction. The bunkerized institution, even when memorialized through photograph or museum exhibit, mutes the empty space around it and refuses witness beyond architecture where meaning withdraws from time. As he describes the artifacts left behind by the chief Nazi architectural planner, Albert Speer, Virilio expresses how military technology shapes atrocity at scale: "The Doctor Jekylls were not necessarily physiologists, as Speer the architect explained: for his Mister Hyde, "his consciousness of having a political mission and his passion for architecture were one and the same." It just so happens that this explanation suited Speer as much as it did Hitler, the passion for architecture simply preceding his passion for politics." Systems with a custodial duty to manufacture violence, including prisons, torture sites, concentration camps, and detention centers, wear the constituent logic of military architecture as a credential. Through this jurisdictional license, these institutions engineer the aperture of how admissible their violence appears to the world. Sometimes, the most visible architectures on the outside are the ones that speak the loudest when the custodians of the architecture no longer determine its future.



The military bunker does not offer narrative redemption, only a shadow of an expired technology, fossilized into residue that resists compost or future. The decision to inhabit abandoned industrial architecture that cannot be replaced has historically been answered through the deliberate act of regeneration, care, and recomposition of space in conditions of surplus abandonment, where material logic offered no consolation. Early underground rave culture in the 1980s, developing throughout Europe with the emergence of acid house, gabber, and dub techno, reflected a different type of contingency entirely: the fall of the Berlin Wall, and the Soviet withdrawal, which resulted in an abundance of abandoned property just within Germany alone. Early warehouse rave culture was what one may call a squat or urban exploration today, where collective anonymity and semantic irreducibility converged towards the development of temporary autonomous zones in abandoned industrial land by which raves could be organized. This type of rave culture dissolved any notion of hierarchy or traceability between individuals, and assumed no barrier between the performer and the audience that could make either of them identifiable to the other. Rave culture during this era was about circulating a place of collective safety in a precarious time, in which the transition out of the Cold War required a cultural intervention that treated space as a residue of jurisdiction. EDM today is an industry, and this industry does not operate on this spontaneous autonomist ethos, frequently requiring electronic musicians to build a brand in order to survive. Brand identity as primacy for musicians assumes easy traceability, commodification of brand as abstraction of art, and semantic reducibility, which in turn commodifies music and musicians. The music is the industry in such a model, and the performer sits atop the audience in creating social space. Culture is always a self-coordinated assertion of one's lineage and creative legacy, but even if the dominant authoritarian rule in the semiosphere deliberately suppresses a cultural lineage, the continuity of access is always available, and thus the legacy of dance music as

survival and adaptation for collective autonomy is one that can always be reproduced. A timeless cultural idea, like a timeless intellectual idea, will always propagate with more evolutionary coordination fitness than one rooted in commodification, exploitation, and institutional dominance.



Spatial thinking as a contingency of social thinking and systems thinking is an emergent pattern across music, visual art, and architecture. However, facilitating the self-organization and mutual collaboration amongst pedestrians to think spatially about the structures and environments they live amongst remains a challenge. In his own prognosis of the tension between space and architecture, Rayner Banham writes for *Art in America* in 1965 about the procedural urges of modern American architecture that designs homes as impersonal machines filtered for mass market commodification and suburban sprawl: "The "house is little more than a service core set in infinite space, or alternatively, a detailed porch looking out in all directions at the Great Out There." Living things often find themselves fraught with the particular constraints of living in a world where they are often robbed of the capacity to autonomously determine how to design the spaces they live in. The logistics of a building, including its HVAC and material systems, are often treated in the present as primary authors that condition the visitor of a building whether the load beams can actually be seen upon entry. The sprawl of contemporary suburbia accepted that homes were commodities to be mass produced, and anything manufactured for industrial efficiency forsakes design grammar or the pattern language generation of the layperson outright. Suburbia has no intentional vocabulary other than selection pressure by industrial outcomes, and the prioritization of servicing systems as the locus of home infrastructure. We are carried by a trajectory where the geometry of the spaces we dwell in are chosen by zoning restrictions, real estate brokerage classifications for neighborhoods,

building codes, and asset mergers, all of which immediately select against the autonomy of people or the natural world, designing against the creative norm of the space they inhabit. The current stage of society is one in which a substantial amount of land in the West is privately owned already, many cities in America are designed around the automobile or highways, and any development is forced to go through the war of attrition fomented by planning committees, municipal governing bodies, permitting processes, legal contracts, and a myriad of other inexhaustible hoops only a corporation and city planner can jump through in order to build architecture in the spaces people live, and yet the people who live in these spaces have no say in the curation of social space beyond the castle walls of private property ownership.



Following Banham's diagnosis, Manfredo Tafuri takes the idea seriously that architecture is inseparable from capitalist production. Tafuri accepts the premise that capitalism preserves no autonomy for the built environments produced by architecture, and the modernist evolution of Bauhaus and CIAM reflect this tension between aesthetic differentiation from material structure and material irreversibility that reorganizes people in lived space. In a 1974 lecture series at Princeton University, Tafuri expresses plainly his own reservations about the gratification of architecture as a self-anointed utopian guild: "Today, he who is willing to make architecture speak is forced to rely on materials empty of any and all meaning; he is forced to reduce to degree zero all architectonic ideology, all dreams of social function and any utopian residues. In his hands, the elements of the modern architectural tradition come suddenly to be reduced to enigmatic fragments, to mute signals of a language whose code has been lost, stuffed away casually in the desert of history. In their own way, those architects who from the late fifties until today have tried to reconstruct a common discourse for their discipline, have felt the need to make a new morality of content. Their purism or their

rigorism is that of someone driven to a desperate action that cannot be justified except from within itself. The words of their vocabulary, gathered from the desolate lunar landscape remaining after the sudden conflagration of their grand illusions, lie perilously on that sloping plane which separates the world of reality from the magic circle of language.” Tafuri’s position follows an adjoint of his application of Marx, and if we apply Marx as an architectural critic, he diagnoses the exact design parameters where capitalism fails at the level of how space reorganizes and conditions movement. In his criticism of 1970s postmodern historicism, Tafuri denounces the language game of architects like Robert Venturi and Aldo Rossi who instrumentalize the aesthetics of history for commodified affect, and recognized that the most honest position architecture could take was to accept what built environments could not convey honestly, against the utopian judgments of the post-Corbusier modernists or the historical naivety of the postmodernist architects. Architecture is not above ideology, and does not liberate or escape into freedom beyond auditing how architecture registers unfreedom through material deficits and waste. Tafuri’s vision of an analogous city, by way of his collaboration with the Gruppo Architettura, strategized about a more archaeological approach to design that constructed space out of the montage of fragments in historical memory, exploring the cumulative index of buildings, urban space, material use, and typology across places and epochs to reassemble built environments from novel reconfigurations. The reconstruction of the city came first as what Tafuri recognized was metaphor or analogy, and the literal construction of a historical past was downstream of present imagination.



The symbols of force which dominate physical space, including highways, roads, and surveillance technology, enforce a particular relationship to space in which knowledge becomes a casualty of abstract time rather than unplanned place-based time. Whether one is dealing

with the speed of a car or the regimentation created by the traffic system, one is always subordinating their body to a machine, and the machine becomes both an instrument and the instrumentalizing force that demands life to encounter the extent of its powerlessness. The Italian architect Giancarlo de Carlo invites in a potent alternative to such a dominant approach, in which his architectural philosophy compassed one where design was mediated by shared activity rather than forced post-hoc consumption. For De Carlo, the ethics and the politics were never separate from the architecture, and his particular opposition to modernist architectural dogma was exemplified in his own participation in anarchist and anti-fascist Italian formations throughout the mid 20th century. De Carlo gave an inaugural address to the Royal Institution of London in 1978 titled "Reflections on the Present State of Architecture" in part of which he asserts: "...the aim of architecture is not to produce 'objects' but to give organisation and form to the space in which human events occur to develop 'processes', which eventually give rise to physical configurations, but in fact begin before these configurations materialise and continue after their dissolution, living on in the memory and projecting themselves on other processes." De Carlo pushed back against the prescriptive Modernist ethos of the time to put the user last in the architectural design process, and instead proposes an architectural approach in which spatial thinking is mediated by process and activity, where people are allowed to go in the direction of what they desire from social space and participate willingly in this process of determining the shape of what becomes a structure. This approach to architecture recognizes that the form is mediated by the ideal, which is not just the building but the entire relational structure surrounding the building, that of which participates in the process of shaping the spaces they live and living in them.

The advent of the automobile as the primary mode of transportation by which all spatial memory is a design from above by planning committee and municipal planner is perhaps the most visible artifact of 20th century fascism and colonialism. The automobile emerged from the genealogy of multiple 20th century modernist visions—Italian Futurism’s glorification of speed and violence through Marinetti’s Futurist Manifesto which Mussolini later appropriated, American Fordism’s dream of mass conformity which aligned transparently with Nazi Germany, and Cold War era military-industrial demand for logistical mobilization—all converging into spatial logic that prioritized machine motion over shared intimacy and ecological memory, as well as social space as subordination to power. The highway system is fundamentally a racist monument that deserves to be eviscerated and demolished if one were to target the colonial nomenclature of modern cartography. Highways were deliberately routed over Black neighborhoods as one of many deliberate forms of displacement and containment of Black communities including but not limited to segregation and redlining, and Robert Moses himself made a point to prioritize urban renewal as a means of removing Black communities from urban life in New York City. In many ways, the modern phenomena of urban gentrification casts the formal shadow of this trend over contemporary cities, resulting in geographies where space is about power and development is about exclusion of surplus population rather than cultural revitalization. Gentrified urban spaces often cater to transient professional populations with limited ties to the social life of the city, resulting in vacancies for prime land. Modular units, designed with homogenized materials and aesthetics, tend to be unaffordable to all but the wealthiest residents, reinforcing the gap between the most affluent and the most marginalized communities while eroding everything in between. Car dependency as a whole alienates drivers from each other, benefits absolutely nobody except the auto and petroleum industry, and creates a permanent debtor class of people who are dependent on a financial albatross as a permanent fixture of their cost of living.

The fascistic worship of speed as freedom and the stark juxtaposition of beauty and violence anchors this core operating logic of an object-oriented society in full detail, both on the earth and in the firmament. Marinetti opines in the Futurist Manifesto with the fourth core tenet: "We declare that the splendor of the world has been enriched by a new beauty: the beauty of speed. A racing automobile with its bonnet adorned with great tubes like serpents with explosive breath ... a roaring motor car which seems to run on machine-gun fire, is more beautiful than the Victory of Samothrace." Motion without constraint erodes attention and presence, and promotes an addictive psychopathology of unresolved eros, but it cannot cleanly fulfill an entire society without devolving into alienation and violence in every corridor by which we live and now plan our world around the logistical emphasis of social space as opposed to the creative spontaneity of encounter. The Italian air power theorist, Giulio Douhet, was more explicit in the aerodynamic register of this logic in his work, *The Command of the Air*: "No longer can areas exist in which life can be lived in safety and tranquility, nor can the battlefield any longer be limited to actual combatants. On the contrary, the battlefield will be limited only by the boundaries of the nations at war, and all of their citizens will become combatants, since all of them will be exposed to the aerial offensives of the enemy. There will be no distinction any longer between soldiers and civilians. The defenses on land and sea will no longer serve to protect the country behind them; nor can victory on land or sea protect the people from enemy aerial attacks unless that victory insures the destruction, by actual occupation of the enemy's territory, of all that gives life to his aerial forces." The unalloyed terror of aerial warfare is explicit as the psychological mediating force of modern combat, in which the freedom that speed and space offer through aerial warfare serve less as a concrete mode of artillery and more as an abstract surveillance technology, where one surrenders fully to the authority of the machine as it reigns thunderously across the sky. Speed and surveillance in

tandem both outgun and outpace agency of living beings, transforming reality by destabilizing the world into a forensic battlefield.



The Situationist artist, Constant Nieuwenhuys, whose mid-century vision of New Babylon imagined urban space as a site of liberated movement and creativity, described his vision of New Babylon as a city of the future as follows: “The project of New Babylon only intends to give the minimum conditions for a behaviour that must remain as free as possible. Any restriction of the freedom of movement, any limitation with regard to the creation of mood and atmosphere, has to be avoided.” The vision of New Babylon carries an echo of what Anatole Kopp identifies as the “social condenser”, initially deployed in interpreting the role of the early 1920s Soviet architectural avant-garde rooted in the nascent constructivist movement. Kopp observed in the context of the pre-Stalinist era of Soviet architecture how social space was not a physical building but an instrument to reconfigure the conditions of organized social life, spatiotemporal habituation, and the fluidity of movement. The social condenser, conceptually associated with Moisei Ginzburg and the OSA group, was an engineering modality that located architecture as a method of qualifying how the composition of social interactions are mediated or restructured by infrastructural form and spatial dynamics. Although the social condenser model initially applied to the development of Moscow in the 1920s, its method of architecture to deconstruct social hierarchy and facilitate communal activity applies to the contemporary context as a modality for planetary infrastructure, by which we consider how material form and social space intersect to satisfy the constraints that make freedom of movement possible. If any community were to consider a project in common with all other communities, one of the major endeavors would invert the infrastructural hierarchy that currently privileges highways and individualized automobile dependency, rendering large-scale road systems obsolete and reclaimable as social, ecological, or public transit

space, alongside the reconfiguration of terrestrial transit that spans across discrete landmasses and between continents. The eventual outcome of such a proposal would reorient entire future generations of people from needing to own rapidly depreciating and expensive assets in order to survive. Urban centers could connect to regional landmasses through an autonomous rail system, and regional land could connect to the total perimeter of the landmass through a distributed network of magnetic levitation pods in low pressure tubes.



At the intercontinental and global layer, high-speed transit could extend through subterranean or submarine tunnels maintaining near-vacuum conditions for rapid, frictionless travel between continents. These conduits would form a planetary circulatory system—an infrastructural bloodstream—bridging communities together through shared motion rather than fossilized isolation on decrepit roads. This system, incidentally, would be safer than car dependency because it doesn't create a permanent spatial architecture of diffuse, soft targets for potential conflagrations such as car crashes or isolation in suburban sprawl. Space normally reserved for roads would just instead be social space for spontaneous interaction and conviviality rather than extending the logic of planning and logistics into the totality of social interaction by needing to drive everywhere or plan around where to live based on mobility access. Freight would consolidate into the rail-vacuum network in such a model, optimizing logistics through a planetary logistics skeleton that ensures connectivity for resource flows while superseding short and mid-haul aviation, repurposing airports as multimodal terminals for global travel. At high altitudes, atmospheric corridors would still be viable for long distance aviation. Seasteads could evolve from isolated market libertarian tax havens to floating interchange terminals that power nearby transit lines, connect undersea routes with surface habitation, and steward marine protected areas (MPAs) from biodiversity loss. Similarly, the entire

planetary network of islands and archipelagos would exist as equal ecological and infrastructural participants in such a model, given that our current exclusionary relationship to mobility pressures them into extractive peripheries for wealthy tourists. Islands currently inhabit a territorially compromised position in the global world system where they are extracted from through rich tourists and designated as surplus by global logistics networks, often more expendable to the supply chain on account of being more remote and resource-intensive to integrate as efficiently into shipping routes as the imperial core. As opposed to being terminals of extraction, along with other peripheral communities in the world system, islands become nodes of ecological stewardship with immense local domain knowledge on their own biodiversity, connected to the rest of the world system as a site where terrestrial and marine infrastructure freely exchange knowledge and resources as equals. This level of integrated mobility and connection globally would facilitate the process of islands to reclaim their autonomy over their relationship to marine ecosystems and resource sharing for wayfaring travelers who can therein expose themselves to crucial experience in stewarding the marine layer. The emphasis on tourism industries in many archipelagos risk particularly damaging trends to the marine layer, including coral degradation and overfishing, and island communities in a more integrated planetary transit model instead can devote more spaciouly to accessing knowledge on their biodiversity, sustainable fisheries, and indigenous custodianship, all without any of their unique vulnerabilities that come with the risks posed by climate change. Personal Rapid Transit (PRT) models cease operational coherence in this model as a substitution for mass transit or individualized rail alternative, and function more through localized scoping and continuous flow dynamics without user-level timetable negotiation. PRTs are only uniquely useful when deployed as continuous-flow, non-deterministically scheduled systems operating at highly localized scales such as campus connectors, hospital districts, dense pedestrian cores, or last-hundred-meter logistics zones. Their function is to smooth micro-mobility gradients, not to replicate the

logic of private automobiles. When PRTs are treated as pseudo-cars by offering individualized routing guarantees, exclusive occupancy, or city-scale substitution for synchronized transit, they collapse under congestion and negate the metabolic advantages of shared infrastructure. In a planetary mobility system, PRTs exist only as flow-equalizers at the periphery of rail, never as autonomous systems of circulation in their own right.



The challenges such a model would entail would take generations of infrastructural development and extensive levels of international cooperation, reconciling the infrastructure replacement question around the last mile logistics problem, along with tackling an enormously complex suite of engineering constraints. Planetary rail corridors entail governance as transnational commons under global circulation protocols and common carrier obligations, as opposed to the current approach to rail as municipal infrastructure subject to parcel-level zoning logic. The city is not the maximal unit of coordination and social stability, but is often relegated to this position alongside the perception that rail serves as a neighborhood amenity that the wealthy organize their lives around. The urban form is a downstream consequence of the planetary circulation infrastructure. When we assume the urban form is primary and common carrier coordination is secondary, we may also inherently assume planning authority is centralized but coordination of resources is not. Shipping lanes, air corridors, undersea cable, GPS satellites, and maritime regimes would never survive the discontinuous veto bureaucracy of a municipal zoning board, and we are suffocating mobility when rail governance is ambiguously conflated with stations or ports. A structural endeavor of this scale would likely require formal verification engineering as a construction principle, beginning not at the level of hardware description but at the level of rewrite-first, time-aware system semantics. Core mobility, scheduling, and coordination constraints would be specified as dependently typed

rewrite systems with explicit temporal invariants, from which schedulable execution models are derived. Only downstream of these verified rewrite semantics would microarchitectural realizations be generated, with register-transfer level (RTL) descriptions serving as compilation targets rather than primary design loci. Verified microarchitecture, equivalence-checked RTL, and proof-verified firmware thus emerge as consequences of temporal correctness, not as its source. The result of this common carrier rail model would substantially reshape human connectivity and mobility beyond our current models where social space is something that is shaped by industry, automobile interests, and urban planners instead of generative human activity. In other words, the coordinated planetary infrastructure for mobility serves the purpose that emancipates human-scale communities to reclaim intimate shared social space without the extrinsically forced configurations that car-centered planning carves out against their will, giving local communities the freedom to design space that does not revolve around parking and traffic flow. This requires a completely different relationship to speed and social space, where social space is not freed by each person moving at a higher velocity but by everyone moving together smoothly and collaboratively in a synchronized flow. The challenges of this level of coordination are nontrivial, but not unprecedented, given that GPS and the internet began with the perception of impossibly complex international projects that demanded enormous global cooperation to implement. The goal is not infinite acceleration, but planetary coherence through the unification of human motion, freight, and habitation into a single metabolic system that minimizes friction, waste, and alienation.



The megastructure work of the Japanese Metabolists offers both a significant precedent and a cautionary tale for this kind of infrastructural task. The Metabolist architects conceptualized buildings as organisms that were constantly prone to adaptation and evolution

of local urban populations in the context of post-WWII Japan. They envisioned a sort of Bio-Tokyo as an urban ecosystem where buildings grew like eukaryotic cells: "We regard human society as a vital process - a continuous development from atom to nebula. The reason why we use such a biological word, metabolism, is that we believe design and technology should be a denotation of human society. We are not going to accept metabolism as a natural process, but try to encourage active metabolic development of our society through our proposals." One of the founding members, Kisho Kurasawa, proposed the modular capsule as what he described as "cyborg architecture": "Future society should be constituted of mutually independent individual spaces, determined by the free will of individuals. Systems are necessary but our policy should be to develop the possibility of acquiring greater spaces for individuals on the basis of the system, not one to reduce the spaces for individuals to conformity through the instrument of the system. Given this proposition, each space should be a highly independent shelter where the inhabitant can fully develop his individuality. Such space is a capsule. This is the meaning of the proposition that the capsule aims at a diversified society. The capsule is planned for perfectly free action, formed for perfectly free movement. The system, too, has its own type of movement. The movements of the capsule and the movements of the system are sometimes contradictory and sometimes coincide. The growth of the system sometimes triggers the grouping of capsules. In other words, the theory of multiple structure - that a system (and its units which are generated in the system) should have its independent laws of motion - also applies here." Kurosawa, like the rest of the Metabolists, understood that megastructures and flexibility were not contradictions in terms, and that participatory social space requires nonlocal architectural mediation by way of modular infrastructure. The structural coupling of these principles was even more exacerbated by the graphic design work of Awazu Kiyoshi, whose visual poster for the publication complemented Kurasawa's presentation of the work at the Expo' 70 in Osaka. Awazu's poster juxtaposed traditional Japanese folk imagery with deliberate

futurist aesthetics, wrapping the entire design ethos in a continuity that signified a dynamic interfusion between historical memory and spatial futurity. The culmination of Kurosawa's work in Ginza, through the Nakagin Capsule Tower, exemplified a particular choice that bridged design theory and application through 140 detachable capsules bunched on top of one another in a highly futuristic mixed industrial space. The tower was both a design marvel and an omen for when megastructures are applied to the needs of industrial capital – the demolition process for the building initiated in 2022 after decades of deterioration, in which only 30 of the capsules were rented for dwelling and the rest of them were exclusively used as commercial property or abandoned entirely. Part of the gap entailed both a need for a genuine cyborg architecture, but one that with cyborg feedback loops built in that responded to local need while also allowing local knowledge to transform the space in both directions. In this sense, the planetary rail requires this level of autonomy to adapt as an organism as the Metabolists intended, because without the participatory design ethos that empowers creative emergence through spatial thinking and building, even bionic architecture risks institutional capture and exclusion to all but those who can afford to dwell in the beauty of cyborg architecture. Metabolic design is adaptive and modular yet distributed in spatial intelligence, encouraging architecture as hospitable participation rather than spatial enclosure.



Theodor Adorno writes: “New art is as abstract as social relations have in truth become.” From this thesis, we depart from the tragic fatalism that Adorno and the Frankfurt School circles around, by offering an alternative: The artist picks up their sword and shield, and asserts that life has shared meaning and ritual beyond the transactional, and chooses to refuse commodification by working through it. The poet decides to witness, and in creating the laboratory of the witnessing, designs the proof. Charles Sanders Peirce discusses

the concept of musement through his writing in *Evolutionary Love*, by which he describes the creative process of the Muses that the word amusement adjacently is derived from: "It is as easy by taking thought to add a cubit to one's stature, as it is to produce an idea acceptable to any of the Muses by merely straining for it, before it is ready to come. We haunt in vain the sacred well and throne of Mnemosyne; the deeper workings of the spirit take place in their own slow way, without our connivance." Peirce indicates that free, creative inquiry into the world of novelty precedes the formalization of scientific inquiry, and drives the possibility to have any dynamic of activity at all that generates culture and survival. The creative form emerges where memory is worked through without the promise of correspondence between spirit and letter. Creativity's first sources are cultural mnemotechnics alongside the *ars vitae* of activity, and that long memory gives us the sculpture of artifacts. Thus, the task of the artist is the task of everyone else: the modification of memory that repairs synthetic disparity between subject and object, irony and sincerity, as well as self and society. The aesthetic experience replicates, but the artist mediates and participates. There is no surprise that many creators across creative mediums often unify around the context in which art is shared and coordinated with the world, because the artist coordinates socially even when their production is personal. Marshall McLuhan explicitly noted in *Understanding Media* that the artist is always engaged with a detailed history of the future because they are the only person aware of the nature of the present. Thus, the artist can be best understood as the mediator between the culture of the current world and the culture of the next world, given that the creative process always sits as a phase inversion that generates the vitality of life through the evolution of the culture that evolves with its creative practice. The aesthetic practice is how a social world rehearses the possibility of its future.

ATHANOR · 330°

★ ■	⇐	⇒	↓	↑
II	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○
▽	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○
≡	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○	★ ■ _____ △ ○

★ = Disc ■ = Azimuth △ = Strata ○ = Mode

Ontological Strata [Being]	Engagement Mode [Becoming]
Meaning How is semiosis and meaning-making practiced?	Action How is the activity coordinated through time, matter and symbol?
Organization What is the composition of the social organization? (Actor-Object, Actor-Network, Actor-Sign, Network-System, Network-Object, Self-Society, Society-Environment, etc.) This the space of reason by which experience composes.	Conversation How is the activity jointly coordinated through mutual conversation according to the organizational format?
Activity What is the current embodiment, pattern embedding, practiced extension, and or coordinated enactment? How is this socially mediated through conversation?	Thought How do we internalize activity into pattern language?
Instantiation What is the place and the event of the occurrence? Were you awake or dreaming?	Play When do we explore and play without a prompt?

⊗

The above artifact is a 256-cell combinatorial matrix for transversal of the text. This is a bounded combinatorial device that the reader can rotate which limits the space of possible moves. The schema constrains orientation rather than interpretation. The following executable format applies:

Symbol	Executable Axis
★	disc I · II · III · IV
■	azimuth 90° · 180° · 270° · 360°
△	ontological strata Meaning · Organization · Activity · Instantiation
○	engagement mode Action · Conversation · Thought · Play

The reader may either roll a dice to select a set of 2–12 pages to search and annotate the text, or choose ★ and ■ freely. For △ and ○, either a four-sided die can be tossed to select a strata △ or mode ○, or both may be chosen by preference; one can also be rolled while the other is freely chosen. Each cell is an 8-bit word instantiated by composing the four categories of the tesseract. Each cell composes from the four combinations as its foundational axes, but the patterns and discoveries emerge through bounded exploration of their combinations.

For example, the reader could sample: I-60-Mng-Act (Disc I, 60°, Meaning, Action) to compose a divination $\Rightarrow \nabla$ named at the reader's discretion, based on a reading and reflection of a prose passage in Disc I describing the reader's application of how meaning composes through action. Or, the reader could sample IV-300-Org-Ply (Disc IV, 300°, Organization, Play) to compose a divination $\Uparrow \triangleq$ based on a reading of a passage in Disc IV describing how an organizational system composes through spontaneous acts of play. The pictograms are entirely up to the reader's imagination and are simply provided as anchors. Based on combinations of pictograms, the reader may develop associative maps between combinatorial pairs until an 8-bit composition emerges that allows the reader to create full spell incantations for novel generated thoughts and associations.

The reader may rotate the tesseract at the divination (two-pictogram) level or the spell (eight-pictogram) level to ascend or descend permutations of the divination or spell. For example, $\Rightarrow \nabla$ may become $\nabla \Rightarrow$, causing one ascent through the Being and Becoming strata, transforming the composition to I-90-Org-Con (Disc I, 90°, Organization, Conversation) to describe a Disc I passage in which an organizational system composes through conversational feedback. The reader may also reverse the rotation at the divination or spell level to descend to the previous strata. To determine direction, the reader can flip a coin – heads for ascent, tails for descent – or choose freely. At each step, the reader may also move randomly to any orthogonally adjacent cell. Compositions may be structured as question-answer

couplings or as pure descriptive open inquiry without prompt. Any complete 8-bit composition may itself be treated as a generator of a secondary tesseract.

As an optional extension, a six-cell string can index a sestina cycle from six permutations of 8-bit states (1-2-3-4-5-6), where the cycle recurs through a fixed combinatorial permutation. One recursion from the six-string operator, for instance, transitions into (6-1-5-2-4-3) to embed a cosmogram. This extension can generate spell families organized around an elemental cycle rather than a single divination, with each part interpreted according to the Disc, Azimuth, Strata $\triangle$, and Engagement Mode $\circ$ at that index of the cycle. The reader may enhance their reading through the ritual of viriditas by singing, chanting, whispering, or speaking each divination or spell combination aloud or with a group, integrating deeper insight through tonal practice. The 256-cell tesseract also supports a Knight's Tour traversal constraint, enabling deterministic path readings in which each cell is visited exactly once to produce a complete ritual circuit. Under this constraint, the reader moves in an L-shaped traversal as though the grid were a 256-tile chessboard, jumping (1, 2) or (2, 1) tiles in any chosen direction until the full board is traversed, without floating arbitrarily across the grid. A full game of chess could be constructed from this setup if the reader chooses to explore the tesseract with another person.

PALIMPLANKTOS . 360°



Hafez was the first and last metaphysician. As Hafez sits in the tavern and inebriates himself with the experience of God, then Hafez's experiencing of the shadow is what gives us his God that he worships. Hafez never discloses what kind of wine he is drinking, because what he emphasizes is the experience of drinking. Hafez's wine is not a substance, it's an act with a remainder. We only know that Hafez is drinking. Intoxication does not bring him closer to God or transcend him from Nature; rather, intoxication is his experience of God. The only survived hapax legomena of the Greek word skoteine, which Heraclitus uses to describe darkness as a method of bridging shadowed intelligibility to what is not yet elucidated, is survived through Aristotle as a pejorative to Heraclitus by claiming he cannot explain himself properly. If we preserve the etymological origin of a skotenic method, darkness becomes a teacher rather than a defect, by which clarity is not a guaranteed criterion of truth. The nocturne, as diagnostic, is what reveals insight in caves and journeys into the wilderness at night when light is obscured. Meaning through the skoteine thus emerges through indirection, paradox, and delayed disclosure, and shared understanding requires the transformation of the knower rather than more rigorous definitional representation of terms. Aristotle and later doxographers similarly use the term asaphe to describe how Heraclitus speaks

ambiguously and unclearly, but in the original use of the term, Heraclitus implies the phrase *asaphe* in its literal Greek translation, which entails something not yet made fully manifest. In the fragments of Heraclitus, clarity is not a given of reason as a default state, earned instead through practiced attunement and encounter rather than through definition. In our relationships and our understanding of the world, the modern philosophical posture on knowledge demands truth to be immediately expressible to be admissible, which places the burden of knowledge on interpretive authority rather than on mutual constraint alignment or shared understanding. An *asaphic* approach to relationships implies humility about what we do not yet know, shifting lucidity to temporal and processual calibration even if undisclosed. Our thoughts may be clear, but clarity is something earned through lived practice, or withheld when trust is not earned. The modern terminology of words like vagueness and ambiguity have reduced opacity to indecision, but darkness was something more seasonal and ancient prior to the modern relationship to it in the English dictionary. We can be methodologically *skotenic* without *asaphe* (obscured but internally ordered and honest about remainder) or *asaphic* without *skoteine* (clear but eventually deferred in disclosure, even if not right away), proceeding from the premise that disclosure is a condition of access.



No relationship is unconditional, be they lovers or families, if we assent to the understanding that meaning is not immediately extractable from disclosure. Sometimes, meaning is something we initiate into. Alignment between individuals emerges not in forgiveness, but in attunement and collective mutual repair. Relationships fail when they cease to be accountable or relationally transparent, and proceed instead from the comfort of temporary control and deceit. The statistical prevalence of failed marriages and failed relationships is not an accident when honesty about maintenance and limits is pathologized. The

biopsychosocial literature on kink psychology locates the development of sensation in enactive constraint, where the mnemonic residue of an unresolved unconscious integrates through erotic play. Speaking in tongues is sometimes the only way to reveal patterns before language that we learn to camouflage through lived experience. Within partnerships, the ecologies of shame and invalidation reveal themselves through unresolved patterns of the psyche, and through the repair practice of psychologically safe encounters, these patterns conform to the symmetry of the integrated whole. The ideal partnership reveals something residual between collective units of people that they cannot achieve individually, but that revelation cannot come at the expense of relationality and collaboration between individuals, since it eventually comes at the expense of unresolved harm. Relationship histories are not defined by mistakes one person makes, and they exacerbate from a fog of nihilism and fragmented self-preservation in how shared challenges and local boundaries are navigated between individuals.



Those who reduce development into the fatal determinism of genes and matter situate the primacy of conditions from when we are born. The problem with grafting materialism onto Hegel's classes in his Philosophy of Right, for example, lies in the assumption that the objects are defined only by materialized ontology and the necessity of belief. For Marx specifically, consciousness is the epiphenomenon of material economic relationships by which class consciousness is expected to flow downstream. Our conditions have created suffering for us because they were laundered by unresolved contradictions, violence, conquest, and genealogical trauma without repair. Historical memory is the limit condition by which material conditions are an expression of it within the capitalist system, which remains only one lineage among many that have persisted to coordinate the affairs of social organization in recorded history. Capitalist realism, as the force that crystallizes the world in an amber of time, is the force that not

only keeps an individual destitute in their part of the world, it also leads to collective fragmentation as ideological detritus. Capitalism has crystallized the world in the statue of a temporary artifice, but its authority is historically contingent, because it is impossible to sustain across the entire yoke of time without incalculable loss.



The classical Talmudic dialectical method was situated in a lineage that resolved ambiguity by thickening the contradictions until a deeper structural invariant unfolded underneath the load paths. In contrast, Hegel's dialectic follows from the Kantian paradigm of the split between phenomena (the perceptible) and noumena (the imperceptible), by which he asserts an all-encompassing reality (the Absolute Spirit) is comprehensible through sublation through an self-moving conscious development (Geist). "Universality is perception's principle" is the core tenet of what Hegel describes as a complex whole of universal organizing principles, and "differentiated, determinate property" is what animates the perception of self. Hegel's Spirit, unlike Spinoza's Substance, is never a static entity. Hegel denies the state of nature as a concept in contrast to the likes of Hobbes and Rousseau. The Absolute Idea that Hegel ends the Science of Logic with conceives of a complete realization of reality through the dynamic nature of his logical method, creating a preface to the dynamical open system of logic this work necessitates. Hegel's Absolute Idea rhymes closely with Spinoza's closing concept in Ethics V of the amor dei intellectualis (intellectual love of God), which closer to the Talmudic dialectic that reveals the intelligibility of oneself and world through intensifying contradictions to reveal the durability of infrastructure underneath.



Both Spinoza and Hegel's inchoate concepts of immanent self-development closely resemble the censured modes of thought expressed

by Evagrius Ponticus, who in the 4th century wrote about the pre-imaginal continuity between beatitude and nous through divine knowledge. The desert monks believed the deepest wisdom of the world was interior to the core of what processes animate the world, which is the oldest recorded dialectic of all because it generates how determinations become negations at every scale. Gnostic thought, or gnostika in the original Greek application in what Ponticus uses, was not esotericism in the way that Gnosticism is often associated with, but an advanced chroma of thought that an apprentice initiates into after knowledge matures sufficiently through practice and use. The logismoi implicated in the work of Ponticus was isolated as his contribution, decapitating the larger implications that go beyond closer readings of his marginal glosses in Syriac scholia or the pre-Origenist account of apokatastasis. In some of the surviving fragments, Ponticus does not assume all nous cleanly returns to God, and in the late scholia, he even considers knowledge itself its own form of temptation, where universal restoration narratives do not have the final word on whether continuity is possible. In these fragments, Ponticus implies that God is simply a law of finitude, neither apophatic in absence nor kataphatic in presence, only something administratively indifferent to outcomes regardless of where you go and where you are. If we follow this logic to its conclusion, then God is simply the remainder. Neutrality is something you earn through exposure to attrition without writing off the price of justification. The cosmos, when stripped of ornament, is purely procedural, unanswerable to ratiocination. Human consciousness does not bind the world through propositional absolution. The world binds processes, and those processes are not given meaning by fiat beyond which local procedures are globally admissible. The forest is indifferent to assignment of preperceptual standing if universality is defined by what humans justify as meaningful. Constraints simply terminate processes that violate them.

Hegel's Absolute Spirit is an angel of destiny that deploys itself everywhere but is grounded nowhere. In the flight of the Absolute, feathers inevitably shed on their wings and land in the places where the eternity of the State emerges, almost as benediction by the Spirit. The Nazi jurist, Carl Schmitt, was shockingly sober on his observation in *Land and Sea* that Hegel's world-historic spirit could be found in Moscow, the Palazzo Venetia, or perhaps in the Third Reich: "I had a longer conversation in private with Mussolini in the Palazzo Venezia on the evening of the Wednesday after Easter. We talked about the relationship between party and state. Mussolini said, with pride and clearly directed against national socialist Germany: 'The state is eternal, the party is transient; I am a Hegelian!' I remarked: 'Lenin was also a Hegelian, so that I have to allow myself the question: where does Hegel's world historical spirit reside today? In Rome, in Moscow, or maybe still in Berlin after all?'" Schmitt himself even admits that the force of will has its limits among any group of people, given that any sovereign state form surviving on the coerced myth of its symbolic order would refuse total integration of the world by default. Schmitt does not disclose why sovereignty survives through law, he explains how sovereignty survives through decision-making and juridical exception, and by leading with this premise, he demarcates the failure modes where sovereignty disintegrates. Schmitt already accepts the premise, as an adjudicator of the Nazi regime, that the nation state can never become a world state and thus politically survives through violence to refuse an integrated world where arbitrary harm resolves without exempting itself from repair. Whether Schmitt admits this or not, by the time he accepts the premise of an interpretive hierarchy of adjudicative authority by which politics is a pluriverse of violence, he also assumes the constraint that no adjudicator has the final word. The Westphalian nation-state, like the age of empires before it, exists temporarily in history, just as paleolithic and tribal life existed before it. The Spirit, despite its agnosticism to source or God, is quite theological in scope – it blesses mortal men with power no matter where power emerges and what that power is. The Absolute Spirit can only exhaust

Protestant theosophy until it realizes nature does not wear a halo. Without the assent of constraints, the Hegelian dialectic reveals itself as a teleological void of religiosity in which contradiction recognizes its limits of reconciliation.



Ethical practice does not evolve through historical process in abstraction, only through learned sensitivity to how local interventions reshape future boundaries. There is no global propositional standing the concept of ethics carries beyond our entrainment of how we act and what we bind ourselves to in order to concede with the basic structure of boundaries and maintenance. The Absolute Idea, in Hegel's world, is through the dialectic, and the inevitability of agonism is what unfolds the rationality of the world. In practice, logic has no master, and reality never completes itself without the provenance of flotsam and jetsam. Hegel's dialectical framework as a whole assumes an outside vantage, a representational mediation that is not a field, and agitation into a backchannel transcendentalism that prioritizes symbol over all metaphysical configurations. Logic emerges naturally through an immanent descent into the depths, not sublation into an idealistic conceptual mythos. The dialectic is a sensate logic of internal descent through active continuity of repair, as opposed to a performance of external opposition that sublimates experience into transcendental vapor. The amortization of an ideal form is concretized through the dialectic of nature, by way of immanent origination. Guyau more carefully elucidates that ethics is not reducible to dialectic or Kantian duty, but instead arises emergently from our creativity and vitality. Morality expands outwardly because life itself naturally overflows through shared participation. If Brunschvicg's premise is taken such that morality expands with reason, we could only assume morality expands where reason governs the causal architecture of action, not just the post hoc justification.



The cohesion of infrastructure narrows the relevance of morality unless reason itself is infrastructural, and morality stops expanding when infrastructure outruns reason to consecrate necessity. Following Guyau's insight, moral facts and moral ideas function as patterns of comportment beyond the merely psychological, insofar as long as we can honestly name when a practice exhausts its own conditions of continuity. Morality emerges as a convivial ecological activity, both psychological and physiological, in which boundaries are disclosed through path dependence, shared practice, and fallibility. Ethics is what gives history its constraints, irreversibility, and recurrent patterns, in informing us that our shared habituations of procedure and understanding, not sovereign gods or individual rulers, shape the trajectory of history. The material norms of ethics culminate in procedural criteria for stopping, withdrawing, or refusing continuation when activity becomes harmful or extractive. To expand from Spinoza's coinage of every determination as a negation, we may determine ethics as objective necessity, but our ethical understanding is historically habituated. The Absolute Spirit does not need to inform the process of becoming for what already exists. It is therefore ironic for Schmitt, in his allegiance to one of Hegel's world horrors, to have identified the core contradiction that breaks his philosophy into the fragments made manifest of the Absolute Spirit.



The assertion of the ideal form through a symbolic order thereby contaminates both the concept of existence and the legal discontinuity assumed by externally imposing a frozen concept of essence, simultaneously confusing continuity with static abstraction. When existentialism becomes dogmatic – that is, when it is lived as a maximalist self-referential theater of memory and meaning – it risks collapsing into melodrama, minimizing shared responsibility, and

inflating austere error handling into cosmic referenda on others. The irony is that this is the very distortion Camus and de Beauvoir warned against: meaning is not created in absolute solitude but in solidarity with the freedom of all. The most fully dogmatic adherence to existential analysis without this lens runs the risk of collapsing into pure solipsism, compromising the discernment between existential self-mastery and existential self-assessment, which also requires you to discern what parts of life can be filtered through the maximalism that existential melodrama can accidentally corrode. One may decide if they truly wish to interpret the wisdom of Camus, de Beauvoir, and Sartre that life itself is a cosmic opera that requires galactic appraisal beyond the decadence of civilization, and the troubles of society or other individuals are purely existential: that is, their mistakes and failures are themselves a referendum on the lives they live, and their failures are disproportionately cosmic. The errors that this analysis creates feel more like perceptual aperture errors than actual category errors. Through such a flattened lens, the mistakes our chosen and inherited families make and the probability of normal human error start to feel existential, as if their capacity to make mistakes or struggle along the way relinquishes any responsibility we have over their development. We too, can become monsters, even when we perceive the people around us as monstrous if we focus our lens deeply enough on them as monsters and not as fallible living beings. The existentialists have long struggled with this tension of mirror-image perception, where both the mistakes and the equivalent mistakes of others mirror back as a cosmic verdict on the meaning they create, but when taken to the limit of its letter and not its spirit, existentialism can produce tortured, maximally self-referential individuals devoid of relational semiotic capacity.



Of the existentialists, we can assert that Camus is distinct in that he is willing to do something daring in mid-century France: he is

willing to speak clearly about the condition of life when he has every reason not to. In the context of post-68 France, a certain set of tropes stretched and tore at the seams of the intellectual milieu, in which academic obscurantism was rewarded in the pantheon of theorists such as Foucault and Deleuze, and France was beginning to split into two distinct revolutionary camps: the Stalinist apologia of characters like Sartre and Althusser, or the performative anarchist aesthetics of Tel Quel or the insurrectionist pastiche of the Invisible Committee. This dichotomy oversimplifies the French political landscape, but the contrast is shared in context of what makes bad writing seem like bad art: we often walk away from highly obscurantist writing drained despite our best efforts to understand what it means, or what it has to say about the world, or perhaps more precisely, how we act accordingly. There is nothing hospitable about art that refuses to reflect back reality to the viewer and demands to be interpreted in the name of pure mystery, because often when we confuse mystery with obscurantism, we discover that the floor to entry is low and the ceiling to discovery about ourselves and the world is also low. Camus chose consciously not to write like this – his works maintain his ideological consistency as someone who rejected hierarchy and domination in all forms no matter which camp it stood in, and his existentialism emerged downstream as accessible because of the clarity of his writing, not in spite of it. Camus articulates this with stunning honesty in one of his lesser known essays, *Betwixt and Between*: “I can say and in a moment I shall say that what counts is to be human and simple. No, what counts is to be true, and then everything fits in, humanity and simplicity. When am I truer than when I am the world? My cup brims over before I have time to desire. Eternity is there and I was hoping for it. What I wish for now is no longer happiness but simply awareness.” Camus, much like Kafka, understood that the existential lens at human scale maintained boundaries by its witness of the absurd; in both of their cases, the absurd is observing what the system does when it no longer aligns sincerely with what it says. Absurdism just entails a method of empiricism applied to sociopolitical bureaucracy, and is

far less drama than it is stenography. Camus held his anarchism, revolutionary necessity, and skepticism towards arbitrary violence in constant contradiction as a pied-noir from Algeria who was willing to interrogate and betray his colonial origins, and he wrangled with a more honest expression of life-affirmation because he was in such proximity to it all. The proximity that someone like Camus had to the site of struggle is how Camus could witness the contradictions of the moment without allegiance and arrive at a deeper structural insight than if he insulated himself as a spectator of the struggle. The French intelligentsia at the time diverged from this discomfort and could easily romanticize political causes from the academy without the material complexity that both organizing a revolution and prefiguring its aftermath often entails.



Similarly in Ottoman Bosnia, Mesa Selimovic wrangled with a different kind of exhaustion by which clarity was impossible to achieve through existence alone. Selimovic writes about characters living on the perimeter of life because they could not exist as themselves unless they stood right at the borderland where they could see the whole world for what it was. The borderland signifies something both in our concept of the nation state and in the context of Selimovic's writing, which is that it is the one space where everything is both devastating yet precise about what it reveals: the literary borderland that Ahmet Shabo or Sheikh Nuruddin write from is often like how we think about games, where one accepts a certain set of rules about the world upon participation, and how one observes the world from this perimeter, where material reality or state violence do not catch up to the characters the same way that they catch up to people at the borderlands of the state every day. Selimovic's characters give themselves permission to wrangle with reality by speaking about the structure of the world where they would lose themselves if they wrote from anywhere less safe than where they were. However, games are

never cleanly partitioned from the real world, and this claustrophobia of psychogeographic space feels most evident in how Selimovic writes about his own main characters. The borderlands outside of a literary fortress are a site of routine violence, where nothing about the condition of life is clearer than the violence that is enforced most proximally at the border. The fortress Selimovic writes about feels mysterious to its characters and its architecture opaque to its readers, but not to Selimovic at all. For him, the fortress is the only thing he could build as a monument to honesty because it's the only thing that would not require him to lie as an author or for his characters to speak honestly. Selimovic is writing from 1970s Yugoslavia about a fictional 19th century Sarajevo about an Ottoman rule, decades prior to the Bosnian War, but at a closer angle, it could be written from any setting: "For something had to be mine, for all else was alien, and I'd adopted the street, the town, the country, the sky above, which I'd looked at since childhood out of fear and emptiness of not belonging to the world. I'd taken the world by force, imposed myself, and the street couldn't care less and the sky above me couldn't care less, but I rejected this indifference, I offered them my feeling, I breathed my love into them in hope that they might return it." The viewpoint that Ahmet Shabo entreates the world from in its mortal stygian coil is where he hopes to find something about the world that is eternal, that refuses to distort his perspective, even when other people cannot reciprocate love. Shabo, and Selimovic as an author, could only speak as lucidly as they could by creating a fortress as total as what was written, given that anything else was a compromise on the truth that there is love and there are streets that remember everything around them.



What we call death is a gentler cocoon than silence. Death is the ambient thickness whose smoke is felt even if it is not burning visibly. Each respective death opens the door into the fire, of which the smoke rises and we are consumed by it. The only way to not be polluted by

the smoke is to access the ritual of grief, by which we recognize the conditions of living with smoke that allow oneself to breathe again. But without integrating one's grief and acting as the ferry between life and death, one no longer treads the sea but is instead devoured by the fire with each respective death of those they love and those they know. For this which we call sadness is distinguished from melancholy, which is that sadness asserts that our lack is complete and determines the fate of our lives, whereas melancholy assumes our sadness is raw ore to alchemize into integration with the whole through the presence of grief. Sadness assumes absence of grief, melancholy assumes presence of grief. Grief is a respiratory practice in a world that has remained thick with death for as long as it has lived. The smoke that the living breathe is the condition of life, and upon the transition into death, one returns into this miasma and forever guides the living. But the praise of grieving is a necessity no matter how deeply grief is denied, for without it, we collapse our lungs into the hellfire. We may inevitably encounter death by what is petrified into amber when life can no longer hydrate. Whether the living realize it or not, they are always guiding the dead in the infinite mist, always in circulation. Paul Celan compresses the necessity of death in three lines: "You were my death: / you I could hold / when all fell away from me." Just as one conveys grief through praise, as Martin Prechtel observed, one also folds death into love and intimacy into remembering. Death determines transfiguration as the great afterwards of the abyss by which living establishes continuity. By accepting death as the completion of a cycle, one recognizes the moment in which we cease to be solitary. The dead carry us so we can nurture our shoulders and walk in a straight line towards a coordinate where meaning is still treasured and found. The physically emptiest moment, by which we witness death in our most intimate connections, becomes the fullest structure of our lives and the form we discover in the ashes that scatter. The holding of this experience is the name of intimacy.

The notion of whether to sanction or forgive an individual or an event for harm done, whether they are alive or dead, assumes there is a global law of reversibility between individuals and an encounter, or between place and time that preserves causality as the only absolute. Outside of the acknowledgement of loss, nothing real carries consequence. Forgiveness to an individual is not the goal, nor is sanction the absolute desired outcome towards that goal. There is only memory and there is meaning behind memory, and the most meaningful decision towards reality is one that preserves both without forcing a distinction between mercy and mercilessness. Memory is only a weapon against a system that forces amnesia onto itself, a bludgeon that forces the skull of the walnut to crack open and reveal what's already there. There are places, events, and relationships between places and events. The most honest return from distortion is not to repeat distortion or return back to distortion. Thus, we do not forget in motion, but we do not repeat in rest. Our situations change only when we stop lying about what is visible in limits and irreversibility. There are no shortcuts to recovery where narratives of blame, retribution, control, infirmity, and indignation are wedged in between as anesthetic. We may only recognize information on information's terms as we learn to metabolize contradictions honestly within ourselves, without an interpretative narrative layer that poisons us long after we drink the anodyne of our moral sentiments. An individual who chooses to injure others repeatedly and callously mirrors a pattern of distortion that also begets the hall of mirrors they recognize they cannot escape from. An individual who injures once and learns not to repeat injury has accepted their reflection and the shadow of their reflection. The cypress and the shadow of the cypress grow as branches and as leaves.



When meaning eventually saturates its relevance, we are confronted with the immediacy that action persists because restraint persists. The self disappears when all that is left is the dependency of conduct. There

are two fundamental truths all religions have, whether they accept it or not: the truth that salvation is automatically achieved by everything that's alive or dead, and their truth that salvation is reached through accessing a particular revelation as a trajectory. Given these two layers, one could argue that all religions carry partial truths, insofar as they serve familiar functions in parallel with each other despite unfamiliar traditions specific to their development, but not that some religions are true, insofar as some religions drive you to salvation because others do not. The only logical starting condition is that all religions have contextual value regardless of participation or understanding of doctrine. Thus, organized religion is not so much an opiate but a glue that keeps people satisfied through cohesion, but never activated to interrogate why the glue never feels fully cohesive. Organized religion insists on conflating cohesion with adhesion, emphasizing unity-as-fidelity to doctrine and social norms over contradiction through revision and inclusion. Napoleon's own observation echoes true: the institutions of religion stifle the impulse that would expose the asymmetry why devotees of a religion bind themselves, but not their institutions, or why patristic soldiers act when their deity does not. Religious revelation implies the possibility that people will not spiritually revolt against the false idolatry of conquest and violence to recognize the illusion of ecclesiastical authority over the affairs of history. In Nikolai Berdyaev's recollection of Aleksey Khomyakov, he specifies exactly the concept of a religious institution is a stabilized artifact preceded by organized spiritual life: "The essence of the Church is inexpressible; like all living organisms, she cannot be encompassed by any formula, is not subject to any formal definitions. The Church is, first of all, a living organism, a unity of love, ineffable freedom, the truth of the faith not subject to rationalization. From the outside the Church is not knowable or definable; she is known only by those who are within her, by those who are her living members." Khomyakov locates the most acute concentration of sobornost (joint spiritual life) in the organized landless peasant communities in the 19th century Imperial Russia, glued by joint life under common material risk and

shared labor. Absent the private property buffer, joint spiritual practice does not depend on obedience to doctrine to survive, only the situated regularity of constraint-relative continuity where no insulation exists between habits of life and habits of ritual.



The Avodeh Zarah 3 asserts that at the last third of each day, that which is called God sits and delights with the souls of the righteous in all nations, not as converts to Torah but in spiritual intimacy with the divine accessible to all faiths. We will also emphasize that the Avodeh Zarah assumes rejections of deification of all things not inherently called God that could be admitted as kedushah(sanctity), including celestial bodies, earth-based pagan fertility rituals, lunar cycles, and wine as libation to the gateway of eros. For this we must live the questions and resolve why we exclude wine from eros, eros from God, astrolatry from the cycle of transformation, and the divinity of intoxication with moonlight, earth, and the reflex of drinking that floods us with water. We know ecstasy is intimacy, for ritual could not have been ritual without it, and for this we have seen that light could have only fully immersed in shadow before eros and psyche were ever considered separable. The names of God, that which is known as YHVH to the children of Jacob, by which Jacob becomes Israel only after wrestling in the Book of Genesis with an envoy of YHVH. This ancient tension of known and unknown is what Esau knows of the loss of his birthright to Jacob, and from this we can assume the original bifurcation of Israel and Edom originated from this wrestling between Jacob and Esau, as the bifurcation of two twins cosmically in relation to one another in the same manifold prior to their fragmentation. When read as the mythopoetic psychodrama about how a people came to be, the Book of Genesis ceases to be reduced to territory or statehood and becomes a question about the source of an ungrieved loss left without suture. The compactification of the divine beyond the Ancient Near East fertility rituals and lunar calendrics that glued this world

together proceeds from this core wound, in which Jacob becoming Israel obscures what even the Qisas al-Anbiya observes about the prophets: that Jacob chose the continuity of a covenant, and Esau chose primal inheritance, and this core family wound originates a fragmentation of a continuous whole. This reading does not assume religious syncretism, but insists on the text preserving the phenomenology of a psychic wound by which its literary expression aligns with patterns descended from Near East cosmology.



It is not enough to believe in justice or balance without the termination-aware practice of persistence. The operating condition of persistence comes with the price of retaining discipline until it coincides with the acceptance of finitude. Maimonides carefully argues throughout the Guide to the Perplexed that scriptural interpretation functions more as allegories, pedagogical layers, and context clues as opposed to literalist orthodoxy. This kind of dialectic between faith and ratiocination was designed to reveal the underlying load-bearing structure that animated both, and that by insisting on quarantining one from the other, we dissolve the hinges that render either spiritual practice or intellectual tool mediation intelligible in the first place. The Rambam achieves this intersection by exploring the overlap between Islamic and Greek philosophy, all of which did not customarily police the boundaries of their shared semiotic ecosystem at the time. The hermeneutics of the Qur'an, the Torah, and the ancient Greek sciences developed an interlingua through a shared symbolic ecosystem, meaning that even if their texts were geographically and culturally worlds apart, their grammar was interoperable, and so they could all talk to each other despite analog technology constraints to reconcile ideas into a shared ontology classification system. Underneath the specific classifications of these broader bodies of knowledge, however, the Rambam was practicing a very ancient continuity embodied by the transmission of Torah and halakha between academies such as the

Amoraim and the Geonim: they took uncoded oral tradition and gave it life through textual provenance. The Gemara extends this by applying the common techniques of epistemic deliberation and contradiction repair into the resolution of concrete social problems. The Daf Yomi program of structured collective learning about Oral Torah and Gemara commentary through the daily daf (folio) is a generalizable method that goes beyond Torah and, incidentally, begins to resemble the classical use of responsa to situate pedagogy in community.



Pre-1492 Iberia was history and memory, because it demonstrated under certain conditions by which domination and erasure was not imposed by decree, that people could differentiate themselves along religious lines in a community and not collapse into internecine conflict. The period of convivencia – from roughly the 700s to the Spanish Inquisition of 1492 – was the event by which Christians, Jews, and Muslims found an equilibrium point and could freely choose to coexist as peers without the distorting narrative that such negotiation of cultural and religious boundaries could be ontologically impossible. The trope of structural impossibility of coexistence between Jews and Muslims in particular is one often repeated in the context of pre-1948 Mandatory Palestine, by which diasporism is categorically inadmissible no matter whether it emerges from the Jews of the Old Yishuv, the Samaritans at Mount Gerizim, or the Palestinian Christians in Jerusalem. The insulation of the British colonial magisters is never relitigated or taken into account, because the strategy of tension can just as easily assign blame to any of the specific factions in the ongoing Palestinian occupation. The pattern, whether we are discussing occupied Palestine or post-Inquisition Andalusia, often rhymes in the grand scheme of history: coexistence and harmonization is practiced, an authoritarian regime imposes itself from above by force, the regime dissolves the social fabric, and atomization is facilitated between communities that have traditionally perceived each other in some

capacity as peers. The consolidation of institutional power in the Catholic Church in pre-1492 Iberia created the template for this type of problem, in which harmonization between communities is emergent and then completely severed mid sentence by institutional capture and violence.



The memory of *convivencia* was not unique to the Iberian Peninsula, and even in the 20th century, we observe examples of this pattern traveling throughout the Mediterranean. Mark Mazower's scholarship focuses particularly on this pattern in Salonica, a city in Greece where the majority demographic for centuries was Sephardic Jews who immigrated to the Balkans from the Iberian Peninsula, and were resettled by the Ottoman sultanate. From the 15th century up until roughly the mid 20th century, Salonica developed both as the Sephardic Jewish capital of the Ottoman Empire, and perhaps most saliently, it did so in collaboration with other denominations outside of Judaism without force or occupation. Ottoman Salonica was not utopian or romantic by any means, given that it was a complex ecosystem of Jews, Muslims, and Christians negotiating shared autonomy in a society that accommodated them through the Enlightenment and Industrial Revolution, but it was an ecology of faiths that earned their coexistence by choice rather than being forced to team with one another. This is partly through a concerted effort by all parties to build shared infrastructure themselves to ensure their world could function, unless something else came from the heavens to undermine this hard-built infrastructure. With the rise of ethnonationalism and historical fascism in the 20th century, there suddenly was a meteor that crashed into this infrastructure that was built and maintained for several centuries: the Nazi occupation in 1941 which deported the vast remainder of the Jews in Salonica to Auschwitz, the Greek annexation of the city in 1912 which imposed the Greek army on the city's religious enclaves, the 1917 fire within the Jewish quarter of the

city which annihilated most of the dwellings of the Jewish community, and the forced migrations of their Muslim neighbors following the 1922 Greco-Turkish War. The reality of convivencia is that it is easier to destroy something by severing our memory of it than it is to rebuild harmony in the ashes of instability.



The medieval period between the 9th century and 13th century was most lucid in part because they were willing to integrate and exchange ideas across domains between faiths. The Scholastics, Sephardic rabbinate, and the Islamic metaphysicians needed to construct an entire metaphysical architecture that could inform the world from every layer, starting from the structure of reality onward. Aquinas and Ibn Sina, for example, were concerned with the excavation of all knowledge rather than subjugation, which is how their writing could span from theology to mathematics to medicaments without ever compromising its internal consistency. Each vantage point, whether it was critiquing or extending Aristotle through the lens of medieval Islam or applying ancient Greek philosophy to Torah commentary, concerned themselves less with the affairs of conquest before interrogating the entire metaphysical universe by which reality was constructed. The House of Wisdom in Baghdad, in particular, was one of the largest universities in the world at this period, serving as the Arab world's nexus of knowledge and translation of Greek, Indian, and Persian works for deeper insight into the world that the Arab world was actively constructing. The sacking of Baghdad by the Mongols in 1258 ended this dialogue between worlds in media res, creating a massive vacuum of knowledge despite working through various tensions in astronomy and mathematics long before the paradigm shift occurred through the Italian Renaissance period. Al-Jazari's Book of Ingenious Mechanical Devices, although by some anecdotal accounts was written largely to impress the Eastern Anatolian elite, described a particular methodology of building elaborate machines that were as cosmological as they were

practical, ranging from musical automata to hydrodynamic water clocks illustrated through paintings and instructions to how to construct the devices he envisioned. Al-Jazari's engineering philosophy served a specific role in part of the Upper Mesopotamia he wrote in, which is one where the technical specifications are always upfront so that someone could reverse engineer the machine and figure out how to refine it, rather than sell a product that was architecturally opaque with no clear throughline in terms of whether the problem it solved was infrastructural or simply just placated the sensibilities of the ruling elite. Al-Jazari was building formalized infrastructure first, like the religious communities at the time were tasked with, assuming that a center needed to be built for people to socially interact with one another and share the burden of trust as equals, instead of designating the axial and shear stress of maintaining trust and coherence onto any one individual, state, or institution which could just as easily revoke that trust for any caste or community writ large or collapse under the weight of its tensions.



Beyond the religious and cultural implications, the contrast in the Mediterranean particularly amongst Greece and Spain against the highly centralized nation states such as France and Germany presents a more stark contrast in the preservation of historical memory in these regions and the autonomy their communities afforded themselves through the memory of coordinating without a centralized state to mediate social relations. In the 20th century, both Spain and Greece were sites of highly resilient anti-authoritarian movements against nascent fascist groups such as Golden Dawn in Greece and the Francoists in Spain. Even when Greece collapsed in the 2008 financial crisis, the Greek anarchists responded to need through their own mutual aid infrastructure they built to provide food and healthcare even when the Greek state was in disrepair. Even in the refugee crisis in the 2010s, the autonomous communities of the Greek

left were responsive because they already practiced the theory of coordinated infrastructure to respond when a state collapses, and they continued to do so during the global COVID-19 pandemic. Spain already practiced regional coordination between coexisting religious communities for hundreds of years in the era of *convivencia* in Andalusia, so when the CNT-FAI fought Franco in the Spanish Civil War, and when the Mondragon Corporation continued to model a socially owned economy, there was already a throughline between these epochs in Spanish cultural and infrastructural practice. Between Spain and Greece, a few patterns emerged: they maintained a living memory of coordinating without a centralized state or market economy, just as many civilizations did for millennia, they sustained regional or human-scale autonomy in the cases of Catalonia and the Basque region in Spain, and they developed an organized legacy of coordinated anti-authoritarian struggle even when fascism attempted to take root on their turf. We can say in contrast that the French Revolution preserved the world-historic memory of a rupture in the chain of enforced divine rule from above, but we cannot say for certain whether the centralization of power in Napoleon inoculated France with the same guardrails against the creep of fascism, whether portrayed through the 20th century insularity of the French academy, the Stalinist-insurrectionist split of the French left, or the inheritance of Bergson and Sorel as vitalism that could comfortably cycle through Marxism and fascism interchangeably.



Hegel's mistake in calling Napoleon Bonaparte the "world-soul on horseback" resulted in the interpretation that Napoleon himself was the avatar of felt historical necessity, and not the collective effort of numerous unnamed and unrecognized individuals acting cohesively with one another to transform the regime of feudalism in France. Perhaps what we alluded to as the long memory Utah Phillips called back to comes from this tradition in history to

remember when historians narrated above history about impossible circumstances and when people within history spoke through history and did what was seemingly deemed improbable at any cost. History is unaddressable to human cause or belief, consisting only of archival for contradictions that never fully resolve but instead reorganize under new circumstances. Sometimes, contradictions find custodianship through ordinary people who metabolize them long enough to let them pass. Occasionally, these transport mechanisms find witness in metaphysicians like Eriugena, Maimonides, Ibn Sina, Spinoza, Hegel, and Grothendieck. Other times, they materialize in the aligned momentum of those denied subjecthood on the surface, but never denied the instance of relational movement, be they the organized slave class or the prisoners of Attica. History comes with the price of metabolizing the possibility that anybody but a God, an emperor, or an industry could ever change history, and that a mere mortal could reclaim life on their terms is something that has been repeatedly denied to no avail. Once the genie leaves the bottle, the kinetic threshold of historical necessity moves through the envelope of life by some impetuous gyre of necessity and chance. As Rabbi Mordecai Kaplan argued, in what was a tract resulting in a cherem declaration from the rabbinical community, all religions are subject to the same evolutionary processes as anything else in life, which means that the institutions of organized spiritual life are the sum of their cultural experience, their histories of belonging and alienation, their recipes and literary contributions, and their relationships to the world as opposed to just the source and interpretive authority of their doctrine. Religions are complex organisms that include a spiritual institution, but they also include a jointly coordinated living community, technologies of archive, and the mere capacity for spiritual experience. Stripped of its mythopoetic flourish, religion evolves as an organismic coincidence of shared ritual through action and silence as completion.

Our only alignment with nature is our word and our sword. An action is only simultaneous: judgment and motion are one event, and form arises together with consequence. The esotericism and implied hierarchy of metaphysical source as an exceptional state one must achieve in the nondual tendencies is, in effect, one that has already denied the existence of a source. The decision to act precedes interpretative authority that still determines what is admissible to an encounter. Buddhism, in some of its institutional monastic forms, implies there is a source of truth and we must always go elsewhere to find it. The concept of divinity becomes a phenomenological ladder one climbs vertically, implicitly conditioning a structural lack upon birth that one approximates into transcendence of ego and subject. We are indefinitely disconnected from source at birth, where being born implies a separation from truth that we must fetch through the suffering of life, therefore the nonduality veils a subtle immanent-transcendental duality between seeker and enlightened. What is the use of spiritual wisdom if governed as a proprietary caste system where the abbots adjudicate the novices *carte blanche*, medicalizing suffering and memory itself as if disabilities to be pathologized? Enlightenment is not a medallion that one anoints through credentials to initiate into a clerical guild, and insight is not a disciplinary technology that decays as private property. The Jonang School plainly asserted that the Buddha is eternal and unchanging— a notion that was so radical and threatening that the Tibetan monastic establishment marginalized them and persecuted them directly for threatening the orthodoxy of the Geluk, and in turn the Geluk school asserted that Dolpopa's teaching had distorted Buddhist doctrine. The Jonang notion of *shentong*, as enumerated by Dolpopa, reveals that Buddha-nature is eternally present in all beings, as their ultimate nature which is realized through direct recognition. *Shentong* partly derives its assertions from the *Tathāgatagarbha Sūtra*, which discloses that the nature of the Buddha is unconditioned and luminously innately present in all beings, empty only of all conditioned phenomena. The pre-sectarian Ancient Indian renunciants, namely the Sramana tradition that Siddhartha Gautama

emerged from, went a step further: that the concept of hierarchy and social domination itself was avidya (ignorance), and that all beings share equal potential for awakening. The Sramana circles refused all forms of caste hierarchy, Vedic and Brahmanical authority, ritual as control, the bondage of private property, and sovereignty over the affairs of life beyond that were not equally shared by all living beings in the cosmos.



Ascesis, in the classical sense of the term, simply initiated the severity of practice under constraint in order to dissolve the need for surplus explanation or borrowed authority. An ascetic posture does not inherently mandate deprivation from pleasure or desire, situating only the bondage of action that does not require an alibi to survive. The traditional Western metaphysicians have proceeded from an inverted phenomenological ethic that has been stratified by interpretive hierarchy. The Western phenomenologists, historical mystics, and the Buddhist nondualists have attempted to dissolve the epistemic ladder in different formulas by arguing that enlightenment is deferred, and truth is some passive object that is waiting to be grasped, where some have achieved enlightenment and others are seeking enlightenment. Enlightenment is only amortization when the demand of self-interpretation no longer applies. We arrive at enlightenment as an accounting condition to end grasping, and mortality cancels the remainder of the bookkeeping. It is no surprise then that many white Western practitioners of Buddhism have afforded themselves a colonial enchantment in which mindful rhetoric is appropriated as a badge of enlightenment as opposed to a deepening of the well that transforms the world and dismantles the systemic sources of suffering. The moment you have a mind, death has already arrived. The Western ruling class has chosen to recuperate Buddhism as a way of incorporating mindfulness as a coping mechanism for living under the subjugation of empire. The Vietnamese monks burning themselves alive

in defiance of the Western bombing of Vietnam did not conceive of themselves as suffering in their decision to immolate, but in the words of Thich Nhat Hanh to Martin Luther King Jr: "...what the monks said in the letters they left before burning themselves aimed only at alarming, at moving the hearts of the oppressors and at calling the attention of the world to the suffering endured then by the Vietnamese. To burn oneself by fire is to prove that what one is saying is of the utmost importance. There is nothing more painful than burning oneself. To say something while experiencing this kind of pain is to say it with the utmost of courage, frankness, determination and sincerity." The Buddhist monks who burned themselves alive in the Vietnam War did not do so out of defeat, for they rejected to categorize the act of burning alive as suicide; in fact, for the Vietnamese monks, as Hanh clarified, suicide was an act of oblivion conferring one's sense of nihilism as exceptional to the world and employing death as an escape hatch to the final word on life. When Vietnam was being ravaged by artillery from above, choosing the viability of fire that one generates meant choosing to participate without escape. The monks were not trying to release themselves from pain they believed lasted longer than their lives, choosing instead to coalesce with fire as the only pruning that would prevent the significance of life from being extinguished by violence. What remains the question beneath the veil of choosing life or death at the threshold between them is the question of whether dignity or despair deserve the final say, and whether our withdrawal could ever justify an exit from the living who shoulder the burden of tidying the ferry where the living and the dead must cross. By choosing to persist with the understanding that life proceeds from dignity, we extend the only threshold by which life remains amid all narratives of despair and consolation for what was lost where dignity was abandoned. Whether one burns flesh to reveal the world or one burns words to reveal distortion, every act that fulfills our capacity for witness, or cloaks it in silence and obscurantism, is indivisible from the task of our temporary assignment as living beings: to ignite legibility for others, to refuse tragedy as the sovereign authority of our lives, and

to keep the threshold open for life to remain answerable to the dead without a promise of salvation.



The tradition of sahaja developed similar intuitions to the Sramana tendency, in its spontaneous realization of all in the other is pure and all that is pure is eternal, encompassed a perspective that goes beyond the white and Western perceptions of both sexuality and Buddhism, and in its relative contemporary obscurity in the West and historic marginalization, has been sequestered not only in its time in history, but in our bias towards the present. The Sahajiya Siddha tradition distinguishes sahaja through the coalescence of what is described as surati (the immanent enactment of willpower towards ego-dissolution) and nirati (the terminus of mental flux and willpower towards ego-dissolution), where the separation between seeker and enlightenment completely dissolves as desire renders obsolete, revealing the pure immanence of the world. The Bengali Sahajiya lineage locates this framework in the worship of the Radha Krishna, the avatar of integrated divine masculine and feminine, pure integration in spontaneous embodied sexual experience, as a gateway to cosmic experience. The immanent embodiment practiced by the sahaja tendency, dissolving the concepts of desire and its lack, and revealing the spontaneity of shared embodied ritual against all other illusions. The Hevajra Tantra source text from the Buddhist Sahajayana lineage around the 9th century describes four kinds of joy(samsara, nirvana, the middle state between the two, and sahaja) where sahaja is the fourth and final joy is free of all of the joys before it; in other words, there is no desire or lack of desire, or a middle ground between them, only the nature of the immediate world. As a ritual practice, sahaja determines that reality is something we choose freely, something we embody, and something that is self-evident without force or involuntary bondage. All things are given temporary shape, and in their lived nature, they render the concept of seeker or enlightenment

obsolete because there is no longer a concept of being at all. The Indian metaphysician Ananda Coomaraswamy describes the radical rupture of this tendency in its comprehensiveness: "There is then no sacred or profane, spiritual or sensual, but everything that lives is pure and void." The doctrine of *niyati* (fate) in 5th century Ajivika receives interpretations as absolute determinism or predetermined causality, but underneath this premise is the absence of a salvific narrative beyond the honesty of living. The world may be structurally articulated, but even true explanations do not require an intervention into the world. The occurrence of *moksha* (liberation) happens as a cycle exhausts itself regardless of whether it is deserved. In contrast to the Western narrative of determinism that implies everything is fixed, Ajivika conveys that nothing is ever negotiated, since restraint is a form of life independent of our interpretation.



Prior to even the *sahaja* or the Buddhism of the Pali Canon, the earliest documented Jain scriptural canon, besides the Fourteen Purvas, dates back to around 5th century BCE through the *Ācārāṅga Sūtra*. This early agama (sacred text) defines the soul as something that all living beings have, including humans and plants, but they go further to include the elemental bodies of water, fire, air, and earth as containing the same soul as a human being. This is a spiritual practice that denies domination at the deepest root of the world system by acknowledging the animate vulnerability of nature and the cosmos itself. The refusal of mastery over the natural world, and thus over domination of life itself, begets not lack but the complete dynamic coincidence of evolutionary meaning and the invariant structure of relating to the world. Following from the Jain doctrine of *ahimsa* (non-harming), the principle of nonviolence is often defanged by moralized, pacifist, and affective interpretations that refuse violence despite violence being produced as normative. Violence is often conceptualized as the kinetic act of external force imposed onto others, but in the

context of the Jain application of ahimsa, violence also includes the failed disposition of restraint where harm is desired or laundered. Thus, ahimsa in practice includes not just absence of violence, but the absence of desire to harm others, which goes beyond post hoc moral interpretation of excess and more closely assumes a procedural restraint around desiring harm for anything that lives. An older ethical hinge is one of nonviolation, which restores boundary integrity rather than minimizing force. Violation constitutes an ongoing condition rather than the act of violence, which operates as episodic and discrete. By committing to nonviolation, we do not commit to minimizing force, but choosing not to trespass against the limits of living systems, redirecting the site of injury towards whether a boundary was crossed that was left without repair. Absence of violence is not a guarantee if violence is the terminable recourse when pathological systems persist by violating boundaries through asymmetric power dynamics, or lacking restraint of their own around laundering harm to others. Violation does not just constitute neutral boundary errors, but also structured advantage to trespass and dominate others without repair. Systems that refuse evaluation on whether they preserve continued coexistence that adapts against pathological patterns of harm, by default, have no propositional standing on any exculpatory metric that invokes optics, sentimentality, or intentions.



Nothing in this world matters that can be recruited by us, since this still assumes mattering is the problem. What matters is nothing we can justify, leaving only the execution of action that does not deposit itself into reality. An event modifies the world, but nothing has those modifications, only the consequence of what damages or repairs another configuration. Purana Kassapa is misinterpreted as amoral in the Pali Canon, but the theory of akiriyāvāda (non-action) cuts deeper than the sortition of merit or moral escrow: nothing binds, and if restraint persists, it does not persist with an ontological carrier or

an account retained by the world. Our actions dissolve once completed, and restraint survives only through exposure. Conduct is the only constant with a guarantee of continuity, only because actions proceed without attachment to metaphysical spillage or external remembrance. Despite what the partitions of history signify, time may thicken the cost of damage, but it does not eventually move toward retribution. The death of Yeshua was a vertical rupture, that as the Gospel of John intuited, was an event that completely redefined an epoch of history: history was partitioned by the story of a figure who, despite various arguments for or against his existence, collapsed the distinction between immanent and transcendent, source and incarnation of source, and recentered history as tension between God and humanity, just as the Enlightenment recentered the tension as between man and nation.



The partition between BC and AD created a precedent that demoted, invalidated, annihilated, and attempted to expunge the entire genealogy of complex, relational, and nonlinear cosmologies that were often felt and received in ancient and indigenous societies prior to the era of religion and era of industrialization. The imperial progeny of Pax Romana, the Enlightenment, and the tripartite age of Abrahamic religions reduced history to grandiose narratives of conquest, erasure, alienation, and forced conversion that presented monotony, subjugation, silent obedience, and simplicity as the answer, despite the embodied complexity of all that came before it and after. The generational wound of the epoch that killed Yeshua revealed itself through preservation of the myth that Yeshua was a transcendent being and not a mere mortal and a prophet held to the relativist standard of hagiography through his sacrifice, and the preservation of guilty conscience needed to maintain this hagiography. The pre-antiquity archive did not coagulate with the goal of systematized written preservation, leaving remainder largely through the ritualized aftermath of memory and oral tradition. What Yeshua and

the Desert Fathers made explicit was the possibility of relationships and survival without justification or institutional mediation, and the inheritance of this testimony sits at the pre-institutional hinge of metaphysical inquiry since antiquity. A paradigm shift, as Kuhn defines it, does not require logical justification to instantiate, only opportunity where the limits of present understanding are traced.



Indigeneity is a thought form more ancient than dispossession. The precolonial grammar of ancestral memory speaks in the respiration of deep time in spite of the settler clock. Such language precedes grievance because this pattern of thought belongs to something older than the concept of private property. Most known human civilization is, in fact, prehistoric in the classical sense of the term. Knowing that the vast majority of human experience is captured in the Paleolithic era should telegraph the possibility that the human nature that Hobbes or perhaps some contemporary fatalist waxing about the infirmity of humankind wrote about have all conflated the internal human need for parsimony with the simplified model someone else had created of humanity. Parsimony is fundamentally more of a biosemiotic process than a positivist one since it doesn't reduce humans to the belief that they are necessarily brutish and violent by fiat. The cuneiform texts in ancient Mesopotamia alone pointed to the ancient folk worship of thousands of deities, including a highly complex taxonomy of major deities, demigods, and spirits that they themselves understood maintained a birthless and endless cosmic order. The Canaanite fertility rituals, the Faravahar symbol of Zoroaster, and lamentation hymns of ancient Sumerian goddesses, and the ancient rock reliefs of Hittite deities all share what Wittgenstein may call a family resemblance. These are different registers of ancient civilization that all spiral around the same enduring vincula: the mythology of renewal, the interplay of sun and moon in a fecund dance, the cycles of seasons, and circulation of the dead with the living. These ancient civilizations

often developed entire grandiose ecosystems of ritual worship not through pure force, but through unfettered access to creativity and generative connection to ceremony that is so often severed from the rote soullessness of indenturing oneself purely to industry and building a life entirely on surviving this bind. Byung Chul-Han speaks very clearly to this modern challenge in *The Disappearance of Rituals*: that by eroding ritual through a culture of pure individualism and capitalist alienation, life loses its anchor, and begins to float against gravity in an amoebic vat that cannot access or know itself. Without incorporating ritual into our daily lives as deeply as these civilizations did, we mirror the hyperconsumerism that gratifies us in capitalism: a world in which nothing endures even though we are constantly producing and consuming new things every day that give us no meaning or self-knowing. The deep emphasis on ritual that we find in the Sumerian tablets reveal the opposite of what happens when rituals become the stable anchor of individual and collective life: time is simply akinetochronic, insofar as time does not move forward or backward, but events do. Time itself does not move or rest, but movement is something that happens within time.



In considering the maintenance for structural integrity, we may consider one such wager that bears use: the problem of instrumentation, or a probabilistic thought experiment, Golgotha's gambit. For any temporal problem presented as a collective solution to a problem that serves the common good, there is a probability that such a problem on an individual level has the potential to be used for injurious purposes collectively by an individual, or result in injurious sanction on the idea. Paradigmatic ideas can be abstracted away by others who choose to twist them for their own instrumental ends to assert control and domination over others. Whether it was a rabbi preaching radical acceptance of others who was later crucified on the cross by his imperial Roman pallbearers, we must recognize that Golgotha is not just

a place, but a condition that has roots beyond the site of crucifixion, because there is no possibility of crucifixion without the possibility of revelation. As the Gospel of John quietly gestures at, the historicity of Yeshua is a secondary matter to the significance of Yeshua as an idea that, for better or for worse, has irrevocably changed the world. The ancient Greeks called this parrhesia: open communication that moves freely because it is owned by nobody. Within Ancient Greece, this meant an obligation to speak everything for the commonweal, regardless of whether speaking begets subjugation or repression. Parrhesia was philologically composed in Greek literature with the term dimosia (public) as an activity to transmigrate knowledge as a public commons in lieu of knowledge as an exclusionary endeavor. Within the Midrashic halakha of the Mekhilta, the term dimus parrhesia appears next to maqom hefker (a place belonging to no one), signifying that knowledge could be shared and taught as convivially as water.



Spinoza's static God, while it served an ultimately selfless purpose in shaping the Enlightenment, also had the unintended consequence of being irreversibly instrumentalized by the pre-institutional capture of the generations after him to serve as the corpus of the segue between the Age of Religion and the Age of Nationalism. Whether the problem was religious empires or the imperialism of the great powers, the underlying privilege of historical specificity applied. Darwin, in demonstrating the shared ancestor of living beings through natural selection, also invited corruption through the eugenics movement and the concept of social Darwinism from the surface level interpretations of his work. The same could be said for Albert Einstein, whose mass-energy equivalence equation was groundbreaking, forever changing the field of physics and grade school classrooms, but also creating the technical groundwork for the progression of the nuclear age. Sometimes, ideas are emptied and recuperated, and other times, like Martin Luther King Jr's case, they get people killed, but what remains

is ultimately the trace itself of an idea and its implications. Thus, in a sense, Golgotha's gambit presents a statistically significant wager: that the most statistically rational decision in a long horizon is to reconfigure the vincula that shifts the paradigm of thought, because although the existential risk of immediate blowback and recuperation is possible and likely, the probability of renewal and change never drops to zero in the long term, creating a flat ground for the expectation of change. Emancipation is a positive sum outcome long term despite the negative sum risk in a non zero sum game. Just as some books are accumulated in a pile in someone's home and never read, there is always a probability that someone will receive an oral tradition, print tradition, or digital tradition and engage with it so that wisdom is shared and not hoarded. Although one may be at a local minimum of coherence, facing either the risk of fragmentation or further distortion, the eventual consequence of an idea remains constant across time, and that renewal is always likely at some point as it ever was, given that someone can always keep playing the game. As long as an idea can be answerable, the idea leaves a trace.



What we call Christianity and what we know about Christ, the prophet that Christianity is named after, are two different things. The historical Christ, whom we have reason to believe was a human being known by his Hebrew name Yeshua ben Yosef and an idea as opposed to a neatly packaged Biblical folk tale in epistolary form, was an impoverished sage from Nazareth who spoke Aramaic, and lived in the context of a highly illiterate society, and thus his character could be interpreted largely through his relationships and teachings as opposed to his linguistic constraints. Yeshua was known to have fraternized with sex workers, the unhoused, thieves, and an assorted motley crew of people who were designated in this era and subsequent eras to be heathens. Among the few of Yeshua's teachings we know of, Yeshua argues from the Sermon on the Mount: the preaching that the Kingdom of God is within oneself,

and can be accessed through direct recognition, and also radical relational love of all who live, from which all relationally can recognize the divinity between each other. Of course, not only was Yeshua crucified by the Romans at the decree of Pontius Pilate, his insights towards directly recognizing God and loving thy neighbor was quickly abstracted away by the institutional capture of Christianity and the Catholic Church, in favor of a Trinitarian Yeshua encompassed by Son, Father, and Holy Spirit, portraying Yeshua as some transcendent figure that judges people for their supposed sins, despite Yeshua himself frequently finding kinship in the sinners of Judea. The resentment of Christianity organically emerged from this authoritarian rulership over who Yeshua was and what Yeshua actually taught, emphasizing grammatical scripture over the practice of experiencing God in the other without the intervention of a church to insist that your ways are sinful or that only the institution could guide you into salvation.



Islam distinguishes from Christianity in terms of its devotional practices. As opposed to a defined Holy Trinity of Son, Father, and Holy Spirit, Islam transparently facilitates deep devotional experience, through highlighting the 99 Names of Allah. The Quran, from a cursory glance of current theological understanding, maintains that there is no distinction between submission and devotion to Allah. As a result, Islam does not have a unifying interpretation that distinguishes between devotion to Allah and submission to Allah, and across schools of Islam, there is shared reverence but not shared interpretation of the nature of the divine. The question of relationship to divinity historically has been navigated within Sufi Islam, which by and large remains a demographic minority of practicing sects within contemporary Islam, in which Shia and Sunni Islam are the majority. Even within Sufi Islam, historical loci of devotional practice vary; for example, the blacksmith Abu Hafs Amr Haddad emphasizes that dhikr (remembrance of Allah) emerges in the quiet work of craft,

emphasizing action under exposure over disclosing personal experience or achieving a specific spiritual state. The malamatiyya explore the value of assigning blame (malamah) to oneself, which in practice has less to do with humility and more to do with the expungement of moral bookkeeping as a justification for practice. The malamatiyya's view on shame shares a resemblance to the jurist Rumaym, for whom absolute deferral to the works of Allah eventually leaves a residual alibi for commitment to stewardship and responsibility for the living. Such is the pluralism of Islam in that among its traits— its deep devotion to Allah through the 99 Names, there are competing interpretations and thus competing practices around the relationship between decision and binding relation to divinity. This takes nothing away from the depth of the Islamic devotional experience, only highlighting that differentiation within faith can reveal a polyphonic interior of spiritual experiences within a faith. However, a deeper read of the Qur'an reveals a way of thought that was common at the time of its development, but buried in the ditch of Western modernity. The Qur'an admits composition through tajnis(patterned phonetic symmetry), tawriyya (semiotic thickening), muqabala (contradiction pairing), mughalata (reverse perspective, not unlike how Florensky attributes to Byzantine iconography) and ayat(signs as excitations of Allah) among a plethora of other deeply sophisticated rhetorical techniques in Arabic to facilitate cross-surah resonance and echoes of structure throughout even when reading disparate verses. The Talmudic mishneh (repetition) and the fiqh(jurisprudence of grammar) within the Islamic sunnah (embodied practices from the hadith) play a cognate role in structuring nonlinear community-generated epistemology about how to resolve the tensions of daily life beyond just linear textual literalism, and both cultural pedagogies encode how generative rules of a world are interpreted, adjudicated, and lived within the context of their respective social ecology. The Talmudic sugya and the Qur'anic aya share a grammatical architecture by operating in a recursive and semiotically fractal epistemology generated from communal adjudication, which the linearity of Protestant thought and the colonial logic of British

empiricism cannot process into the coherence and dimensionality that this thought developed as infrastructure. The colonial mode of hermeneutics designates the problem to the content of words themselves, but the Qur'an and Talmud concern themselves with contextual aperture. Western modernity inherited an impoverished hermeneutic method from the colonial past. The colonial world has confused impoverished grammar with impoverished syntax, and they have attempted to conjure a therapeutic salve by calculating grammar with prices and syntax in kind.



Islam's own development, similarly, is not separable from the historical context by which Islam evolved at different times and places. The development of the contemporary Islamic movement through figures such as Rashid Rida and Sayyid Qutb were not discrete civilizational aberrations that ontologically defined the essence of Islamic philosophy or application, but were instead informed by a complex interplay of circumstances in the 20th century between the Sykes-Picot Agreement, Balfour Declaration, the founding of the Muslim Brotherhood, and the political complexity of the post-WWII Arab world, all of whom were navigating similar questions about power and strategy often against the tension of the stage of modernity and Western industrial development. Sayyid Qutb's writings, such as *Milestones*, were fundamentally a conversation about how Islam could develop as a grassroots movement with armed struggle, and early Salafi figures like Rida advocated for an Islamic vanguardism that seized state power to expand the authority of the caliphate. These are just historical actors responding to conditions in the context of the broader geopolitical arena. If anything, these questions were not that dissimilar to what 20th century Marxist-Leninist theorists were attempting to reconcile about strategy against Western capitalism, because they were all navigating Cold War-era dilemmas of strategy and power, despite holding conspicuously different values and visions of society, and contrasting belief systems

about the society they were trying to build. Some Islamic figures like Ali Shariati were trying to reconcile these two belief systems to conceptualize a vision for society in post-revolutionary Iran, even though the Twelver Shiism of Khomeini became the authoritative standard of the state and left the communist political prisoners to be executed en masse. In the 1980s Iran-Iraq War, these lines blurred even further; Israel was one of the main military suppliers to Iran in this war, and the US was overt in supporting Iraq's invasion of Iran with intelligence and chemical weapons, despite the US invading Iraq decades later. These are all constitutive elements of the confusion that lumps Islam and left-wing thought together into some undifferentiated amoeba in the perception of their adversaries, even if those Western Christian nationalists could only project the symbolic expression of an imagined civilizational clash.



The Lebanese philosopher Mehdi Amel observed that structural conditions within the Arab world tended to shape into a reality that was far more muddled than the reductive comfort of orthodox interpretations of Marxism imposed externally on Arab and Islamic societies who were theorizing from within. Amel proposed that the mid-20th century Arab world was attenuated by what he called the colonial mode of production, where the primary structural medium was through colonial forms of social relations. What this means is that the conventional framings of the 20th century Arab political sphere had less to do with tribal signaling between secularism and religion or differentiable stages of modernity, and more to do with what was happening in Lebanese society in his time, which involved the structural inhibition of the Lebanese working class that was caused by the social form of empire. Lebanese workers inhabited multiple class positions at once in different resolutions based on where they lived and the village they returned to, none of which indicated what they represented as monolithic class structure, but adapting their survival intelligence to

often highly distinct social and material contexts. Amel distinguishes between what he calls “class substitution” – the consolidation and rearrangement of ruling class factions in between regimes – and what he called “class non-differentiation”, where an underorganized and dispossessed caste of a class-stratified society does not differentiate themselves into a stably organized class given that they are exploited not by productive industrial forces, but by the structurally inhibitive logic of colonialism and empire. Given this lens, we cannot easily simplify the class and cultural structure within Arab and Islamic societies in a way that is easily packaged for Western audiences who can observe and prescribe with no stakes or context.



This context, in fact, clarifies how Islam emerged in the 12th and 13th century as the most prominent critic of the Western interpretations of Plato and Aristotle. Islam has strategically positioned itself as a potent critic of Western modernity through most of its lifespan – whether it was Ibn Rushd revealing a shared unity of intellect or Ibn Bajja revealing the continuity of experience through “a science of perception across time,” the Islamic theologians were innovating across science, astronomy, and philosophy at a place that drastically outpaced Imperial Rome. The House of Wisdom is arguably the most intellectually fertile ecosystem in medieval antiquity; in some ways, the knowledge produced in Baghdad and Andalusia stabilized civilization for centuries even long after the Mongols sacked the Library of Alexandria. The direct influence of Ibn Sina, Ibn Arabi, Ibn Rushd, and the broader constellation of Perso-Arabic polymaths and scientists were an infectious influence of all of the travelers crossing their paths, including the Sephardic and Maghrebi Jewish sages who were directly influenced by Suhwawardi’s “philosophy of light” or Illuminationism.



The material convergence of this dialectic from nature emerged through the Sabians of Harran, who fervently practiced astrolatry through lunar calendar engineering diagrams which traveled as far as Baghdad, the Geonim, and all way to the Sephardic enclaves of Provence and Andalusia, all of which circulated throughout the Abbasid intellectual network. The ecstatic cosmology of the Sabians was not a religion in the contemporary sense at all; rather, these star worshipping priests coalesced their felt intuition that structure was ritual, and a science coextensive with the the infinitude of the cosmos was the only machinery that could generate a timeless structural integrity for the epochs of all who live within the world ecology. The trouble of knowledge has less to do with the infrequency of known geniuses and more to do with the artificial entropy that wipes out all potential geniuses. It's less tragic that the scale of which someone like Euler could shape civilization is in and of itself exceedingly rare than it is the possibility of many brilliant minds at Euler's scale could have been from Palestine, Latin America, Vietnam, or the Congo if the jurisdiction of admissible knowledge admitted their testimony, or if the Western world hadn't claimed enclosure over the exclusionary frontier of known ideas. The Islamic metaphysicians were not less capable of ingenuity than the Aristotelian philosophers they were expanding upon just because Baghdad was sacked by the Mongols, nor did the colonization of pre-Colombian Mesoamerica nullify the ingenuity of its mathematics and astronomy that it was contextually cultivated on. Colonization itself is animated not by civilizing societies as they claimed, but by the exact opposite: the use of calculated violence in order to strip away societies of the context that they built enduring civilizations upon.



The contextual fabric the universe is built on fundamentally precedes written language and written history, and thus by pressuring the neck of both of those things under a jackboot, we are collapsing

the possibility of civilization to breathe. David Graeber points out that debt is the construct of an empire that needed to classify guilt and redemption into partitioned schema, and that debt and credit cycles enabled cycles of bondage and disrepair. Colonialism may be best understood as the avatar of this primordial urge to submit the world to an amnesiac regime of debt that must be paid through remembering rather than silence. The continuity of context between all cultures is the lifeblood that keeps civilization alive, and it cannot be repressed through domination or sanction. From the haunted halls of Soledad, the prophet George Jackson writes: "The living condition, though bad, have no effect upon me physically. But how much longer will this last for me in and out of prison, for you in and out of debt, for the others of our kind who suffer jail, mental institutions, and the like. How long will we be forced to live this life, where every meal is an accomplishment, where every movie or pair of shoes is a fulfillment, where circumstance never allows our children to develop past a mental age of sixteen. I've been patient, but where I'm concerned patience has its limits. Take it too far, and it's cowardice." The prophet is not the one who prostrates themselves before God. In fact, they are the ones who come out of the wilderness to bear their fangs and bring God to trial, and God either dissolves into a deeper divinity or incinerates the world into the covenant of ash. The prophet recognizes once they accept the possibility of a burning home, they cannot return to it, so that they may only testify in front of the world to come. If the prophet burns with God, then the prophecy outlasts the ashes.



Responsibility is instantaneous, given that our actions have no before or after, only an uninterrupted line where necessity survives passage through us at once and vanishes without a trace. God is not an impersonal transcendental object that creates the world and disappears into silence. Rather, God is inaudible, which is the only way that mercy may be canonical in this world. God is only what must be done even

when it costs us the possibility of understanding error. Correctness is only at the instant of an action that repairs asymmetry. Beyond inhaling, the universe does not participate in human judgment; that is, we can damage or repair without any echo that it could be eventually tempered into fairness. James Baldwin writes: "If the concept of God has any validity or any use, it can only be to make us larger, freer, and more loving. If God cannot do this, then it is time we got rid of Him." Along these lines, God is that which is exhausted into the world until divinity expires. God does not depart the world or die for it, nor does God become the world, only expended into the world until that residue is no longer operative. The patriarchal nomenclature of God, one which we accept as common parlance, obscures the genealogy of the elder deity Shaddai, rooted in the deeper cosmogony of the Ancient Near East. In the cosmotechnics of ancient West Semitic civilization, Shaddai is philologically adjacent to the Akkadian root word for mountain based on the Deir Alla Inscription, reinforcing the conceptualization of Shaddai as a mountain adjudicating the boundaries of civilization, mediating as the invariant at the boundary of substrate and form. Shaddai is an intensional expression of a cosmic topography rather than a personalized anthropomorphic patriarch that attempts to intervene from outside the grain of history. This is how so many folk religions prior to the Abrahamic religions could hold the complexity of many deities but no masters, or the differentiated invariance that makes plurality possible through harmonization of the sacred and the relational. The ritual is the mastery of harmony amongst the tribe, and the witnessing of chaos outside of it. The sacred is democratized into all acts of meaning making that one deems precious, whether they are summoned in ritual, art, ceremony, families, shared breath, and ghost stories. Within the pre-exilic textual strata, Ruach Elohim (the breath of the divine) functions as the first shear flow operator, breathing the mirror symmetry of Shaddai's mountainous boundary to induce a phase shift in the primordial continuum. This shearing wind perturbates as a preparatory entropic

mode, yet precipitates form out of the undifferentiated cosmological substrate.



The corpus of Assyriology research substantially nullifies the bulk of downstream theological creation myths by asserting there is no sui generis institutional authority ruling over the pre-Biblical cosmotechnics on Ancient Semitic civilization. The archaeological and philological distinctions in the West Semitic source material (including but not limited to the Ugartic tablets, Samaritan Pentateuch, the Masoretic Text, the astrology of Berosus, and Chaldean numerology) situate the ancient Israelites within the surrounding cultural matrix, reinforcing a complex semiotic ecosystem where interlocked tribes shared cultural antecedents for seasonal cycles and flood narratives. In the Hebrew Bible, the michtam (golden psalm) has been largely left to hermeneutic interpretation, but its philological root structure overlaps substantially with the pre-Israelite Akkadian word kaniktu (sealed document or sealed tablet). In its context with Hebrew apotropaic poetry, the michtam is irreducible because it sits in a liminal place that is not fully Hebrew nor Akkadian, but a semiotic entanglement of the Israelite religion and Mesopotamian cosmogyny, entrenched in chaos and order in which the michtam signals a protective crest over the depths of disorder. However, given the semantic overlap, the more precise interpretation underneath the narrative that these psalms signify sentimental verses is that the Hebrew Bible contained a loanword for a sealed cosmological writ. The michtam thus signifies the sealed tablet of primeval cosmogenic inscription as a ritual practice for sealing the boundary of an undifferentiated primordial chaos. In the Lurianic Kabbalah, the shevirat ha-kelim (shattering of the vessels) is the photonegative inversion of this concept; whereas, the shattering of the vessels signifies the cosmic catastrophe causing the divine light to fragment, the michtam signifies the sealing of the vessels that contain the source of this catastrophe at the cusp boundary of

the light, revealing the prototype of a dynamic process of a primordial abyss prior to the light that transitions into form. The subsequent institutional narratives, such as Nicene Christianity and the Roman Catholic Church, evolved partly as claims of sovereignty as opposed to dispute resolution between original source code and later inherited tradition.



If we are to strip away the ineffable flourish of the early Merkabah mysticism documented in the hekhalot literature, we would recognize that the vision of a fiery chariot of light reigned by God is neither a chariot nor a vehicle driven by fire, but a cosmological machinery rendered in the iconography available to a civilization that modeled the divine as a control system for water, agronomy, pressure, cyclical stabilization, and shared access to purification. Even Ezekiel's earliest documented prophecies that the hekhalot builds from speaks about Babylonian captivity near the "river Kebar", closely indicating proximity to the Kebar canal that was used as a commercial route. The same vision of Ezekiel is where the place Tel Abib is sourced in Ezekiel's testimony, which derived from the Akkadian loanword tel abubi (the mound of the flood) as one of many Akkadian phrases Ezekiel could communicate in. Nahum Sokolow later appropriated the Hebraized version of Tel Abib (Tel Aviv) into his translation of Herzl's The Old New Land(Sokolow titles it "Tel Aviv") for circulation amongst the World Zionist Organization. Seemingly, the riddle behind the first major metropole of the Zionist movement, beyond the broader Zionist claim to indigeneity, is that it named itself through inherited mythos off of a misappropriation of a Mesopotamian hydrological nomenclature used by Ezekiel, situated along an irrigation canal in modern day Iraq while he dwelled amongst the Babylonians. When the throne-chariot is observed purely as engineered infrastructure, the mystique dissolves and reveals the Merkabah as a diagram of a hydraulic engineering structure. The stages, seals, names, adjurations, gates of angels, and

operational functions of the throne are describing something that resembles cosmic machinery with access controls, but not a throne that someone lords over. In other words, the Merkabah is not a celestial vehicle one pilots, but it is a celestial engine, which seems paradoxical in Western modernity until you realize that premodern civilizations assumed no partition between machine and cosmos, and thus any engineered infrastructure could become most useful through the cosmological scale of load bearing machinery. It was not anomalous for the premodern polymaths that converged in the House of Wisdom to specialize in mathematics and astronomy simultaneously, reminding us that the epistemic contradiction between mystic and engineer is a modern confabulation.



Prior to the late modern incantation of governance as polis, civilizations of antiquity understood governance as a hydraulic ars technica of material life. Al-Jazari's Book of Knowledge and Ingenious Mechanical Devices contained numerous diagrams of highly developed machinery including hydraulic water clocks, programmable peacock fountains with automated soap and towel dispensing, and canal engineering for local water supply systems. Al Jazari developed hydropowered machinery and the earliest recorded forms of robotics hundreds of years before Da Vinci's manuscripts where he theorizes about water as a "body in perpetual motion." Underneath Da Vinci's hydrodynamic literature was a shared belief more ancient than him that rivers are the earth's bloodstream, water drives all of nature, and that life was fundamentally the movement of flow into form. The archaeoastronomy and sediment analysis within Nilotic cosmology research also points to similar patterns of the pastoral communities along the Nile River, which extended the memory of the Nile as both a deity and hydraulic machinery; that is, the existing nilomatic fluid mechanic data and inscriptions of the deity Nun reveal a similar community in the broader network of Ancient Egypt which personified water as the

primordial eternal abyss that all come from and return to, and thus have chosen to engineer a world around the Nile River to stabilize this world. Karl Butzer documented how Egyptian agriculture resembled a very complex water distribution infrastructure that required resource-sensitive coordination mechanics that handled dependencies upstream and downstream the Nilotic flood management network. Butzer also notes that the system began to decohere under the excessive micromanagement of the New Kingdom period, which compromised the local knowledge base that kept the Nile stabilized for thousands of years. Fekri Hassan similarly points out that the floods in the Nile were often highly stochastic and prone to dissipation, requiring the Egyptians to develop complex disaster control system technology that were assumed to hold flood insurance in common rather than as a privatized adjudicative hammer mediated by insurance cartels or an actuarial liability exposure calculated for private asset protection.



Egypt understood risk management meant privation in common, developing risk management technology through temple granaries, predictive models of inundation records and astrological charts, and multi-year rational planning constraints for ecological attunement. Reducing the Merkabah into emanationism misses the unspoken negative space entirely about what it does not share literally: the Ancient Near East civilizations needed infrastructure for their agricultural networks, and the engineering of hydraulic systems for irrigation provided the basis for resource-sensitive water transport that kept the crops fed and to extend access to clean water for livestock. When read against the historical residue of other hydrological cosmologies, the Merkabah becomes an adjacent abstraction of the same water machine cosmogram that encodes how ancient societies regulated fluid dynamics as a way to regulate the respiration of the world itself. The shared cosmotechnics of ritual throne mythology was an early lived system of distributed computation, by which Plato contributed

to an epistemic regression in abstracting lived knowledge away through his Theory of Forms. The major Levantine and Mesopotamian civilizations had a throne-machine at the center of their palace powered by a hydraulic engine, usually etched with symbols that represented seasonal cycles, wind shear flows, and storm protocols, and these waterworks were structurally coupled with the symbology of a throne-palace even if conceptually distinct from one another. The Jerwan aqueduct, Sumerian throne iconography and the Shamash's throne wheels all shared family resemblance in their respective sign ecosystem with the divine irrigation computers that are diagrammed in the Merkabah documentation, which in the context of the royal ideology that these massive water control projects lived in, paints a picture of a world that funneled hydraulic infrastructure through a network of other palaces that ordained themselves through divine rule over resources. The Ancient Israelites shared the cosmological framework with the population of the Levant and Mesopotamia that controlling water meant retaining the memory of the cosmos.



What Marx and Engels projected inadvertently through their European colonial lens about the "Asiatic mode of production" was not about production or economic modes at all. Unbeknownst to many spectators in the modern Western world, early settled societies of the Indus Valley Civilization, Mesopotamia, and the Seima-Turbino culture shared very similar cosmotechnic grammar: land stewardship oriented in collective dwelling and use rather than private property, hydraulic polities, governance by archivist temples for data maintenance, collective labor as kinship rather than wage work, societies of ritual and food sovereignty, calendrics as cosmology, and the natural world as the ledger rather than the profit motive. The Assyriology literature even uses the term "archival governance" to describe the function of the Near East temples: they were public research bureaucracies for data centers and libraries simultaneously where people could read, pray,

and grieve. The concept of religion in these ancient civilizations derived from logistics coordination and administrative upkeep for communal ritual infrastructure that was shared amongst civilizations that were actively trading and communicating with one another. The primordial technology of state formation in this corridor of the world was stewardship of land and cosmos that measured flood cycles and grain yield through civic hydrology. The temple was just a public computer that could accommodate distributed resource tracking at macro scale for flood probability and grain distribution without a market system of supply and demand curves. Gebhalz Setz points out, for instance, the deities encoded in tablets fulfilled an institutional role in Mesopotamian civilization, and the myths written at length provided early testimony over resource management disputes, where Dumuzi and Enkimdu signified a conflict arising between pastoral and agricultural resource coordination. The first statecraft machinery was the water canal, not a king or a God. The throne in this context was an altar to the seasons and the agricultural cycles for resource regulation through hydraulic control systems, and was never meant to be ruled by a divine right of kings. Given the philological throughline between YHWH and the Canaanite moon deity Yarikh, we can infer the following: in the genealogy between the Avodeh Zarah and the land of Canaan, the scope reduction of idolatry corresponds to exactly the theistic significance of Yarikh, who was worshipped as a Canaanite moon god of the night sky, fertility, and timekeeping in cities such as Jericho and Ugarit. Yarikh governs over cycles, phases, and oscillations(e.g. flood cycles), yet YHWH governs breath, fire, mountain, voice, revealing a schism of breath and oscillation that once shared a symbolic grammar, bifurcating in conflict through the development of monotheism among the Israelites repackaged as sui generis.



The throughline of these hydraulic states between Sumer and the Indus Valley Civilization and their communication systems, upon

reconstructive inference, did not develop scripts as linguistic isolates but as hydrological-administrative semiotic networks that needed a shared framework to establish exchanges of goods based on resource constraints. The Indus script resembles a proto-metrological accounting glyph system tethered to an ecology of water management, grain maintenance, and irrigation corridors, sharing semiotic resemblance with the Sumerian cuneiform tablets that tally barley, water quotas, canal rotation, and temple granaries. The Ur III period between 2100-2000 BC, as Piotr Steinkeller writes, lasted nearly a century and resembled a planned economy that was not mediated by the commodity form, designating these ration tablets instead as shares of labor credit. Steinkeller also points out that early lending practices in this Babylonian period were often not securitized through incentives of interest-generating profit: "As the extant data demonstrate clearly, the lender's primary objective in advancing loans was to get possession of either the borrower's labor or his land or often both. In such instances, interest was a tool and not an economic end in itself, being therefore devoid of real economic value." Similarly to Graeber's argument, Steinkeller observes that lending is a moral and juridical technology rather than a financial instrument, often shaped entirely by the socioeconomic context that crediting occurs. Within halakhic law in Judaism, for example, the *heter iska* principle stipulates a contractual obligation that explicitly forbids interest from property lenders, and instead securitizes an arrangement where the lender and borrower share equal responsibility in coordinating the outcome of an investment. Islam also explicitly shares this practice through strict prohibition in the Qur'an on *riba* (interest), which they explicitly understood as privileging a wealthy borrower into exploiting the poor. Within Judaism, the technology of *heqdes* and its Islamic counterpart in *waqf* were not charity sites embedded in capital; on the contrary, they functioned by immobilizing capital entirely through a reclassified inalienability principle. Both *waqf* and *heqdes* pledged resources to remove property from arbitrary market circulation under the constraints of communal asset management, forming distributed

trusts without the boardroom access funnel of donor governance, trusteeship, personal prestige handshakes, and institutional capture. Historically, legal-juridical casuistry systems in this period emerged not exclusively to regulate exchange, but to withdraw common resource needs from market logic altogether. Both waqf and heqdesh convey that assets are held in common without discretionary authority, restricted to circulate resources in support of education, care, libraries, art, hospitals, and scientific observatories. In practice, this can scale to the planetary level, where assets are determined by need and not specified by shareholder requirements, distributing resources through a time-parameterized network of commons in alignment with ecological and planetary constraints.



The technology of debt as an instrument of subjugation reflects older expungement practices, in no small part by forcing technology to regress through the rhetoric of automation as pagan magic. Early Greek pneumatic engineering devices were lost in translation in Roman literature, which Tracey Rihll noted was connected to the Christian sacking of Alexandrian libraries to erode knowledge they interpreted to be too pagan; that is, threatening to the Christian institutions which could not handle the idea that people could live autonomously with better infrastructure that could reduce their toil and dependency on labor as subjugation. The dissolution of the connection between pneumatic engineering and the Renaissance world was, in no small part, motivated by fear that the slave economy could be made obsolete. The one enduring fragment of Petron of Himera, whom is documented as living between 4th and 5th century BC, comes from an attribution between Plutarch and Phantias in which Petron testified to the existence of 183 cosmoi "in contact with each other" via coaxial rotation. George Huxley points out when diagrammed, the combinatorics of Petron resemble a square rather than a Pythagorean triangle, which severely constrains the scope of inference into the

hydraulic cosmology that circulated in communication through Crete. The documentation of cosmoi in contact, along with the specificity of the number, especially reveals the inferential scope. In Petron's case, 183 is close to half a solar year; thus, if they are "in contact", the spheres are assumed to be continuous and smooth in transition, which would more closely resemble phases or cycles rather than literal universes. Subsequent metaphysical interpretations abstract this claim away from its hydraulic cosmological context, whereby 183 reads more plausibly as procedural accounting of cycles in a space of configurations rather than an inventory of emanative worlds. Given the bureaucratic repetition of the Linear A symbol sets, the early Aegean states expressed congruent semiotic alignment with hydraulic-administrative calendrics that needed a communication schema to parse the shadow cast by an environmentally constrained hydraulic ledger. The Linear A script of the goddess-centric Minoan civilization developed a palace-complex water and in-kind commodity accounting system for wine, oil, and grain balances, with similar sign patterns to the Mesopotamian ration tablets issued to workers in the form of record keeping for bread, onions, and oil, such as the tablets sourced from Jemdet Nasr. Linear A, in particular, employs a mixed accounting system that coupled pictographs and metrics not unlike the early Near Eastern metrology tablets; in this sense, Linear A resembles one of the early attempts at a linguistic semantics that evolved from a chiral functional pattern of token-based systems cognate with the evolution in other nearby hydraulic organizational systems.



Prior to flat symbolic representation of linguistic scripting and written text, the earliest forms of recorded civilization followed a particular pattern: they initially exchanged information through a stable grammar of ecological constraints, before transitioning into impressed shapes and then administrative sign systems of language and metrics. The seals in the Indus script, based on existing evidence and research,

convey stable repetitive grammar, positional syntax, and a cartouche structure based on merchant routes and water-basin geography. In accordance with the Schmandt-Besserat thesis, cuneiform tablets convey a logic of clay tokens with an impressed geometry in order to quantify the constraints of hydrological resources. As script evolved to prioritize phonetic representation, we actually compactified and stripped layers of the semiotic dimensionality that came with network coordination at the time, and to this day the price signal runs on a gospel of monetary wealth centralization not unlike the Ptolemaic epicycles. The Sindhu-Sarasvati basin, Tigris-Euphrates region, and Aegean palatial system marked three major nodes of one macro-semiotic ecosystem shaped by river basins and mediating through hydraulic system coordination. Through the infrastructure created by the Persian Empire, resource flows of physical goods could circulate among trade routes between Greece, the Ancient Near East, and Indus Valley with accounting tethered to concrete resources rather than abstract financial value. The Royal Road at the time was a logistics infrastructure that could coordinate message passing as well as production constraints and necessities between each of the participating bioregions in the trade network. In their accounting practices, there was never assumed to be an abstract resource equilibrium beyond an approximation of complementarity in ecological trade, such as coastal fish for inland grain or copper for tin, since the profit was not assumed until it was asserted as a moral technology for an organization of a financial regime. If anything, the modern Western empire, beyond mass commodity production, is drastically less advanced at coordinating resources than the Bronze Age hydraulic network thousands of years ago, because none of their alleged efficiency gains through the profit motive arise from ecological constraints prior to linguistic representation.

What can be determined is enumerable, and what is free evacuates from enumeration. What follows here as a throughline is not a metaphorical testimony of ancient religion, but a material and semiotic reconstruction of how cosmology emerges from hydraulic coordination under ecological limitations. The polytheisms of the Ancient Near East consisted of real people rather than canonized deities that transcended the mortal coil, and they inhabited a network of royal families and administrative offices amongst the elite as opposed to a Great Chain of Being. When we let the history speak for itself, divinity presents as thickening of deep time of how societies organized amongst themselves prior to scripture speaking for them. The royal families and administrative bureaucracies back then, such as the Sumerian *ensi* and Akkadian *ilum*, served a structural and genealogical role when flood cycles and agronomy needed an organized system, but were later reclassified as a theology of intelligent design to justify domination over the living. The coordination of irrigation for food systems came first before the inherited ideology of the divine right of kings, and closer to the antediluvian epoch, a bureaucracy worshipped water and cosmos as home for the world despite being confused later for a castle in the sky. Jan Aasmann himself has argued that the concept of monotheism and patriarch as creation myth developed as a trauma response left unresolved to justify rupture and exclusion as political technology for the horizon of mythogenesis. Aasmann points out that the pre-monotheistic societies converged more closely to cosmotheism, which composes social, ecological, and cosmic stability as one unified feedback process. The Egyptian *Ma'at*, when read in this lens, signified that the coordination of living systems, ecological constraints, and cosmic order were inseparable from one another as the foundational principle for civilizational stability. All of these faiths in antiquity ultimately reflected a complex ecology of signs, shared symbolic *lingua franca*, and a living autopoietic operating system of interacting nodes that needed to self-regulate collectively through bioregional feedback, ritual, and informational flow. The Sumerian cuneiform inscriptions were an in-kind coordination system of surplus accounting rooted in

the sensitivity of natural resources, which is why metals were traded rather than fiat currency. The first "ledger" was the tributary and flood calendrics as opposed to the debt tribunal. The ancient world governed infrastructure through cosmology because they saw the invariant necessity of worldcraft through ars technica, even if these societies were unfathomably ruled by the altar of networked empires.



The creation myth as a memory-bearing device resists distillation into a single scalar of creation. Creation survives passage through us regardless of how we express it or believe in it, and our only task is to let the process complete what has already begun. Often, at least a few partially ordered chains of creation are occurring: the stabilization of a surface for memory to persist in separating land from water, the survival of the return from an environment that refuses your plans, and ongoing phase coupling to scheduled periodicity that comes with the contract of seasons and rotations. When life gives us a floodplain, our stability conditions are provisional, and how we chain ourselves forward through storage and memory is all that survives any illusion that the universe is optional. The human species is only one of many living systems responsible for mediating the axis that keeps us phase-locked with the cosmos, whether through natural disasters or hydraulic infrastructure maintenance. Beyond the interpretive caricature and negligent romance of Bronze Age raid nostalgia lies a deeper understanding of how world building truly works: people who see themselves as within nature understand that they are within cosmos and thus not above anyone. Following the Roman denarius debasement and its derivatives in the modern financial system, the process of financialization decoupled the concept of value from use and any shared sense of resource sensitivity, compressing entire dimensions of value away from bioregional resource constraint and into abstract syntactic drift. The technology that glued earlier civilizations into some semblance of common stability was replaced

by a structurally inferior counterfeit technology of monetization that enables a more efficient systemic machinery of imperial extraction.



The entire Enlightenment narrative of progress rests on the categorically false doctrinal narrative that abstract monetization coordinates resources more efficiently through accelerated industrialization, but has only succeeded in its epoch in scaling violence more efficiently through colonial erasure, private enclosure of the commons, and mass proletarianization. The Bronze Age, ironically enough, could endeavor to sustain civilizations for centuries if not millenia through feedback sensitivity and coordination, contrasting heavily with the current trajectory of the post-Enlightment epoch, which accelerates collapse of habitability for much of the world system. The idolatry of private property is actually less advanced and more evolutionarily unfit for the survival of any living system, be they nation states or local predators, not just because they imply a biblical logic of lack that predates their origin, but because they depend on thermodynamic incoherence, which is a category error at the level of physics rather than moral genealogy. Premodern cosmotechnics had highly engineered solutions and infrastructural continuity that were chosen for abandonment by colonial modernity, and cannot be filtered into Malthusian population myths or anti-civilizational parochialism. These premodern societies led with the assumption that nature generates longevity, world systems generate recursion rather than sovereignty, and the concept of property was custodial activity rather than passive ownership. By monopolizing water or natural resources, we control food systems, resource networks, states, and ultimately living systems, and assuming control over the primeval pattern of water assumes control over a self-organizing motion and transformation that is cosmically inadmissible to nothing alive. To control an undifferentiated primeval chaos means controlling all that came from it.



When the peasant miller Menocchio argued that the worms that emerged from the mold of cheese were the angels, he was arguing blasphemously against the idea that the high Catholic priesthood maintained a chokehold on the capacity to make meaning out of reality or to make order out of chaos. His declaration that "All is chaos" is a declaration that threatened the foundation of the feudal society created in part by the authority of the Catholic Church, which insisted peasants were at the bottom rung of social hierarchy and stayed there. The blasphemy was that a mass formed out of chaos rather than by some divine decree, not that the moon was literally made of cheese or that we all are made of pure entropy. By arguing this, he broke through the illusion that peasant society was involuntarily in bondage, and instead could forge their own meaning-making capacity through the chaos they've endured through this chokehold, and for this, Menocchio was tried and burned at the stake. Similarly, the witches who were burned at the stake for witchcraft were just not persecuted for witchcraft ritual specifically, but for defying the idea that men could control them or define purity for them. Giordano Bruno understood this separate from any of these events that nobody has jurisdiction over the unmediated complexity of the cosmos, and that the infinite plurality of the cosmos is simply just that: a finite individual sampling of an infinite mediation of complexity itself in all of its possible configurations and modes of instability. Bruno led with a cosmogony by which the structure of civilizational *ars technica* fell out naturally, and for this reason the Roman Inquisition persecuted him to death. Bruno's memory palaces were rife with wheels because they were not just static interfaces to inhabit; rather, Bruno recognized that memory took a life of its own if it was reparable and re-inaugurable. Memory is the temperance device that maintains the world but never finishes it by indexing the causality of absence. Plurality emerges from the replication of this complexity, whether locally now or across the worlds inhabited by memory, keeping the world from lying about what cannot

be reversed. Cosmogogenesis is the initial operation, which generates the first bifurcation of metaphysics and cosmology. The evolution of the worlds within the cosmos is culturally situated as opposed to territorially asserted by fiat.



It is also important to emphasize the shared doctrinal overlap that Judaism and Islam share in regards to their account of the historical Yeshua, in contrast to Christianity itself. Islam and Judaism both emphasize the prophetic account of Yeshua as opposed to his divine nature, which portrays him as an immanent presence as opposed to transcendent one that maintains divine separation from the mortal coil of humanity. Contemporary Trinitarian accounts of Christianity proceed from the Nicene Creed, which establishes Christ as the Son, Father, and Holy Spirit and the one God of Christianity, and in establishing a creed and an institution, a church can then fulfill its duty to separate institutional religion from authentic spiritual experience, in which believers could be separated from heretics at the discretion of Church doctrine and the authority invested in religious institutions. Even the Shekinah, as referenced in the Zohar, could never tether to a specific land or person, and in her embodied experience with the world, she was more able to flow freely into the world. The Shekinah is not a condition of enlightenment that one locates geographically, because the direct experience of Shekinah is far more primordial and cosmological than any divine right to land or nation. The Shekinah's eros and awareness is automatically accessible and omnipresent at all times, without being mediated by a shul or a nation-state insisting that you must believe in them to be safe in this world. The Kabbalist Abraham Abulafia's commentary speaks into this tension of a "unio mystica", by which he writes in his epistolary collection *VeZot LiYihudah*: "...all the inner forces and the hidden souls in man are differentiated in the bodies. It is however in the nature of all of them that when their knots are untied,

they return to their origin, which is one without any duality, and which comprises the multiplicity.” The ecstatic quality of Abulafia’s commentary is subsequently a side effect of the technical discipline Abulafia practices in: the core of Abulafia’s ecstatic Kabbalah is the *chochmat ha-tzeruf* (letter-combination) in composition with vocalization and breathwork, iterating a transformation across a combinatorially finite exploration of states until attention or affect is reconfigured. In this regard, Abulafia’s combinatorial protocol, captured especially in the *Sefer ha-Hesheq* and *Sefer Ha-Ot*, codify an input alphabet of lexical-numerical operators, which generate reconfiguration of the felt state of attentional regulation through somatic discipline.



The Castilian Kabbalah lineage, and in particular Joseph Gikatilla’s early work in the *Ginnat Egoz*, engineers a combinatorial operator system with a bounded ruleset over a discrete letter graph: the garden of nuts, as Gikatilla calls it, proceeds from a iterative permutation-forward path from the initials of *gematria*(base tokens), *notarikon*(acrostic bundling) and *temurah*(admissible permutation rules) all abbreviated to (G, N, T) in total. The Names of God are weighted typed semantics, letters are the discrete combinatorial operators, and *niqqud* (vowels) are the control surface modulating continuous deformation over the discrete combinatorial base. If Gikatilla’s system composes the regulatory combinatorial system, and Abulafia can be thought of as the lived phenomenal execution of that system, then the reader may be thought of the kernel that mediates between the two: Abulafia and Gikatilla, together, may be read as a mnemonic technology that originates not in the head or heart of a reader’s experience, but in the entire semiotic environment of text, breath, voice, archive, and time; thus, the practitioner is a phase-coupled medium that executes constrained transformations through the entire environment that carries ritual, pedagogical lineage, and disciplined

relations to time. What once remained unsaid in modernity is that the world is the text, not the physical representation of the text itself in scripture. History is thus just the syntax of this text, and the adjudication of justice is the grammar that shapes history.



Even dating back to the philology of Ancient Semitic word ecology, the Greek word for grammar (gramma) simply translates akin to "written line" or "mark", and in Biblical Hebrew, the word ot meant sign or token. The concept of mishpat roughly translates as "to judge" or "to rectify" which aligns with their understanding of justice as the active repair of symmetry, and Qur'anic Arabic term for ayah similarly translates to sign, miracle, or verse. The ancient world understood that casuistry begins with evaluating the structural coherence of the world first instead of defaulting to harm or punishment, and by evaluating the coherence they could repair the grammar of the text embedded in the living world system. The prophet is simply the grammarian who observes when a sentence is incomplete and resolves it by revealing what is deferred. When understood less as faith and more as an architectural diagram, grammar simply entails the coherence rules of the world through its shared rules and patterns, and prophecy simply reflects the repair of the trauma imposed onto this grammar through deferred maintenance. The gospel is not a belief system that one joins through a temple, but it is structurally coupled with grammar to actively participate in the structural stabilization of a wounded world. Machinery, ritual landscapes, and infrastructure can survive in a field manual, but when environments that produce them are dissipated, the ecology of memory carries the scars of that dissipation in response. The territory is the covenantal ash of a burnt map.



The intellectual current between the Luranic Kabbalists and the Geronese Kabbalah is one that, up to this point, had not yet been emphasized in its totality. The Kabbalah of Meir ben Ezekiel ibn Gabbai, Azriel of Gerona, and all of their descendents in their beit midrash, was mostly severed in history in favor of the transcendentalist mythopoeia of the Zohar, but the Geronese Kabbalah admitted an entirely different relationship to divinity. Azriel of Gerona developed a universe in which the creation was not an ex nihilo God creating the world, but a potential existence transforming into an actual existence. The atzmut (Godhead) is ontologically prior to Hashem (God), by which the name of divinity is an expression knotted through process, transition, and inversion. This immediate act of embodied creation could only develop within the inherent dignity of the natural world, not as a theology of symbolic myth, but as a structural diagram of a shared ecosystem. The etz chayyim (tree of life) could only be engineered from the first principles of constraints by transitioning from the world's potential representations to its actual reality through the immediacy of immanent dynamics. The ten sefirot (attributes) traced to the Kabbalists from Luria onward were structural transformation rules between bulk and boundary, rather than ten divine names that one must seek to enlighten themselves. The Kabbalah of Azriel of Gerona emphasized Godhead over God, and immanent process over transcendence, and that the effluence of this transformation was mediated by Atzilut (the world of causes), the highest of the four worlds within which the sefirot take differentiated form.



The Kabbalah that Azriel developed was one that ultimately, had it fully canonized, would've permanently shaped the course of Judaism. Through this collapse of symbol into structure, and structure into process, the Ein Sof becomes not a sign of transcendence but a movement from an unseen principle to a visible stability. The ten sefirot are the bones and joints that stabilize the field of life itself.

Azriel of Girona defines the Ein Sof as a sacred fire, in which the infinite quality that endures underneath all losses and all residue is its only real property as fire: that it does not lose its spark by circulating, and that the fire can ignite an infinite number of lights in this world. This collapse of Ein Sof (infinite) into Malchut (oneness) is that annihilation of the boundary between the Godhead and life itself. The only absolute, endless, and invariant process in the world is the light, which washes over this world eternally even in its darkest nightfall. For many generations of history, we have denied ourselves the provenance of sensing what Peirce called the phaneron: that field of intelligibility by which relationships, transformations, and whole of possible experiences may appear. The Geronese Kabbalah denies that life could be intelligible any other way beyond its load paths, boundary conditions, field behaviors, descent into their foundations, and the form generated from the collective tempo of life. Such is how we coordinate the affairs of the living, who are tasked with restoring the longevity of their ancestors in our lifelong journey to resolve the contradictions between tension and equilibrium, so that the invisible skeleton tree of the world may reveal itself to us through what is most load bearing and what withstands collapse no matter how much time passes. The stability of the world's structure reveals contingency more deeply in our felt sense of necessity, beyond the temporary seduction of mythic drama and the comfort of a wounded soul. There is simply no return in this world that is not a continuation, a completion of the cycle, and the active movement of salvation through the mercy of redemption for all that lives as pure and necessarily whole.



Within the school of Castilian Kabbalah, the Keter-ha-Kefulah defines the soul as dual aspects of polarity in tension: the Keter Elyon (upper crown) and the Keter Tachton (lower crown), where the soul glues these crowns together as negotiated dynamics between the crowns, neither of which are assumed to be the primary substrate. The Keter

ha-Kefulah argues that reality is structured through the dynamics of how these two crowns interact: the upper crown generates the all-possible modal horizon of form based on all possible configurations, and the lower crown determines the actualized structure of stabilized form. The nefesh (soul) simply weaves the local configurations together that contain a possibility space and fixed point stabilization, and by the weaving of the soul we admit the neshama (breath of life) as the convergence that mediates intensional and extensional modes together through a unified manifold of experience. This process of weaving reveals the countenance of the divine as neither a patriarchal God or a vertical stone column of a Godhead as ladder, but of the most primordial sensation: the divine as Godsibb, the weaver of the breath of life who does not emanate only when accessed in silence but inhaled as the mnemonic vessel of the atmosphere. The Godsibb is the one beside the snow who stewards the cemetery so that the custodial duty becomes ours to hold through our inherent kinhood with all that live and all that carry the pails of water to the funeral site. The Godsibb is the divine of breathing, a chosen family accompanying transformation, and the dissolution of a sovereign on a throne in the sky. Divinity becomes the reciprocal kinhood in the hospice of metabolized time, as companionship before domination or enlightenment, and as sense before textual representation. Indeed, divinity as Godsibb revitalizes us to participate in time as a stewarded vigil, and to thicken the continuity of memory that facilitates an involuntary return to the oasis. This does not reduce the world to faith, but whets the scope through phenomenological aperture so that the metabolics of care are not disassociated into the fantasy of sovereign domination as an organizing principle.



Rebbe Nachman of Breslov hints at the practice of hitbodedut in the Likutei MoHaran as part of this embodied activity: the active convergence of desire, harmonization, and transformation by accessing

what one may call the *mundus imaginalis* and seeking to participate in creation within a field of equals. Rebbe Nachman's *hitdodedut* is an active practice of embodied spiritual experience, which one cannot reduce to contemplative quietism or transcendence through doctrine. Adjacent to, within Lurianic Kabbalah, the concept of *gilgul* (reincarnation) navigates the questions of how a soul hops between bodies and why a soul persists throughout time. The *Sha'ar HaGilgulim* describes a rectification of the soul that is agnostic to the object it inhabits, and can seamlessly enter a plant, animal, or a rock. *Gilgul* can only be resolved through *tikkun* (repair) by fulfillment of duties (*mitzvot*) for transgressions in a past continuity (*aveirot*). We can think of *gilgul* as a cycle or recurrence of the unresolved patterns that *neshamot* (souls) establish as a trail of provenance for historical memory and inherited trauma that one person is tasked with stewarding in their lifetime, as the body is designated by the soul to resolve a pattern that was left unresolved. This understanding of *gilgul* highlights that trauma is an incomplete process that returns until it is repaired. The soul does not "work harder" or self-purify in the next life as much as it returns later to finish what was left without repair. At its core, that's really what reincarnation is: the task of completing a sentence punctuated by deferred maintenance until the period bookmarks it. The transmigration of form is only possible because form was admitted to be an image that could be transmigrated at all. Joseph of Hamadan's concept of *gilgul* generalizes the continuity of the soul beyond human life to animal life, unifying them under a single substrate. For Hamadan, the migration of the soul between species is not a supernatural deviation or a punishment, but a deformation of structure when coherence of ethics or cognition deteriorates.



What Joseph of Hamadan identifies as animal grief reflects this continuity: traces persist across embodiments of form because the

underlying breath of life is one continuous respiratory process. The quietly radical implications of Hamadan's vision of reincarnation unfold through the assertion that Talmudic interpretation inhabits its covenantal constraints through a decentered scope beyond rabbinical authority or cultural identity, given that Jewish men could reincarnate as other genders, faiths, or animal life beyond human life, and thus share a responsibility along with all of them to maintain the continuity of the world without claiming ownership over it. Matter does not need matter to be complete. What persists is not identity or moral residue, but only the configuration of habituations, patterns, and material norms that recombine in continuity. Life rearranges regardless of our accumulation, leaving us responsible for the execution of form without any promise of archival, because the instance of a configuration will damage or repair another configuration. Thus, what we may describe as the transmigration of a soul is actually the principle of transconfiguration between living systems through continuous feedback, in which repair of the world is demanded with no privileged observer and without the guarantee of an outcome. The demand for repair does not arrive from authority, foresight, or reassurance that we will not be abandoned, but because there is no position where we sit outside of the continuity of the world we are left with as the condition for life to occur.



The world is governed by disintegrability as a constant, and any integration or order that persists thereafter is a luxury. Structure requires explanation only insofar as its deformation survives loss of distinguishability and does not collapse under failure of integration. Repair ultimately precedes completion, and contradictions precede the structures that attempt to contain them. If we assume the premise that the world did not begin as a divine fist from above and actually emerged as a boundaried transition between worlds, then no such claim to territory or myth of a chosen people exists at the level of

physical law. There are no final revelations or stages of development that sublate us to the myth of conquest. Upon considering that life is foundationally calendrical, nothing in this world is promised to anyone except the possibility of having a memory, which dissolves any ideological basis that anyone in this world is more exceptional than the other. No human, or humans as a class of species, operate at the center of time, and by this consequence we would assume that no natural phenomena claim exceptional status over land or cosmos. There are no first traumas or first stories, only what we have of each other to commit to the circulation of care and the development of the world. Linear time requires an origin story and a patriarchal genealogy of an eschaton, but there is no origin of anyone at all, only the following constants of life: developmental passage, inheritance of memory, mediating boundaries, and reopening wounds so that metabolic load may continuously redistribute without localizing it into any particular source.



From what we know of Shlomo Molcho's life, he refused any and all conversions into spiritual practices other than his own, to the point where he was executed for his refusal to bow to the Catholic Church. Among his surviving work that does exist in collections such as the Kitvei Shlomo Molcho, the following motifs and foundations have been traceable between extant manuscripts, pietist midrash, scribal marginalia and patterned attestations: Within the Izbica and Radzyn margins, for example, Shlomo Molcho's doctrine of hafakhah (zones of inversion) was circulated as a vision of stability condition dynamics to reveal a deeper structure at a boundary layer. Within the marginalia of the Radzyn manuscript, Molcho dreams about a pattern of interference between two spheres of light: a divine potential that descends and a divine immanence that ascend into convergence, revealing a crack in the boundary where the edge of chaos reveals its moment of synchronization. Within an Izbicer commentary, Molcho also

speaks of a voice in the dream realm: "What burns is not the world, but the illusion that the world is separate. Within this dream, the roots of a tree burn because the boundary between Ein Sof(the heavenly immanence) and Malkhut (the earthly immanence) collapse into one. Some anonymous marginalia have copied a dream where Molcho speaks: "When the rhythm is whole, the Messiah breathes. When the rhythm is broken, the world sleeps." Molcho speaks of the coherence of an entire plane of souls, where redemption is an unfolding into a network of signs, synchronization, and inherited memory.



There is no object or symbol that innately has meaning unless it is used once. These symbols otherwise decay if they are not circulated in common, and they gain persistent utility through shared practice. Molcho's dying imagination as the Church burned him describes a flame that he claims entered his mouth that transformed him into the fire itself, and the inquisitor at his trial speaks of what he describes as his final gift of understanding: "Death is the only shedding of the shell that hides unity." We may dance with death as we would dance with darkness as the ashen shadow of what remains when the body finally transitions into ash, rendering a fully sovereign soul of only the invariant nucleus under all flows, where immanence and transcendence become the mirrors of light and shadow. There is no truly no origin outside of who we are, only the continuation of the origin story. Molcho's transition was one that refused the meaninglessness of grief by building a bridge on his back of catastrophe and purpose, whose death reconfigures the world and we cannot sense why, but that in his transition, denies the need for explanation and begins to return to the shoreline and precipitate into foam.



Molcho did not die drowning in the fire as he embodied the rupture, oscillating instead into life as a tide crashing onto the earth; following this witnessing, our task of all life that crashes to shore is to give them the astrolatry of a dignified burial. The dead who carry us across the rubicon demand to be inhaled through the candlelit flesh of twilight and exhaled into the flute of incommensurable loss so that the funerary rite restores breathing before lungs collapse for air. For this, if we have known a reflection in the ocean that brings us grief, the consequence of this grief is that we are knowable by the catoptromancy of crushed glass, that we are not consoled by time, and ultimately, that we cease resisting the instinct to fix the fractured mirror and start carrying the memory of the reflection behind it so the dead may finally speak. Indeed, what could be a more beautiful thing in the world than devoting our attention to a memory that talks through us? The matter of the living is finite, but as Tarkovsky says of creation: "it is possible to create an illusion of the infinite: the image." We have refused to depend on narrative on explanation because memory is structured, and after a while the memory returns the way all things do: to cross the rubicon of when things in this world can be fixed and into the place where things must be understood. The world is a memorial of those we cannot save, by which no consolatory measure can restore the past and can entreat us of our responsibility to the dead beyond the task of resolving a shared sense of order in the cosmos so that the dead can finally lay down their burden and rest.



The sheol (realm of the dead) shares a phenomenological grammar with what the Tibetan Book of the Dead calls the bardo: a silent, attenuated liminal space where memory thickens and control unravels, revealing the dead in their fullness as a temporal continuity that persists without narrative or doctrine. The process of ritual is temporal orientation, by which if emptied as superfluous, determines the trajectory of the world regardless of our resistance to it. The vitality of the dead dilutes as

our witnessing of the world thickens through them, by which the yarn of the sun knits the duration of the world as a spindle. The ancient depictions of the morning star as Lucifer diminishes him to a morally absolute traitor narrated into an undignified symbol, as opposed to his older duty as Helel ben Shachar, the custodian of a descent into seasons and genealogies where falling is witnessing to rupture. Helel's earlier namesake, Atthar, oscillates into ascent to Baal's throne, and in recognizing the vastness of this throne, descends back to the cemetery of the soil. The morning star signifies the calendrics of washing the pearl of one's skull as they would the cyclical hygiene of one's jaw, when the plaque of the season asks for it. By accepting this, we initiate into the world in which we are invariantly governed by the memory of the dead that lithify into the shore of destiny, and we are obliged to meet them there. The shattering of the vessels is not the eternal tragedy of a core wound in need of an autopsy, but a task admitted by everyone tasked with being alive, because they commit to the work of the mikonenet (one who makes a nest) as the primeval needlework of life. We enter this story when we are ready to inherit the world.



There is never an explanation that outruns survival. The soul is eternal, even if temporarily reconfigured by our embodied activity. Eternity is death with a mask, and the soul wears the skin that keeps the mask disintegrable as it passes through the world. The life of the exposed soul is operationally eremetical— not in the sense that it is spatially evacuated from the world, but that it is removed from any temporal buffer between perception and action, any interior surplus in need of expression, and any moral prime rate accruing over time. Simultaneity is the only bedrock of life when it has no other alibi to rescue it from consequence. The performance of demonstrating that a part of us is real necessarily unfurls the latent sciamachy of reason. What remains in memory through this world may eventually no longer be reducible to adequation, for our explanations arrive at a terminus that exhaust

their source of cause. The Greek Presocratic philosopher Heraclitus argued that the arche (first principle) of the universe is fire, for the possibility of fire and the discovery of the flame as a technology and a lantern originates the possibility that nature loves to hide. When reading through the remainder of the Milesian natural philosophers, they may differ in terms of the material or elemental reagent they determine to be the first cause, but they do not vary methodologically in terms of scope of enquiry and observational constraints; in fact, the bifurcation between idealized form and concretized matter came with the canonization of Plato, and we have only gradually recovered ever since.



A life consists only of possibilities that remain live until the world forces a resolution, by rock or by tide. The material fire of the planetary core and the immaterial substrate of the soul proceed from the first principle that life is received through the extension of continuity rather than discovered through the completion of a story. Around 1972, Kurt Gödel wrote to Hao Wang: "The world is rational, but incomprehensible." By this point, he admits that not only is propositional logic necessarily incomplete at formalizing reality, but so is experience and ontology itself. Rationality is only the responsibility that we answer to without transference. In this sense, the limits of formalization are not defects but the invariant of any living system: the threshold by which structure reveals openness beyond what any formal system can contain. The necessity of aliveness precedes axiomatic demonstration, and thereby determines the responsibility we share to the convivial surface of the cosmos. We endeavor to seek the universal principle that organizes the universe and integrates the shadow, but by doing this, we paradoxically admit that at the highest abstraction, there are limits to what we can formally comprehend beyond the tomography of our perception. We can sense carrying a soul, and we can even ritualize around the spiritual implications of the souls that are assumed

to be universal amongst the living, but we cannot formalize what a soul is, what the soul looks like, or what the soul universalizes to as a property in all living things without flattening the complexity of experience that we inhere. We assume that we will never fully capture a complete integration of our shadow or reality as a whole, but we can nonetheless expect that there will come a time in our lives when there is nothing left for us to prove or contemplate, only a time for us by which we act in kinhood to organize the affairs of our lives, so that the imperceptible and merciful fascicles of the world are no longer ours to admonish. Anything in this world that avails itself to us only does so by the affordances of what endures without guardianship. The rawest ochre of the universe we inhabit is that life is the invariant that reveals itself, arising beyond reflection from the structuring of experience.



The resolvent is the answer of cumulative spectral decay, and it answers only one instant before discharging into the abyss. Any stabilization is provisional by delay under decay. Such a world supports nothing beyond orientation and spectrum, and anything that exists does so only by a momentary alignment of bandwidth and trajectory, as percepts under the non-simultaneity of vergence. The subject is never contemporaneous with the retroactive braid of time, surviving because it fails to resolve into simultaneity after damage is done. Life only persists because of the delay chord where time fails to align with itself. What appears are fleeting crossings of consonance between orientation and bandwidth in orthodromic course, under conditions that encode the ineluctable sparing of disappearance. All stability is resolvent stability. The cut and the line are the same. Sometimes, the line survives, and the line connects the point. A period remains.

END SCENE

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THE UNIVERSE ALWAYS DRINKS FROM ITS SHADOW TO KNOW
ITS THIRST

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תּוֹרַחָהּ רַפֵּס

Sefer ha-Hazarot

The Book of Returns

“What’s yet in this
That bears the name of life? Yet in this life
Lie hid moe thousand deaths; yet death we fear,
That makes these odds all even.”

— William Shakespeare, Measure for Measure (Act 3, Scene 1)

BEGIN SCENE

Return to the beginning of the text, read
backwards, or recur to any other phase and
proceed in any direction. The choice to renew,
continue, pause, rewind, or fast forward is yours.

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OMNIS DETERMINATIO EST NEGATIO